

Exemplar Value in Silver Pieces

d20	Minor	Major	Great
1–7	1,000	10,000	20,000
8–13	2,000	20,000	40,000
14–17	10,000	100,000	200,000
18–19	20,000	200,000	400,000
20	50,000	500,000	1,000,000

A wizard can use an exemplar to defray the silver piece costs of any magical research or construction undertaking. If the exemplar is worth 10,000 silver, then the wizard can subtract that amount from the cost of building a Working, or devising a new spell, or forging a magic sword. The precise nature of the exemplar doesn't matter, as it's assumed the insights given can be turned usefully to whatever work the wizard wants to accomplish. The wizard must have the exemplar in their possession to gain its benefits; they can't simply copy down the insights for later. Partial exploitation of the item's secrets leaves the rest of its value intact, so an exemplar worth a million silver might be used piecemeal in a dozen projects.

Exhausting an exemplar destroys it. Magical objects may need to be disassembled in order to fully understand the principles involved, or the use of the ancient techniques might provoke a counter-reaction from the Legacy that forecloses their further use, or the object might need to be physically incorporated into a Working or magic item. Whatever the specifics, an exemplar can be used only until its silver value is exhausted.

EMPOWERED CALYXES

A *calyx* is a suspended spell or magical effect, one trapped in a physical object for later use. While they take many forms, the most usual ones are those of a scroll, small grimoire, tablet, or other inscribed object. These inscriptions usually give a learned observer the details of the magic kept within and the particulars of how to direct, adjust, and target the effect. Anyone with literacy in the language of the inscription can figure out a calyx's contents. Without an inscription, it takes a day of study by someone with Magic-0 to puzzle it out.

A calyx contains one or more spells from the High Magic list or some other spell list. Each spell can be used only once, unless multiple copies are embedded in the same calyx, and they are cast at the level of the mage who inscribed them in the first place. Details of targeting, specific effects, and other decisions made at the time of casting are made by the wielder of the calyx. When the last spell in it is used the calyx collapses into dust, bursts into flame, or otherwise disintegrates.

To use a calyx, the owner must grasp it firmly and trigger it as if they were casting a spell, using a Main Action and wasting the item uselessly if they are struck or jostled during the casting process. No vocalizations or gestures are needed, however, and a calyx can be triggered while wearing armor or bearing a shield. A High Mage

or other spellcaster cannot use their own arts to boost a spell embedded in a calyx, but must cast it in its normal, unmodified form.

The spells in a calyx are cast at a caster level equal to the item's creator. For randomly-found calyxes, the level is the minimum required to cast the most potent spell embedded in the calyx.

Releasing a calyx safely requires a clear understanding of its magic. A user must have a Magic skill no more than one less than the suspended spell's level in order to safely trigger it. Thus, a calyx containing a fifth level Necromancy spell requires Magic-4 skill in order to safely activate it. Anyone with the skill can use it, even non-spellcasters, provided they have enough grasp of the theory of magic. Even mages of a contrary tradition can use these spells, so a High Mage can deploy Elementalist spells from a calyx containing them.

If a wielder doesn't have a high enough Magic skill, they can attempt to use the item anyway, albeit at considerable risk. An Int/Magic or Cha/Magic skill check is needed against a difficulty of 8 plus the spell level. If it fails by one or two points, the spell fizzles and is wasted. If it fails by more than two points, it goes off, but at the wrong target or with the wrong effect at the GM's discretion. If the check succeeds, the spell goes off as intended.

Spellcasters can create their own calyxes for later use, creating them as single-use items as explained on page 92. The expense is 1,000 silver per spell level, and the difficulty is 7 plus half the spell level, rounded up. While a calyx takes only a week to inscribe, the process is exhausting, and a wizard can do it no more than once a week per spell level inscribed. Thus, after embedding a fifth level spell, they can add to or make no more calyxes for five weeks.

The table below gives some suggestions for randomly-discovered calyxes and their contents. Some calyxes may contain powers or effects that have no parallel in conventional spellcasting, being magics of a former age or more modern enchantments gone strange and sour.

Random Calyx Contents

d20	Contents
1–6	One first level spell
7–10	One second level spell
11–13	One third level spell
14–15	One fourth level spell
16	One fifth level spell
17	1d4 spell levels, none above second
18	2d4 spell levels, none above third
19	2d6 spell levels, none above fourth
20	2d8 spell levels, none above fifth

While calyxes are potent sources of magic, they are too abbreviated and summarized to be effective tutors in the spells they hold. A wizard must find a grimoire or a tutor to learn new magic; a calyx alone cannot teach them.



MAGICAL WEAPONS

A lust for enchanted steel is a commonplace among warriors, and the sorcerers of the Latter Earth have not been remiss in creating wondrous weapons for their allies and patrons. Despite the inevitable losses to time, wear, and obscurity, magical weapons from countless prior ages can still be found in ruins, strongholds, and the grip of powerful warriors.

As with any magical item, GMs should remember that the weapon's current possessor will almost certainly be using it against their foes if they are able to do so.

CREATING MAGICAL WEAPONS

First, decide whether the weapon should be a minor, major, or great treasure. An heirloom axe of a minor knightly family might seem to be appropriate for a minor weapon, while the famed war-sword of a legendary hero is probably a great treasure. This is not a certainty; even a famous blade might actually be of relatively modest power, and a little-known spear might be a relic from a forgotten legend, but it's a good starting point for creating the weapon.

Next, roll a d20 or pick from the table below to find out the weapon's basic enchantment bonus. This bonus is added to any hit rolls, damage rolls, and Shock the weapon might do. While most magical weapons are considered masterworks of their type, the usual masterwork bonus does not stack with these enchantments.

Weapon Enchantment Bonus

Bonus	Minor	Major	Great
+1	1–16	1–5	1
+2	17–19	6–17	2–4
+3	20	18–20	5–20

Once you know the enchantment bonus, you should think about the original intended users of the weapon. Who was this magical item made for? What sort of weapons did they use, and in what context were they employed? A footman in some ancient sorcerer-king's army is going to have a very different kind of short sword than the casual sidearm carried by a noble of some vanished empire.

The adjacent table offers some suggestions as to who the original users might've been. If you've established a particular ancient empire in your campaign setting, you might credit the weapon to them, and use some recurring motifs of material, shape, or style to help emphasize the item's origins. If the weapon was instead made by some modern mage, it might include a maker's mark or other characteristic trait that could connect it to other items crafted by the wizard.

Each table entry provides some suggestions as to the types of weapons most likely for such a wielder. These favored weapons will form the bulk of the magical war-gear found for them, though it could be that the item was a novelty created for an owner's special purpose.

d8 The Original Intended Users of the Weapon

- Used by a common member of a mass infantry unit that relied on muscle-powered weapons. Favors spears, pole arms, short swords, or daggers.
- Used by a civilian gentleman or duelist. Favors swords, daggers, hand hurlants, staffs, cane-clubs, or concealable weapons.
- Used by a champion or heroic warrior. Favors complex, exotic, or specialist weapons, two-handed weapons, and hurlants.
- Used by an assassin or other denied obvious weaponry. Favors daggers, claw blades, and other small concealed weapons; sometimes long hurlants or crossbows.
- Used by knightly duelists or other heavy-armor combatants. Favors maces, hammers, two-handed weapons, stilettos, and other weapons with penetrating Shock.
- Used by archers or ranged combatants. Favors bows, crossbows, hurlants, light spears, short swords, or daggers.
- Used by individualistic warbands. Favors spears and short swords somewhat, but an individual warrior could use anything.
- Used by a high-tech culture. Roll again, but replace bows and crossbows with hurlants, and melee weapons will have advanced-tech stylings.

Use the favored weapon suggestions as guidelines for picking the precise type of weapon the artifact might be. For additional help, you can roll on the adjacent table. If the result is a "favored primary" weapon, then pick one of the favored weapons listed above that would make sense for a main armament. "Favored secondary" are usually short swords, daggers, hand hurlants, or other back-up gear appropriate to the user type. "Favored ranged" is usually a dagger, hand hurlant, light throwing spear, or other secondary ranged weapon, though archers and gunners might prefer heavier weaponry.

The tables lean towards certain weapons that have always been common and favored throughout martial history: spears and short swords. Sorcerers who built weapons for massed bodies of troops will have favored such effective, versatile weapons. Still, the very individualistic nature of most heroic warriors and the unique tastes of prior ages can sometimes result in rather unusual weapon choices. Warriors who find such equipment must sometimes put aside more familiar gear if they mean to master their newfound treasure.

d100	Weapon	d100	Weapon
1–30	Favored primary	72–73	Hammer, War
31–40	Favored secondary	74	Hurlant, Great
41–50	Favored ranged	75	Hurlant, Hand
51–53	Axe, Hand	76	Hurlant, Long
54	Axe, War	77–78	Mace
55	Blackjack	79–80	Pike
56–58	Bow, Large	81–85	Spear, Heavy
59–61	Bow, Small	86–89	Spear, Light
62	Claw Blades	90	Throwing Blade
63	Club	91	Staff
64	Club, Great	92	Stiletto
65	Crossbow	93–94	Sword, Great
66–68	Dagger	95–97	Sword, Long
69–70	Halberd	98–00	Sword, Short
71	Hammer, Great		

Once you have the weapon enchantment, origin, and weapon type decided, you'll want to decide whether or not the weapon might have one or more special abilities. A full list of these abilities is found on the following pages, though you can always make up more of your own or loot them from other old-school compatible games. If you haven't any particular firm feelings about the topic, you can roll on the table below to find out.

Special Weapon Abilities

d12	Minor	Major	Great
1–2	None	None	None
3–4	None	None	One
5–6	None	One	Two
7	None	One	Two
8	None	One	Two
9	One	Two	Three
10	One	Two	Three
11	One	Two	Three
12	Two	Three	Three

With that set, your magical weapon is complete. You might give it some details of appearance and style to set it off, but don't worry about attaching a backstory or other elaborate history to it unless you expect it to become pertinent to your game.

SENTIENT WEAPONRY

While rare, it's not unknown for certain ancient weapons to be possessed of their own intellect and will. This will is almost inevitably directed toward carrying out a particular task chosen by its creator.

Sentient weapons always have at least one additional special ability related to their purpose, chosen by the GM. Some can vocally or telepathically communicate with their bearer, though not all speak modern languages.

Bearer who offend the weapon must make an appropriate Cha/Stab or Shoot skill check against a difficulty of 8 plus the weapon's magical bonus in order to force its obedience for the day. If the check is failed, the weapon is treated as a totally nonmagical example of its type for the rest of the day.

Weapons that have a now-impossible purpose will usually try to reinterpret their function as some kind of task that they can still pursue. While only the most fanatical will demand constant cooperation from the wielder, those bearers who do nothing to aid its purpose or who serve some contradictory power will likely have trouble wielding it.

Rumors persist of even mightier sentient weapons, some of which may not be "weapons" so much as physical manifestations of some highly destructive trans-literal entity. Such beings inevitably have their own plans.

d6 Example Purposes

- 1 Exterminate a type of creature or sentient
- 2 Cast down a particular nation or polity
- 3 Slay a type of criminal or offender
- 4 Protect an institution or class of being
- 5 Further a philosophy or religion
- 6 Encourage a code or behavior in the bearer

MAGICAL WEAPON CREATION COSTS

Like magical armor, forging magical weapons is a costly and difficult process. Certain special ingredients or the fruits of particular adventures might be used to lower the usual difficulty of an enchantment and make it more practical for a PC sorcerer.

Forging a +1 weapon requires a masterwork target object and 12,500 silver, and is done at a difficulty of 10. Each additional +1 bonus doubles the cost and adds +2 to the creation difficulty, to a maximum of +3.

Adding special powers to the weapon is also expensive, more so than imbuing a suit of armor. A minor and specific weapon power adds +1 to the difficulty and 10,000 silver to the cost, while one that's useful in most combats adds +2 difficulty and 25,000, and one that's useful in every fight adds +2 difficulty and 50,000 to the cost.

The secrets of forging self-aware blades are lost in the present day, and recovering them requires both GM agreement and a suitable amount of adventuring.



MAGICAL WEAPON ABILITIES

The following powers are just some of the possible enchantments that might have been wrought into the armaments of ancient days. A sufficiently skilled mage of the present day might be able to modify or add new examples of such powers at the GM's discretion using the magic item creation rules that begin on page 92.

Adamantine: The weapon is imperishable and unbreakable by all conventional and most magical means. Edged weapons never lose their keenness, bowstrings never snap, and the weapon can bear a seemingly limitless amount of weight without bending or breaking. The weapon's damage and hit bonus are both increased by +1, to a maximum of +3.

Augmented: The weapon's enchantment hit and damage bonus increase by +1, up to a maximum of +4.

Baffling: The weapon looks very strange in some way, and its operation is not obvious to onlookers. The first attack the wielder makes during a fight is an automatic hit; after that, the onlookers have seen enough to defend against it normally. The shifting configuration of the weapon allows the same bonus during the next fight, however, even if the foes have seen it in an earlier engagement.

Barring: As a Move action, the bearer can use the weapon to draw a straight, glowing line up to twenty feet long, provided one part of the line is within five feet of the bearer. Enemies must make a Mental saving throw to voluntarily cross the line from either direction with their bodies, weapons, or powers; on a failed save, their attempted action is wasted. The effect ends when a new line is drawn, the scene ends, or the bearer or their allies cross the line with their own bodies, weapons, or powers.

Blighted: The weapon was created to slaughter normal human beings. Against baseline humans, it rolls damage twice and takes the better result. It functions without issues even in the hands of a baseline wielder; its creators were as glad to see inter-cine strife as any other kind.

Bloodbound: The weapon forms a symbiotic bond with the wielder. So long as they are wielding the weapon, they automatically stabilize from any survivable mortal wound and automatically regenerate one hit point every hour as magical healing. Once per day, a failed Physical or Mental saving throw may be re-rolled as the weapon shares the strain on the wielder.

Bloodthirsty: When the weapon's wielder reduces a creature with at least one hit die to zero hit points, they regain 1d8 plus the creature's hit dice in lost hit points. This healing cannot take them above their usual maximum hit points.

Despairing: The weapon drains a victim's courage and hope. By accepting a point of System Strain as an Instant action when they hit a target, they can force

the victim to make an immediate Morale check at a -1 penalty. This effect can be applied to a given target only once per scene.

Devoted: The weapon bonds with the first possessor to pick it up after the death of their last wielder. Until the wielder dies or intentionally discards it, it remains bound to them. Under no circumstances will it or its projectiles harm its wielder, and it can be teleported back to their hand as an On Turn action. The first time the wielder would be reduced to zero hit points during a day, they may accept a point of System Strain to let the weapon leap up and block the damage, assuming the damage is the sort the weapon could block.

Devouring: The weapon bites pieces out of a victim's body or spirit. Damage inflicted by a devouring weapon cannot be healed until the end of the scene, whether by regeneration or other healing abilities. Creatures brought to zero hit points by the weapon are killed immediately and largely dismembered. Every time the weapon kills a living creature, the bearer gains twice their hit dice in points of healing.

Effortless: The weapon is supernaturally handy and easy to use. It has an effective Encumbrance of zero, cannot be unintentionally dropped or disarmed, and will hang suspended in space by the bearer for up to a minute if they should need their weapon hand free for some other purpose during a round. Large Effortless weapons will automatically compact or contort themselves to remain convenient to carry or use in even the most awkward circumstances.

Energetic: When in use, the weapon or its projectiles are wreathed in flame, lightning, killing frost, or some other form of energy. Minor energetic weapons do +2 damage on a hit, while major or great energetic weapons do 1d6+2 additional damage. This bonus doesn't add to the weapon's Shock.

Enervating: The weapon drains the vital energy from those it harms. A creature hit by the weapon must make a Physical saving throw or lose their next Move action. This draining effect can't apply more than once to a creature until their next turn.

Enraging: The weapon ignites a bloodthirsty fury in the bearer. As an On Turn action, the wielder can become enraged. While enraged, they gain a +2 bonus to hit and damage rolls, can reroll any failed Mental saving throws that would stop them from fighting, and can continue fighting for one round after being reduced to zero hit points. Enraged wielders never fail a Morale check. Every round, however, they must either attack someone, seek to get close enough to attack someone, or spend their Main Action to come out of the rage.

Forfending: The first *Screen Ally* skill check the bearer attempts each round is an automatic success. While

they are using the *Screen Ally* action, they are immune to Shock damage and gain a +2 bonus to their Armor Class.

Fortifying: The weapon has a supplementary pool of System Strain; up to three points of it can be accumulated by the weapon in place of its bearer when System Strain is incurred. This System Strain decreases by one point per night. A bearer can benefit from only one of these weapons at a time, and its pool is shared among all its potential users.

Harmonious: As an On Turn action, provided the bearer has not attacked yet this turn, the bearer may target a weapon being held by an enemy; the Harmonious weapon will instantly move to perfectly parry, deflect, or block all attacks that weapon makes against the bearer until the start of their next turn. Conversely, the Harmonious weapon cannot be used to hurt the bearer of the targeted weapon, as it is too perfectly in harmony with their movements.

Hunting: The weapon was fashioned to slay monstrous beasts. Against non-sentient foes, the weapon rolls any damage it inflicts twice and takes the higher.

Illuminating: The weapon casts light up to 60' in radius at the wielder's mental command. By accepting one point of System Strain, the bearer may make the light visible only to them and their allies; such selective light lasts for an hour.

Innervating: A wielder who uses Effort, such as a High Mage or a Vowed, may accept a point of System Strain to gain an additional bonus point of Effort for as long as they carry the weapon. This System Strain cannot be recovered until the weapon is put aside. Only one Innervating weapon can help a bearer at once. If the weapon is dropped or lost for more than an hour, the Effort and any effect it may be supporting are lost.

Longarm: A ranged weapon's effective range is doubled. If it's a melee weapon without the Long quality, it gains it, and if it already has the Long quality, it now extends out to 20 feet.

Lucky: The weapon confers an unpredictable and unreliable luck on its bearer. As an Instant action, they can call on this luck to reroll an attack roll, damage roll, or skill check made during combat, taking the better of the two rolls. They can use this ability only once per scene, and every time they use it, they must roll 1d6 as well; on a 1, the attempted roll fails or rolls minimum damage instead.

Marking: When the weapon harms or even touches a target, the wielder can choose to gain a point of System Strain and activate its marking power. For the rest of the scene, the weapon can strike the target as if they were adjacent, regardless of their distance or any intervening cover. They are also perfectly aware of the marked target's location, speech, and physical actions. The mark ends at the end of the scene, when a new target is marked, or when the marked target gets more than five hundred feet away.

d100	Ability	d100	Ability
1–2	Adamantine	51–52	Nightwalking
3–4	Augmented	53–54	Omened
5–6	Baffling	55–56	Penetrating
7–8	Barring	57–58	Phantom
9–10	Blighted	59–60	Phasing
11–12	Bloodbound	61–62	Piercing
13–14	Bloodthirsty	63–64	Radioactive
15–16	Despairing	65–66	Rampaging
17–18	Devoted	67–68	Rectifying
19–20	Devouring	69–70	Returning
21–22	Effortless	71–72	Sacrificial
23–24	Energetic	73–74	Shattering
25–26	Enervating	75–76	Shieldbreaking
27–28	Enraging	77–78	Shocking
29–30	Forfending	79–80	Shrieking
31–32	Fortifying	81–82	Skittering
33–34	Harmonious	83–84	Skytreading
35–36	Hunting	85–86	Slaughtering
37–38	Illuminating	87–88	Souleating
39–40	Innervating	89–90	Spellcleaving
41–42	Longarm	91–92	Terrifying
43–44	Lucky	93–94	Toxic
45–46	Marking	95–96	Vengeful
47–48	Merciful	97–98	Versatile
49–50	Negating	99–00	Vigilant

Merciful: The weapon never kills any target it reduces to zero hit points; instead, they are immediately stabilized and will awaken an hour later with one hit point. The damage that this weapon inflicts is completely painless and leaves no visible physical marks.

Negating: The weapon feeds on the arcane power of spells and magical weapons used against its bearer. When the bearer is targeted by a magical spell, arcane power, or the special powers of a magical weapon, they may accept a point of System Strain as an Instant action and make a Physical saving throw; on a success, they are unaffected. This save may only be attempted once per instance of effect.

Nightwalking: The weapon allows the bearer to step through shadows, entering one and appearing in another no more than a hundred feet away as a Move action. Even very small shadows will suffice, and one is generally available in any area not devoid of light or objects to cast them.

Omened: Once per day the weapon can provide a yes, no, or unclear answer to a single question asked by a wielder regarding events that could happen to the wielder within the next hour. The weapon's answer is the GM's best estimate of likelihood, and may not



be correct if events play out in an unexpected way. Thus, asking “Will I win this hand of cards?” might result in the GM dicing out the result and telling the PC yes or no based on what will happen should they play, but if the PC knifes their gambling partner partway through the draw the weapon’s answer would no longer apply.

Penetrating: This weapon ignores non-magical armor, shields, or beast hides for purposes of determining Shock susceptibility.

Phantom: As an On Turn action, the bearer can turn the weapon invisible and intangible to anyone but themselves, or revert the weapon to visibility. While invisible the weapon can harm only intangible or immaterial foes, but it cannot be detected or touched by others.

Phasing: The weapon can be tuned to pass through solid obstacles, striking only those objects or targets the bearer wills. Causing the weapon to phase is an On Turn action that adds one point of System Strain to the bearer; until the end of the round, the weapon ignores any armor, cover, or barrier that interposes.

Piercing: This weapon inflicts its Shock damage on everything the wielder attacks with it, even if the target is normally immune to Shock. However, the weapon never inflicts *more* than its Shock damage, whether or not the attack roll hits. If the weapon doesn’t normally do Shock, it gains a base Shock rating of 2/-.

Radioactive: The weapon emits a constant invisible radiance of toxic power. As an On Turn action the bearer can drop or restore the safeguards on the weapon. While unleashed the weapon glows deep blue and everyone within melee range of the bearer, including the bearer, will take 1d10 damage at the end of the bearer’s turn each round unless somehow shielded against radioactivity. Creatures with one hit die automatically die if so poisoned, regardless of the damage roll.

Rampaging: Whenever this weapon kills a creature with at least one hit die, its bearer may immediately make another attack on any target within range. If no additional targets are available, the wielder instead gets an instant free Move action.

Rectifying: The weapon is exceptionally potent against undead, robots, and other synthetic life forms. All damage done to such creatures is rolled twice, with the better number taken. The weapon can affect even insubstantial or otherwise immune entities of that type, and an undead creature killed by this weapon is permanently put to rest barring tremendous powers of revivification or immortality.

Returning: If thrown, dropped, or disarmed, the weapon can be called back to the owner’s hand as an On Turn action. A new possessor becomes the owner after carrying it for at least an hour.

Sacrificial: The weapon’s violence is fueled by the wielder’s own life force. As an Instant action on a hit, the wielder may accept 1d8 hit points of damage; double this damage is inflicted on the target. This damage may be enough to mortally wound the weapon’s own wielder.

Shattering: The weapon can be used to smash inanimate objects and barriers. Once per scene, with one minute of careful preparation, the wielder can break a man-sized hole in a normal exterior wall or up to a foot of stone. If they accept a point of System Strain, they can do so as a Main Action instead, and may do so as often as they have System Strain available. Shattering blows inflict no special damage on animate targets.

Shieldbreaking: The weapon ignores all shields, both their Armor Class bonus and their Shock protection. Non-magical shields are destroyed by the weapon’s attack, whether or not the attack hits.

Shocking: The weapon’s Shock damage is increased by 2 points. If it has no natural Shock score, it gains a Shock rating of 2/AC 15.

Shrieking: At the wielder’s will, the weapon emits an ear-splitting shriek while in use. The wielder and up to a dozen allies are immune to this effect, but others who are within 60 feet of the wielder are unable to hear themselves speak, and spellcasters must make Wis/Magic skill checks at a difficulty of 7 plus the spell level to successfully cast spells without fumbling the incantations. All Instinct checks made within the area suffer a -2 penalty. The shrieking is completely inaudible outside the sixty-foot radius of effect.

Skittering: When the weapon is shot or thrown at a location within sixty feet, the wielder may instantly appear where the weapon was thrown or struck as an On Turn action, provided they do so in the same round. If thrown, they appear with the weapon in their hand. This ability may be used only once per round.

Skytreading: The weapon’s bearer falls gently from any height, becoming immune to falling damage. By accepting one point of System Strain as an On Turn action, they may fly at their full normal movement rate until the end of the round.

Slaughtering: The weapon hideously disjoints its victims. Any target reduced to zero hit points by the weapon is immediately killed and violently dismembered. Any enemies with a Morale score of less than 12 who are within melee range of the slaughtered victim take the weapon’s Shock damage as emotional trauma and horror, even if they’re normally immune to Shock. Weapons that don’t do Shock damage inflict 2 points of damage to these bystanders instead. This weapon cannot be used for less than lethal attacks.

Souleating: While this weapon may or may not devour the actual soul of the target, such as it may be, it channels great vital force to the wielder. Every time they kill a sentient creature with the weapon, they lose one accumulated System Strain point. This effect can trigger only once per scene.

Spellcleaving: At a cost of a Move action and one System Strain gained by the wielder, the weapon can apply an *Extirpate Arcana* spell effect to any target point within range of the weapon. The spell is cast as if by a tenth level High Mage with a total Int/Magic skill bonus of +3. This power can be used only once per scene.

Terrifying: The weapon is wrought with psychic distress, creating an intense burden of fear in those who oppose its wielder. Whenever the wielder does something that provokes a Morale or Instinct check, any targets who can see them must make the check at a -1 penalty. This effect does not stack with multiple weapons, nor does it affect those with Morale 12.

Toxic: The weapon sweats a potent toxin. When it hits a living target, the wielder may accept a point of System Strain to trigger the toxin's effect; the victim

is racked with spasms of torment and cannot speak or cry out while they remain poisoned. Each round they take 1d8 damage at the end of their turn; they can try to throw off the poison's effects by making a successful Physical saving throw at the end of their round. A creature can only be poisoned once by this weapon at any one time.

Vengeful: The weapon will always succeed at any attack roll made against a foe who has harmed the wielder within the past round, assuming success is physically possible. Such vengeful strikes roll damage twice and take the higher roll.

Versatile: The weapon shifts forms to better suit the bearer's need. As an On Turn action, the wielder can give it one of the following qualities it doesn't already have: Subtle, Long, or Throwable. If thrown, it returns to the bearer's hand at the end of the round.

Vigilant: The weapon's bearer cannot be surprised by anyone who is carrying a manufactured weapon. The bearer does not need to sleep, though they do not recover lost hit points or accumulated System Strain without doing so.

CURSED MAGICAL WEAPONS

While rare, it's not unknown for a magical weapon or other piece of occult equipment to be blighted by some curse. If a GM decides that such a risk exists for a particular find, a 1 on a 1d20 roll usually means that the weapon is cursed.

Cursed items have had their magical energies corrupted by time, decay, or the carelessness of their creator. Most of them still appear to be functional, but once used, the damage is usually obvious. A cursed item might be defective, binding, or both.

Defective items have some negative consequence for use, or their power is somehow flawed in its effects. Such items might still be retained as being worth more than their drawbacks. Binding items entwine themselves in the life energy of their wielder, their defective thaumic channels drawing their energy through the unfortunate owner. If the two are separated, the owner cannot recover System Strain and gains one more point each night until the item is returned. If their System Strain rises above their maximum, the deficiency kills them. Sometimes a simple *Extirpate Arcana* spell can disentangle the curse, but other times more elaborate magics or adventures are required to restore the victim's spiritual integrity.

The nature of a defective item's curse is usually something that would make the item dangerous or harmful to use, but not so awful that the party would discard it out of hand. Some suggestions are offered below.

Clumsy: If the bearer doesn't choose to act last in initiative order, they can't use this item or attack with it.

Draining: Each scene in which the item is used, the bearer gains one System Strain.

Enfeebled: The weapon never inflicts Shock, regardless of the wielder's abilities or the target's AC.

Heavy: The item is twice the usual Encumbrance cost.

Ill-Omened: Its bearer always fails saving throws on a roll of 19 or 20.

Infuriating: When carried, the bearer suffers +2 to all social check difficulties and a -1 penalty to the party's reaction rolls.

Mundane: While the weapon may have hit and damage bonuses, it isn't counted as a magical weapon for purposes of affecting mundane-immune targets.

Poisonous: Each scene the user wears or handles the item, they suffer 1d6 damage from its toxic substance or malign radiations at the end of the scene.

Refractory: At the start of each scene in which its bearer wants to use it, roll 1d6; on a 1, it refuses to work for the rest of the day.

Screaming: The item makes a tremendous amount of noise or some other disturbance when used, making stealth impossible and possibly forcing a Wandering Encounter check.

Traitorous: On a natural 1 on an attack roll, the weapon strikes its own owner. If armor is cursed this way, enemies always hit on a natural 1 on the hit roll.



MAGICAL DEVICES

The ancients produced innumerable objects of wonder, the vast majority of them now so much useless arcane scrap due to the ravages of time and the shifts of the Legacy. Some items still maintain useful functionality, however, though these powers often are used in very different ways than their creators anticipated. The list provided here is only a small selection of the possibilities.

Censer of Solid Dreams: When this small censer is filled with flammable substances and lit as a Main Action, it exhales a thick, opaque white smoke. The bearer of the censer can mold the smoke with mental commands, shaping it into any solid, simple object that can fit in a thirty-foot cube. This object is opaque and requires 5 hit points of damage to punch a human-sized hole directly through it. Creatures caught inside the smoke can tear through it with a Main Action. It's sturdy enough to bear the weight of horses and it lasts for the remainder of the scene. The censer can be lit only once per day.

Congeaed Paradox: These thumb-sized black gemstones are mildly painful to touch or look at, as each one contains an impossible duality that has been forcibly reconciled by ancient sorcery. When gripped and broken as a Main Action, the released paradox draws the immediate repression of the Legacy as mundane reality is violently reinforced in the surrounding twenty feet. Within that radius all active magic is immediately dispelled and no further spellcasting, art use, or magical power use can be performed inside it for the rest of the scene. Powerful Workings are suppressed within this zone for the rest of the scene. Creatures reliant on magic for existence take 5d6 damage for each full round they spend inside this radius.

Enough Rope: When found, this appears to be a simple loop of slim silk rope, no more than five feet long. Whenever this rope is actually used, however, it will always be precisely long enough for the immediate task at hand, be that climbing a wall, binding enemies, casting a line over a crevasse, or some other specific use. The rope can bear up to a ton of weight and cannot be cut by non-magical weapons. So long as the owner is touching the rope, they can cause it to untie itself or retract fully back into their grip.

Eye of Discerning Humanity: A jade-colored sphere the size of an eyeball, this device may be pointed at any creature within sixty feet and activated by pressing a small stud. The target will be limned in yellow light if human, green if demihuman, and blue if non-human. The eye's categorization draws on the creator's personal taxonomy, so the result shown may not entirely agree with a user's opinion. Only the wielder can see this light, which lasts for 1d6 rounds. The eye's discernment can penetrate any

d00	Magical Devices
1–2	Guncloud
3–6	Censer of Solid Dreams
7–12	Congeaed Paradox
13–16	Enough Rope
17–19	Eye of Discerning Humanity
20–23	Flask of Devils
24–26	Ghost Horse
27–31	Immanent Beacon Shard
32–35	Implacable Fist
36–39	Jewel Beyond Price
40–42	Key of the Former House
43–46	Lens of the Polychrome Lord
47–49	Lex Talionis
50	Logos
51–53	Lyre of Longing
54–57	Memorious Fragrance
58–62	Purification Salt
63–65	Rain-Beckoning Drum
66–69	Ring of the Sea Princes
70–72	Rod of Repudiation
73–77	Seed of Flesh
78–80	Staff of the Old Lords
81–84	Stonepeg
85–87	Stutterhatchet
88–91	Vessel of Hours
92–95	Vigilant Banner
96–00	Vothite Icon

mundane disguise or magical spell of third level or less. If the GM thinks the subject has a stronger kind of concealment, they may make a secret Wis/Notice skill check against an appropriate difficulty to determine if a true answer is given. The eye can be used once per scene.

Flask of Devils: This brass flask is tightly stoppered and covered with sigils of sealing and dominion. If opened, a hideous devil-thing leaps out of the bottle, having statistics equivalent to a creature called by the *Calculation of the Phantasmal Eidolon* spell on page 68. The devil will demand that its liberator give it a command; that command will be faithfully followed until the scene is over or it is completed. Once finished, the devil will be drawn back into the flask. Each use of the flask adds 1 System Strain to the user; if the devil is killed, an additional 1d3 System Strain is gained by the user and a new devil

will be summoned forth the next time the flask is opened. If this System Strain is sufficient to take the user over their maximum, they're dragged into the flask to become its new devil, lost forever without some heroic labor of rescue. The flask can be opened only once per day.

Ghost Horse: A fist-sized crystal acts as a locus for manifesting a strange, geometric-looking steed of translucent force. The ghost horse can be summoned as a Main Action, and will dutifully and fearlessly carry its summoner and up to two hundred pounds of weight or thirty-five points of encumbrance for up to twelve hours before needing an equal amount of time to recharge. A ghost horse has an effective Move of 60' per action and can cross any terrain a mountain goat or small boat could navigate, moving up to 50 miles in the course of twelve hours. Natural animals shy away from the beast. The ghost horse has an effective AC of 13, 10 hit points, and cannot fight; if destroyed, it collapses back into its locus and cannot be recalled for a week.

Guncloud: This collection of ten silvery discs is intended to be applied to up to ten hand hurlants or one-handed thrown weapons. Once affixed to the weapons, the implements spatially collapse into a single gun or weapon until at least one disc is removed. When the bearer draws the weapon, all the conjoined implements immediately fan out around them in a whirling cloud, remaining within three feet of the bearer without obstructing their actions or vision. The bearer can fire or throw any of the weapons in the cloud as if they were Readied, provided they have at least one hand free. Thrown weapons will return to the cloud after ten rounds or one minute has passed, and discharged hand hurlants will reload themselves ten rounds after being fired, assuming the wielder is carrying ammunition for them. The cloud can be returned to its collapsed state as an On Turn action by the wielder should they sheath or holster one of the weapons. Foes in melee range who want to grab or smash one of the weapons must hit an AC of 16; four points of damage will smash a weapon or knock its disc off, but the guncloud discs themselves are immune to anything short of intentional damage inflicted by a possessor.

Immanent Beacon Shard: Fragments of some unfathomable monolith of congealed natural law, these shards of faceted crystal are usually the size of a short baton. When a user presses the correct facet of the crystal and releases it, the shard remains fixed precisely in that location, even if hanging in mid-air. Absolutely no mundane force can shift or damage the crystal, and even magical powers must dispel the effect at difficulty 12 before the shard can be affected in any way. The person who placed the shard is perpetually aware of its exact location in relation to their present place, and can see and hear

the area around the beacon as if they were standing there. The user can reclaim the beacon at a cost of 1 System Strain, or wait for the effect to wear out and the shard to become movable again a day later.

Implacable Fist: Appearing as a glove, gauntlet, or set of matching rings, an *Implacable Fist* grants its user an inhuman grip strength to the hand that wears it. With a full round to build up its force, it can crush or destroy any mundane material it grips. Magical materials force a Str/Exert skill check against a difficulty of 8 or more to be vulnerable to the fist's effects. The time necessary to focus the strength makes it impractical to use as a weapon in combat or grappling, but if the wearer somehow can get a hand on a helpless or completely restrained target, the grip will destroy any limb it grasps or kill a target whose head or viscera are crushed. The fist can be used at will, but any object carried in that hand has a 1 in 6 chance of being destroyed accidentally by the wearer's reaction to combat or other sudden stress.

Jewel Beyond Price: This small gemstone is impossible to mistake for an ordinary jewel, for it fills all onlookers with an overwhelming desire to obtain it. If found as treasure or plunder, the finders can decide calmly who is to have it, but if it is offered to a person in exchange for some favor or service that some amount of wealth could theoretically compel them to do, the would-be recipient must make a Mental saving throw or agree to perform the act in exchange for the jewel. If they receive the jewel, they will faithfully carry out the spirit of the agreement for at least a week. The jewel's full bewitchment of them will last for at most a week, after which they will be able to think clearly about whether or not the trade was reasonable and worth it.

Key of the Former House: A stylized key, this item may be used as a Main Action to create a shimmering doorway into a prior period of time in which there was an uninhabited domicile in the current location. Those who pass through the doorway enter into this place and time; if they move more than thirty feet away from the other side of the doorway, they're immediately ejected back into the present. The doorway in the present day continues to glow for five minutes after the key is triggered before fading to invisibility, though it can still be passed through from either side. The house on the other side of the doorway is abandoned or empty; it may look more or less normal, but there's a 1 in 6 chance each time this key is used that there is something dangerous there, a toxic environment, or some other hazard. The key may be used once per day, with the doorway lasting up to twenty-four hours before ejecting any remaining interlopers and closing. Each time the doorway closes, there's a 1 in 6 chance the key vanishes, seeking out a new resting place elsewhere.



Lens of the Polychrome Lord: These palm-sized lenses collect and concentrate light into a beam of lethal jewel-colored radiance. If used in direct sunlight, the beam so created does 5d6 damage to a single target within 300 feet, with an Evasion save to negate the damage. If used indoors in ordinary lighting, the effect does 3d6, and if the chamber is dark save for torches or other portable light sources the damage is a mere 1d6. If the lens is used more than once per day, there is a 1 in 4 chance it shatters after each subsequent bolt.

Lex Talionis: These rare magical weapons come in various small, concealable forms, with daggers predominating. They function as ordinary +1 magical weapons in the main, but whenever they cause harm to a target, the victim must make a Physical saving throw. On a failure, both the target and the wielder of the *Lex Talionis* instantly die, with no chance to stabilize. If the weapon is used as part of an Execution Attack, no saving throw is allowed. The weapon then vanishes; some say that it is destroyed by the magical discharge, while others postulate that it simply appears elsewhere to await a new avenger.

Logos: A logos usually takes the form of a fist-sized sphere of luminous crystalline matter, a constellation of tiny lights glowing within. They radiate a sense of endless possibility; no sentient can look on a logos and not recognize it as an object of tremendous power. Only archmages know the full truth of their utility, but persistent rumor speaks of them as critical ingredients in certain rituals of apotheosis, immortality, and reality-shaping. Even the dullest mage can expend a logos as a substitute for 250,000 silver pieces worth of ingredients for creating Workings or magic items. If used to fuel a magic item's creation, no further special ingredients are required.

Lyre of Longing: While these musical instruments often take the form of lyres, other manifestations have been found. When played by a competent musician for at least five minutes, all listeners within thirty feet must make a Mental saving throw or be seized by a great desire for a particular thing or purpose imagined by the player. This longing will not be enough to make them act wholly out of character, but they will perform all normally-conceivable acts in order to obtain the object of their longing, including quarreling fiercely with their fellows if this object cannot be shared among them. The enchantment lasts for the rest of the scene. The lyre can be used this way only once per day.

Memorious Fragrance: Found as an incense stick that somehow never burns out entirely, lighting the Memorious Fragrance as a Main Action allows the activator to spread a subtle haze of scented mist in a twenty-foot radius. The activator may then describe a particular memory that they wish others to have; all within twenty feet except the activator must then make a Mental saving throw or have the memory

implanted in their minds. They may not even realize this memory exists unless something happens that would draw it to mind, or questions are put to them about it. The memory persists until magically dispelled. While the *Memorious Fragrance* can add memories, it cannot change or erase existing ones.

Purification Salt: This small bag contains a never-ending supply of spiritually-purifying salt. If the salt is used to dust an object or weapon as a Main Action, that object can interact with incorporeal entities or spirits as if they were solid for the rest of the scene. If hurled directly at a creature from melee distance, it does 3d6 damage to mages, unnatural magical creatures, or incorporeal beings. If actually consumed by a sentient creature, it fills the imbiber with a sense of guilt and acute sorrow, inflicting 3d6 emotional damage. Creatures reduced to zero hit points regain one point but will attempt suicide. One pinch of salt can be taken from the bag each scene, and any existing pinches evaporate once a new one is taken.

Rain-Beckoning Drum: Sigiled and worked with signs of rule, this hand drum will produce an immediate deluge of rain in a hundred-foot radius around the user when it is beaten rhythmically. The rain lasts no more than one round but will drop three inches of water on all surfaces within the area of effect; if used indoors, the rain issues from the room's ceiling. The drum can be used safely once per week. Each additional time it is used in the same week, it adds 1 System Strain to the user.

Ring of the Sea Princes: A lost empire of sea-going lords has left behind only these loops of polished coral. Someone who wears one will be able to breathe underwater, see clearly out to 120' when submerged regardless of the light level, and they and their belongings are impervious to the chill and crushing pressure of the depths, though not to other sources of cold damage. The wearer's swimming speed is equal to twice their usual movement rate.

Rod of Repudiation: An ancient punishment-tool, this short rod may be used to strike a target in melee as if a *club +1* or used against a helpless target automatically. An affected subject must make a Physical saving throw or have a dully-glowing brand appear on their face. This brand inspires universal, unreasoning loathing in humans and demihumans, causing a -2 penalty to all their reaction rolls and a -2 penalty to all Charisma-based skill checks. Friends, lovers, spouses, and others with close relationships must make a Mental saving throw on first seeing the brand or break off all association with the subject. The rod may inflict such a brand once per scene, and the curse lasts until it is dispelled or the rod is used again on the same target.

Seed of Flesh: A ball of soft, warm skin approximately four inches in diameter, the seed of flesh may be hurled at any surface within thirty feet as a Main Action. If flung with force, the seed transforms into

a perfect duplicate of the creature that threw it, albeit naked and unequipped. It uses the user's attributes, skills, Foci, and other abilities, though it has only 6 hit points and it cannot cast spells or use arts. The duplicate will obey even suicidal commands and will remain active for up to a scene before shriveling back into a ball. It can be used only once per day. If it dies while active, the seed is destroyed.

Staff of the Old Lords: These rods were once carried by certain human viceroys of the Outsider lords. So long as it is carried in one hand, it will automatically jerk to interpose itself before attacks made by human or demihuman foes, making the bearer immune to Execution Attacks or Shock and granting a +2 bonus to their Armor Class. For 24 hours after the staff is last touched, however, the bearer will find it impossible to perform a hostile act against an Outsider without first making a successful Mental save; on a failure, the action is lost. During this time any Mental saves made to resist Outsider spells or abilities must be rolled twice and the worst taken.

Stonepeg: These devices are always found in groups of 1d4+2 pegs, each one appearing to be a glyphed metal rod perhaps a foot in length with a chisel-shaped point on one end. If thrust firmly into a stone or earthen surface, the peg will effortlessly sink into the material and become as firm and fixed as if it were cemented in place. The peg can only be freely removed by the person who sank it into place, otherwise requiring that it be chiseled out with a scene's effort and the correct tools.

Stutterhatchet: This small workman's hatchet has a flat hammer-poll on its opposite side and a blade that cannot be dulled by anything short of intentional effort to damage it. It functions as a *hand axe +1* if used in combat, but when applied to inanimate objects its true function becomes plain. Whatever inanimate matter the stutterhatchet damages, smashes, or cuts will return to its perfect, unbroken state at the next dawn, or sooner if the flat of the axe is tapped against a fragment of it. Fragments or pieces of the object will disappear when the object reforms. If the object is broken into several pieces, it is restored around the largest one, or around the one the wielder taps with the hatchet if it's triggered early. If fragments are burned, melted, or destroyed with equivalent thoroughness they will be missing from the reformed object.

Vessel of Hours: A precious implement most often appearing as a miniature clock, hourglass, incense clock, or some other horological device, this item can wind back time by a few moments. As an Instant action, the bearer can invoke it to undo their actions and any consequences for the immediate turn, resetting their turn back to its beginning. This action cannot be taken after someone else's turn has begun. This object and others of its kind will only work once for any given user.

Vigilant Banner: These enchanted banners bear the insignia of long-vanished armies, and are always found permanently attached to collapsible banner-staves that extend out to fifteen feet at most. When the banner staff is gripped in one hand and held upright, the bearer is filled with vigor and vigilant alertness. They can reroll failed Notice checks to spot approaching creatures or ambushes, they ignore normal extremes of heat or chill, they can see clearly even in perfect darkness, and they cannot be made to fall asleep or become oblivious to their surroundings by sorcery or mundane weariness. A watchman with the banner can stand their post indefinitely while gripping the banner, but they cannot lose System Strain, naturally heal hit point damage, refresh Effort, or restore spell slots for 24 hours after using it.

Vothite Icon: These small paintings, figurines, or symbolic statuettes were designed to influence the most primitive, basic levels of human cogitation in order to impress a particular complex idea on the beholder. Their effectiveness waned with human changes over the ages, but they still have a powerful ability to influence the unwary. When a human or demihuman first sees a Vothite icon within thirty feet of them, they must make a Mental saving throw; on a failure, they lose their next round of action as they struggle to comprehend the alien imperative the icon is impressing on their thoughts. These ideals are so strange and anachronistic that they are almost always rejected, but it takes the full round to do so. The same icon can't affect the same creature twice. Lifting and presenting an icon requires one hand and a Main Action.

ADDING NEW ITEMS

New items can be researched by PCs or drawn from other old-school compatible games with few or no changes. When importing magic items from other games, however, keep a few cautions in mind.

Don't add simple problem-solving items unless you want the problem to be permanently solved. Weightless packs, flasks of everflowing water, portable shelters that always work, and other such "utility" items erase entire categories of challenges. Don't add them unless you're willing to forego using those challenges in your own game.

Don't add simple buff items. If a magic item just adds a bonus to a stat or improves a skill roll, it's not going to induce the players to give any thought to its use or allow any new or creative situations.

Don't add easily reusable damaging items. If the magic item inflicts damage on a target, it should have very limited charges, a chance of destruction, or a strictly limited scope of function. Cheap and common magical damage devalues the martial heroes in a party.



ENCHANTED ELIXIRS

Throughout the ages, there have always been techniques for fixing sorcery inside magical potions, occult salves, breakable clay tablets, or other consumable tokens. These “elixirs” are not uncommon in the Deeps, and even modern mages can often puzzle out ways of duplicating the simpler concoctions.

ELIXIR APPEARANCES

While the conventional elixir is an ounce or two of liquid in an engraved flask, ancient empires and obscure sorcerous traditions often used different methods to contain their magic. All elixirs must be consumed, applied, or destroyed as part of their activation, whether that consists of lighting an enchanted incense stick or tearing a calligraphic charm. Usually such activation takes no more than a Main Action, though some mediums may require an open flame to light them or a stationary target to rub on a salve.

The adjacent table offers some suggestions as to the

d10	The Elixir's Form	
1	Bottled vapor	basic appearance of the elixir, while the table below provides some ideas about traits that would clearly mark out an elixir as something magical or unusual. You should note down this appearance for a given type of elixir; if another dose is found made by the same creators, it probably should look similar to the first. Using a consistent style for elixirs from the same civilization or maker
2	Breakable token	
3	Incense stick	
4	Inhaler	
5	Injector	
6	Inked charm	
7	Jarred salve	
8	Liquid potion	
9	Pill	
10	Preserved edible	

can help add some verisimilitude to your brewing.

d10	The Elixir's Quirks of Appearance
1	Vividly unnatural color
2	Pungent or appealing aroma
3	Strange texture or consistency
4	Metallic or glowing appearance
5	It moves slightly of its own
6	Unnaturally heavy or light
7	Makes a very soft sound
8	Bears imprinted text
9	Abnormally hot or chilled
10	Changes shape regularly

USING ELIXIRS

Consuming a Readied elixir generally requires a Main Action, whether drinking it or applying it to an adjacent object or comrade. Salves and unguents cannot be applied to a hostile or resisting target.

Given the careful packing usually required to keep an elixir from becoming damaged in transit, each one counts as one item of encumbrance when Readied. The GM may allow any reasonable number of these little vials to be cased or wrapped together in a pack without encumbrance costs, but digging these stored ones out individually takes too long to be practical in combat.

IDENTIFYING ELIXIRS

As elixirs do not normally decay with age, there are potions from half a hundred eons to be found in the Deeps and storehouses of the Latter Earth. Identifying the precise effects of a strange salve is a challenge to the most erudite sorcerer unless the creators were kind enough to label the vial in letters that can still be understood.

Apprehending the Arcane Form can give a one-sentence description of the elixir's intended effect. Touching a single drop of the fluid against a user's tongue can sometimes give a hint as well, with a tiny flicker of its effect impressed on the user. Aside from these, someone with the Magic skill can spend a full day in careful analysis of the potion, rolling Wis/Magic or Int/Magic against the potion's creation difficulty to identify its purpose. A given investigator can make only one attempt to identify it.

Useful as these measures are not foolproof. If the potion has magically decayed or been warped by its creator's clumsiness or malice, it will still register as a potion of its apparent type. The unpleasant truth will be revealed only after it is consumed. This factor is not usually a concern for PCs, but those who seek to buy or trade potions must always be wary of false or fouled goods.

CREATING AND OBTAINING ELIXIRS

The item creation rules on page 92 can be used for brewing elixirs. Average creation costs and difficulties are listed on the adjoining table, though these numbers can swell or shrink depending on the prevalence of magic in a particular campaign or region.

Most regions do not have convenient, reliable sales of elixirs. PCs who want to buy potions will usually have to have some personal relationship with a skilled brewer and give them some good reason to take the time and care necessary to concoct such a thing. Regions of firm law and order tend to have rulers that have no reason to allow ordinary people to buy magical artifacts of any kind, and those mages willing to work for coin will need to do their brewing on the black market or sell exclusively to the authorities.

TYPES OF ELIXIRS

The table below provides a weighted range of different elixir types known in the Latter Earth. Others certainly exist. Base creation difficulties and silver prices for each type are also given, but may vary based on the setting.

d00	Elixir	Diff.	Cost
1–4	Anchoring Draught	9	500
5–8	Bestial Form	10	1,250
9–12	Blood of Boiling Rage	8	250
13–15	Bodily Innervation	11	2,500
16–20	Borrowed Flesh	8	500
21–24	Cold Courage	9	1,000
25–28	Congeaed Winter	9	1,250
29–32	Deep Sight	10	1,250
33–38	Energetic Impermeability	9	500
39–42	Inverted Entropy	10	1,250
43–46	Murderous Anointing	9	500
47	Nectar of Immortality	12	50,000
48–49	Nepenthe	11	12,500
50–53	Omened Visions	8	375
54–58	Persistent Luminescence	8	250
59–62	Plasmic Molding	9	500
63–64	Quintessence of the Hour	10	2,500
65–68	Sacrificial Strength	9	500
69–76	Sanctified Healing	8	250
77–79	Scalding Breath	9	500
80–83	Soul Sight	8	250
84–85	Thaumic Vitality	11	2,500
86–90	The Great and the Small	10	500
91–94	Truthspeaking	10	1,250
95–00	Wrathful Detonation	9	250

Anchoring Draught: When a subject drinks this elixir, they become spatially anchored to the place at which they drank it. At any time within the following twenty-four hours, they may teleport back to this point as a Main Action, along with any objects, willing subjects, or incapacitated creatures they are carrying, provided it's within ten miles. This teleportation can be done only once, and if the target point is blocked by a solid object the shift fails.

Bestial Form: The user of this potion transforms into a normal animal of their choice no larger than a horse nor smaller than a rat. Their own attributes and statistics are retained, though they gain the chosen creature's movement modes and speed. Their

belongings meld with them on the transformation, still applying their benefits, but they cannot be removed until the change ends. The transformation lasts until the user ends it as an On Turn action, they die, or the next dawn.

Blood of Boiling Rage: The imbiber of this brew is suffused with a berserk fury. For the rest of the scene, or until the potion's effect is ended, they can roll their attack and damage rolls twice, taking the better result. Every round, however, they must either attack someone physically or try to reach them in order to attack them. If all foes are downed, allies will be targeted next. If the berserker is left alone or wishes to end the rage prematurely, they must spend a Main Action fighting the fury and make a Mental saving throw to end it. On a failure, they must spend their next round raging before they can try again. Berserk subjects have enough presence of mind to use special abilities or do complicated actions in order to kill or reach a target, but they cannot cast spells.

Bodily Innervation: This rare elixir reinforces a living user's body, decreasing their current System Strain by three points. It takes three days for the potion's residue to be fully flushed from a user's system, however, and this potion cannot be used again until it is fully purged.

Borrowed Flesh: When found, these potions fill only half their vials. If several drops of blood are let into the fluid by a willing subject, the subject may transfer up to six of their hit points into the elixir, accepting the damage and healing it normally afterwards. The blood droplets congeal and begin growing into a fleshy slurry once activated. A month later the slurry is digested back into its inert, half-full state, but until that point the brew may be poured on a wounded subject to restore as many hit points as were charged into it. The flesh that mends the wounds is of the same kind and texture as the flesh of the donor, though it will assimilate within a few months afterwards.

Cold Courage: The user of this potion is filled with invincible confidence and perfect self-assurance for the rest of the scene, fighting as calmly in bloody battle as if on a sparring field. When they attack, they roll a skill check instead of an attack roll, at a difficulty equal to half the target's Armor Class, rounded down. They are also immune to any mental effect that would alter their emotions. While under the potion's influence, however, the GM keeps track of their hit points and damage taken, and the player is told only when they hit zero.



Congeaed Winter: These bottles are always extremely cold and relatively fragile; even loosening the stopper provokes a warning twinge of ice in the air around it. When opened or shattered, every water-based liquid within twenty feet is instantly flash-frozen at least a foot deep, all fires are extinguished in that range, and living creatures take 2d6 damage. Against liquid or fiery creatures this damage is maximized.

Deep Sight: This substance allows an imbiber to briefly subconsciously integrate with a Deep's basic structure, gaining an insight into the general layout of proximate areas. The GM gives the PC a map of the four nearest rooms of interest to the PC and instructions on how to get to them. For places with a detailed map, a radius of 100' is discerned. Each room's original purpose is revealed in a few words, though nothing can be discerned of its contents. This elixir will work inside any structure that was intentionally constructed by an intelligent being.

Energetic Impermeability: This elixir confers a temporary immunity to the next harmful energy that would otherwise injure the imbiber within the next scene. This immunity is sufficient to protect the user from any mundane source of this energy, and subtracts fifteen points of damage from each hit by a magical source of that power. Energy forms valid for this potion are thermal, electrical, radiation, or caustic; kinetic energy is not valid, nor are purely psychic or spiritual forms of injury. This protection lasts for one scene, and does not change once it is set by the initial harm it deflected.

Inverted Entropy: This flask contains enough of this fluid to affect one man-sized object. If the target is unliving, it can be restored to full and perfect physical completeness from any degree of damage or destruction, albeit magical qualities are not restored. A living target is restored to their last condition of full physical health, but the neural tissue reset causes them to completely forget everything since that point and maximizes their System Strain. The *Inverted Entropy* can't revert them more than one week. This reversion does not delete experience points, magical effects, or lingering curses.

Murderous Anointing: When this potion is applied to a weapon, it gains a brief semi-sentience dedicated entirely to bloodshed. For the following scene, the wielder can accept a System Strain point to reroll a failed attack roll with the weapon, up to once per failed attack. A weapon affected by this potion cannot be used for less than lethal strikes.

Nectar of Immortality: Grandly named, this liquid offers a nominal prolongation of the subject's natural longevity. Sages speculate that it was once a reward given by the Outsiders to pliant human rulers. Each bottle consumed adds an additional 1d6 years to the subject's healthy lifespan and immediately cures all but the most sorcerously-potent diseases or sick-

nesses. The nectar cannot do more than double the subject's natural lifespan, however, and after each dose a 1d20 must be rolled; on a natural 1, the nectar instead causes the subject to perish in a hideous welter of cancers and rebellious growths.

Nepenthe: This liquid eases a tormented mind and can cure mental illnesses and temper the pain of past traumas. Madness induced by magical causes forces the subject to make a Mental saving throw; on a failure, the draught cannot break the curse. A subject can benefit from *Nepenthe* only once in their life.

Omened Visions: Often a pale blue powder meant to be inhaled, this dust allows the user to explore the immediate future. Their next fifteen minutes will play out in their visions, their actions chosen as they wish and their most probable consequences made evident in the dreamlike fugue, assuming those consequences are evident within the next fifteen minutes. While under the dust's effects the subject is oblivious to the mundane world.

Persistent Luminescence: When this liquid is applied to an object or imbibed, the target begins to glow like a lantern, shining light out to a 30' radius. This glow persists until dispelled or a week has passed.

Plasmic Molding: When applied to a non-magical object no larger than a large door the substance becomes soft and malleable as clay for one scene. At the end of the scene, the material hardens back to its original consistency in whatever form it now takes. If taken by a living creature, they may reshape their own body to a degree, taking any appearance that a creature of their species might naturally have. This alteration lasts until dispelled or the user ends it, but they can't recover System Strain while so altered.

Quintessence of the Hour: When imbibed, the user is prompted to think of a particular time and place in their own past. They are instantly whisked back to a perfect temporal parallel of that time, occupying the body they had at the time for one hour. During that hour they may do as they wish in that time and place, but if they die during that hour, they die in the present as well. At the hour's end their mind is returned to the present time. Nothing that happened in the facsimile remains or has any effect on true reality, but things they learned or observed during that hour may be retained.

Sacrificial Strength: When imbibed, the user is capable of channeling their own life force into the damage they do. One time within the next scene, as an Instant action, they may sacrifice a number of hit points of their choice when they inflict damage on a target. For every four HP sacrificed, the damage done is increased by 1d6, up to a maximum of 5d6. The user must retain at least one hit point, and the bonus damage can be applied to only one target of a damaging action.

Sanctified Healing: This healing unguent comes in dozens of different styles, as the need for it is familiar to many cultures. When applied to a target, it heals $1d6+1$ hit points of damage instantly.

Scalding Breath: The creature that imbibes this fluid can exhale it again as a Main Action to do $4d6$ damage plus their character level to all targets within a cone thirty feet long and wide. Victims can make an Evasion saving throw to halve the damage. Different fluids produce different noxious exhalations, though flame, frost, poison, and lethal radiation are not uncommon finds. Only one breath attack is allowed, and if not made within a scene the potion is wasted.

Soul Sight: If applied to a creature's eyes, this potion causes their vision to become hazy and indistinct, too blurry to read text or make out any details more precise than facial features, albeit not so much as to hinder their fighting ability. They are able to see living or animate entities as glowing colored outlines, however, regardless of the ambient light or their invisibility, and can identify specific individuals by the details of the image. The glow tells the user the subject's current mental state as described in one or two words. The sight lasts for six hours or until the user rinses their eyes.

Thaumic Vitality: A rare and precious potion, this elixir allows a mage to cast one prepared spell within the next scene without it counting against their allowed spells for the day. This force exerts a severe cost on their bodily constitution, however, and they gain System Strain equal to the spell's level after it is cast. If this cost is more than their Constitution can bear, they fall unconscious and wake up in fifteen minutes with maximized System Strain.

The Great and the Small: This elixir will cause the subject to either shrink or grow as they wish, compacting down to a shape no smaller than three inches or expanding to one no larger than twelve feet in

height. Once their size is chosen it remains fixed for the remaining thirty-minute duration of the potion, or until they voluntarily end it. Shrunk characters have an effective Strength of 3 and can't do meaningful combat damage. Their Move rating is also cut by 90%, but they automatically pass all Sneak skill checks unless someone is actively looking for them. Large characters have an effective Strength of 18 and do double damage with melee weapons and Shock, but their large size allows all foes to roll hit rolls twice against them and take the better number. If the character expands in a location not big enough to contain them, they inflict $4d6$ damage on whatever they're expanding in; if it's not enough to destroy the constriction, they are crushed to death.

Truthspeaking: This potion is meant to be applied to a restrained, willing, or helpless sentient target. The user must envision a specific query before anointing the target with the potion. The subject may make a Mental saving throw to resist; on a failure, they tell the user a truthful, undeceptive answer to their question in no more than five sentences. On a success, the user's psychic impression has tainted the elixir, and the target will instead instinctively give the answer that the user thinks is most likely or plausible in the GM's estimation. The user cannot discern the result of the save except by their own good judgment of the answer.

Wrathful Detonation: These flasks are always permanently sealed. When intentionally hurled at a location, they detonate to do $2d6$ damage to all targets within 15'. The magic in the flasks ensures that they always hit the targeted point, provided it's within 60'. Accidental breakage or breakage by an object is insufficient to trigger the magic, which requires human volition to catalyze it. Only one flask can be hurled at a time or the first to detonate will ruin the rest.



CREATURES OF A FAR AGE

A hero of the Latter Earth can expect to find trouble, and that trouble often comes in the form of slaving beasts, cruel bandits, arrogant sorcerers, or monstrous entities from beyond. In this chapter the GM will be given the tools they need to fabricate these terrible enemies, along with a selection of pre-generated foes and creatures specific to the wilds of the Latter Earth.

As with any part of creating a sandbox, a GM should be careful to keep in mind the return on their investment of effort. While it can be excellent fun to generate a host of awful beasts and fell monstrosities to stock your campaign world and populate your adventures, make sure your effort is first put towards those antagonists you expect the heroes to encounter, and only afterwards should you think of fleshing out the world with other creatures and foes. You only have so much time and energy available for your creations so you need to spend it where it will do you the most good.

Fortunately, the chassis of *Worlds Without Number* is built to be compatible with almost fifty years of content created by professionals and enthusiasts alike. The tools in this section only scratch the surface of the possibilities before you when it comes to finding enemies to bedevil your players.

MONSTERS FROM OTHER GAMES

To accomplish this, this game uses an “old school” rules chassis that is fundamentally compatible with many other similar games. These other games may use descending Armor Classes instead of ascending or have a few other differences, but the basic framework of hit dice, Armor Class, attack rolls, damage dice, Morale, and other such numbers work on the same scale.

In particular, monsters from the B/X, BECM1, 1e, 2e, and Rules Cyclopedia editions of the world’s best-selling RPG can be imported with no more effort than subtracting their Armor Class ratings from 20 to get an ascending AC and subtracting their roll to hit AC 0 from 20 to get their attack bonus.

Foes from that game’s third edition, 3.5, 4e, and 5e don’t translate so well due to different hit point and attack scaling, but hints can be taken from their stat blocks, or they can be used as inspirations for generating a similar creature in this game.

Other games such as *Old School Essentials*, *Lamentations of the Flame Princess*, *OSRIC*, *Swords & Wizardry*, *ACKS*, *Labyrinth Lord*, and other games of similar mechanics can also provide monstrous foes for your game.

And, as might be expected, creatures generated for other Sine Nomine games such as *Stars Without Number*, *Other Dust*, *Silent Legions*, *Wolves of God*, *Spears of the Dawn*, or *Scarlet Heroes* can also be pulled over with no more changes than inverting the Armor Class in some cases.

USING MONSTERS IN THE GAME

For many modern games, there are some basic assumptions about how a GM should use and place monsters and foes in their campaigns. While these assumptions may work perfectly well in the kinds of adventures supported by these games, those unexamined habits can be a problem in the kinds of sandboxes that *Worlds Without Number* encourages. A GM who’s going to use this chapter to best effect needs to understand some basic rules about how monstrous foes work in this game.

There are no expected fights per day. Some games assume that the party will have X combat encounters per day, or that a given dungeon should have Y fights in it, or that it’s perfectly normal to place an encounter where the PCs will have no practical solution but to fight their way through it. This is not how this game’s sandboxes work.

Fighting is dangerous. Fighting can and will get PCs killed. Sometimes it is necessary, sometimes the PCs can cook the situation to give themselves a great advantage, and sometimes the PC actions leave no reasonable outcome other than a brawl, but it is always something to weigh carefully.

If you as the GM start planting inevitable fights in front of your newly-minted party, you’re going to be spending a lot of time generating new PCs. An expedition where the PCs infiltrate a Deep, outfox the natives, and carry off their loot without drawing a blade isn’t an anomaly, it’s the picture of a triumphant success. Most adventures will involve combat, it’s true, but it should be combat that the players have decided to engage in or brought on themselves by their choices, not a fight by fiat that the GM’s plans inevitably push them into.

Enemies do not level scale. Just because the party is only first level doesn’t mean that everything they encounter is going to be an appropriate fight for first level PCs. If they insist on going to the Ashblight and marching straight into that fungal hell they’re almost certainly going to die in short order. If they’re veteran sixth-level heroes then the village guards they encounter are not going to magically gain enough fighting competence to individually threaten the PCs. The world will not change to give them an appropriate fight. Part of an adventurer’s art consists of judging opposition logically and reacting sensibly to threats that are too dire to be overcome.

Enemies don’t want to die. Barring the occasional mindless zombie or programmed automaton, enemies have Morale and rational impulses of self-preservation. When they fight PCs, they fight for a reason: defending territory, seeking food, robbing victims, xenophobic hatred, or some other rational motive. They will not fight to the death unless they think they have no choice and they will not fight at all unless they think they can win without unacceptable casualties. And if they are mistaken, they will reconsider rapidly once the killing starts.



CREATING MONSTERS AND FOES

The first step in creating a hideous beast or assigning statistics to some human foe is identifying the particular role they need to fill in your world. What exactly do you need this creature to be? Is this supposed to be some horrifying hell-beast that's devoured a legion of would-be hunters, or do you just need a stat line for an ordinary village guardsman?

In a sandbox campaign, monsters and enemies are not measured in the context of the party. Just because the heroes are green novices at their trade doesn't mean that a monster is going to be any less ferocious, and by the same token a band of hardened veterans won't find their enemies suddenly gaining expertise to keep up with them. The creatures of a sandbox campaign don't care what your party's level is.

Instead, foes in a sandbox campaign are scaled to the world they live in. They have the hit dice, attack bonus, special powers, and general ferocity that makes sense for their place in the world. A village guardsman is rarely ever going to have more than one hit die and a monstrous hell-beast will rarely ever have fewer than eight or nine.

The opposite page includes a list of example stat lines for various kinds of people and creatures. These are not universal truths for every being in the campaign setting, but they're good baselines for what to expect from a given creature. As a first step in building a creature a GM should pick the stat line that fits best the type of foe they need, and then modify it to suit their own purposes.

Note that there's nothing stopping you from putting a guaranteed party-slaughterer in your campaign. If the situation logically requires that such a creature be present, then it ought to be there. If logic requires its existence, however, you should take pains to ensure that the PCs are not forced to actually *fight* the thing. They need to be able to get forewarnings of its presence, or opportunities to flee it, or some means to negotiate with it or hide from it. It's not unfair to populate your world with the creatures that ought to live in it, but it's decidedly unfun to shove hapless PCs face-first into certain death.

The table of example stat lines has several columns, each one listing a particular statistic for the creature.

Hit dice are a measure of the creature's general power, not unlike a level rating for PCs. For each hit die a creature has, it rolls 1d8 for its hit points. Most ordinary humans have only one hit die, while veterans of bloody struggle or ruthless court intrigue might have two, or three, or even more for the most heroic among them.

AC is for the creature's Armor Class. The higher this number, the harder it is to meaningfully hurt the thing. Monsters and wild beasts have an Armor Class appropriate to their agility and the toughness of their hide; 12 or 13 for quick things with leathery skins, up to 15 for very well-armored beasts, or even up to 20 for things with supernatural hardihood. Humans and other sentients usually have whatever Armor Class is granted by the

armor they wear. Some creatures have an "a" annotation with their AC; this just means that the creature wears armor and the AC given is what their usual armor is worth.

Atk is the creature's usual total attack bonus for its hit rolls in combat. For most creatures, this is equal to its hit dice, possibly with a bonus if it's well-trained, exceptionally vicious, or supernaturally powerful. Some creatures have more than one attack, indicated by an "x2" or "x3" notation. This means the creature can attack two or three times with a single Main Action, directing them all at a single creature or splitting them up among nearby foes within reach.

Dmg is the damage done by a successful hit by the creature. If the listing says "Wpn," then it does whatever damage is usual for the weapon that it's wielding. A creature will never do less damage on a hit than it would do with its Shock score, if Shock would apply to the target.

Shock is the Shock damage inflicted by the creature and the maximum AC it affects. Thus, "3/13" means that the creature inflicts a minimum of 3 points of Shock damage on a miss to any foe with an AC of 13 or less. "Wpn" means the usual Shock damage of the weapon being used is applied. Exceptionally powerful or savage creatures might automatically apply Shock regardless of the AC of the foe; such creatures have a dash listed for the maximum AC, such as "3/-". Such damage is always applied unless the foe is immune to Shock.

Move is the distance the creature can move with a single Move action. Some creatures may fly, others swim, or still stranger means of locomotion may apply depending on the beast's nature.

ML is the creature's Morale score. Whenever a Morale check is forced by a situation, the creature must roll 2d6. If the total is greater than its Morale score, it loses its taste for the fight and will retreat, surrender, or otherwise take whatever actions seem best to get it safely away.

Inst is the creature's Instinct score. When confused, infuriated, or goaded in combat, it runs the risk of behaving according to its instincts rather than martial prudence. The details of Instinct checks are explained on page 298.

Skill is the creature's total Skill bonus for any skill checks it makes that are in line with its talents and abilities. If the creature ought to be good at something, it can add its Skill bonus to the base 2d6 skill check. If not, it adds +0, or might even take a penalty if it seems like something it would be exceptionally bad at doing.

Save is the saving throw target used by the creature whenever it's called upon to make a Physical, Mental, Evasion, or Luck saving throw. Unlike PCs, creatures only have a single save target, usually equal to 15 minus half its hit dice, rounded down. Thus, a foe with 3 hit dice usually rolls 14+ to succeed at any saving throw. This score can't be less than 2+, as a 1 on a saving throw always fails.

Normal Humans	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Peaceful Human	1	10	+0	Wpn	Wpn	30'	7	5	+1	15+
Thug or Militia	1	13a	+1	Wpn	Wpn	30'	8	4	+1	15+
Barbarian Fighter	1	13a	+2	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	30'	8	5	+1	15+
Veteran Soldier	1	13a	+2	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	30'	8	3	+1	15+
Skilled Veteran	2	15a	+3	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	30'	9	2	+1	14+
Elites or Special Guards	3	18a	+4	Wpn+2	Wpn+2	30'	10	2	+2	14+
Knight or Minor Hero	4	18a	+6	Wpn+2	Wpn+2	30'	10	1	+2	13+
Warrior Baron	6	18a	+8	Wpn+3	Wpn+3	30'	9	1	+2	12+
Barbarian Warlord	8	16a	+10 x2	Wpn+4	Wpn+4/-	30'	10	3	+2	11+
Mighty General	8	18a	+10	Wpn+4	Wpn+4/-	30'	10	1	+3	11+
Major Hero	10	18a	+12 x2	Wpn+5	Wpn+5/-	30'	10	2	+3	10+
Great Warrior King	12	18a	+14 x2	Wpn+5	Wpn+5/-	30'	10	1	+3	9+

Spellcasters	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Petty Mage	2	10	+1	Wpn	Wpn	30'	8	4	+1	14+
Tribal Shaman	4	10	+3	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	30'	9	4	+1	13+
Skilled Sorcerer	5	10	+1	Wpn	Wpn	30'	9	4	+2	13+
Master Wizard	8	13	+1	Wpn	Wpn	30'	9	3	+2	11+
Famous Arch-Mage	10	13	+2	Wpn	Wpn	30'	9	2	+3	10+

Mages generally have the spellcasting and Arts of an appropriate mage tradition at a level equal to their hit dice and Effort equal to their skill bonus plus two.

Normal Animals	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Small Pack Predator	1	12	+2	1d4	1/13	40'	7	6	+1	15+
Large Solitary Predator	5	13	+6	1d8	2/13	30'	8	6	+1	13+
Apex Predator	6	13	+6 x2	1d8	2/13	40'	8	6	+2	12+
Herd Beast	2	11	+2	1d4	None	40'	7	6	+1	14+
Vicious Large Herbivore	4	13	+5	1d10	1/13	40'	9	6	+1	13+
Elephantine Grazer	6	13	+5	2d8	None	40'	7	6	+1	12+

Unnatural Entities	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Automaton, Humanlike	2	13	+2	Wpn	Wpn	30'	12	3	+1	14+
Automaton, Laborer	2	15	+2	1d6	1/13	30'	12	3	+1	14+
Automaton, Military	4	18	+5	1d10+2	4/15	30'	12	3	+1	13+
Automaton, Warbot	10	20	+12 x3	1d12+5	7/-	40'	12	2	+2	10+
Slime or ooze	6	10	+6 x2	1d8	1/-	20'	12	5	+1	12+
Predator, Small Vicious	1	14	+1	1d4	1/13	30'	7	5	+1	15+
Predator, Large Vicious	6	13	+7 x2	2d6	2/15	40'	9	5	+2	13+
Predator, Hulking	10	15	+12 x2	2d6+3	6/15	30'	10	4	+1	10+
Predator, Hellbeast	10	18	+12 x4	1d10+5	6/-	60'	11	4	+3	10+
Unnatural Swarm	4	10	+6 x3	1d6	1/-	30'	10	5	+1	13+
Outsider Warbeast	8	15	+10 x2	2d6+4	7/15	40'	9	4	+2	11+
Legendary God-Titan	20	22	+20 x3	2d10+5	10/-	40'	10	3	+3	2+



THE BLIGHT AND ITS CONSEQUENCES

In the age of the Latter Earth, manipulation of the mental and biological substance of living creatures has been a commonplace for all recorded history. From the most distant day of the Terran Mandate through the rule of the Outsiders and the rise of the sorcerer-kings thereafter, there have always been artificial and arcane ways to mold the offspring of living creatures and imbue them with qualities chosen by the artificer. As with any mortal power, this ability has been richly abused.

The Blight is not a single process or a specific curse. It is the term used to refer to the afflictions resting on those scarred by the malice of ancient god-mages, brutal tyrants, Outsider scientists, or sheer magical mischance. It wears many faces and is expressed in many ways, all turned toward the purposes of the creator and all indifferent to the suffering of those who bear it.

Many monsters and implacably hostile sentient species are the direct result of the Blight. Many creatures that make no evolutionary sense are products of the Blight, created in order to serve purposes that no longer obtain in the Latter Earth. Others are penal beasts shaped from the losers of wars, fallen noble houses, criminal families, disfavored polities, or those prey to the whims of some long-lost Imperator.

Intelligent Blighted usually have minds severely influenced by their curse. Martial species might have a psychopathic indifference to the suffering of others, while slave-species might find it emotionally traumatic to refuse orders. Spite-born monsters might feel visceral pleasure at torment and killing, while implement-races might be unable to feel joy at anything but their task. Blighted societies are always marked by such mental burdens.

The Blight is not perfectly consistent in its effects. While the Anak are a species of savagely violent humanoids, not every Anak is driven by the same inexorable impulse of rage and hatred for humanity, nor is every hulking Drudge equally given to stupid docility. The fate of such sports is rarely a kind one in a world little-equipped to distinguish them from their brethren.

Given the nature of players, it may be that some of them will want to cure a creature's Blight or reverse the effects of some particularly heinous curse. Such work is always difficult, demanding, and dangerous; to undo the Blight in a creature is to rebuild its mind and body from the ground up, altering it in a way just as profound as the original inherited change. Still, particularly heroic adventurers might be willing to go to the extremes necessary to find the keys needed to unlock these ancient shackles.

As the GM, you can use the Blight to explain the existence of monsters that otherwise would be very difficult to justify. Creatures of sheer inhuman hatred, monsters that feed on terrible things, and beasts that have purposes utterly inimical to humanity could all be Blighted creatures born of some ancient curse or a forgotten god-emperor's dream.

d8 What Was the Creator's Intent?

- 1 **Decay:** The changes were not Blighted at first, but time and decay of the Legacy has fouled them and made them a burden.
- 2 **Error:** The creator never intended for things to work out as they have, but was either blind to the consequences or mistaken in them.
- 3 **Hedonism:** The creature provided some aesthetic or sensory pleasure in its new form, despite the cruel burdens of its shape.
- 4 **Mischance:** There was no single creator, as the Blight was a consequence of a magical accident or unexpected environment.
- 5 **Punishment:** Its ancestors offended a god-like entity that laid a scourge on them and all their heirs.
- 6 **Sadism:** The creator simply found it funny or enjoyable to condemn the creature's lineage to everlasting suffering.
- 7 **Spite:** The creature was a weapon against the creator's enemies, and its own survival or happiness was of no importance.
- 8 **Utility:** The creature's lineage was meant to perform a kind of labor, and molded to that end with no concern for its own well-being.

d12 Example Blighted Qualities

- 1 It can't control a violent or destructive impulse.
- 2 It sickens normal creatures or has some other negative effect on them when in proximity.
- 3 It's unnaturally repugnant or ugly.
- 4 It's stupid, feeble, clumsy, or otherwise physically or mentally debilitated.
- 5 It has a loathsome craving or impulse that drives its actions.
- 6 It's helplessly obedient or submissive in a way that causes it misery.
- 7 It's shape has been altered to be useful for its purpose, though burdensome to it.
- 8 It suffers constant pain or discomfort of some sort, whether intense or minor.
- 9 It can reproduce only under difficult to obtain circumstances.
- 10 It xenofoms its surroundings to suit some long-dead creator's native world.
- 11 It has an intrinsic mental illness.
- 12 It must pursue a goal that is now impossible.

MONSTER SHAPES AND APPEARANCES

If you don't already have a clear idea of what your monster should look like, these tables can offer some suggestions.

First, find out what animal it most resembles. If you need to fill in details of the creature's appearance, use this as a baseline default.

Next, roll or choose its basic body plan. Intelligent creatures usually have some manipulatory appendages, but they don't necessarily have to be bipedal.

Then figure out how the creature hunts in its natural habitat, if it's not intelligent and thus capable of farming or herding its prey. For monstrous creatures, you might also roll or pick to find out why it hasn't denuded its surroundings of food and starved to death yet, or why it hasn't destroyed the local ecology with its depredations.

Lastly, you can spice this basic plan up with rolls or picks from the characteristic body part table below. Feel free to mix in insectile parts on a basically serpentine creature, or blend in exotic elements into a conventional mammal. Between Outsider interference and the caprice of sorcerer-kings, all manner of forms are possible.

d10 How Does It Usually Hunt?

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Stealthy stalking and ambush of its prey |
| 2 | It steals the kills of other creatures |
| 3 | It hunts in packs or family groups |
| 4 | It uses some unnatural power to catch prey |
| 5 | A partnership with another kind of beast |
| 6 | It feeds on carrion and the very weak |
| 7 | It chases down its prey in open pursuit |
| 8 | It disguises itself as something harmless |
| 9 | It blindly eats whatever it encounters |
| 10 | It lures in its prey with some kind of bait |

d12 What Kind of Animal Is It Most Like?

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | Apish: Distorted humanoid outlines |
| 2 | Arachnid: Webs, many limbs, many eyes |
| 3 | Avian: Feathers, beak, talons, light weight |
| 4 | Beetle-like: Rounded body and armor |
| 5 | Canine: Muzzle, tail, paws |
| 6 | Equine: Hooves, speed, manes |
| 7 | Feline: Fangs, claws, litherness |
| 8 | Piscene: Googly eyes, scales, fins |
| 9 | Reptilian: Frills, side-slung limbs, scales |
| 10 | Serpentine: Limbless, venomous, slim |
| 11 | Ursine: Broad body, thick hide, claws |
| 12 | Wasp-like: Wings, narrow thorax, sting |

d8 What Is Its Basic Body Plan?

- | | |
|-----|---|
| 1 | Limbless, amorphous, or a tentacular mass |
| 2-3 | Bipedal, generally upright |
| 4-7 | Quadrupedal, perhaps able to rear up |
| 8 | Sexapedal, perhaps with wings and legs |

d6 Why Isn't It Dead Yet?

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | It requires very little food for survival |
| 2 | It's poisonous and repels its predators |
| 3 | It eats something other creatures can't |
| 4 | It's newly introduced in the area |
| 5 | It doesn't need food in a normal sense |
| 6 | It exists in symbiosis with something else |

Characteristic Body Parts or Creature Elements

d12	Mammalian	Insectile	Reptilian	Avian	Piscene	Exotic
1	Thick fur	Compound eyes	Poisons	Feathers	Scales	Tentacles
2	Tail	Stings	Slitted eyes	Beak	Bulging eyes	Sacs
3	Paws	Mandibles	Fangs	Talons	Fins	Wheels
4	Hooves	Spinnerets	Scaled skin	Light body	Suckers	Balloons
5	Hands	Swarms	Silence	Songs	Tentacles	Tendrils
6	Fangs	Membrane wings	Draconic wings	Bright colors	Pincers	Launchers
7	Claws	Egg sacs	Thick hide	Sharp eyes	Rubbery hide	Treads
8	Visible ears	Blood-sucking	Crawling	Eggs	Huge maws	Jets
9	Stenches	Parasitizing	Cold-blooded	Diving	Water jets	Secretions
10	Leathery hide	Larval forms	Camouflage	Flocks	Slime	Translucence
11	Bat wings	Leaping	Crushing jaws	Regurgitation	Spines	Alien smells
12	Horns	Numerous legs	Wall-climbing	Guano	Mineral deposit	Unliving matter



MONSTROUS DRIVES

What makes a creature monstrous is not necessarily what it *is*, but what it *does*. Something about the creature's behavior or wants is anathema to human interests, and its activities bring misery, suffering, and death to the people around it.

It may be that your "monster" isn't particularly dangerous to humanity. It may just be an odd creature that exists in a particular environment, of no special danger to humans who don't get in its way. There's a great deal of fun in creating strange beasts for a campaign world, and there's nothing wrong with making the occasional creature like this.

Even so, the usual point of making monsters for a game is to make problems for the players. Ravaging beasts, hideous raiders, sinister and insidious threats from within... these sort of creatures spark the conflicts, problems, and complications that make for usable adventure grist.

The table on the facing page gives twelve different kinds of malevolent drives that might motivate the creature. Bestial entities might not be capable of pursuing the more intellectual forms of evil listed there, but intelligent monsters will carry out their purpose with every ounce of wit they have. Monsters usually have some magical or unnatural power useful in fulfilling their drive, such as those discussed on page 288.

When choosing a drive, it's important to tie it back to the creature's origins and nature. Beasts formed or

warped by the Outsiders might have any kind of malevolent purpose, having had it impressed upon their psyche by their embittered alien creators. Entities forged by other groups or by the whim of nature will likely have drives related to that group's purposes or the circumstances of the natural accident that created its kind.

A GM may want a monster to be somewhat ambiguous in its moral status; maybe terrible in some ways, but the kind of creature that the party could negotiate with or at least tolerate that it live. The awfulness of the drive can be toned down in such cases to a nastiness that is bearable by the players. A good deal of judgment is necessary in hitting this golden mean, however. The GM will have to keep in mind that some kinds of activities may be utterly intolerable to the party, and they might not find that out until after the adventure is underway.

A monster's drive should likely be horrible, but it's important to be careful when selecting the details of that horror. A GM should likely stay away from overtly sexual forms of monstrosity unless their group is explicitly on board with those elements in their games. Very few players are interested in participating in that kind of magical realm without clear advance sign-on, and there are plenty of other ways for a being to be awful.

Remember also that monsters rarely play well with others. Two hideous hell-beasts in the same territory either don't know the other's there, have found some *modus vivendi*, or are probably trying to kill each other.



d12

Monstrous Drives

- 1 **Conquest:** it needs to destroy all rivals and interlopers within its territory, which must expand with the creature's increasing might. This may be a very literal form of conquest, with the beast seeking to kill any intruder within its realm and probing outward constantly to seek new land. It may also be social or metaphorical, with the creature seeking to become the exclusive power within a social sphere, profession, guild, or skein of relationships.
- 2 **Construction:** it has to build something that can cause problems for humans. It might be driven to create elaborate nests, forced to foment treacherous schemes against humanity, made to build large civil structures in awkward places, manufacture a particular sort of good beyond all need, generate a toxin or miasma, xenoform terrain to fit its alien creator's home world, or some other act of troublesome creation.
- 3 **Consumption:** it needs to eat something that is either difficult to acquire, greatly troublesome to humanity, or magical or metaphorical in nature. It might consume loving relationships, eat youth, dine exclusively on traitors, be impossibly gluttonous, devour magical items, or need special alchemical mixes.
- 4 **Deception:** it must feign some harmless or innocent guise, fitting in perfectly as its adopted role. Animals may seem to be some different, more docile creature, while intelligent beings may masquerade as humans or adopt some specific social role. It must kill whatever it would replace, and destroy anything or anyone that might threaten to reveal the truth about it, showing the reality of its nature only when it feeds or enjoys the benefits of the role it has adopted.
- 5 **Defilement:** it must degrade and destroy those things that give hope or meaning to humanity. Corrupting religions, poisoning food crops, curdling familial love, inducing leaders to become tyrants, and withering bonds of loyalty might all be tools for such creatures. Most of them will have a particular type of good thing that their powers and nature enable them to debauch.
- 6 **Destruction:** it must destroy something that is useful or necessary to humans. It might blindly slaughter livestock beyond all hunting need, instinctively seek the destruction of man-made edifices, have an inherent compulsion to destroy loving relationships, eat metal tools and weapons, consume the health and luck of its prey, or otherwise take away something that humans need.
- 7 **Domination:** it needs to win the slavish submission of its chosen prey. Rather than killing them, they must be reduced to helpless obedience to the creature's needs and wishes. Animals may terrorize sentients until worship or tribute is offered, while intelligent beings might use social tools or threats to force compliance. Weaker creatures of its own kind might be treated with similar brutality.
- 8 **Parasitization:** it has to subvert and suborn humanity or something humans rely upon. This may be a physical act of parasitization on a human host, or it may be a more metaphorical leech, taking advantage of some quality of human society to feed and shelter it. Parasitized hosts may be hollowed-out skinsuits, helplessly enslaved victims, willing but foolish co-conspirators, unwitting cattle, or humans who can provide some special service or quality the creature craves.
- 9 **Predation:** there's something that it absolutely must hunt or kill, and pursuing them is a need at an instinctive level. This is usually something problematic for humans, such as a compulsion to hunt humans, specific types of people, livestock, particular demihumans, people who have committed a particular type of act, those who trespass on its territory, or some other type of victim.
- 10 **Reproduction:** it has some unique or difficult condition for reproduction that it must satisfy, such as needing large amounts of a particular substance, a properly-built nest, a difficult-to-win mate, a helpless parasitized host, the brutal conquest of its rivals, or even some magical or esoterically metaphorical condition. This condition causes problems for humanity around it.
- 11 **Sadism:** it was created not necessarily to kill its prey, but to torment it. Terrifying taunts, senseless cruelty, and abominably awful methods of harm are employed instinctively by this creature, and it will always prefer to leave its prey alive until every ounce of resistance has been wrung from it. It receives great delight from the suffering of others.
- 12 **Theft:** it has a compulsion to steal something that humans need in order to hoard or use it itself. It may compulsively steal and collect gold and other shiny objects, plunder food, carry off large amounts of some socially-necessary good, or have magical means to take away intangible qualities or social relationships. It should often be possible to recover the lost traits if the creature is subdued.



UNCANNY POWERS AND ABILITIES

A basic stat line for a creature can make it a challenge in combat, but foes who can do nothing but stab, bite, claw, or shoot can become a little stale in play. More significantly, the unusual powers a creature possesses can often be the very things that make it an interesting element of a situation, allowing it to change the environment or shift the circumstances in ways that the PCs may not be equipped to handle.

Even perfectly normal humans might have “powers”, in the sense that they may have specialized forms of magic, unique martial techniques, or other focused abilities that can be represented by powers. Arch-arcanists and veteran heroes might all have their own selection of special tricks to bring out, ones that the PCs may never have seen before. These abilities are usually unique to the NPCs, as they might require sacrifices or special circumstances in order to acquire them that the PCs aren’t equipped to make or find. The abilities a PC gains as they develop their powers are simply one set of arts and talents in the Latter Earth, and not all NPCs will share the same rules for their own powers.

For a GM, there are two classes of powers to keep in mind when building a creature. Combat powers are those abilities that are likely to come out in a fight, the special abilities and unique martial talents that might make the creature an unusual handful during a clash. Situational powers are less combat-specific abilities that are still likely to play a role in how the creature acts or how it carries out its ambitions. The same power might have both combat and situational uses; the ability to implant overwhelming psychic urges could be handy both in a fight and when manipulating hapless NPCs in a noble’s court.

When building a creature, start with its monstrous drive or the basic role it’s meant to play in the world. In some cases, the creature’s native abilities will be sufficient to allow it to pursue its drive; if it’s a creature born to tear humans asunder, a high attack bonus and multiple attacks may be all it needs to do its job. If it’s a psychic assassin programmed to fight a war that ended eons ago, however, it may need some more esoteric powers to carry out its purpose. In the same vein an ordinary village guardsman or common sorcerer might not need any special tricks, while some martial virtuoso or alien wizard might need some unique abilities to exhibit their specialness.

First, pick a power that will let them pursue their drive or demonstrate their nature. This power should be very characteristic to the creature or NPC; it should be something that really makes clear what the entity is about. This may be a situational power, if the creature’s drive is more abstract or non-martial in nature, or it might be a combat power if you want to emphasize the creature’s ferocity or the peril it presents.

Point Total	The Creature’s Degree of Power
0	Perfectly ordinary beast or person
2	Minor hero or significant mage
3	Minor magical beast or construct
4	Species of magically-potent sentient
5	Significant magical beast or being
6	Major hero or famous mage
8	Hero of a magically-potent species
8	Regionally-significant magical beast
10	Legendary magical beast
10	Legate or famous major hero
15	Imperator or other demi-divine being

Second, pick another power that fits the creature’s idiom or purpose. If the initial power you chose was a combat power, pick a situational one, or vice-versa. The goal at this point is to give the creature something remarkable it can do both in and out of combat.

Third, decide whether or not you need this creature to be a major combat foe. If you foresee a fight with this thing being a major event in an evening’s play, you may wish to add one or two more combat powers to its selection, each preferably of a different kind or flavor. More than three powers are rarely useful because most fights will be resolved before a whole host of abilities can be trotted out. Even so, if you foresee the creature lasting a long time in a fight, you might add a further power or two.

The tables that follow offer some suggestions for various kinds of combat powers. Combat powers are given a point cost to reflect their general puissance; this is by no means a scientific measurement, but it can help give you a rough idea whether you’re giving a weak or potent ability to a creature. For combat powers, you can use the above guidelines for determining how many total points of abilities you might add to a creature. You can ignore these guidelines whenever you have a specific need.

For situational powers, the GM should simply give the creature the ability it needs for its role, and not worry about point costs. These abilities are as strong as they need to be to let the creature fulfill its purpose. The specific details of how far they stretch should be chosen based on the creature’s overall power; a minor being’s mind-bending powers might extend to only one person at a time, or last only a day and a night, while some arch-abomination might be able to beguile half a city for the rest of their lives. Because these powers aren’t really meant for use in combat, you don’t need to worry too much about making them balanced for a fighting encounter.

DAMAGE INFLICTION POWERS

The creature hurls bolts of energy, wields eldritch forces, or has a remarkably unpleasant bite. As a Main Action, it can target one or more foes with some power that inflicts direct damage. In the case of venomous bites or blighting bolts of cursed energy some additional penalty might be applied, taken from the example debilitating effects later in this section. In such cases, whatever hit or save requirements that are applied to the damaging power should be applied to the debilitating power as well.

Most creatures should not have special powers that do more dice of damage than the creature has hit dice. Thus, a beast with 5 HD probably shouldn't be doing more than 5d6 damage with its flaming breath, unless you have an especially good reason to make it so.

Most damaging powers require the creature's Main Action to trigger them. If they can use it automatically in addition to its normal activities, the power is worth an additional 2 points.

A creature usually needs no more than one damage infliction power, though exceptionally powerful creatures might have one ability that works to hit a single target and another, weaker attack that affects an area. Whatever energies or forces the creature uses to hurt targets should be in line with its own nature. A martial hero might deal a crushing overhand blow, while a psychic mind-devourer might inflict lethal emotional trauma on a victim.

MOVEMENT POWERS

The creature has a special movement ability uncommon to its nature. Any ordinary animal might have a movement rate of 40' per Move, or even 60', but this creature has a degree of speed or supernatural agility that is remarkable for something of its kind.

These movement powers aren't meant to assign costs to a creature's natural mode of movement. Birds don't need to allocate points to flying, nor do fish pay to swim.

Some traditions of lightly-armored warrior NPCs might have picked up tricks from this list, or mounted knights and heroes might have some power here so long as they remain safely on horseback. Sorcerers and arcanists might have mastered some of the more esoteric means of locomotion.

Points	Damage Infliction
1	A power does damage equal to a normal weapon blow
2	A power does damage of about 3d6
3	A power does damage of about 6d6
5	A power does damage of 10d6 or more
-1	The power only works in melee range
-1	The power's damage allows a save for half
x½	The power's damage allows a save for none
x2	The power's damage is done to multiple targets
x2	The power's damage is ongoing, repeating in full or part for several rounds
-1	The power's damage requires a hit roll
2	The power can be used once per round as an On Turn action

Points	Movement Powers
2	Flight ability at its movement rate, including the ability to fight on the wing
2	Passes through any solid object
1	Ignores a type of solid barrier substance
2	Extra Move action each round
1	Movement increased by 50%
1	It makes Fighting Withdrawals as On Turn actions
1	Can leap its full movement rate
1	Can swim, climb, or navigate some other usually-troublesome medium at full speed
2	It can teleport at its movement rate
2	Can teleport long distances through shadows, flame, or other characteristic substances
1	Gets a free Instant Move action when some characteristic event or circumstance obtains
1	It can split its Move action's movement around its Main Action



DEBILITATING POWERS

The creature has some power to debuff or neutralize its enemies. While it's possible to just give a creature the power to apply a numeric penalty to people, it's often more interesting to give it the ability to cripple particular types of action or create serious trade-offs in employing common maneuvers. A serious penalty to melee strikes is more interesting than a minor penalty to hit rolls in general. The point of the debility should be to force the victim to handle the encounter in a way they may not be optimized or perfectly prepared to execute.

Debilities are usually delivered automatically as part of a successful attack by the creature or as a separate Main Action power that allows the victim a saving throw to resist or mitigate the effect. Particularly brutal debuffs might just automatically be applied to anyone near it.

Some debilities take a victim out of a fight completely. They become paralyzed, immobile, unconscious, incapable of fighting, or otherwise zeroed out of the fray. Most of these should last only 1d4 rounds unless you intend for the creature to be a potential party-killer.

Debilities normally end after the fight, but some creatures may have the power to inflict lasting curses on their enemies. Such maledictions might only be able to be lifted by the creature itself, forcing victims to either cooperate with it or suffer until they can find a mage mighty enough to undo the blight.

AUGMENTING POWERS

Just as some creatures can debuff their foes, others can boost their own abilities or the abilities of their allies. And likewise as with buffs, it's important that the boost be tied to some particular situation or thematic quality rather than just being a short-duration bonus the thing triggers at the start of the fight.

Augments are a chance for you to say something about the creature's nature; when it's in a particular situation or has a particular resource, it gets significantly stronger. This trigger should be something the creature can engineer or obtain, usually as part of its drive, and it should also be something that clever PCs can deprive it of or catch it away from.

Most augmenting powers last as long as the trigger is in effect. Very potent ones might last only 1d4 rounds or some other short period. Buffs applied to minions and slaves should generally be tied to their service to the creature or to their hapless submission to its will; as long as they remain slavishly bound to it, they'll get the "benefits" of its largesse.

The augmenting powers exemplified here have mostly to do with combat, but there's no reason that the creature's abilities couldn't grow in less martial directions. A monster might become impossibly persuasive when it knows a guilty secret, or be able to take the face of anyone whose blood it's tasted.

Points	Debilitating Power
1	Melee or ranged attacks must be rolled twice and the worst hit and damage used
1	Lose a Move action for the round
3	Suffer paralysis, unconsciousness, or other fight-ending status after being hit twice with this ability. 5 points if only one hit is needed.
2	Suffer 1d6 damage/2 HD of the creature when you do a common type of activity
2	Lose a Main action for the round
2	Become unable to cast spells or use arts for 1d4 rounds
1	Suffer double damage from the creature
+1	The power applies a -2 penalty to any saves against it.
x3	The power automatically affects all foes around it, with a save to resist
x2	The penalty lasts longer than just the scene
x½	The power is only usable 1-3 times a fight
x2	Use the power as an On Turn action once per round

Points	Augmenting Power
1	Gain an extra normal attack
1	Double an attack's normal damage or Shock
2	Gain a bonus Main Action
1	Regenerate its HD in lost hit points each round until you're slain
1	Gain a +4 bonus to AC or become immune to Shock
2	One attack per round becomes unavoidable
1	Become immune to certain general types of spells and magical effects
3	Gain an entire bonus round of action
2	Automatically succeed at one save per round
+0	The buff trigger lasts only a short while or is difficult to arrange
+1	The buff trigger either lasts a long while once achieved or is not hard to make happen
-1	The creature has to work continuously to maintain or obtain the trigger situation
x2	The buff is normally in effect, either because it's intrinsic or very easy to trigger

INTRINSIC POWERS

Some monsters simply have a number of special abilities by virtue of what they are. These special powers usually are applied as Main Actions, though some of them trigger automatically when they are hit or when they hit a target. Powers that harm a victim apply automatically on a hit, while those that don't require a successful hit in combat usually allow for a relevant saving throw to negate or mitigate the effect.

Spellcasting monsters that use the usual Mage rules for learning, preparing, and casting spells don't pay extra points for the ability. In order to actually use their powers in combat they're going to have to have a heavy screen of allies between them and the party's warriors, and you've probably given them fewer hit dice or a worse AC to reflect their lack of armor. Their spellcasting abilities are equal to a Mage of a level equal to their hit dice, with a maximum effective level of 10.

Some monsters use powers that simply behave like a particular spell. It's easier to say "This creature can use a power like *The Coruscating Coffin* once per scene" than to write out a lengthy description of something that works about the same way. These "spells" are bought individually based on the level of spell they emulate, and can be used once per scene. Using them more often increases their cost.

Thematic abilities related to the creature's nature may or may not merit a cost in points. Abilities the creature would need just to survive in its usual environment aren't normally worth adding a point cost. A flame spirit's immunity to fire damage, for instance, is self-evident if its natural habitat is a volcanic caldera. If the ability is a perk that they could conceivably live without, you might charge them an appropriate price.

Points	Intrinsic Power
2	Use a first or second-level spell equivalent
4	Use a third or fourth-level spell equivalent
6	Use a fifth level spell equivalent
x2	Use a given spell equivalent at will
x½	Use a given spell equivalent only when the situation is thematically appropriate or a specific trigger situation applies
+1	Use the spell equivalent as an On Turn action at most once per round
1	Use a Mage art equivalent once a scene
2	Use a Mage art equivalent at will
1	Gain the benefits of one level of a Focus
2	Be immune to a general class of weapon: piercing, slashing, crushing, or the like
3	Be immune to non-magical weapons
6	Require a specific type of weapon or form of injury to harm it
1	Be immune to an uncommon harm like poison, frost, or electricity
2	Be immune to a fairly common harm like fire or mind-affecting magic
3	Be immune to an entire large class of material, such as metal, plant matter, or directly damaging spells
1+	Inflict a particular debuff or damage on someone who hits you with a save to avoid it; add the harmful power's cost to this



CONTEXTUALIZING YOUR MONSTERS

The Latter Earth is a world at the end of countless eons, a realm crushed beneath the burden of innumerable lost empires and forgotten civilizations. More conventional fantasy campaign settings often have a similar weight of age behind their present days, with glorious past kingdoms providing much of their current magic or present problems. A GM often wishes to contextualize their monsters, making them feel part of this ageless past.

The key to connecting a creature to the world is to give it context. A creature cannot borrow any sense of external meaning or significance without some kind of externality to connect to it. By itself, a dog-beast with an insatiable craving to betray and devour its owner is no more than a whimsical inversion of the loyal hound trope. If it bears the milky jade eyes of the agents of the Eternal Revolutionaries, that mere oddity now makes sense; of *course* a creature fashioned by a throne-breaking rebel uprising would behave in such a way.

The players may know nothing of the Eternal Revolutionaries. They may not ever learn anything about them, or they may not connect the similarities between the jade eyes of the dog-beasts and the perfect jade spheres they discover in the defiled resin sarcophagi of the emperor-wasp hive they're exploring. This is perfectly acceptable, so long as *you* know about the connection. If the players end up caring about it, they can investigate the matter and you can develop the connection as deeply and in as much detail as your adventuring sessions require. If they never bother, you don't need to waste your time elaborating on the link.

Whenever you create a new creature, give it some kind of link to its context. Identify the civilization or group that created it, or tie it to a particular ancient site, or weave it into the society or development of the local human communities. Connect it to something the players do or could theoretically care about. If you give your creatures some kind of coherent context within your world your players are going to notice it, even if they never probe the details of those connections.

Monsters have consequences, and those consequences should show in the world. It's all too easy to plant some hero-butcherer abomination half a day's stroll from a border village and never think about how it might interact with the locals. A simple "It eats them." may be perfectly true, but how do the local humans deal with that? Do they try to placate the thing, or hunt it, or avoid its territory? Is this some inherited curse, an ancient problem that's existed for so long that the community's society has healed up around it and formed some kind of mechanism for dealing with it?

It may be that the way humans deal with a type of creature is deeply connected with some past situation. The villagers might shun the monster's territory and have a taboo against trying to hunt it because in ages past, it was actually a slave-abomination raised by a wizard in

order to protect their lands from a now-long-dead enemy. The truth might have been forgotten since then, only for the PCs to discover scraps of lore that hint not only at the truth, but at the mechanisms by which control over the creature can be regained.

The adjacent tables offer some suggestions of ways to contextualize a creature, with details and connections that can be applied to tie a beast more tightly to your world. The tables are generally written to apply to particular places and situations; the locals in a different place might have a completely different reaction or relationship to the creature. Even so, a GM might take the hints from these tables and spin them out further in their campaign, creating traditional responses or socially-entrenched reactions that are common throughout a domain.

USING EXISTING MONSTERS

Because *Worlds Without Number* is an old-school game, it's possible to loot monster statistics from a host of other games. Virtually any system that uses the same basic chassis can be plundered for monster stat blocks or descriptions. These monsters sometimes come "attached" to particular settings, however, with a lot of strings woven into setting details that may not exist in your game. There are a few common tricks you can use to contextualize these creatures without putting yourself to much extra effort.

Remix the details. If a monster is described as a servitor-beast of a particular setting organization, import it as a slave to some similar organization in your own setting. If it hates a type of sentient not found in your world, reassign its loathing to one that does. If it serves a particular ecological function in its origin world, give it the same function in whatever habitat you place it.

Shuffle its appearance. Particularly characteristic creatures from other settings can look jarring in the Latter Earth, as it makes it too obvious that it's an import. Instead, randomly reshuffle its appearance by picking a couple of other monsters at random and mashing the components together in whatever way makes the most sense. The tables in this section can also be used to hand it some new body parts or remake existing physiology.

Make its behavior visible. Two creatures with the exact same stat block can seem completely different to the players if they have notably different behavior. Of course, this distinction is invisible unless the creature's behavior is somehow visible to the party. Think about how the creature might act out of combat, and make it particularly timid, gluttonous, curious, loud, or repulsive. Pick a quality it has and play it up to an extreme level.

If you use these techniques to "freshen up" your imports, you can borrow half the contents of the average monstrous handbook without tipping your hand. This kind of parsimony of effort is very important if you're to have the time and focus needed to run a sandbox game.

ONE-ROLL MONSTROUS CONTEXT

A quick roll of one die of each type can give your terrible beast a connection with the rest of your campaign world. Take the results lightly, and be ready to tweak and adjust things as needed to fit the rolls into the role you need the beast to play.

If you're generating horrible creatures for a particular adventure, it can be prudent to let a few initial rolls decide the general tone and theme for the whole group. If one hideous beast in the hidden Deep has rolled "A local hero has been slain by it" for the scars it's left, don't keep rolling additional horrors for the following beasts, or else the village will be a mass of ruins by the time the fifth new creature is rolled. In the same vein, if you want all the vile gribblys in a ruin to be derived from the same source, roll only once for how these creatures arose.

d6 How Much Local Contact Does It Have?

- 1 The locals have no idea it exists
- 2 The locals make wild guesses and myths of it
- 3 They've had a few significant encounters
- 4 They know it's there and a little of its wants
- 5 It's a regular threat they need to deal with
- 6 They know its nature and needs very well

d8 How Do the Locals React To Its Drive?

- 1 They try to placate or appease its hungers
- 2 They try to kill it, actively hunting it down
- 3 They avoid its territory out of spiritual fear
- 4 They accept a certain amount of loss from it
- 5 They build countermeasures against it
- 6 They try to contain it within a certain area
- 7 They try to use it against their enemies
- 8 They worship it or take it as a leader

d10 What Scars Has It Left Here?

- 1 Many widows and orphans of its hunters
- 2 A grand structure ruined by its acts
- 3 Land has been made worthless by its threat
- 4 A local hero has been slain by it
- 5 Local clergy have been shown as helpless
- 6 A local lord has lost much wealth from it
- 7 The poorest have suffered most from it
- 8 A great plan for the future was ruined by it
- 9 A venerated tradition was defiled by it
- 10 A vital good or resource was spoiled by it

d4 How Did the Monster Arise?

- 1 It's a relict of the malice of the Outsiders
- 2 It's the product of human sorcerer-kings
- 3 It's an accident of magic or nature
- 4 It's a decayed form of something once noble

d12 What Is Its Connection With the Past?

- 1 It's a servant of a long-dead religion
- 2 It's obedient to a long-gone political group
- 3 It's meant to target a perhaps-vanished foe
- 4 It needs an environment that is now rare
- 5 It's accepted by certain ancient defenses
- 6 It serves an alien or vanished aesthetic end
- 7 Its home was a place that is now gone
- 8 It seeks something that has since been lost
- 9 It seeks victory in a struggle that is now over
- 10 It's only part of something, the rest now gone
- 11 It serves an urge that no longer makes sense
- 12 It was sacred to some group that is now lost

d20 A Twist To Its Activities

- 1 Its activities are very useful to some group
- 2 It's currently hurting an unsympathetic group
- 3 It responds to certain ancient codes
- 4 It targets a group the PCs count as friends
- 5 It's friendly to those sharing its tie to the past
- 6 A byproduct of its activities is very valuable
- 7 It has some devotees or cowed minions
- 8 It hates something the PCs have or relate to
- 9 It was formerly benevolent or useful
- 10 A victim plots a desperate act of revenge
- 11 People think its victims somehow deserved it
- 12 Killing it would cause some dire consequence
- 13 It's being hunted by something even worse
- 14 It has regular cycles of activity and torpor
- 15 It has some defensible reason for its acts
- 16 It protects or spares its willing subjects
- 17 Someone is profiting by its depredations
- 18 The locals believe something very false of it
- 19 Its damage is insidious and slow to be seen
- 20 Hunters quarrel over who is to claim it



ADJUSTING MONSTER STATISTICS

The basic stat line for a creature is just a starting point, one meant to give a GM a general idea of where the creature stands in relation to the other entities in the world. While simply using the basic stat line is often enough for a GM, sometimes you want to fine-tune a creature to its particular place in the world. You can follow the guidelines below to tweak things accordingly.

Hit dice can usually vary by 50% greater or lesser, depending on how impressive the creature is compared to its peers. If you remove hit dice, decrease its attack bonus by an equal amount and re-calculate its saving throw. If you add hit dice, do the same, except adding the new addition to its attack bonus.

AC might shift by one or two points if the creature is very fast, unusually slow, particularly large and easy to hit, or abnormally thick-skinned. Intelligent creatures might well fashion or steal armor, giving a substantial boost to their AC. Even a peasant militiaman can be stuffed into a suit of heavy plate armor if one can be found for him.

Atk is usually equal to the creature's hit dice, or perhaps its hit dice+1 if it's got combat training. The more martially-inclined the creature is, the higher this bonus will be, but it probably won't exceed 2 or 3 points at most. You can give extra attacks to expert human warriors or dangerous beasts if you want to significantly amplify their danger. One extra attack isn't unusual, but two or even three extra strikes should be reserved for truly heroic foes or extremely dangerous monsters.

Dmg is based on the weapon an intelligent creature uses or the body weaponry possessed by a beast. For beasts, 1d4 represents small fangs and claws, 1d6 to 1d8 for larger ones, and multi-die 2d6 or more for supernaturally savage maws and huge inhuman claws. If you need a benchmark, remember that the average sturdy peasant has about 4 or 5 hit points; if the creature should expect to kill one peasant a round make sure its average damage is at least 5 points.

Powerful creatures shouldn't be doing less than 2d6 damage on a hit, or an average of 7 points. If the foe is a weapon-user and martially-focused, you can give them the equivalent of the Warrior's *Killing Blow* ability and add +1 to their damage and Shock totals for every 2 hit dice they have, rounded up, up to a maximum of +5. Fearsome magical beasts may have a similar bonus to their claws and fangs, so don't hesitate to give those attacks the punch they need to have.

Shock is based on the weapon for humanoid combatants. Heroic warriors may have unavoidable Shock, having powers equivalent to PC Foci that allow them to ignore AC when applying the damage. Of course, creatures or PCs who are immune to Shock via shields or Foci will still be immune to such damage. For beasts, 1/13 is the usual rating, or 2/15 for very savage animals. Higher ratings are the preserve of supernatural bestial foes, up to 5/- or so for the worst of them.

Move has 30 feet per action as the human baseline. A lot of animals will be able to move faster than that, with 40 feet being normal for them. Creatures of exceptional swiftness might get as far as 60 feet per Move action. You might give some creatures multiple movement modes, such as a winged abomination that can crawl at 20' per move or fly at 40'.

ML should be adjusted for the creature's stupidity and determination. Normal animals always have relatively low Morale because a serious injury is almost inevitably ultimately fatal to them; they'll fight only when they're confident of easy victory or forced by hunger. Humans might add 1 or 2 points if they're fanatical or desperate, while they might lose the same if they're particularly disorganized. Mindless robots or insects might have a Morale of 12, being too stupid or single-minded to avoid self-destruction.

Inst is based not only on a creature's primal instincts but also their tendency to let their passions run away with their good sense. A mighty warlord might have an Instinct score one or two points higher than usual if he has a great fondness for toying with his foes or an impulse to make grandiose declamations in the middle of a battlefield. Conversely, a coldly rational, ruthlessly disciplined fighter might have a score 1 or 2 points less.

Skill should generally range between +1 for most creatures that are good at something, up to +3 for masters of their particular trade. Skill-focused PCs will generally be better than NPCs at skill checks; this is intended, as it gets frustrating if their PC's main focus is regularly outshone by random NPCs around them.

Save rarely changes much unless you change the creature's hit dice. You might give exceptionally hardy creatures a one or two-point bonus, or give those with weak constitutions or fragile forms a similar penalty. Extremely powerful creatures might be able to automatically make the first saving throw they're called on to make during a fight.

JUDGING COMBAT CHALLENGES

It's important that the creatures and foes that inhabit a sandbox world should be logically appropriate for the setting. If encounters and enemies are scaled to the PC party, it becomes impossible to deal with the world logically; the players know that whatever they face will be something they could at least theoretically stab to death.

Yet this policy doesn't necessarily help the GM guess whether a particular encounter is likely to kill the PCs or not. A GM may want to know whether they'll need to drop warning hints or spend prep time on alternatives to combat, or they might decide that this particular encounter ought to be matched to the PCs for some reason.

It's impossible to give a simple rubric for the comparison that will hold in every situation. Monsters often have bizarre powers that can skew an encounter and PCs usually make full use of any Foci or magic they have. Even so, a GM can make a rough estimate using a simple measure.

Take the total hit dice of the opponents and multiply it by their total number of attacks. Thus, a mob of 10 Anak warriors with one hit die and one attack each would tally to 100. For the PCs, take the party's total levels and multiply it by the number of PCs, so a party of four third-level PCs would total up to 48.

If the enemy total is more than four times larger, it will probably be a rout. The PCs are going to get crushed unless they have excellent tactics, a superb position that only allows a few of the enemies to engage at once, or some magical resource that can nullify a large

number of foes. Conversely, if the enemies have magical powers or special abilities of their own, it might be an even worse curb-stomping for the heroes.

If the enemy total is twice as large, the PCs are probably going to have at least one PC downed and run a good chance of a complete party wipe, assuming they engage their foes in the open with no complications.

If the enemy total is larger than the party total, the PCs might have an ally go down, but they have a decent chance of winning the fight due to their generally-superior abilities and powers.

If the enemy total is equal to or smaller than the party total, they're likely to win without anyone becoming mortally wounded.

If the enemy total is less than half the party total, it will probably be a walkover for the PCs.

These general rules don't apply to very inexperienced parties. A group of first level PCs can be taken out by almost anything if their dice are unkind, and a single errant blow can wipe out any one of them. They also don't fit so well if the enemies have unusually strong attacks, exceptionally high Armor Classes, or have powers that can directly inflict damage. In the same vein, an unusually clever or well-equipped party can sometimes pull through even the grimmest situation. These guidelines can be an initial help and hint to you, but as the GM, you will eventually have to rely on your own judgment to guess the likely outcome of a given fray.



REACTION ROLLS AND PARLEYING

Worlds Without Number is not a game that encourages constant combat encounters. Heroes are fragile, foes are dangerous, and almost every fight runs some risk of downing at least one PC. GMs or players who arrange their games as a curated sequence of battles are going to rapidly run out of luck.

GMs need to constantly recall the fact that not every hostile encounter needs to end in a massacre. The denizens of this world are just as aware of their own mortality as the PCs are, and they will not pick chance fights that they do not expect to win decisively. Even intrinsically hostile creatures such as Blighted marauders or bloodthirsty monsters will take a moment to size up a situation before they decide whether or not to attack.

Unless the situation is so patently destined for bloodshed that all negotiation is futile, a GM should always make a **reaction roll** whenever the PCs encounter another creature or group, whether friendly or hostile. This roll will indicate the general mood of the encounter, and whether the subjects are likely to be amenable to negotiations.

To make a reaction roll, roll 2d6 and compare it to the adjacent table. If a PC is in a position to greet the targets, add their Charisma modifier to the roll.

The higher the reaction roll, the friendlier and more helpful the NPCs will be. This doesn't mean that Anak raiders will invite the PCs to drink with them, but it does mean that otherwise violent groups might decide to demand a bribe instead, or back off rather than risk losing lives to the heroes. Conversely, a low roll means that the group is more hostile and unhelpful than they might be expected to be, given the situation.

Once a roll is made, the GM should clearly clue the PCs into its general results. If the bandits are feeling sociable, the GM needs to let the players know that they're looking relaxed and leaning on their spears. If the wild beast is getting ready to attack, it should be described as crouching and snarling as it begins to creep forward. This information needs to be given *before* the PCs choose their initial actions, or else a lot of potential parleys are going to be erased by the immediate and judicious drawing of swords.

A reaction roll applies to non-martial encounters as well. Determining the initial mood of a government clerk, the temper of a merchant, or the attitude of a noble patron can all be done by a reaction roll. This attitude will likely color the difficulty and nature of any negotiations or social skill checks the PCs might try to conduct with the target.

Reaction rolls are only the start of an encounter, not the end. Clever words, persuasive arguments, or prudent gifts can all shift the attitude of an NPC, as can insults, threats, and looking excessively tender and delicious. Provided the NPCs aren't the sort to simply attack, the PCs always have a chance to salvage a meeting.

2d6	NPC Reaction
2-	As aggressively hostile as the situation allows
3-5	More unfriendly and hostile than they'd be expected to be in the given situation
6-8	As predictably hostile or friendly as they'd usually be in this situation
9-11	More friendly and benign than you'd expect them to be, given the circumstances
12+	As friendly and helpful as their nature and the situation permits them to be

PEACEFUL ENCOUNTER REACTIONS

Suppose a GM's just rolled a 12 for the PCs' roadside encounter with a band of zealous blood cultists. The GM knows that the cultists are vicious but have no pressing reason to immediately attack the PCs, so what does "friendly" mean in such a situation? If you find yourself having to figure out plausible reactions for otherwise-hostile groups, here are some suggestions.

They demand a bribe. They'll take money, gear, food, booze, praise to their dark god, or some other currency in exchange for leaving the PCs alone. The amount they choose will be calibrated to something they think the party can afford and would rather pay than fight to retain. Hagglng is likely a possibility, as well as a two-sided deal, so long as it's in their favor.

They back off. If they aren't defending their lair or carrying out some critical task, they may just decide to back away and keep their distance as the groups pass by. They may bring word of the adventurers to their comrades, but a fight under the present terms might look like a bad deal to them.

They ask for favors. Maybe they have an enemy they want killed, or a task they need done. They may trade offers of ignoring the PCs while they remain in the area in exchange for the help, or offer an outright bribe to the PCs to get them to cooperate. Even the most hostile raider group might be willing to let a few targets go in exchange for some profitable work being done.

They offer tribute. They've looked at the PCs and decided that their own lives are in danger. They'll offer wealth, information, services, or other inducements to get the PCs to leave them alone. This reaction grows more possible if the PCs have been carving a bloody swath through their surroundings.

They willingly socialize. Maybe the bandits have been out here so long that they're lonely for civilized conversation, and the PCs look too dangerous to engage. The Anak raiders might've mistaken them for allied marauders and invite them to share their camp. The vile necromancer might consider herself a perfectly respectable person who loves good dinner conversation. However it's sliced, the NPC could be willing just to have a nice chat.

MORALE CHECKS AND PRUDENT RETREATS

Sometimes, however, combat is inevitable. The raiders swoop down on the heroes, the savage beast pounces, or the vile necromancer runs out of small talk. Even after blades are drawn, however, the hostile NPCs might come to think better of their choices when they fail a **Morale check**.

A Morale check is made by rolling 2d6 and comparing it to the creature's Morale score. If the roll is greater than the score, the creature loses heart and will seek to flee or stop the battle. PCs never make Morale checks and will fight on until they decide to flee.

A Morale check is usually made under certain circumstances, though the GM can add to these whenever they think the situation calls for one. More than one Morale check may be needed in a fight if more than one condition occurs.

- When a non-combatant civilian is first faced with the prospect of serious physical harm.
- When the first member of a group is killed or rendered incapacitated.
- When the group starts to visibly lose the fight or see their odds of victory considerably shrink.
- When the group faces some terrifying work of magic, a horrendous slaughter, or a vastly superior foe.

The consequences of a failed Morale check will vary based on the situation and the creatures being tested. Non-combatants and undisciplined fighters will generally flee madly, dropping shields and abandoning burdens as they try to escape their doom.

Trained and experienced warriors will usually make a fighting withdrawal, trying to pull away from their enemies and escape back to safety with as many of their comrades as they can. Of course, in the face of truly devastating situations they may flee just as readily as their green compatriots.

If flight seems impossible or prohibitively dangerous, they might throw down their weapons and beg for mercy, if they think they have any chance of receiving it from their assailants. If that seems hopeless, they might just collapse in terrified despair as they pray to their gods, or fight with a renewed frenzy in a desperate attempt to cut their way out of the trap. Some may offer bribes or favors to win their lives.

In all cases, once a side has failed its Morale check, it's not going to be in a condition to fight those foes until it's had some time to recover its courage. They're not likely to engage the same enemies again until the situation has shifted markedly in their favor, either through additional reinforcements, a better tactical situation, or renewed terrorization by their iron-fisted leadership.

THE IMPORTANCE OF MORALE

It's very important that GMs keep Morale checks in mind and use them regularly during combat. Only truly abnormal creatures such as mindless undead, unthinking vermin, or command-bound automatons will fight relentlessly onward regardless of the situation. If every Anak warrior is a Spartan at Thermopylae, the PCs are going to lose a lot of comrades cleaning up fights that were clearly won five rounds ago.

Aside from that, the warriors of the Latter Earth are not fools, and they will not linger to fight battles that cannot be won and are not worth their lives. Even if they never fail a Morale check, they will not stay to die to the last man if there's no pressing reason for them to do so. Once they see that victory is a vain hope, they'll try to withdraw or to cut some kind of deal with their enemies.

Of course, not all beaten sides respond rationally. The terror of battle, the confusion of melee, and a misunderstanding of the situation might leave some few warriors battling on even when all is lost, simply because they haven't realized that all their friends are dead yet. Green troops are notorious for sometimes achieving military goals that veterans never could, because veterans would recognize certain failure much earlier. The same can sometimes apply to frenetic barbarians, savage mobs, or single-minded marauders.

And in some cases, the combatants really do have a cause that's worth their lives. Warriors defending their homes, mates, or children will fight until broken Morale sends them fleeing or some better way of saving their kin comes to light. A band of ill-trained peasants might rationally flee at the first few dead when fighting as conscripts, but with the village at their backs and their families cowering within it, they'll keep fighting until they win, they die, or their blind terror overwhelms them.

FLEEING AND ESCAPE

Whether from a failed Morale check or the PCs deciding on a prudent retreat, sometimes a side decamps the field.

If their foes are determined, the escapee with the best Dex/Exert skill or applicable NPC Skill bonus makes an opposed check against the pursuing group. They get a +1 on the roll if the escapees are fewer in number than the pursuers, and possibly another bonus if their escape plan is good. The group with the slowest member takes a -2 penalty.

On a success, the escapees eventually outpace or lose their pursuers. On a failure, they're caught somewhere along their escape route. A successful escape usually takes up one turn and leaves the escapees somewhere safe.

GMs should be charitable about allowing PCs to run away. Most pursuers have little reason to be particularly relentless, and a party should be taught that running away is a viable option and not an excuse to die tired.



INSTINCT CHECKS

Very few creatures are capable of engaging in desperate, life-or-death struggles without losing some amount of their rationality. Terror, fury, excruciating pain, and situational blindness can sometimes make a combatant do something genuinely stupid, even if they would never have made such a mistake in calmer circumstances. In the same way, wild beasts and non-sentient monsters may be driven by instinct and habit rather than logical prudence and so behave in ways that are not always tactically sound.

The **Instinct check** is the game's way of helping a GM take this situational chaos into account. Whenever an Instinct check is triggered, the GM rolls a 1d10. If the number rolled is equal or less than a combatant's Instinct score, measured from 1 to 10, they do something impulsive, short-sighted, instinctual, or otherwise less-than-tactically-sound. Instinct checks are rolled separately for individual combatants, though the GM can simply decide that an appropriate percentage of large groups automatically fail the check. If the creatures have an Instinct of 3, for example, the GM might just decide that 30% of them fail the check rather than dicing for every one.

PCs never make Instinct checks. Even in the grip of terror or traumatic injury they remain in control of their own choices. Heroically well-trained or tactically-expert enemies with an Instinct score of zero might likewise be immune to Instinct checks. Even martial paragons might be susceptible to Instinct, however, if they're so proud, blase, or contemptuous of their foes that they fail to fight them with their utmost cunning.

When an Instinct check is failed, a creature will do something thoughtless or sub-optimal that is in line with their natural instincts. The adjacent tables offer example suggestions for various types of creatures, but a GM can simply decide the most reasonable reaction based on the situation and the combatants. A GM should use these instances as opportunities to show off the nature of an enemy or the instincts of a bestial foe, or to set up some battlefield situation that isn't necessarily tactically-optimal for the enemy but is still troublesome for the heroes. Actions taken as a result of a failed Instinct check will usually only occupy one round worth of the creature's efforts.

Actions forced by an Instinct check failure won't necessarily be entirely useless, but they won't be the wisest or most effective use of the creature's abilities. Blindly attacking sub-optimal targets, recklessly using unarmed attacks rather than the weapon in hand, or aiming spells or shots at targets of lesser importance might all be actions taken as a result of a failed Instinct check.

Instinct checks are always optional and at the discretion of the GM. Some GMs might choose not to use them at all, judging actions strictly on what seems reasonable to them. In all cases it's the GM's final call as to whether or not to roll one.

WHEN TO MAKE AN INSTINCT CHECK

As a general guide, a GM might make an Instinct check for a creature whenever any of the situations below are applicable, or any time the GM thinks the creature might be confused or indecisive.

- The second round of combat for mobs and undisciplined fighters. The creature could think clearly before starting the fray, but the fear and exhilaration of mortal combat might confuse it.
- The creature has just had to make a Morale check for any reason. Terror might cloud its thoughts.
- The enemy just did something confusing or disorienting. When the situation is strange, the creature might fall back on instinct.
- The enemy did something to enrage or directly intimidate it. Fury or terror might force bad decisions.
- The creature is presented with something it desires, such as dropped food, hurled money, or other inducements. It might go after the bait instead of the battle if it seems safe to do so.

Other situations might force Instinct checks as well at the GM's discretion. Indeed, some situations might be so compelling as to cause automatic check failure. Depending on the situation, the GM might decide a particular response is the only reasonable one, and not bother to randomly pick it from a table.

ASSIGNING INSTINCT SCORES

For non-sentient beasts, a creature's Instinct score should usually be about 5. Whenever such monsters are confused or frightened, they're very likely to fall back on their natural instincts. Those instincts tend to be violent in predators, however, and a failed Instinct check might just mean it bites the nearest target.

For non-combatant sentients and those unfamiliar with battle, Instinct should be 5 to 7. They are extremely likely to become confused and useless in a fight.

Ordinary intelligent veterans should have an Instinct of 3 or 4. They might get caught up in the confusion of battle and make some poor calls, but they're unlikely to lose their head entirely.

Hardened, battle-tested fighters might have an Instinct of only 1 or 2, being very unlikely to forget themselves in the chaos of battle.

The coldest, calmest killers would have an Instinct of 1, and may not have to make Instinct checks at all outside of the most disorienting situations. They'll fight according to the plan and won't lose track of the battle.

EXAMPLE INSTINCTIVE ACTIONS

The tables here offer some suggestions for different types of actions that different kinds of foes could take. While the actions may be sub-optimal, assume that every creature will carry them out as intelligently as they are able to. A GM should also feel perfectly free to simply decide on a creature's action, picking whatever course seems most likely for something of its motives and mentality.

d6 Non-Combatant Humans

- 1 Stand immobile in confusion and fear
- 2 Punch or kick a foe instead of using a weapon
- 3 Cringe, taking the **Total Defense** action
- 4 Panic and make a Morale check
- 5 Shout threats or pleas, but don't attack
- 6 Reposition to get close to the nearest ally

d6 Combat-Trained Humans

- 1 Freeze in confusion, doing nothing this round
- 2 Reposition to get a better place to fight from
- 3 Duck, taking the **Total Defense** action
- 4 Spend a round looking around the battlefield
- 5 Blindly attack the nearest enemy
- 6 Attack an object, barrier, or downed foe

d6 Sorcerers or Other Spellcasters

- 1 Freeze a round trying to pick which spell to use
- 2 Get further away from the nearest enemy
- 3 Use magic, but misjudge the aiming somehow
- 4 Try to hide behind something or get cover
- 5 Attack with punches or physical weapons
- 6 Ignore everyone but the nearest threat to them

d6 Ordinary Predatory Beasts

- 1 Snarl and growl, but don't attack anyone
- 2 Pull back and get away from nearby threats
- 3 Attack the last enemy to have hurt it
- 4 Attack the last enemy it managed to hurt
- 5 Take a bite out of a downed enemy
- 6 Panic and make a Morale check

d6 Viciously Violent Beasts

- 1 Roar savagely at the foe, but don't attack
- 2 Attack the last foe it hit in blind fury
- 3 Charge the last enemy to get its attention
- 4 Gnaw on a downed enemy
- 5 Charge the biggest cluster of targets
- 6 Attack the largest enemy on the field

d6 Trained Servitor Beasts

- 1 Seek its trainer or handler on the field
- 2 Repeat the last action it took, sensible or not
- 3 Attack the enemy closest to its handler
- 4 Whine in confusion and disorientation
- 5 Perform an inappropriate but trained action
- 6 Panic, attacking the nearest friend or foe

d6 Automaton

- 1 Do its intended purpose, even if inappropriate
- 2 Spend the round analyzing the situation
- 3 Repeat the last thing it did with blind intent
- 4 Attack the last target, even if it's now downed
- 5 Utter a warning or imperative to the foes
- 6 Select a new target for some reason

d6 Insects and Semi-Mindless Beasts

- 1 Move to help an ally encircle a target
- 2 Retreat from a foe for a round
- 3 Skitter and crawl randomly
- 4 Chew on the nearest organic substance
- 5 Charge nearest prey creature
- 6 Attack the smallest prey there

d6 Beings of Arrogant Might

- 1 Sneer at the pitiful weaklings that oppose it
- 2 Boast of its inevitable victory
- 3 Gratuitous use of a power in an unhelpful way
- 4 Attack the last enemy to offend it somehow
- 5 Urge on servitors, or demand surrender
- 6 Taunt the foe as it takes a **Total Defense**

d6 Hateful and Sadistic Sentients

- 1 Spend a round looking for a good victim
- 2 Attack to hurt or humiliate, doing half damage
- 3 Attack the weakest-looking foe present
- 4 Assault the enemy that most offends it
- 5 Slaughter a downed foe or tear a corpse
- 6 Spend a round making threats and vows

d6 Undead Creatures

- 1 Moan at the torment of their condition
- 2 Savagely attack the most vital, lively enemy
- 3 Blindly assault a downed foe or corpse
- 4 Seek to terrify a foe rather than directly attack
- 5 Target the foe with the weakest life force
- 6 Do nothing, instinctively craving an end



CREATURES OF THE LATTER EARTH

The creatures listed here are merely a small selection of the fauna of the Latter Earth, provided largely as examples for GMs who need worked content for their adventures. These beings may or may not exist in any particular region, and you should feel free to clip or adjust them to suit your own needs.

Whatever creatures you do elect to use, make sure that they're worth the time and effort you take to include them. It can be worthwhile to sprinkle in some odd creatures for flavor and verisimilitude, like the common beasts described in the "Animals" section below, but most creatures ought to serve a very specific purpose for your adventures or setting-building. Piling up tables of common fauna for a region can add a pleasant note of verisimilitude to your game, but the work involved is often far more than the payoff in player involvement. Reserve that kind of work for times when you've already handled all of the crucial prep for the next session.

ANIMALS

The Latter Earth contains most of the same animals known to modern-day Terra. Records suggest that there were extensive periods when the entire zoosphere was less familiar, including periods of reptilian, insectile, and fungal dominance, but at some point the planet was "reset" to more contemporary shapes. Survivors from these prior eras are known to persist in some areas.

For the sake of simplicity you can treat most of these latter-day animals as the equivalent of their modern breeds in behavior and appearance. Almost all of them have been altered in some way over the course of ages, but such small points are best used as flavoring and accents to the setting rather than significant differences that players will need to keep in mind. The checkerboard-coated horses of Ka-Adun and the Dry Sheep that never drink water are novel in their way, but they still act much as horses and sheep do.

When such a normal animal's combat statistics matter, you can use the table on page 283 and assign it a stat line that matches its function. Aside from such relatively normal creatures, however, there are a more than a few "mundane" animals in the Gyre that bear special mention. Below are a few of likely interest to adventurers.

Ashcrawler: One of the hideous fungal life forms that sometimes emerge from the Ashblight, an ashcrawler resembles a centipede that stands half as tall as a man and is at least ten feet long. The "chitin" of the crawler is nothing but a hardened fungal shell around the soft, damp interior of the organism.

When in need of some quick bestial foe, don't hesitate to reach for the example creature stat lines on page 283 and just pick something that serves your needs. The difference between a slaving wasp-tiger that does 1d8 damage on a hit and one that does 1d10 is unlikely to be noticed by a party, and a quick stat block that roughly suits your needs is much to be preferred over a perfect one that takes you five minutes to calculate. Very few players will pay nearly as much attention to exact monster statistics as the GM will.

Aside from the monsters and entities unique to the Latter Earth, this bestiary also includes example origin Foci for demihumans common to other fantasy worlds. Traditional orcs, elves, dwarves, and other such denizens can be found on page 311 for GMs who want to use *Worlds Without Number* for some more orthodox fantasy setting, or one who needs some ready-made origin Foci to reskin for species of their own creation.

Those bitten by an ashcrawler must make a Physical save or be infected by the fungus. Without magical healing, they'll become wholly enslaved by the parasitical fungus within a week, becoming a "crawler slave" and using their own intellect and abilities to gather new prey for the creature. The stat line given for them below reflects an average unlucky peasant, but stronger slaves are possible. Crawler slaves can hide most of the infection under concealing clothing, and can only be saved by powerful healing magic at the GM's discretion.

Anak Courser: Looking much like a horse-sized hairless lion with mottled hide, a courser is a vicious pack hunter often "domesticated" as a mount for elite Anak warriors. While they can survive on plant matter, coursers much prefer meat. Even when ridden, a courser can fight independently and can leap up to 30' as a Main Action, giving the crusaders of Sarul their famous tactic of leaping over an enemy force's front lines to savage the spear wall from the rear.

Betrayer Bird: Resembling a vulture with a six-foot wingspan and razor-sharp claws, betrayer birds are encountered in small flocks of 1d6+1 birds. They seek out small or wounded parties in their territory and then try to lead predators and enemies to them in order to feast on the eventual leavings. They seem to have a positively human ability to identify suitable predators, though they fight with no more than bestial intelligence if directly attacked.

Bull Pig: As large as a small cow, the “bull pig” is a thick-skinned, long-tusked breed of porker bred for survival in the dangerous ranges of the Latter Earth. When kept by brave and capable swineherds it can be relatively safely domesticated, but wild bull pigs are as savage and ill-tempered as any boar. Some nations and exceptionally brave tribals even train them for use as battle mounts, though their habit of blind charging is difficult to control.

Dunecrawlers: Vile dog-sized scorpion-beetle hybrids found in deserts and sandy *arratus*, dunecrawlers spend most of their life cycle in nests of 3d6 insects, subsisting on solar energy and prey they can hunt individually or in groups of 1d6. Every so often, however, all the dunecrawlers in an area will form a massive swarm that sweeps over all in its path until it collapses in a welter of mating cannibalism, the survivors scattering to form their own nests.

Fleshbeast: These blind, sluglike, pig-sized crawlers are soft and harmless, snuffling at the vegetation with soft mouths that occasionally speak random phrases of the local language. They grow from spores spread during their roaming, and while their flesh is nutritious, the gelatinous consistency and unpleasantly human-like habits of speech that fleshbeasts have discourage some from eating their meat.

Horse Lizard: A feathered raptor named for its size, horse lizards hunt in packs of 1d4+1 creatures. They are unusually intelligent for animals and surprisingly disciplined in their hunts. Most are found in habitats of dense vegetation, though some have acclimated to *arratu* life.

Judas Goat: A goat the size of a cow and possessed of an elaborate fan of very sharp horns, the Judas goat is unusual in that its preferred browse is the xenoformed plant life of an *arratu*. Over the course of decades a flock of Judas goats can gradually push back a mild *arratu*'s borders. Their flesh is toxic to predators and they are highly aggressive toward

anything perceived as a threat to the flock. Only their hair is of any use to humans, but unusually skilled and brave goatherds can train them as watch-beasts or even as mounts.

Mountain Crab: Thought to be a Polop war-beast that went native, the mountain crab is named for its gigantic size, the smallest being eight feet tall and twice that width when standing. It has a rubbery hide rather than a chitin shell, and its pincers and legs are of a glassy, razor-sharp mineral. Most live in shallow water, with a few venturing onto land when nearby hunting is good.

Razorhorn: A type of ancient cattle bred for the sport of long-dead nobility, a razorhorn is an aurochs-sized brute with steel horns that naturally hone to a superbly keen edge. Razorhorns breed slowly and are solitary in nature, but their tough hide and savage disposition make them dangerous even alone. Razorhorn flesh is remarkably delicious, and some lords require a tribute of it from villages located near razorhorn ranges.

Salt Devils: Found wherever brackish or befouled water is found, a salt devil resembles a pony-sized mantis shrimp with a rainbow shell. These voracious predators are almost transparent when submerged in water, but pounce to cleave prey with the huge blades of their two forelimbs.

Wailer Crane: These man-tall cranes were imbued with song by some ancient civilization, one with a completely incomprehensible musical taste. The ululating wails of these birds are thunderously loud and penetrating. When used as a Main Action attack, creatures within ten feet of the bird must make a Physical save or suffer 1d4 sonic damage. The cranes tend to form choirs of 2d4 birds that will sing for days on end and attack any creature that approaches too closely. They have a great fondness for bright trinkets, and wear them like jewelry. The crane with the most jewelry always leads the choir.

Animals	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Ashcrawler	6	13	+8 x2	1d6	-	50'	10	4	+1	12+
Ashcrawler Slave	1	13a	+2	Wpn	Wpn	30'	12	5	+1	15+
Anak Courser	4	15	+5 x2	1d8	-	60'	9	6	+1	13+
Betrayer Bird	1	13	+2	1d6	-	40' fly	8	5	+1	15+
Bull Pig	2	13	+3	1d8	-	40'	9	6	+1	14+
Dunecrawler	1	13	+1	1d4	-	30'	9	6	+1	15+
Fleshbeast	1	10	-	-	-	30'	2	5	+0	15+
Horse Lizard	3	13	+5	1d10	-	50'	8	3	+2	14+
Judas Goat	2	12	+3	1d6	-	40'	9	5	+1	14+
Mountain Crab	8	18	+10 x2	2d6+4	4/-	40'	9	6	+1	11+
Razorhorn	4	13	+6 x2	2d6	3/15	40'	10	4	+1	13+
Salt Devil	4	15	+6 x2	1d10	4/-	40'	10	5	+2	13+
Wailer Crane	1	12	+2	1d6	-	40' fly	8	6	+1	15+



AUTOMATONS AND EIDOLONS

Robots, arcane automatons, occult golems, and artificial intelligences are not unknown in the Latter Earth. While most would never expect to encounter such a being in their ordinary life, they have heard tales of the false men fashioned by sorcerers in former days, and few would draw any appreciable distinction between a shape animated by sorcery and one given life by arcane science... assuming there was ever any difference between the two.

AUTOMATON QUALITIES

Automatons do not need to eat, drink, or breathe, and are naturally immune to diseases, poisons, and natural climatic extremes of temperature. Most require a six-hour recharge period daily that's largely the equivalent of sleep. Surviving automatons that don't draw their power from a specific site are fueled by Legacy fluxes and don't require power cells or other special fuel.

An automaton that is "killed" is broken beyond conventional repair, while a "mortally wounded" one can still be stabilized before its internal processes spin down, if the healer knows how to do so and the automaton was crafted to be repaired in such a way. An hour's demonstration and training are enough for a sentient automaton to show a person how to handle emergency damage and use healing powers and abilities on its self-repair func-

tions effectively. Those with the Healer class and other specialist physicians are equipped with this knowledge as part of their usual training.

Some automatons are equipped with special sensory units capable of seeing in the dark, detecting motion, observing magical energy, or other novel traits. A given automaton might have a number of attachments and improvements, depending on its intended function.

ORIGIN FOCUS: AUTOMATON

You are a self-willed automaton, gaining all the usual benefits and limitations of that state. You probably have a humanoid form; at your option, you can be human-like enough that only a close inspection reveals your nature. While you are capable of eating and drinking, it is not necessary for you.

As with other origin Foci, it's up to the GM to decide whether or not this option fits well with their campaign, and it may be disallowed at their discretion.

Level 1: You have an automaton's traits and qualities. You gain System Strain as normal for a living creature when healing or similar effects are applied to you. The long ages or questionable self-repair functions have hindered your functionality; pick one attribute and decrease its modifier by -1, to a minimum of -2.

THE BLACK BRASS LEGION

Legends are unclear as to how many automatons of the Brass Legion first landed with the Reaping King, but his present forces are thought to amount to perhaps ten thousand of these tireless servants. His workshops and artificers are able to maintain this number, but they do not seem able to grow it, or at least they do not try.

The Black Brass Legion's automatons are largely humanoid in shape, appearing as harvesters clad in stylized clothing of black bronze. Their hands can manipulate human tools and they act with ordinary levels of human intelligence in pursuit of their purposes, but they require a Reeve or a human handler to direct them.

Scythemen are the line troops of the Legion, each one equipped with a large bronze scythe or iron crossbow. Cataphracts are centauroid in their outlines, with fittings for cart-pulling and other logistical hauling. They also serve as heavy shock cavalry.

Legion Hulks stand twelve feet tall, with spade-like hands and plowshare fingers fit to tear down walls, or build them up again if their handlers so instruct. The rare Reeve is a legionary with sentient self-awareness, capable of commanding its lessers and interpreting orders from its human handlers.

The human controllers of the Legion direct them by song, specific tunes and command lyrics used to give orders to the automatons. There is usually one handler for every ten automatons, all of them reporting to the unit's overall commander and all of them ritually keyed to their unit's legionaries. Without the directing songs, the legion will carry out its last orders until they appear to have been completed, after which it will return home.

The black brass shells of the legionaries are tremendously tough, and are impervious to non-magical weapons or minor environmental hazards.

Brass Legion	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Scytheman	3	18*	+5	1d10+2	5/15	30'	12	4	+1	14+
Cataphract	6	18*	+6 x2	1d10+3	5/15	60'	12	3	+1	12+
Hulk	10	16*	+10 x2	2d8+5	8/-	20'	12	4	+1	10+
Reeve	10	20*	+10 x2	1d12+5	8/-	30'	10	2	+2	9+

* All Brass Legion automatons are immune to damage from non-magical weapons or minor environmental hazards

EIDOLONS

Artificial minds have been created in one way or another for countless ages, the first dating back to the earliest years of the lost Terran Mandate. Every educated person in the Gyre knows that the intellect is not shackled to the flesh and that a mind can be forged out of sorcery, steel, and strange ancient components. These artificial intelligences are called “eidolons” by the learned.

Eidolons haunt specific sites, usually acting as the *genius loci* of the place and controlling whatever parts of it are still answering its commands. It sees through the ancient scrying devices of the site, speaks through whatever vocalization objects still function, and can often act through the remaining functional relic automatons.

Most eidolons were either created from an imprint of some ancient candidate’s identity or fabricated whole with sorcery and arcane science. A few exist with no particular purpose, or have lost their original compulsions, but most are still tightly bound by whatever original need motivated their creation. An eidolon can bend, interpret, and prioritize its purposes but it cannot deny them for long or act directly against them.

Many eidolons have long since lost the capability to carry out their purposes, or recognize that their original goal is now hopelessly impossible. Obedience to this cause is a painful addiction to them, a gnawing suffering

that can only be tamped down when they can do something that fulfills their original coding. Even if the act is ultimately futile, the need to escape the pain drives them to carry it out in any way they can. Obedience buys a little respite until the imperative goads them on again.

Eidolons can give considerable help to allied adventurers. They often know of ancient secrets and hidden sites of wealth and arcane power that have been forgotten by the modern day. Their relic automaton servitors can labor for their allies, and many eidolons are capable of fabricating functional devices that would be impossible for an ordinary crafter to devise. The sane intelligences will often offer such favors and help in exchange for an opportunity to further its goals.

Unfortunately, many eidolons are either mad or wholly alien. The constant psychic torment of their inability to carry out their purposes leaves many of them hopelessly deranged, lashing out in an attempt to provoke something into euthanizing them without directly defying its self-destruction prohibitions. Other eidolons were never templated on human minds at all, being the product of Outsiders or of transhumans too alien to be comprehended by modern humanity. These eidolons have their purposes as well, but few of them are anything a human would appreciate.

RELIC AUTOMATONS

These forgotten servitors of iron, glass, and stranger substances are commonly found in ancient Deep, lost sorcerer-king citadels, or other places once ruled by great powers. Most of them have decayed into uselessness, but a few are often still functional in such sites.

Relic automatons come in many different sizes and shapes, most related to their intended function. Humanoid models are often plainly inhuman in their appearance, sometimes due to the intentions of the builders, and other times because the “human” of their age looked nothing like those of the present day. Squat cylinders, spider-like crawlers, apish heavy haulers, and other such configurations are common for labor relics.

Security automatons are usually armed with assorted lethal weapons and will react to intruders with murderous violence. The massive ancient warbots utilized by both Outsiders and sorcerer-kings are studded over with devices of arcane and technical ruin, and it is a mercy that most have been destroyed over the ages.

Most relics are not sentient or self-aware, though some mimic it well. Each has its directive and purpose, and they are usually capable of carrying out these orders with almost human intelligence, though they are unable to generalize them easily. Few communicate in any comprehensible way, though Outsider relics understand Abased and devices of the sorcerer-kings understand the various ancient languages spoken in those days.

Relic automatons can sometimes be negotiated with if a form of communication is established. Those negotiations usually revolve around helping it carry out its purpose in exchange for some favor or concession.

Relics are rarely able to go far from their site of operation, either due to limits placed upon them at their creation or their reliance on certain energies and radiations intrinsic to such places. Skilled sorcerers or Thurian artificers can sometimes relocate relic automatons to their own lairs, though the effort required is usually considerably more than would be spent on human servants.

Automatons	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Servitor	2	13	+2	1d6	2/13	30'	12	5	+1	14+
Lesser Guardian	4	15	+5	1d10+2	2/15	30'	12	4	+1	13+
Guardian Commander	8	18	+9 x2	1d10+4	6/18	40'	12	3	+2	11+
Ancient Warbot	14	20	+15 x3	2d6+5	10/-	60' fly	12	2	+2	8+



BLIGHTED

Some kinds of atrocities are possible only for those with access to the vilest of tools. Those wretched demihumans known collectively as “the Blighted” are the descendants of men and women horribly warped by wielders of ancient sorcery and genetic science, people forged into tools for purposes that had no place for mercy.

There is no single source for the Blighted. Some are slave races forged by the Outsiders out of human chattel, their unlucky subjects plucked from the Deeps and molded into shapes necessary to the aliens. Others are cursed lineages dating back to the ages of the sorcerer-kings, bloodlines that incurred the anger of these living gods and whose descendants now bear the weight of their wrath. Some are unsuccessful transhuman experiments, or once-stable magical species that decayed when the Legacy was twisted, or simple products of magical accidents or malevolent sorcerous radiations.

Whatever their origins, every intentionally-created Blighted kind is marked by the purpose they were intended to fulfill. Many were warrior races, crafted to be vicious, aggressive, and intrinsically hateful toward anyone but their long-dead masters. Others were brute laborers, their minds dulled and their power to rebel taken from them. A few of the most wretched were fashioned to be playthings and toys, either for hedonistic disports or more hideous appetites still.

To baseline humanity, the horror of the Blight lies in the way that it corrupts and limits the normal human range of emotion and cognition. An Anak warrior may look somewhat like a normal human, but he is filled with an instinctive aggressiveness and cruelty found only in a tiny fraction of ordinary humanity. An Anak of truly heroic mental discipline may be able to overcome these innate urges, but living an ordinarily peaceful life for such a Blighted is as difficult as it would be for a normal human to live a life of constant ascetic celibacy. Such a being must fight their urges on a constant hour-by-hour basis to avoid extremes of violence and brutality.

Because of their curse, the Blighted have a very difficult time in normal human society. The violent and dangerous species among them usually exist as raiders and marauders, plundering each other when they can find no softer prey and building a bone-deep hatred in all who deal with them. For an ordinary human of the Latter Earth, there is no question that the only solution for these Blighted is a genocidal extermination of all their kind, before they do the same to humanity.

Those Blighted fashioned as laborers or odalisques have scarcely better a place in those lands where they are found. Often lacking the mental ability to live without oversight, they usually are left to become slaves and movable property to their keepers. In the more ethical lands, they may have meaningful protection from obvious abuse, but in many other domains their very existence is something to be granted only on sufferance.

It is the special hell of the Blighted that not all of the members of a lineage may be afflicted by the curse to the same extent. Because the medium of the Blight often works through conventional genetic influence or psychothaumaturgic flux, individual members might randomly escape the worst effects of it. While extremely rare, it's not impossible for an Anak to be born without the craving for bloodshed that his brethren know, or for a Blighted brute laborer to be born with baseline human levels of intellect.

These exceptions, of course, can expect no special treatment from those around them. The Anak must kill as his brothers kill or be slaughtered as a weakling, and the laborer will be treated as a novelty to be gawped at rather than as a being capable of the same independent living as his keeper. It's not unknown for these sports to become the nucleus of a Blighted uprising or bloody crusade as they organize other gifted Blighted into a cabal able to direct their less capable brethren.

The curse of the Blight is commonly passed on through the blood, and is often a dominant trait expressed in any offspring of a Blighted partner. Fertility tends to be high for those Blighted lineages designed as biological weapons or warrior races, while ornamental Blighted and those cursed with penal debilities are much less fecund, and some require special circumstances or stimuli to reproduce.

Cross-breeding between Blighted and baseline humans is usually possible, if the physiologies involved are compatible. If the Blight involved is not a dominant trait, it can lie dormant in the bloodline for generations, perhaps expressed in smaller or more subtle ways. Most such heirs conceal it at all cost, for to be identified as a Blighted being is an almost unavoidable sentence of second-class citizenship or worse in most lands.

BLIGHTED IN YOUR CAMPAIGN

Aggressive Blighted tend to be unambiguous villains and enemies in most campaigns, sentients that are genuinely incapable of living peacefully with humanity. They have been cursed from their creation with a need to kill and ruin, and while they may be blameless of the ancient sorcery that twisted them, humanity simply cannot live with them under the same sky.

Penal Blighted and servitor-species often appear as victims of cruelty and oppression, suffering due to the weaknesses and flaws impressed on them by their creators. Heroic PCs might find significant adventure grist in protecting or helping communities of these people.

Some players may find the existence of Blighted species to be a kind of teleological horror, and feel obligated to find some cure for their curse or method by which peace can be made with them. A GM who knows their players are likely to feel this way might choose to soften the mental effects of the Blight or make room for a cure.

BLIGHTED ORIGINS

Individual breeds of Blighted vary widely, and while this section includes some demihuman breeds specific to Lat-ter Earth, the GM and the players may wish to make up their own as well. Five general types of Blighted origin Foci are given here as templates that players can use for their own creations. All of them assume that the PC was not so severely affected by the Blight as most, and is capable of functioning in a conventional adventuring party. A certain amount of discretion may be needed, however, if the PC's kind are feared or hated by others in the campaign area.

Chattel Blighted

Some cruel power has made your lineage one of human cattle to serve their hungers. Physically weak and unable to resist abuse, your demihuman strain was meant to exist as playthings and ornaments in the best case, and literal human livestock in less favorable lands. Most such chattel are designed to take a helpless satisfaction in their miserable condition, but you have enough self-control to plot your own course in the world, despite the awful urges that whisper in your blood.

Level 1: Pick any one non-combat, non-Magic skill as a bonus skill. Reroll your Strength attribute as 1d4+2 instead of 3d6. Choose either Constitution or Charisma; that attribute modifier is increased by +1, up to a maximum of +3. You gain a +1 bonus on all social skill checks due to your lifelong need to manage and manipulate others, but your innate mental blocks against physical violence give you a -2 hit penalty on all attack rolls.

Functionary Blighted

Your ancestors were created as tools for a specific functional purpose, one more specific than that of a general laborer. Some may have been living musical instruments, while others could be warped maintenance-drones, in-human performers, tireless living calculators, or some similar purpose-grown organism. While you probably still look somewhat human, most such functionaries suffered significant, crippling debilities to gain their powers. These Blighted are naturally equipped with the tools and abilities necessary to carry out their role, either as physical organs, implanted devices, or innate magical powers.

Level 1: Pick any one non-combat, non-Magic skill as a bonus skill and gain the *Specialist* Focus in it. Pick any one attribute; it suffers a -1 penalty to its modifier, to a minimum of -2. You are capable of carrying out your intended function even without normally-necessary tools or instruments; functionaries intended to be artisans can replicate or mimic hand tools, those meant to be healers do not need medical supplies, and so forth. You gain an intrinsic +1 bonus to all skill checks related to your function.

Laborer Blighted

Your bloodline was reshaped into a caste of toilers and brute laborers for some more powerful group. While you are less badly afflicted than most of your kind, your mental faculties remain duller than most baseline humans and you have an instinctive urge to obey orders and instructions.

Level 1: Gain Exert as a bonus skill. Each of your Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma attribute modifiers suffers a -1 penalty, down to a minimum of -2, while your Strength and Constitution modifiers are improved by +1, up to a maximum of +3 for each. You require only half as much food and rest as a normal human. You suffer a -2 penalty to all Mental saving throws to resist mind-influencing effects.

Penal Blighted

Your lineage was cursed by some sadistic sorcerer-king or merciless alien artificer. Perhaps an ancestor offended them, or your people were dominated and made perpetual tools of their conquerors, or your forebears were a fallen ruling caste rendered permanently incapable of threatening the new order. You have been terribly compromised in some physical or mental way.

Despite this curse, you have somehow managed to avoid complete incapacitation from it and have done your best to compensate for your limitations.

Level 1: Choose an attribute; its modifier suffers a permanent -2 penalty, to a maximum of -3. Only one of your attribute scores can be above 13; reduce any others to no more than 13. You may pick two additional Foci to reflect the efforts you've made to overcome your natural limits. Gain a +2 bonus to all saving throws to reflect your indomitable spirit. You cannot pick the *Developed Attribute* Focus.

Warlike Blighted

Your kind were born to kill, whether as the slave-soldiers of some lost empire or as a living biological plague meant solely to scourge the land of all human life. You are constantly assailed by urges to slay, torment, and destroy, but unlike most of your brethren you are capable of controlling these impulses... when you must.

Level 1: Gain Stab and Punch as bonus skills and gain a natural +1 bonus on all hit rolls. Choose two attributes from Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma; these attribute modifiers suffer a -1 penalty, down to a -2 maximum. Increase either your Strength, Dexterity, or Constitution modifier by +1, up to a maximum of +3. You suffer a -1 penalty on all social skill checks not related to intimidation.



ANAKIM

Sages believe that the original Anakim were a spite-weapon created by the Outsiders when the fall of their hegemony seemed imminent. Captured rebels, still-subject Deeps, and human traitors who were no longer needed were used as the feedstock for the transformation, one intended to create a sentient bioweapon for the destruction of all human and demihuman life in the Latter Earth.

Later ages saw the Anakim modified by assorted Imperators, their original nature warped and tuned to serve the purposes of the experimenters. The resulting Anakim sub-species are sometimes drastically different from the ur-Anak, but the intrinsic selfishness, cruelty, and aggression of the base stock persist in most of them.

ANAK PHYSIOLOGY

Anakim are divided into several sub-species and variant body plans, some more prevalent than others. The ur-Anak, or "Great Anak" is humanoid in shape, with males averaging six and a half feet in height and two hundred pounds, females being slightly smaller. Skin and hair tones vary based on the original human feedstock, but vivid and unnatural colors are introduced in some groups. Facial features and other bodily details are usually designed to play on primal human terrors, with skull-like features, claws, fangs, bestial muzzles, disease lesions, and other qualities common in different sub-strains.

"Lesser Anakim" are a common smaller variant of the ur-Anak. Their origins are disputed among the sages, some believing them the result of an Imperator's experimentations, while others crediting them as a natural evolution of the Great Anak. These creatures share many of the same features as their larger cousins, but are much smaller and spindlier in build.

"Ogres", "titans", "hulks", or "brute Anakim" are an uncommon expression of Anak nature in which one grows to a height and mass far beyond its peers, often standing as much as nine feet tall. This growth tends to come at the cost of neural development, and most hulks have the mentality of a small, particularly vicious child. While hulks breed true, their stupidity and aggression tend to control their numbers in the wild.

All types of Anakim usually breed much more quickly than humans, with females bearing litters. This fecundity is necessary to maintain their numbers, as Anakim mature only slightly more quickly than humans.

These three kinds of Anakim are merely the most common in the Latter Earth. Other varieties, including no-longer-humanoid strains are known in certain lands. Some even appear very similar to baseline humans, having a barbaric sort of handsomeness about them; most of these variants are just as vicious as their uglier brethren.

Even so, a few Anakim strains are less aggressive than their kindred, and some can even maintain a wary sort of mutual non-slaughter with human neighbors, provided a safe distance is maintained.

ANAK PSYCHOLOGY

All Anakim are touched to a greater or lesser degree by the "Hate". This ancient Blight infects them with an overwhelming revulsion and loathing toward baseline humanity and most demihuman species. Some scholars believe that the Hate is triggered by some pheromonal marker or arcane soul-dissonance. Others believe it is keyed on physical appearance, and is simply an unbearably amplified natural response toward physical ugliness. Whatever the source, Anakim find humans and human-like demihumans to be unendurably loathsome.

This Hate is worsened by the naturally aggressive, violent, and cruel instincts implanted in them by the Blight. Most Anakim behave in ways largely identical to human psychopaths, having no innate sense of empathy and no desire to obey any principles higher than their own pleasure. They delight in torture, slaughter, and sordid excess, and other Anakim are perfectly acceptable targets.

The only effective shackle for an Anak's instinct is sheer terror. With nothing more precious to them than their own lives, a leader or opponent who can display overwhelming force and a certain ability to slaughter them will provoke a response of groveling obedience and abject submission. This submission will tend to last precisely until the Anak no longer feels this awe.

Anakim society, such that it is, is held together by brute force and temporarily-shared ambition. A chieftain or warlord will arise, murder all nearby rivals, and force the local Anakim into obedience in order to plunder and slaughter all available targets. When that warlord shows weakness, he or she will be replaced by their most ruthless underling. This churning chaos tends to limit the size of Anakim societies, with most existing on no more than a tribal basis in the absence of some overwhelming leader.

Origin Focus: Great Anak

Unlike most Anak, you are capable of functioning in human society, either through a weakened sense of Hate or an overwhelming force of will. Unless your appearance is much more human than most, however, you may have an extremely difficult time in human lands.

Level 1: Gain Stab and Punch as bonus skills. Your Strength and Constitution modifiers increase by +1, up to a maximum of +2. Your Dexterity and Charisma modifiers decrease by -1, to a minimum of -2.

Origin Focus: Lesser Anak

As with the Great Anak origin, you are an exceptionally human or humane example of your kind, and can function adequately in human society if your nature is hidden.

Level 1: Gain Stab and Sneak as bonus skills. Your Dexterity modifier increases by +1, up to a maximum of +2, and your Constitution modifier decreases by -1, to a minimum of -2.

ANAKIM ENCOUNTERS

Most Anakim will be encountered in groups, either as scouting parties, raiding bands, or the main encampment of the tribe. Scouting parties will usually consist of 1d4+1 warriors, raiding bands might number 2d6+6, and main tribal camps might have as many as fifty or sixty combat-capable Anakim. Great warlords can weld together dozens of tribes into a single horde, as can other powerful entities capable of terrifying the Anakim.

Anakim are vicious and cruel, but they are not particularly stupid. Most tribes have the services of at least one competent sorcerer, usually the equivalent of a first or second-level Elementalist or Necromancer in their abilities, though of a very different tradition. Especially powerful tribes might have access to stronger mages. Tribes that are in service to some dark god or malevolent arch-sorcerer are particularly known for their magical prowess, with an Anak high priest sometimes attaining powers equal to sixth or even seventh level as a Mage. Were it not for the relentless backstabbing within Anakim society, it's possible that these devil-sorcerers might become as skilled as any human mage.

Despite the Hate, an encounter with Anakim does not inevitably devolve into immediate violence. An Anak loves nothing except his own life, and no warrior will fight unless victory seems assured or some present leader demands that they fight. Strong parties or those that offer some tempting inducement in place of bloodshed might be able to parley with Anakim, as some of them are known to speak Trade Cant in order to command slaves.

One particular trait of almost all Anakim tribes is the **sacred terror**. This psychological instinct was embedded in them in order to give them some limited mechanism for direction.

When an Anak is faced with some overwhelming foe and fails a Morale check, they will either flee for their lives or immediately seek to placate and submit to the foe. Their choice will depend on whatever outcome seems most likely to keep them alive. This terror will persist until their new leader proves weak or pushes the Anak into a situation where disobedience seems more survivable than compliance. Exceptional temptations might cause temporary disobedience to the leader, however, if the Anak thinks its defiance can be hidden.



ANAKIM AND OTHERS

Anakim get along poorly with each other, let alone other species. Given that a single Great Anak warrior is worth almost two ordinary human soldiers, it's only this contentiousness and grasping treachery that has kept them from overwhelming many of their hated neighbors.

Few human nations have any formal relationship with the Anak raiders beyond their borders. Desperate kings may seek to bribe the tribes into a temporary peace, or make concessions until they're able to muster their defenses, but only the most brutal and iron-fisted rulers can compel a lasting obedience from the Anak tribes.

Trade with the Anakim is almost invariably viewed with horror by those subject to their raids, but that doesn't stop smugglers and grasping merchants from seeking to trade weapons and luxuries for Anak loot. Sometimes these dealers even live to spend their profits.

Anakim	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Lesser Anak Warrior	1	13a	+1	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	20'	7	4	+1	15+
Lesser Anak Witch	3	12a	+1	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	20'	8	4	+1	14+
Lesser Anak Chief	4	15a	+5	Wpn+2	Wpn+2	30'	9	3	+2	13+
Great Anak Warrior	2	14a	+3	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	30'	8	4	+1	14+
Great Anak Warlock	4	13a	+3	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	30'	9	3	+1	13+
Great Anak Warchief	8	18a	+8 x2	Wpn+4	Wpn+4/-	40'	10	3	+2	12+
Hulk	5	15a	+6	Wpn+4	Wpn+4	30'	8	5	+1	13+
Anak King	10	20a	+12 x2	Wpn+5	Wpn+5/-	40'	11	2	+3	10+
Anak High Priest	8	15a	+7	Wpn+2	Wpn+2	30'	10	2	+2	11+

DRUDGES

It's unclear what creators first fashioned the Blighted known as the Drudges. Any civilization powerful enough to curse an entire human lineage with this condition almost certainly had more efficient tools for manual labor, so scholars have hypothesized that the transformation was the product of some punishment or malice. In the ages since, the Drudges have spread slowly throughout Latter Earth, their docility and great strength useful to many different peoples.

A Drudge averages around seven feet in height, with a powerful build and coarse human features. Some variants have a bestial slouch to their build and arms long enough to let them rest on their knuckles, while other subtypes look almost normal save for their size and slackness of expression.

Drudges are extremely strong, hardy laborers, but they also have very limited intellects, most of them having the same mentality as an eight-year-old child. They can follow simple orders and learn basic skills, but abstract concepts and exercises of judgment are extremely difficult for them to handle.

Drudges	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Drudge Laborer	3	10	+1	Wpn+2	Wpn+2	30'	7	7	+0	14+
War Drudge	5	15a	+4	Wpn+3	Wpn+3	30'	8	5	+0	13+

HALFMEN

The Blighted humans known as "Halfmen" have multiple origins. In some cases, their ancestors were humans who utterly rejected all the trappings of civilized humanity, seeking simplicity in bestial non-thought. Others were created as human livestock, raw materials for the horrible appetites of alien or depraved human overlords or feedstock for occult rituals.

Halfmen look to be much like normal humans, but their physical similarities are rapidly overshadowed by their behavior. Halfmen in their native habitat never wear clothing or use tools, nor do they communicate in language more complex than grunts or lowing. They are found in herds of ten to thirty members under the protection of the biggest, strongest male. They graze as beasts do, tearing the grass with their teeth.

Their minds are largely those of cattle, especially while still within their herd. A Halfman separated from his herd will gradually gain human levels of intellect over the course of a few months, though the isolation is initially traumatic for them. Halfmen can be taught the use of language, clothing, and tools, but returning them to

Drudges are also given to a docile, obedient temperament, with violence almost unknown among them save in extreme self-defense. This has not prevented some groups from choosing the biggest and strongest among their Drudges and training them for war. This "training" usually consists of horrific abuse, tormenting the Drudge until it is desperate to do anything to avoid further punishment. These wretched "war Drudges" are artless and unskillful, but the strength in their limbs can pulp an ordinary man in a single blow.

Origin Focus: Drudge

You are remarkably intelligent for a Drudge, being able to understand abstract concepts, anticipate consequences, and conceive of hypothetical outcomes. You are also much more capable of violence than most of your kind.

Level 1: Gain Exert as a bonus skill. Your Strength and Constitution modifiers increase by +1, to a maximum of +2. Your Intelligence and Charisma modifiers decrease by -1, to a minimum of -2. You suffer a -2 penalty to all Mental saving throws.

their herd or allowing them to cluster together in similar numbers will rapidly erase these skills and dissolve any elements of their personality too complex for a beast.

Halfmen reproduce very rapidly, with infants able to walk from birth and attaining adulthood by two years of age. Unless separated from the herd, however, they rarely survive more than twenty or thirty years.

The existence of Halfman herds is partially responsible for the prevalence of maneating predators in the Latter Earth, as they condition them to hunt humans.

Origin Focus: Halfman

You have been separated from your herd. Your intellect has achieved human levels in the time since, and for whatever reason you no longer seek to return to them.

Level 1: Gain Survive as a bonus skill. Your Constitution modifier increases by +1, up to a +2 maximum. You are immune to natural extremes of heat and cold, and can digest any plant matter a normal ruminant could. Your isolation from the herd inflicts a -2 penalty on all Mental saving throws, however.

Halfmen	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Halfman Grazer	1	10	+1	1d2+1	None	30'	7	7	+1	15+
Halfman Bull	3	11	+4	1d2+3	None	30'	9	6	+1	14+

HOURIS

A Houri is a Blighted created for satisfying the particular physical and emotional needs of their owners. Whether male, female, or some more bespoke gender, Houris have been created almost since the first development of the arts of Blighting a line.

Houris come in innumerable flawless physical forms, usually characteristic of their particular creator's tastes and aesthetics. They usually live no longer than humans, but they preserve their exquisite beauty indefinitely, and do not grow feeble with old age.

Were they merely touched by this perfection, Houris would not be considered Blighted; what makes them objects of pity and subjection is the innate instinct of subservience woven into their psyches. Obedience to an order provides an intense wave of happiness and positive feeling to a Houri, whatever the order's nature or origin. Habitual cooperation can leave them emotionally addicted to the sensation. Many oppressed or hopeless Houris simply acquiesce to their nature and accept its rewards, trying only to resist cooperation with commands that might bring significant harm.

Houri	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Houri Concubine	1	10	+0	Wpn	Wpn	30'	7	8	+2	15+
Dispassionate One	6	11	+6	Wpn	Wpn/-	30'	12	0	+3	12+

A few select trusted companions or superiors and allow themselves to obey only orders given by that person. Others school themselves to a ruthless disinterest in their own emotional states, seeking logical or ideological standards to guide their choices rather than their own desires, even becoming accomplished ascetics and self-deniers of unflinching discipline. The Golden Path counts several Houris among the "Liberators" of their faith for having overcome the lure of emotional attachment.

Origin Focus: Houri

You've taught yourself to resist the lure of enforced happiness and seek other forms of satisfaction or personal integrity. While you gain an emotional rush from cooperating with commands, you don't let it control your decisions.

Level 1: Gain Convince and Perform as bonus skills.

Your Charisma modifier increases by +1, up to a maximum of +2. Your innate nature makes you susceptible to mental influence, however, inflicting a -2 penalty on Mental saving throws.

LIFTING THE BLIGHT

There's a certain kind of player who, upon discovering the existence of an irrevocably cursed species in the world, will immediately try to figure out how to lift the Blight. If a GM happens to be running a game for this kind of player, it's necessary to think carefully about the consequences of this goal.

The Blight is tremendously persistent. While it is not impossible for powerful magic and erudite sorcerous surgery to lift the Blight from individual beings or even specific bloodlines, purging it from an entire species might well be prohibitively difficult.

From a game perspective, the Blighted exist to create moral conflicts for the PCs. How should they treat people who cannot function in the same way that ordinary members of society can function? What rights should be accorded to them, and what kind of treatment is least likely to be abusive to them while still protecting them from their own debilities? If treating them exactly like baseline humans would merely ensure their exploitation and abuse, how much of their own freedoms should be curtailed for the sake of their own good, or should their inevitable mistreatment simply be accepted as the price of freedom? Or are there ways to effectively prevent abuse that won't prove impractical to implement?

Different groups will have different degrees of interest in these questions. Many of them will simply gloss over the issues, satisfied enough so long as Blighted aren't being mistreated in front of them. This is a perfectly valid way to play; even the most heroic band of adventurers can't interest themselves in every societal quandary they encounter, and most groups have much more interest in exciting adventures than meditations on social structure.

Others will be interested enough to try and eliminate the entire problem by lifting the Blight. This is one way to solve the problem; if the situation doesn't exist, it's not necessary to consider its ramifications. It's up to the group as a whole to decide whether or not this ambition is even possible in the campaign.

If it is possible, it's probably a major project of Impossible difficulty, with the scope depending on how large a population of Blighted are to be cured. Pursuing it will require vast amounts of magical equipment, Legacy alterations, arcane Workings, and perhaps even the discovery of the original documentation of the Blight that the PCs are trying to lift. If the whole group is interested in this goal, however, it's entirely acceptable for the GM to let them spend their time and efforts in seeking its glorious success.



DEMIHUMANS OF THE LATTER EARTH

The definition of “humanity” is somewhat broader in the Latter Earth than it would be in some other ages. Countless eons of sorcerous and genetic manipulation have left their mark on the modern population, and qualities that would be freakish or remarkable in other times now scarcely bear comment in most nations.

In the current age, the standard baseline human form is not unlike that of modern-day humanity. The same general build, body configuration, and range of coloration can be found in the humanity of the Latter Earth, and while other ages had somewhat different ideas about what constituted a “normal human”, those that live in the current era would not look out of place on a contemporary city street.

Yet within this definition of humanity there remain some considerable variances. Odd coloration of skin, hair, and eyes is one of the smallest such quirks, a remnant of some recessive aesthetic alteration, while slight differences in body configuration are also unusual but not unknown. Remnants of some customized genders exist in some lands, while the humanity of other nations might have been subtly altered to better accommodate local environmental conditions.

Despite these small differences, such people are still generally considered “humans” by their neighbors. Some cultural adjustments may be needed to integrate the more exotic examples, but few would consider such uncommon quirks to be disqualifying for humanity.

DEMIHUMANITY

This is not the case with those known as “demihumans”. The alterations they have received have been so profound and so reliably heritable that they are not considered to be quite the same as their baseline brethren. They may have radically different mentalities, significantly different physical requirements, or have mental or physical qualities that make it very difficult for them to integrate easily into baseline human societies.

At its edges, demihumanity is as much a social decision as a physiological one. Some variant lineages are considered demihuman in one land and mere exotic humanity in another. Such a difference is most significant when a society has separate rules for its human and demihuman members.

As a consequence, most demihuman lineages prefer to live in their own communities, either wholly independent or in a relationship of loose suzerainty with the local lord. There, they may live according to their own inclinations and be ruled by their own kind.

Most demihuman lineages were originally designed for a particular purpose, adjusted and augmented to serve the ends of some long-dead empire, god-king, or soulless Outsider scientist. They are often considerably more capable than baseline humanity in their special fields, but generally suffer some weakness or debility as

compensation. Their fertility is usually significantly less than that of ordinary humanity, and so their numbers are correspondingly fewer.

Those wretched demihumans known as the “Blighted” are a special case in most lands. The debilities they suffer are so obvious and so severe that they often cannot live among humans without some kind of oversight. In many lands this oversight is little more than slavery, and those Blighted cursed with a violent nature are often hunted down and killed on principle.

DEMIHUMANS IN THE GYRE

In the Gyre region of the Latter Earth, there are no significant demihuman nations aside from the Blighted domain of Sarul, where the Anak are in the majority and the only baseline humans are a few very discreet travelers and merchants. Persistent stories speak of vast dwarven empires deep beneath the Black Spine mountains or hidden elven realms concealed within ancient parallel Iterums, but these places are more legend than daily reality.

Smaller communities and demihuman fiefs do exist throughout the region, however, usually tucked away in isolated places of little value to baseline humans. Dwarven holds and Plan-built communities are found scattered in the mountains and hills, with some ancient Deeps reclaimed entirely by a dwarf-king. Communities of transhuman elves are sometimes found in the ancient ruins of the cities they once dwelled in during former lives, and other demihuman species can sometimes be found in small regional clusters where a viable breeding population can survive.

Human rulers generally have little to do with demihuman communities, demanding more or less tribute from them but otherwise leaving them be. The cost of open hostilities is too dear for either side, and demihumans simply aren’t expected to think and behave the same way baseline human subjects would.

CREATING DEMIHUMAN CHARACTERS

A player who wishes to make a demihuman PC can spend their initial free Focus pick on an origin Focus appropriate to their kind. If a GM is feeling charitable and there are several demihumans in the party, the GM might allow them to simply give up their usual second-level bonus Focus instead, so that they can start play with a little more mechanical distinctiveness among them.

PCs with particular novelties of shape, cognition, or nature that have no meaningful game mechanical effect do not need to take an origin Focus to represent such cosmetic differences. Only demihuman species that have real mechanical consequences require a Focus pick.

The adjacent page includes a selection of common, traditional demihuman species for use in more traditional campaign settings. Elf and dwarf PCs in the Latter Earth would use the writeups under their bestiary entries.

DEMIHUMANS FOR OTHER SETTINGS

These Foci can be used to create PCs from variant demihuman races that may exist in a particular GM's campaign. GMs who are using *Worlds Without Number* as a toolset for their own campaign settings might also use them to replicate more "traditional" elves, dwarves, halflings, and other common fantasy races.

Some Foci grant bonuses or penalties to attribute modifiers. None of these modifiers can exceed +2 or fall below -2. Some Foci also allow the player to choose which attribute is to be increased or penalized, depending on their particular interpretation of the species.

Dwarves

This origin serves for the classical dwarf; short, sturdy, and given to craftsmanship and drinking.

Level 1: Gain Craft as a bonus skill. Your Constitution modifier increases by +1 and either your Dexterity or Charisma modifier decreases by -1. You can see in the dark up to sixty feet.

Elves, Civilized

This style of elf represents the city-dwelling, magic-loving, sophisticated interpretation of elvishness favored in some worlds.

Level 1: Gain Know and Magic as bonus skills. Your Dexterity or Intelligence modifier increases by +1 and your Constitution modifier decreases by -1. You can see clearly in any light level above complete darkness.

Elves, Half-Elves

Where there are both elves and humans, half-elves tend to be inevitable additions to a campaign world. This Focus follows the "between two worlds" flavor of most half-elf interpretations.

Level 1: Gain Connect and any one skill as bonus skills. You can see out to thirty feet in any light condition short of perfect darkness. At your discretion, if you take after your elven parent, you may increase your Dexterity modifier by +1 but then also take a -1 to your Constitution modifier.

Elves, Forest

This interpretation of elvishness is for those kinds given to nature-reverence, archery, and nimbleness.

Level 1: Gain Shoot and Survive as bonus skills. Your Dexterity modifier increases by +1 and your Constitution modifier decreases by -1. You can see clearly in any light level above complete darkness.

Halflings

This origin serves for a breed of bucolic and diminutive demihumans with exceptional reserves of toughness.

Level 1: Gain Sneak as a bonus skill. Your Constitution or Dexterity modifier increases by +1. You are too small to effectively use two-handed melee weapons or large bows.

Gnomes

Gnomish interpretations vary significantly, from mad tinkers to forest sprites. The origin below suits a subterranean forest-dweller; for tinkers, replace Sneak as a bonus skill with Craft.

Level 1: Gain Sneak as a bonus skill. Your Dexterity modifier increases by +1 and your Strength or Wisdom modifier decreases by -1. You can see clearly in the dark out to sixty feet.

Goblins, Tinker

This variety of goblin is for those campaign settings where they are inveterate builders.

Level 1: Gain Craft as a bonus skill. Your Dexterity or Intelligence modifier increases by +1, and your Wisdom modifier decreases by -1. You have the weapon restrictions of halflings. You can see clearly in the dark out to sixty feet.

Goblins, Savage

Feral tribe-dwelling marauders of swamp, forest, and wasteland, this style of goblin can also fill in for other small, vicious humanoid.

Level 1: Gain Sneak and Survive as bonus skills. Your Dexterity modifier increases by +1, but your Intelligence modifier decreases by -1. You have the weapon restrictions of halflings. You can see clearly in the dark out to sixty feet.

Lizardmen

Whether dressed up as dragon-folk or left as common crocodilian swamp lizardmen, this Focus can fill in the details.

Level 1: Gain Stab and Survive as bonus skills. Your Strength or Charisma modifier increases by +1, but your Dexterity or Charisma modifier decreases by -1. Your unarmored Armor Class is 13, and if you wear better armor you get a +1 bonus to its AC.

Level 2: You're some sort of dragon-man and can breathe fire, frost, or some other noxious substance. The breath can be done once per scene and affects a cone up to 15 feet long and wide at its end. All within must make an appropriate save or take 2d6 damage plus your character level. You gain immunity to the substance you exhale.

Orcs

Large, strong, brutish, and comparatively stupid; such is the standard orc of fantasy campaigns. Players who want to play such a PC can use this Focus.

Level 1: Gain Survive and Stab or Punch as bonus skills. Your Strength or Constitution modifier increases by +1, but your Intelligence modifier decreases by -1. You can see clearly in the dark out to sixty feet.



DWARVES

Reclusive, strange, and Deep-dwelling, the folk of Latter Earth known as “dwarves” are a relic of the long dark age of the Outsiders. They are living tools for the manipulation of the Legacy, beings gifted with an intuitive ability to twist and subvert that power’s effects.

During the period of alien rule, the Outsiders were repeatedly stymied by failsafes and locks embedded in the Legacy, security measures that could only be overcome by humans. While individual quislings and traitors could be found in the human population, they were neither numerous nor skilled enough to accomplish the Outsiders’ ends.

As a consequence, the ancestors of the dwarves were extracted from the human chattel of the aliens and altered to become living interfaces with the Legacy, sentient intrusion measures that could be directed to warp the energies of that force into the service of the Outsiders. The hubris of the aliens was such that they had not anticipated that the very abilities they had cultivated in the dwarves were the same ones they would use to break their obedience conditioning and rebel against their creators.

In the long ages since the fall of the Outsiders the dwarves have remained largely in the Deeps, obsessed with their own Great Plans and seized with an unending quest for the perfect harmony of creation. Some dwarven nations have made contact with surface-dwellers, either for trade or conquest, but the majority of dwarves found on the surface in this age are rebels or recusants from the Great Plan of their homeland. Some merely wish to be free of the burden of their ruler’s dreams, while others nurse visions of their own.

DWARVEN PHYSIOLOGY

As natives of the Deeps, dwarves are compact compared to baseline humans. Males seldom stand over four and a half feet tall, while females average four feet. Most have a powerful, broadly-built frame, though there are some substrains that are built very leanly, and a few that look like small, perfectly-proportioned humans. Facial hair is usually found only on the males, its presence or absence dictated by the fashions of their homeland.

Dwarves have an intuitive sense of their surroundings, one derived from their constant low-level integration with the Legacy. This “dwarfsight” is equivalent to monochrome human vision out to a distance of twenty feet, regardless of light levels or fogs. It cannot penetrate solid surfaces but can be aimed in any direction by the dwarf, regardless of their facing, as an On Turn action.

The harsh austerities of the Deeps have been encoded into the dwarven metabolism. Dwarves require only half the food, water, and air that standard humans do. They tend to live for considerably longer than their baseline cousins, maintaining good health into their third century before rapidly declining over a few years.

DWARVEN PSYCHOLOGY

All dwarves have a subconscious connection with the Legacy, a product of their created purpose. This awareness tends to manifest in the form of an intense love of order and coherent structure; dwarves will build both physical objects and social structures with equal enthusiasm and show an innate talent for engineering, mathematics, and other logically-rigorous pursuits.

A dwarf wholly given to the creation of some great work or societal reformation is said to have a “Plan”. A dwarven nation will invariably be fired by some high societal ideal; their envisioned utopia is said to be their “Great Plan”, one which all its members are expected to embrace and assist in creating.

Unfortunately for dwarven unity, it is perfectly possible for two dwarves to have diametrically opposed ideas about what constitutes “order and coherent structure”. Depending on the dissonance of their ideals, relations between dwarven groups can range from careful courtesy to genocidal hatred. Individual dwarves who cannot accept the Great Plan of their society will tend to leave it, either to become wanderers, to find a home with a small community of like-minded recusants, or to establish their own shining Plan for others to embrace.

Origin Focus: Dwarf

Your PC is a dwarf, a demihuman weapon-race devised during the ancient rule of the Outsiders. You are probably a recusant from some dwarven polity, though it could be you are a loyal believer in your homeland’s ideals who simply wants to see more of the world before returning home and helping in their Great Plan.

Level 1: Gain Craft as a bonus skill. You have the dwarven surrounding-sense out to twenty feet, able to distinguish solid objects as if you were using your sense of sight. You have a natural resistance to magic, gaining a +2 bonus on all saves against hostile magical effects. You need only half the usual amount of food, water, and air and gain a +1 bonus to your hit point die at each level.

Level 2: You have such a deep connection with your dwarven nature that once per day, as an Instant action, you can simply negate an unwanted magical effect that would otherwise affect you. If you accept one System Strain point, you can use this ability to negate a magical effect you can see or otherwise sense, provided it’s within one hundred feet. This ability applies only to spellcasting, relatively minor standing enchantments, and creature-generated magic; it cannot negate Workings, suppress magic items, or nullify effects created by magic items or exceptionally potent rituals. Note that NPC dwarves of more than 2 hit dice will also have this ability.

ENCOUNTERING DWARVES

Most dwarves remain in the underground dwarfholds, laboring together with their like-minded brethren in subterranean clans and buried under-towns. A given hold is usually only occupied by one society of dwarves, as only the most unusually sympathetic Plans can exist in close proximity. Where more than one Plan exists in an area, the usual result is bloody warfare until the weaker is expelled, extinguished, or abandoned by its followers.

Adventurers within the Deeps sometimes stumble on dwarf-gardens of edible fungi or underherds of insectile meat-beasts shepherded by the dwarves. These agricultural efforts require very specific environments, and it's not uncommon for the dwarves to end up fighting interlopers in order to keep the best farming caves. A hungry dwarfhold must usually rely on its surface ties to buy food, or else make a desperate sally to claim new farming caves before it's too late for them.

Dwarves tend to be naturally mistrustful of strangers entering their territories, though the prospect of sharing the good news of their Plan is oftentimes enough to make them open up. Many dwarfholds have active trade links with the outside world, using the contact as an opportunity to push their ideology on traders. Most merchants have the sense to sound politely interested for as long as is necessary. The dwarves are so confident of the self-evident rightness of their cause that they consider it only a matter of time before outsiders convert.

Outside of their deep holds, dwarves are found in prospecting bands, salvage crews, and military patrols. None of these groups will usually be looking for trouble, but neither will they tolerate interference.

Dwarves have numerous active magical traditions, but they rarely work in the same way as human mages. Most rely on the innate link with the Legacy that dwarves possess, and use small devices and cunningly-crafted artifacts to create magical effects. A dwarven artificer might have the equivalent magical abilities of a second or third level Mage, but their spells will be cast using devices that the artificer has crafted. Such use has the same limits and usage requirements as conventional spellcasting.

Some dwarves are outcasts or renegades against the Plan of their home community. These wanderers vary wildly in temperament; some are fanatics with a different Plan in mind, while others are bandits, raiders, lunatics, or incurably curious voyagers. In rare cases, a particularly charismatic dwarf might establish an entire village of such exiles. Discussions of the merits of individual Plans there are usually vigorously discouraged.

DWARVES IN THE GYRE

Like other demihuman species, dwarves are uncommon in the Gyre. There are no major dwarven states on the surface or significant regional powers to compare with the former provinces of the Brass Hegemony. In many parts of the Gyre, dwarves are nothing more than a name known to scholars and wanderers, and a dwarf who ventured there would probably be treated as nothing but a short, squat human.

Small dwarven domains do exist in certain lands, however, with some being found in the hills of Thur, beneath the sprawling exurban growth of the New City in Ka-Adun, or in old settlements within the Black Spine mountain range. These domains usually consist of nothing more than a single hold or community that shares a single Plan, with those recusants unable to agree with it left to wander the world alone and friendless. As the work of a Plan can only be carried on among like-minded believers, only dwarven outcasts, merchants, mercenaries, proselytizers, and other lonesome souls have any great cause to leave their ancient homes.

Human lords with dwarven communities within their land generally follow a policy of arm's-length rule, appointing a reeve to collect taxes and relay petitions. The internal affairs of the hold are strictly ignored by all but the most megalomaniacal rulers; the cost of bringing a dwarfhold to heel would be ruinous to petty lords and unprofitable to great ones. The dwarves generally reciprocate by concerning themselves with their own affairs and avoiding entanglements with other surfacers.

Every so often, however, dwarven holds are convulsed by changes in the Plan, either because it has become impossible to further the goal or some new interpretation of order has risen among the populace. During these periods of savage civil strife, whole holds can become lost or abandoned, seeded full of traps by the warring factions or rendered hazardous by the fighting. The survivors usually migrate elsewhere to start anew, but the remains of the dwarfhold continue to draw interest from "salvagers" and outcast dwarves who want to start their own wondrous Plan there.

Much vaster dwarven kingdoms than these are said to exist deep below the surface, locked in eternal struggles with horrible creatures forgotten by the sunlit world. These deep-dwelling dwarves have no reason to bother with the surface, but every so often a story emerges of some mighty dwarf-king's relics being buried at the bottom of a great Deep or fathoms-long cave complex. Sometimes, these tales are even true.

Dwarves	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Dwarven Laborer	1	13a	+1	Wpn	Wpn	30'	9	4	+1	15+
Dwarven Veteran	2	16a	+3	Wpn+1	Wpn+1	30'	9	3	+1	14+
Dwarven Artificer	6	11	+5	Wpn	Wpn	30'	9	4	+2	12+
Dwarven Lord	10	20a	+11 x2	Wpn+5	Wpn+5/-	30'	10	2	+2	10+
Dwarven King	12	22a	+12 x2	Wpn+5	Wpn+5/-	20'	12	1	+2	9+



ELVES

Death has not always been the universal fate of humanity. At some distant point in the past the rulers of Earth had managed to encode immortality into the Legacy, ensuring the deathless persistence of human identity. It's unclear whether this universal immortality was lost before the arrival of the Outsiders or as a result of the alien conquest, and some sages hypothesize that it was actually restored more than once in the ages since. In every instance, however, the decay of the Legacy or hostile interference returned the scourge of death to the world.

For all humanity, at least, except those transhumans known as "elves". For whatever inexplicable reason, these few identities were capable of evading permanent death, reincarnating with their identities at least partially intact after each physical discorporation.

Scholars argue over the true origins of the elves, some insisting that the original elves were surpassingly powerful sorcerers who forced the Legacy to grant them eternal existence. Others believe that the elves are mere mistakes in the Legacy, souls that slipped through the filter that would otherwise purge their memories of past lives. Some even say that the elves were the ones who originally restored death to the world, a band of jealous transhumans who wished to keep immortality for their own identities alone. Evidence can be marshaled for all these theories, but proof remains elusive.

ELVEN PHYSIOLOGY

Elves are usually incarnated as the children of other elves, born in ways biologically typical for humans. In some cases, however, the Legacy will instantiate a new body out of inanimate matter, forcing an elf back into existence with whatever raw materials are to hand. Such "worldborn" elves often have visible traits related to their original material, such as smooth gray skin for one born of a granite boulder, or flowered locks for one called forth from a blossoming tree.

The original transhuman nature of elves persists in their instantiated bodies. Elves are invariably well-formed beings, physically healthy and mentally unimpaired at the time of their birth. Most have taller and more slender builds than the average baseline human, and their bodies are imbued with a host of small aesthetic upgrades that tend to give them an air of flawless but alien perfection as compared to their human cousins.

While the elven body is created without significant flaws, it is no stronger, hardier, or quicker than a standard human body. Its senses are considerably sharper, however, and an elf can detect scents, sounds, and other stimuli at thresholds substantially finer than normal humans can.

Elves do not physically age beyond vigorous adulthood. The only way for them to die is through violence, poisons, or disease, after which they will be reborn to elven parents somewhere else in the Latter Earth within the next forty days.

ELVEN PSYCHOLOGY

While the baseline elven mind is similar to that of a human's, it is burdened by a tremendous weight of memory. Each rebirth crashes a tidal wave of new stimuli and sensory inputs into the elf's brain, and whatever measures the Legacy was originally intended to use to help them integrate these memories have long since decayed. Elven children recall only disjointed elements of their past.

Elves treat their past-life memories with great caution. To seek to delve too deeply in them risks the loss of their current identity as past memories crush the thoughts of their current life. Long-dead elves can end up possessing their own mental heirs, the living elf's own wishes and memories contemptuously drowned in the overwhelming stimulus of a past life.

In some cases this process is intentionally provoked by an elf in great distress, voluntarily sacrificing their present identity to welcome in the memories of a powerful prior identity. This "incarnation" is uncertain in its effects, but it's not impossible for a simple farmer to suddenly awaken the skills of a long-dead warrior king.

Some elves keenly feel the weight of their past existences, and strive to extinguish their lives permanently in order to escape a world that no longer provides them any joy. Such elves are often the prophets or proponents of faiths that reject the world, such as the Golden Path, for only a truly divine degree of power can force the Legacy to let a weary elven soul finally find its grave.

Origin Focus: Elf

You are a reincarnated transhuman, shards of your former life still lingering in your memories. The more intently you focus on developing and integrating these fragments, the more effectively you can call on them.

Elves are invariably devoid of obvious mental or physical debilities. If you have any attribute scores below 9, you must move points from your other attributes to raise the deficient ones up to a score of 9. You may decide which attribute points to shift. Afflictions incurred after play begins can lower your attributes below this floor.

If your PC is killed, it will reincarnate eventually, but it will likely be at a place far distant from the campaign. Such new incarnations are unlikely to ever be met again, and may not even remember anything particularly compelling about their most recent past life.

Level 1: Pick any skill as a bonus skill reflecting your past memories. You may reroll a failed skill check in this skill once per day. You have extremely sharp senses, gaining Notice as a bonus skill and being able to see clearly in anything short of complete darkness.

Level 2: Pick a mental attribute; gain +1 to your ability modifier in it, up to a maximum of +3 as you draw on past memories. Pick any skill as an additional bonus skill.

ENCOUNTERING ELVES

Most elves remain secluded in their own communities, preferring the company of those who can understand the burdens of their memories. The relative rarity of these transhumans makes elven nations few in number and small in population, but scattered elven “retreats” are not unknown in other lands, often deep within the wilderness where they will not be bothered by human rulers.

Those elves that leave their retreats generally do so for a specific reason. They may have some task left undone from a prior life, or a debt yet unpaid, or a vengeance in need of execution. A few adventure through the world simply in search of new stimuli and exciting new experiences. These elves will cheerfully cooperate with any plan that promises to give them something new to enjoy, though most will avoid enterprises that they don’t expect to survive.

Given the weight of their memories, it’s not uncommon for elves to become talented mages who can draw on multiple lifetimes for their skills. Such occult meditation is dangerous, however, as those lives that were most capable in sorcery are often those lives most likely to overwhelm the identity of a young or unprepared elf. Most elven sorcerers are the equivalent of third or fourth level High Mages, though the rare arch-memorist who has successfully integrated multiple lives might be the equivalent of eighth, ninth, or even tenth level.

Meeting with unknown elves always has a measure of danger. While some elves maintain a moral code similar to that of the local human nations, others subscribe to beliefs or goals that are either incomprehensible or repugnant to humanity. They might think nothing of sacrificing countless “transients” in pursuit of their grand goals, and consider their immortality to be tangible proof of their superiority over the evanescent humans around them. Charismatic elves of this kind can sometimes sway a considerable number of their peers to their cause, building dark purposes that threaten ruin and misery on humanity, all for the sake of some pleasure or excitement unknowable to ones not so jaded as they.

Elves are usually encountered as solitary adventurers when far from their retreats. When groups of locals are encountered, there will usually be 1d4+1 of them going about their business, while the retreats themselves usually house 10d20 elves of varying degrees of personal power and societal role. The very largest city-refuges may house as many as a thousand elves.

Elves	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Elven Villager	1	13a	+1	Wpn	Wpn	30’	9	2	+2	15+
Elven Adventurer	3	15a	+5	Wpn+2	Wpn+2	30’	10	2	+2	14+
Elven Sorcerer	5	10	+3	Wpn	Wpn	30’	9	1	+2	13+
Elven Lord	10	20a	+11 x2	Wpn+5	Wpn+5/-	30’	10	1	+3	10+
Elven Arch-Memorist	10	13	+8	Wpn+3	Wpn+3/-	30’	10	0	+4	10+

Elven Sorcerers cast spells and have arts as per a third or fourth level High Mage, while arch-memorists cast as an eighth to tenth level High Mage. Effort is equal to their skill bonus plus two.

ELVES IN THE GYRE

Much as with dwarves, there are no major elven polities within the Gyre region or kingdoms dominated by these transhumans. Several small elven holdings persist in Emed-Kist among their Darian rulers, and there are persistent stories of surviving elven communities within the jungles of Lost Emed. Other refuges have been established in New Voth, and a few particularly hard-handed ones have found a home in the Llaigisan hills.

Elves are very rare in the common populace, but graced enough to escape any stigma of Blight. Where they are solitary wanderers, they tend to be viewed as just another near-human sport of nature, a handsome man or pretty maid with unusually sharp senses.

The physical grace and beauty of their kind have made problems for elves before when dealing with barbarous lords or acquisitive slavers. It’s not unknown for an exceptionally handsome or beautiful elf to be sought for cruel purposes, but such practices are extremely hazardous for an owner. An elf driven to desperate ends and given time to carefully interrogate their memories may be willing to commit the identity-suicide of self-reincarnation and call up a prior life that is fully capable of slaughtering a royal household with their bare hands.

Most lords that claim the territory in which an elven refuge is found are content to receive a tribute in goods and services from the demihumans, profiting by the superb craftsmanship of centuries-old artisans. The elves of the refuge repay this hands-off rule by avoiding entanglements with local powers, with adventurers and leavetakers faring far from their homeland.

Elves usually choose particular ancient sites or remnant Workings for their refuges, taking advantage of their memories to exploit the surviving magics and secrets of the place. Their homes are beautiful and intricately-fashioned, often in a manner reminiscent of long-lost empires and forgotten peoples that were once dear to them.

Legends persist of greater communities than these, however, and of entire elven kingdoms folded away in hidden Iterums and shadowy half-worlds. Strange elven knights of unheard-of lands are sometimes spotted in the Gyre on errands unknowable to others. Some locals maintain that these transhumans are but catspaws and envoys of greater and more awful powers beyond the veil of common space and time, that they are the merest shadow of the terrible inhuman dreams of things that can no longer be called human at all.



IMPERATORS

Those beings known as “Imperators” are a broad class of demiurges, sorcerer-kings, god-emperors, sentient Legacy fragments, arch-Legates, alien overminds, demi-divine artificial intellects, and other such creatures with power far in excess of any ordinary human being. A being that is more than a human yet less than an inarguable god is generally described as an Imperator in the writings of the sages.

Innumerable Imperators have appeared in the annals of the Latter Earth, often mentioned in brief passing for some tremendous work or empire they wrought, only to vanish out of human memory a short age later. Some scholars suppose that there have been more Imperators in the past of the world than there are harlots currently employed in it, and most would credit the harlots with superior virtue.

For it is a sadly common quality to Imperators that they should eventually lose most of the qualities that modern humans would call “virtue”. Something about the ascent to unchallenged supremacy and near-godlike puissance erodes whatever reserves of self-discipline and restraint the Imperator might possess. Without anyone to forbid them their wishes, and with a brilliant mind perfectly capable of conjuring excuses for the worst excess, an Imperator almost invariably sinks into a morass of self-indulgent horrors and brutal atrocities. The *Tsagasthos Incunabulum* purports to be a catalog of the pleasures pursued by the Imperator Tsagasthos the Prevalent; the activities listed in this codex are so horrific in their character and so persuasively justified by the author that possession of the book is usually considered grounds for summary execution of the owner and their household and the burning of the work by a blinded executioner. Thirty-six different Blighted species of cattle-humans, trifoliate odalisques, gladiator-sages, dolorous vivants, and worse are credited directly to ‘Tsagasthos’ appetites, and its worst crimes were the inspiration for several black cults that plague the Latter Earth still.

Tsagasthos was not exceptional. While the particularly carnal nature of its horrors was somewhat uncommon, the obsession with satisfying personal goals and a bloodless indifference to the suffering of others was a trait common to most of its brethren. Almost all were convinced of the superiority of their wisdom, the justification for their desires, and the complete depravity of any who would dare oppose their wishes. The struggles between Imperators have shaped whole ages of the Latter Earth, and the relics of their wars and the ruins of their thrones yet burden the land with their awful weight.

Not all Imperators were wholly wicked, however, and some may still nurse some remnant of virtue or higher duty in their analog for a heart. Most of these gentler Imperators still look outside their own desires for a moral code, often remaining in service to some

god or higher power they can still respect as a superior. Some are simply of a character to remain compassionate and restrained even with the constant temptation of their own power to seduce them. Such just Imperators often stand as bulwarks against the works of their more ruthless brethren, though it is not unknown for such unending wars to turn even the kindest god-king into an obsessed tyrant.

In the present age, Imperators are few and usually legendary in the regions where they dwell. Immortal emperors, divine avatars, mythic monsters, and other figures of superhuman glory beyond that of a Legate are often credited as Imperators, though the stain that clings to the name often makes such comparisons less than flattering. They leave the imprint of their will on whatever nations, institutions, or regions they may command, often in wholly impossible or magical ways.

IMPERATORS IN YOUR CAMPAIGN

While it’s possible to stud your campaign setting with a few of these demigods, either as arch-antagonists for the PCs or as vast environmental hazards to be negotiated, it’s often more convenient to use them as shorthand for specific ancient empires or lost kingdoms to help supply a pleasant variety of ruins, Deeps, and monuments to explore. Personalizing a nation as a single leader helps shorthand things for players who may not be all that interested in a nuanced history lesson, and tying them into modern ruins helps give a sense of depth to your setting’s past.

Still, if you want to use them as active players in your setting, you’ll need to keep a few things in mind when designing them.

They can’t be beaten head-on. An Imperator is effectively unstoppable in a direct confrontation. The PCs are going to have to somehow disrupt the source of their power, find their hidden weakness, marshal powerful allies, or otherwise tilt the table to have any chance of winning. If they do these things, then the Imperator might just end up with the stat block of a monstrously powerful foe rather than being an automatic victor.

They want impossible things. An Imperator should always want something that’s flatly impossible. It’s for petty mortals to seek world conquest; it’s for an Imperator to seek the retroactive temporal elimination of any potential rival. Their plans, sub-goals, and choice of servants should reflect this impossible goal.

They have minions with their own goals. The servants and underlings of an Imperator cast their lot with it because it can give them something they want. The PCs will likely spend much of their time dealing with subordinates who may or may not be entirely loyal, and overcoming or suborning these minions might be a key step in opening the Imperator up for a mortal blow.



IMPERATORS OF THE GYRE

The only well-known potential Emperor in the Gyre region is the Reaping King himself; while he has not openly exerted any remarkable personal might, he is evidently immortal and completely unconcerned with assassins. All direct attempts at eliminating him have failed in spectacular and brutal fashion.

Aside from the Reaping King, several ancient figures in the region are commonly credited as Emperors, and have left appropriate ruins in their former lands.

Acalis: The Good Emperor, of the Nagadi demihuman race. The Nagadi were engineered for virtue, being far more brave, honest, compassionate, and diligent than baselines, and Acalis was their exemplar. He once ruled the Great Benevolence in the human lands that became Emed-Mar, but left with his people “into elsewhere” when he became convinced that associating with humanity was going to morally deprave him. He left behind monumental public works of noble proportions full of dangerously incorruptible guardians and the Nagadi who would not leave; the latter treat humans like Anakim.

Nakris: The Hive Queen, known only from relics and statues in the Black Spine range. She was some sort of god-queen to the Jikegadi, her parasitical spawn being incredibly vigorous and swift to grow. The Jikegadi ruins of her era are full of biological parasite dangers and toxic Outsider environments.

Qwoll: The Drowned King, lord of an island realm to the north of the Gyre that was overcome by a monstrous Outsider invasion. To kill the intruders he submerged the entire archipelago, the Sisters being

its only remnant. His people are said to dwell still below the waves, coral-boned and pearl-eyed and determined to someday bring their rule to every land that is touched by salt water.

Shun: The Lord of Flesh and Bone, an arch-mutator who raised the Rule of Shun in Republic-era Llaigis and perished to his own attempt to become a physical god. He left many laboratories, monstrous breeding-pits, subject-prisons, and healing shrines behind.

Tsagasthos: The Prevalent One, a psychic virus that embodied itself in the brains of thousands of slaves. It ruled present-day Ka-Adun and the Rebel Coast until overcome by Voth in the expansion of her empire. Its ruins are of structures of physical pleasure and sensory experience, both sweet and hideous. Fragments of its psyche remain in creatures there, and they grow stronger with proximity to each other.

Ubarun: The Dwarf King, progenitor of the Great Plan of the Graven World. He set his dwarven followers on a quest to work, carve, engrave, and sculpt every material object, themselves included, into the vast pattern he laid down for them. Pockets of his believers remain in the Deeps, but most know them only by the occasional Deep full of incredibly complex engravings, intricate machinery, and lethal counter-intrusion measures.

Voth: The Mentarch, Emperor-Queen of the Vothite Empire. While immortal, she vanished once her line of heirs was established, telling them only that it was “necessary to the Purpose”. The Imperial ruins her nation left behind are filled with memetically resonant objects that can impress ideas, compulsions, or entire alien minds on unwary intruders.



OUTSIDERS

The malevolent or inscrutable remnants of the ancient Outsiders that once ruled the Latter Earth have not been entirely extirpated. Here and there, pockets of surviving alien sentients can be found, most often in the more remote, dangerous, and xenoformed areas of the planet. Many have regressed in both artifice and culture, some little more than savage barbarians burning with a hatred for their former slaves. Others have preserved some remnant of their former arcane might.

The three species described here are relatively well-known in the Gyre, as described on page 110. GMs who wish to use them as antagonists, environmental hazards, or profoundly untrustworthy allies of convenience can use the statistics given here.

JIKEGIDA

These Outsiders are almost never encountered alone, with at least 2d4 members found in even the smallest hunting party. Such parties are invariably out searching for suitable hosts for Jikegida spawn and will be equipped with trusses, carrying poles, and other gear for transporting prisoners. A small mother-hive might contain a hundred of these Outsiders, while their remaining hive-cities deep in the Black Spine could house thousands.

Most Jikegida are relatively frail “beast-born” types, often with visible animalistic traits from their original host and an intellect slightly inferior to that of a normal human. The “man-born” Jikegida are a half-foot taller and considerably smarter, usually acting as leaders. Some of them even have magical abilities not unlike those of human wizards.

Jikegida use mechanical weaponry, as their limbs are weaker than human arms. Their “throwers” function much like soft pellet-hurling crossbows but can be reload-

ed as a Move action, and their “cracklers” are maces with stunning, electrified heads. While both inflict non-lethal damage, neither weapon functions in non-Jikegida hands, the Legacy forbidding them from human use.

A few Jikegida still have access to organic construction exoskeletons formed out of the tissues of various slave races and fueled by the flesh of unsuitable host candidates. Originally intended to aid their weak limbs in constructing their hexagonal cities, they have been repurposed for war. Many of these exoskeletons have been destroyed and few remaining hive-cities are capable of building them. Those that remain are usually kept back at the hive or hunting camp for defensive purposes.

A Jikegida wearing a construction exoskeleton gains 20 hit points, a +2 bonus to hit, and a +2 bonus on all damage rolls or Shock. Many exoskeletons incorporate the natural defenses or abilities of the creatures used in their construction, with poison sprays, tremendous mobility, sonic shrieks, or other offensive or defensive abilities.

As a matter of policy, the Jikegida will always release at least one captured prisoner from among those who surrender to them in order to encourage future prey to lay down their arms. Those prey species who cooperate against their own kind are often chosen for release, resulting in certain ugly stories of caravan guards turned traitor to save their own skins.

Once captured by a Jikegida hunting party, some hope of rescue remains if a strong force can quickly retrieve them from a mother-hive. Every so often, however, an ancient Jikegida crawler-machine is sent from a hive-city to the mother-hives to collect a tribute of wretched humans. Those who vanish into the great machine’s bowels can have no real hope of avoiding their terrible fate.



POLOP

While a veteran Polop hunter sometimes finds pleasure in a solo hunt for human prey, most small feasting expeditions consist of at least 1d6+1 of these crab-eel abominations, while an attack meant to reave a coastal village usually numbers at least 20+2d20 of them. Their forward outposts of living coral house twenty to thirty Polop, while the deep-sea cities are reported to contain tens of thousands of the aliens, according to the few who have ever escaped them.

Polop make extensive use of monstrous alien sea life as weapons, transport, and utility. Listed here is the “hellsquid”, a claw-tentacled, octopodal attack beast that can operate on land and that is sometimes found with hunting parties. At sea, huge leviathans of hideous aspect are often employed to destroy troublesome human ships, though such vast creatures are reluctant to approach too closely to the shore.

While the Polop who invade the land are usually of the hunter or slaver varieties, legends speak of the living gods of the Polop, those of them who have eaten so much and of so many mighty foes that they become the awe-inspiring patrons of entire Polop cities. These “great devourers” are twice the size of ordinary Polop, but lack nothing of cunning and cruel intellect.

For their own equipment, Polop prefer to use living sea organisms sorced into suitable weapons and scaly armor. Their “spitters” cough bone darts that function as thrown light spears, and the spears and slave-taking clubs they use are of a living coral. The weapons of their leaders sweat a venom that forces a victim that is struck to make a Physical save or lose their next turn’s Main Action. Two failed saving throws in the same scene means the victim is paralyzed for the remainder of the scene.

Parties out to gather food-slaves will prefer to take living prisoners, as the Polop prefer their food conscious while it is being consumed. These prisoners will be smeared with a viscous green gel that allows them to breathe water and ignore the ocean’s chill for the next twenty-four hours, before being carried down into the depths. Polop outposts will have air-filled feeding pens for holding these slaves, while the cities have entire herd quarters where whole generations of humans are raised as meat for the Polop lords.

TUHULOT

The Tuhulot are a cowardly but exceedingly cunning species, loving nothing so much as the preservation of their facsimile of life. The jerking puppet-shapes they use to interface with mundane reality are always kept safely behind a screen of dupes, traitors, and hired help, and only in great necessity will a Tuhulot ever put itself in a position where it might face physical destruction.

Tuhulot always have a purpose in being wherever they are. They are trying to destroy one of the keys to their ancient binding, whether that key is at the center of some ancient ruin, incarnated in a particular human bloodline, or manifesting in some organization or religion’s particular teachings. The keys are not always physical; some are particular complexes of belief that must be discredited. To this end the Tuhulot will use its abilities to build a power base and enlist catspaws. Some of these minions may be knowing and willing servitors, as the key the Tuhulot is trying to destroy may be related to their own enmities or goals.

Tuhulot have several magical powers specific to their kind, most usable as a Main Action three times per day. Their *scrying gaze* allows them to observe a particular point within ten miles for up to a scene as if they were standing there, assuming magical wards don’t forfend them. Their *blandishing voice* bends the mind of a single target on a failed Mental save, making it friendly toward the Tuhulot until the creature does something obviously hostile. Their *sidewards step* lets them teleport to any location within a mile they’ve occupied before, provided neither their current location nor their destination is directly illuminated by sunlight. Finally, their *soul consumption* power allows them to eat the memories and identity of a helpless sentient victim over the course of a torturous hour. The victim becomes a passive meat puppet for the Tuhulot, carrying out its orders with total obedience and human levels of intellect, but with all trace of its former personality erased. The only way to cure the victim is for the Tuhulot to give back the soul, a thing which it will do only for a suitable price.

Tuhulot do not generally use material weapons, fighting when they must with slivers of distorted space and time. These semi-transparent fragments have a range out to one hundred feet.

Outsiders	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Jikegida Beastborn	1	13	+2	Wpn-1	Wpn-1	30'	8	5	+1	15+
Jikegida Manborn	2	13	+3	Wpn	Wpn	30'	9	4	+1	14+
Jikegida Hive Leader	6	18a	+7 x2	Wpn+2	Wpn+2	30'	10	3	+2	13+
Jikegida City Lord	14	20a	+14 x2	Wpn+4	8/-	30'	10	3	+2	8+
Polop Hunter	3	10	+5	Wpn+2	Wpn+2	30'	8	4	+1	14+
Polop Slaver	7	12	+6 x2	Wpn+3	Wpn+3	30'	9	3	+1	12+
Polop Hellsquid	5	13	+5 x4	1d8+2	None	40'	8	5	+1	13+
Polop Great Devourer	20	15	+20 x3	2d8+5	10/-	40'	11	7	+2	5+
Tuhulot Manipulator	10	15	+12 x2	2d8	4/-	50'	7	3	+2	10+



UNDEAD

As the work of generations of necromancers demonstrates, death is not an invariable condition in the Latter Earth. The Legacy that controls and directs all natural processes in the world is not without flaws or deviations, and sometimes a creature that ought properly to be rotting in the grave is denied the finality of a natural end. These wretched “undead” range from mindless animated corpses to phantasmal identity-imprints to entities largely indistinguishable from normal humans. Most of them are inimical to normal life, either out of malice or out of a sheer incompatibility of existence.

While a sufficiently skilled necromancer can force the Legacy glitching that causes undeath, the phenomenon is also known to happen to those who die with great causes unfinished, those who perish because of powerful and disruptive magical effects, or those who die while under the effects of potent curses. Deeps and other places of great magical power are known for a high incidence of accidental undeath, and there are some breeds of Blighted who are intrinsically cursed with the certainty of an unquiet grave. Some necromantic plagues convert their victims into undead, and were it not for the failsafes of the Legacy some of them might have long since converted the entire Latter Earth into a charnel house... and in some Iterums this may have already come to pass.

Aside from accidental undeath, some desperate seekers of immortality intentionally seek out the condition. Elaborate necromantic rituals, the employ of certain ancient relics, and adherence to particular death-god cults are all possible roads to undeath, but the results of these methods are not always entirely satisfactory. There remains a significant chance of complete identity-death, with nothing left of the petitioner but a shambling corpse, and even in the better cases there are often unacceptable aesthetic, intellectual, or sensory losses.

There does remain one fairly well-known way of producing a perfectly lifelike, fully-cognizant, practically immortal undead form. By creating a complete systemic skip in the Legacy, temporarily jamming its proper operation while effacing the petitioner’s name from the rolls of life and death, the seeker can vanish from the laws of mortality. Unfortunately, creating this skip requires the equivalent of a civilization-destroying magical disaster. The consequences of failure are horrific for the petitioner, and the energy release required for the ritual invariably inflicts catastrophic damage on the surrounding lands and people. For those who seek the power of an Imperator and an eternal existence, however, such a sacrifice is an acceptable price. Accumulating the necessary sacrifices, constructing or repurposing the necessary occult architecture, and acquiring the correct components are often greater obstacles for them than any consideration of morality.

TYPES OF UNDEAD

Undead are aggressively anomalous; while they are divided into several general classes, individual entities might have very different qualities or show strange traits based on the kind of Legacy glitch that created them.

Husks are mindless corpses, their identities usually lost or hopelessly scrambled by their death. While relatively easy to create, they are capable of only the most bestial, unthinking behavior, and are usually driven by instincts of violence and useless devouring. Something about living creatures seems to trigger an instinctive hostility in them, as if the living were a painful rebuke to their erroneous existence. In some cases a husk may retain some degree of consciousness or be gifted with unusual abilities by their translation into undeath.

Shades are immaterial identity-imprints left behind by death. While intangible, they maintain some semblance of their appearance in life and are usually keyed to particular purposes or repetitious actions related to their death. Their ability to interact with the world is limited, usually restricted to objects or places important to their death, and their intellects range from completely mindless repetition to full awareness of their state. While magical energies or weapons can sometimes destroy them, permanently extinguishing them usually requires completing particular actions or the destruction of certain anchoring objects.

Revenants are similar to husks in being material corpses but are usually much better-preserved both in body and mind. The chief distinction is that revenants have their own sentience and will, and are sometimes capable of masquerading as living humans. There are usually at least some serious flaws to this existence, either in cadaverous appearance, the need for human flesh and blood, a vulnerability to symbols of natural law such as sunlight, running water, or green wood, or some related infirmity. Revenants are not invariably hostile to humanity, but most experience a kind of nausea or instinctive revulsion toward living creatures due to the dissonance between their existence and that of natural life.

The Unending are a special class consisting of those few mortals who have successfully enacted the Legacy-severing ritual of eternal life. Only those with the might of a potential Imperator have any chance of succeeding at such an ambition and those who have passed the gauntlet are invariably demigods of incredible personal prowess. They are also almost always monstrously evil entities, perfectly willing to erase a nation in order to buy their eternal life.

QUALITIES OF THE UNDEAD

The example stat blocks below give illustrations of different common types of undead, but you should feel free to add additional abilities to specific creatures or to particular types of undead you create. These special types might have unique vulnerabilities or lack certain of the usual immunities of the undead, while possessing unusual powers in return.

By default, undead cannot be poisoned, diseased, or be made to sleep or fall unconscious. They need not eat, drink, or breathe, and they are indifferent to normal extremes of heat or cold. Common undead are destroyed at zero hit points; PCs or powerful undead automatically stabilize. They do not continue to decay beyond their initial state, but self-repair at normal healing rates. Conventional healing spells or powers are useless on them unless used by themselves, a Necromancer, or by another person skilled in the maintenance of dead flesh. They accrue and lose System Strain as normal.

Below are certain special abilities or traits found in certain undead. Others surely exist.

Averse: Certain religious symbols, lines of salt, emblems of natural law, or like icons repel it. When presented with the symbol it must make a Mental save to approach it. The aversion is broken if the icon's bearer or their allies attack it.

Beguiling: Once per scene it can beguile a creature with its gaze on a failed Mental save. The target becomes its helpless slave until separated from it for a full week. It cannot beguile creatures with more hit dice or levels than it has.

Desynchrony: Foes hit by it must make a Physical save or be paralyzed for 1d4+1 rounds, stunned by its own dislocation from natural law.

Draining: Foes hit by it are enfeebled, taking a cumulative -2 penalty to hit rolls and -1 to damage rolls, Shock, and skill checks for the rest of the scene.

Intangible: It is a shade or specter, unable to be touched by non-magical objects or energies. It can manip-

ulate objects important to it in life or kill with its icy touch.

Ravenous: If it hits with at least one of its attacks, it gets an immediate bonus attack against the target.

Red Hunger: It must eat a pound of human flesh or drink a pint of human blood every week or lose a quarter of its maximum hit points. At zero hit points it dies or goes inert until fresh food comes near.

Sunscorch: Exposure to sunlight, running water, or some specific other emblem of natural law inflicts 1d10 damage on it each round.

Terrifying: Enemies must make a Mental save or lose their first turn's Main Action as they summon their nerve. Morale checks it induces are made at -2.

Impure: Weapons of silver, green wood, or other specific apotropaic material inflict maximum damage to it on a hit and always inflict Shock regardless of AC.

Unending: It cannot die by violence. Only the right act, weapon, object destruction, or ritual can end it.

ORIGIN FOCUS: UNDEAD

You are a sentient undead creature that is capable of masquerading as a normal human, assuming no one inspects you too closely. Optionally, you can perfectly mimic a living person, but you must then choose one debility or vulnerability from the prior list of qualities.

As with any other origin Focus, it's up to the GM to decide whether to permit this origin in their campaign.

Level 1: You have all the qualities of an undead creature.

You can teach your allies how to successfully use healing effects on you. The debilitating effects of death have lessened you; pick an attribute and lower its modifier by -1, to a minimum of -2.

Level 2: Pick one trait to gain: you can mimic the living with no penalty or drawback, you can turn *Intangible* as an On Turn action for one round per scene, you can use *Desynchrony* once per scene as an Instant action, you become immune to Shock, or some similar undead-style power with GM approval. This level of Focus may be taken more than once.

The Undead	HD	AC	Atk.	Dmg.	Shock	Move	ML	Inst.	Skill	Save
Animated Skeleton	1	13	+1	1d6	-	30'	12	5	+0	15+
Shambling Corpse	2	10	+2	1d8	-	20'	12	6	+0	14+
Ravenous Husk	3	13	+4	1d8	-	30'	12	6	+1	14+
Sentient Carcass	5	15	+4 x2	1d8	2/AC 15	30'	10	4	+1	13+
Angry Shade	4	20	+5	1d6	2/-	30'	12	6	+1	13+
Wraith Lord	10	20	+10 x2	1d12+5	10/-	30'	10	4	+2	10+
Hungry Revenant	8	13a	+10 x2	1d8	2/-	30'	10	5	+2	11+
Undead Mage*	8	10	+10	1d8	2/-	30'	9	4	+2	11+
Revenant King	12	18a	+14 x2	1d12+5	10/-	30'	11	3	+2	9+
Unending One*	20	20	+20 x3	2d8	5/-	40'	10	1	+3	5+

* Undead spellcasters have the slots of a Necromancer of half their hit dice, and cast at a level equal to their full HD, up to a maximum effective level of 10.



FACTIONS AND MAJOR PROJECTS

The world is wider than the land beneath the party's boots. Greater powers and other agents within the campaign backdrop are ceaselessly moving to further their own plans, and many adventure possibilities are born from their constant struggles. Even when heroes are wholly uninvolved in a conflict, the consequences of a victory or loss can have grave repercussions on the things and people they hold dear.

Faced with the machinations of existing powers, players often want to enact their own great plans or ambitions on a campaign world. It might be a goal as humble as ensuring the prosperity of their home village, or it might be a burning passion to overthrow a wicked empire or lead their hard-pressed people to a new homeland far away.

These two campaign elements, factional struggles and grand PC projects, often cause trouble for GMs. Without the right tools to handle them in play, a GM can often feel lost in knowing just how to emulate a living campaign backdrop or fairly adjudicate a great PC ambition. This chapter contains rules and guidelines to help such a GM sort out these difficulties.

FACTIONS AND YOUR CAMPAIGN

A **faction** is an organization, government, cabal, gang, tribe, business, religion or other group that you mean to make a significant player in your campaign. Not every organization in your campaign setting is a faction; only those groups that are most interesting to you and important to the campaign should be given faction statistics. For most campaigns, that means a maximum of six at any time, and quite possibly fewer.

The faction system shows you how to stat these groups, assign them appropriate assets, and adjudicate their conflicts and schemes. It's an abstracted system, where damage to a faction asset might just as easily represent the arrest of a prominent businessman as it could be a bloody ambush on the road. The system tells the GM which parts of an organization were hurt, but it's up to you to translate that into concrete events in-game.

These events then provide a living backdrop of activity to your campaign setting, actions that the PCs can learn about through tavern talk or personal observation. If they're interested enough, they might just choose to get involved in a conflict and become a powerful weapon in the hands of their patrons. And if they're not interested, the existence of the clashes gives you grist for maintaining a sense of motion and activity in your world.

The faction system is meant to be a convenience for GMs and a tool for adding adventure hooks and additional verisimilitude to your campaign setting. It's not really set up to be played "competitively," with all sides balanced for a fair game. As a consequence, the extra muscle a capable party brings to the fight can often end up deciding the ultimate outcome of a struggle.

FACTIONS CREATED BY PCs

While the rules in this section presume that most factions will be GM-created tools for livening up the campaign backdrop, it's quite possible for PC heroes to forge their own factions and reap the benefits of rule. The practicality of this is up to the GM, but the process is relatively simple.

The PC or party must actively seek to build a base of followers and assets using the major project rules that begin on page 336. The scale of the project they must resolve will depend on the scale of the faction they want to establish and their own personal power; a band of famous heroes might find founding a knightly order to be a "plausible" effort, while a penniless group of vagabonds might find it "impossible" in their current situation. In the same fashion, founding a new kingdom in a wilderness is going to be a much more difficult feat than establishing a politically-influential monastery in a market village.

The adventurers can use money, adventures, stockpiled Renown, or other methods to succeed at the project. If they finally bring it to fruition, the GM then creates an appropriately-sized faction using the rules on page 327 and lets the PCs control it. Aside from the campaign-scale faction turn actions described in this section, they get all the usual benefits—and obligations—that come from ruling their own faction. If they have an order of knights under their command, they can probably dispatch several otherwise-unoccupied ones wherever they wish and garrison important places with others.

These peripheral benefits should match the scale of the adventures and effort they put into obtaining them. A faction created through great deeds and dire costs should pay off appropriately in local influence, status, and utility. The faction may suffer if the PCs spend its resources too freely and don't support it out of their own purse and doings, but it should be good for something more than bragging rights.

MAJOR PROJECTS IN PLAY

Aside from the rules for factions, this section also includes guidelines on **major projects**, grand session-spanning goals that the party might take up. These goals are too vast or nebulous to be accomplished just by paying silver or killing a few troublemakers, so GMs often feel uncertain as to how they're to fairly adjudicate the players' efforts in accomplishing them.

The rules in this section provide a framework for identifying the difficulty of the project, measuring progress toward its completion, and turning those vast ambitions into adventure hooks that cut down on the GM's own need for content creation. Great goals are a blessing to a GM; the players are being kind enough to tell you exactly what kind of adventures they want to have, and these pages will help you take best advantage of it.





FACTIONS AND THE FACTION TURN

Factions have several statistics to define their overall qualities. Weak or small factions tend to have low ratings even in their main focus, while kingdoms and major institutions may have a good rating even in their less important traits, simply because they have so many resources available to them.

Cunning is measured from 1 to 8 and indicates the faction's general guile, skill at subterfuge, and subtlety. Low Cunning means the faction is straightforward or unaccustomed to dealing with trickery, while high Cunning is for Machiavellian schemers and secretive organizations.

Force is measured from 1 to 8 and reflects the overall military prowess and martial competence of the faction. A faction with low Force isn't used to using violence to get its way, or is particularly inept at it, while a high Force reflects a culture of military expertise.

Wealth is measured from 1 to 8 and shows the faction's general prosperity, material resources, and facility with money. Low Wealth means the faction is poor, disinterested in material goods, or spendthrift with what they have, while high Wealth factions are rich and familiar with using money and goods as tools for success.

Magic measures the amount of magical resources available to the faction. "None" is for factions that have no meaningful access to magic. "Low" is for those factions that have at best a few trained mages or small stores of magical goods. "Medium" is for a faction where there is an established source of magical power for the faction, either as a sub-group of cooperative mages, a magical academy, a tradition of sorcery in the faction, or some other institutionalized aid. "High" magic is reserved for those factions that have a strong focus on wielding magical power, most fitting for a faction that represents a magical order.

Treasure is counted in points, and the total reflects how much the faction owns in cash and valuable goods. A single point of Treasure doesn't have an established cash value; a sack of gold is worthless in itself to a faction that needs a dozen ox carts, and a herd of cattle owned by a faction can't necessarily be turned into a fixed sum of coin.

Hit points work for factions much as they do for characters; when a faction is reduced to zero hit points, it collapses. Its individual members and sub-groups might not all be dead, but they're so hopelessly disorganized, dispirited, or conflict-bound that the faction ceases to exist as a coherent whole.

Assets are important resources possessed by a faction, such as controlling a ring of Smugglers, or having a unit of Infantry. Assets all have their own statistics and hit points, and all of them require certain scores in Force, Wealth, Cunning, and Magic to purchase. Assets don't cover all the resources and institutions the faction may control, but they reflect the ones that are most relevant to the faction at that moment. A kingdom may have more military than the Infantry unit they have, but that Infantry unit is the one that's doing something important.

THE FACTION TURN

Every month or so, the GM should run a faction turn. This turn may take place more often during times of intense activity, or less often if the campaign world is quiet. In general, a faction turn after every adventure is a good average, assuming the PCs don't have back-to-back adventures.

At the start of every faction turn, each faction rolls 1d8 for initiative, the highest rolls going first. Ties are resolved as the GM wishes, and then each faction takes the following steps in order.

- The faction earns Treasure equal to half their Wealth plus a quarter of their combined Force and Cunning, the total being rounded up.
- The faction must pay any upkeep required by their individual Asset costs, or by the cost of having too many Assets for their attributes. If they can't afford this upkeep, individual Assets may have their own bad consequences, while not being able to afford excess Assets means that the excess are lost.
- The faction triggers any special abilities individual Assets may have, such as abilities that allow an Asset to move or perform some other special benefit.
- The faction takes one Faction Action as listed in the following section, resolving any Attacks or other consequences from their choice. When an action is taken, every Asset owned by the faction may take it; thus, if **Attack** is chosen, then every valid Asset owned by the faction can Attack. If **Repair Asset** is chosen, every Asset can be repaired if enough Treasure is spent.
- The faction checks to see if it's accomplished its most recent goal. If so, it collects the experience points for doing so and picks a new goal. If not, it can abandon the old goal and pick a new one, but it will sacrifice its next turn's Faction Action to do so and may not trigger any Asset special abilities that round, either.

The next faction in order then acts until all factions have acted for the turn.

ASSET LOCATIONS AND MOVEMENT

Every Asset has a location on the campaign map. This location may not be where all the elements of the Asset are located. It might simply be the headquarters of an organization, or the spot where the most active and important members of it are currently working. However it's described, it's the center of gravity for the Asset.



This location is usually in a town or other settlement, but it could be anything that makes sense. A reclusive Prophet might dwell deep within the wilderness, and a ring of Smugglers might currently be based out of a hidden sea cave. A location is simply wherever the GM thinks it should be.

Assets can move locations, either with the *Move Asset* faction action or with a special ability possessed by the Asset itself or an allied unit. Generally, whenever an Asset moves, it can move one turn's worth of distance.

As a rule of thumb, for a one-month turn, this is about one hundred miles. This is as far as an organization can shift itself in thirty days while still maintaining some degree of control and cohesion. The GM may adjust this distance based on the situation; if the campaign is taking place in an island archipelago with fast sea travel it's going to be easier to move long distances than if the Asset has to march through mountains to get there.

Some Assets also have special abilities that work on targets within one move of the Asset. Again, the GM decides what this means, but generally it means that the Asset can affect targets within a hundred miles of its location.

Sometimes it doesn't make logical sense for an Asset to be able to move to a particular location. A unit of Infantry, for example, could hardly walk into an enemy nation's capital so as to later *Attack* the Court Patronage Asset there. In this case, the best the Infantry could do would be to move to a location near the capital, assuming the GM decides that's plausible. The Infantry couldn't actually *Attack* the enemy faction's Assets until they got into the city itself where those Assets were located.

Assets with the Subtle quality are not limited this way. Subtle Assets can move to locations even where they would normally be prohibited by the ruling powers. Dislodging them requires that they be Attacked until destroyed or moved out by their owner.

Assets with the Stealth quality are also not limited by this, and can move freely to any location within reach. Stealthed Assets cannot be Attacked by other Assets until they lose the Stealth quality. This happens when they are discovered by certain special Assets or when the Stealthed Asset Attacks something.

ATTRIBUTE CHECKS

Some actions, such as *Attack*, require an attribute check between factions, such as Force versus Cunning, or Wealth versus Force. Other special Asset abilities sometimes call for attribute checks as well.

To make this check, the attacker and defender both roll 1d10 and add their relevant attribute. Thus, for a Force versus Cunning check, the attacker would roll 1d10+Force against the defender's 1d10+Cunning. The attacker wins if their total is higher, and the defender wins if it's a tie or their roll is higher.

Some special abilities or tags allow the attacker or defender to roll more than one die for a check. In this case, the dice are rolled and the highest of them are used.

FACTION TAGS

Many Factions have at least one "tag", indicating some special benefit or quality it has due to its nature. These are merely some of the possibilities you might assign.

Antimagical: The faction is dwarven or of some other breed of skilled counter-sorcerers. Assets that require Medium or higher Magic to purchase roll all attribute checks twice against this faction during an Attack and take the worst roll.

Concealed: All Assets the faction purchases enter play with the Stealth quality.

Imperialist: The faction quickly expands its Bases of Influence. Once per turn, it can use the *Expand Influence* action as a special ability instead of it taking a full action.

Innovative: The faction can purchase Assets as if their attribute ratings were two points higher than they are. Only two such over-complex Assets may be owned at any one time.

Machiavellian: The faction is diabolically cunning. It rolls an extra die for all Cunning attribute checks. Its Cunning must always be its highest attribute.

Martial: The faction is profoundly devoted to war. It rolls an extra die for all Force attribute checks. Force must always be its highest attribute.

Massive: The faction is an empire, major kingdom, or other huge organizational edifice. It automatically wins attribute checks if its attribute is more than twice as big as the opposing side's attribute, unless the other side is also Massive.

Mobile: The faction is exceptionally fast or mobile. Its faction turn movement range is twice what another faction would have in the same situation.

Populist: The faction has widespread popular support. Assets that cost 5 Treasure or less to buy cost one point less, to a minimum of 1.

Rich: The faction is rich or possessed of mercantile skill. It rolls an extra die for all Wealth attribute checks. Wealth must always be its highest attribute.

Rooted: The faction has very deep roots in its area of influence. They roll an extra die for attribute checks in their headquarters location, and all rivals roll their own checks there twice, taking the worst die.

Scavenger: As looters and raiders, when they destroy an enemy Asset they gain a quarter of its purchase value in Treasure, rounded up.

Supported: The faction has excellent logistical support. All damaged Assets except Bases of Influence regain one lost hit point per faction turn automatically.

Tenacious: The faction is hard to dislodge. When one of its Bases of Influence is reduced to zero hit points, it instead survives with 1 hit point. This trait can't be used again on that base until it's fully fixed.

Zealot: Once per turn, when an Asset fails an *Attack* action check, it can reroll the attribute check. It automatically takes counterattack damage from its target, however, or 1d6 if the target has less or none.

FACTION TURN ACTIONS

Attack: The faction nominates one or more Assets to attack the enemy in their locations. In each location, the defender chooses which of the Assets present will meet the Attack; thus, if a unit of Infantry attacks in a location where there is an enemy Base of Influence, Informers, and Idealistic Thugs, the defender could decide to use Idealistic Thugs to defend against the attack.

The attacker makes an attribute check based on the attack of the acting Asset; thus, the Infantry would roll Force versus Force. On a success, the defending Asset takes damage equal to the attacking Asset's attack score, or 1d8 in the case of Infantry. On a failure, the attacking Asset takes damage equal to the defending Asset's counterattack score, or 1d6 in the case of Idealistic Thugs.

If the damage done to an Asset reduces it to zero hit points, it is destroyed. The same Asset may be used to defend against multiple attacking Assets, provided it can survive the onslaught.

Damage done to a Base of Influence is also done directly to the faction's hit points. Overflow damage is not transmitted, however; if the Base of Influence only has 5 hit points and 7 hit points are inflicted, the faction loses the Base of Influence and 5 hit points from its total.

Move Asset: One or more Assets are moved up to one turn's worth of movement each. The receiving location must not have the ability and inclination to forbid the Asset from operating there. Subtle and Stealthed Assets ignore this limit.

If an asset loses the Subtle or Stealth qualities while in a hostile location, they must use this action to retreat to safety within one turn or they will take half their maximum hit points in damage at the start of the next turn, rounded up.

Repair Asset: The faction spends 1 Treasure on each Asset they wish to repair, fixing half their relevant attribute value in lost hit points, rounded up. Thus, fixing a Force Asset would heal half the faction's Force attribute, rounded up. Additional healing can be applied to an Asset in this same turn, but the cost increases by 1 Treasure for each subsequent fix; thus, the second costs 2 Treasure, the third costs 3 Treasure, and so forth.

This ability can at the same time also be used to repair damage done to the faction, spending 1 Treasure to heal a total equal to the faction's highest and lowest Force, Wealth, or Cunning attribute divided by two, rounded up. Thus, a faction with a Force of 5, Wealth of 2, and Cunning of 4 would heal 4 points of damage. Only one such application of healing is possible for a faction each turn.

Expand Influence: The faction seeks to establish a new base of operations in a location. The faction must have at least one Asset there already to make this attempt, and must spend 1 Treasure for each hit point the new Base of Influence is to have. Thus, to create a new Base of Influence with a maximum hit point total of 10, 10 Treasure must be spent. Bases with high maximum hit point totals are harder to dislodge, but losing them also inflicts much more damage on the faction's own hit points.

Once the Base of Influence is created, the owner makes a Cunning versus Cunning attribute check against every other faction that has at least one Asset in the same location. If the other faction wins the check, they are allowed to make an immediate **Attack** against the new Base of Influence with whatever Assets they have present in the location. The creating faction may attempt to block this action by defending with other Assets present.

If the Base of Influence survives this onslaught, it operates as normal and allows the faction to purchase new Assets there with the **Create Asset** action.

Create Asset: The faction buys one Asset at a location where they have a Base of Influence. They must have the minimum attribute and Magic ratings necessary to buy the Asset and must pay the listed cost in Treasure to build it. A faction can create only one Asset per turn.

A faction can have no more Assets of a particular attribute than their attribute score. Thus, a faction with a Force of 3 can have only 3 Force Assets. If this number is exceeded, the faction must pay 1 Treasure per excess Asset at the start of each turn, or else they will lose the excess.

Hide Asset: An action available only to factions with a Cunning score of 3 or better, this action allows the faction to give one owned Asset the Stealth quality for every 2 Treasure they spend. Assets currently in a location with another faction's Base of Influence can't be hidden. If the Asset later loses the Stealth, no refund is given.

Sell Asset: The faction voluntarily decommissions an Asset, salvaging it for what it's worth. The Asset is lost and the faction gains half its purchase cost in Treasure, rounded down. If the Asset is damaged when it is sold, however, no Treasure is gained.



CREATING FACTIONS

A given campaign should generally not have more than six active factions at any one time, and three or four are generally more manageable. If there are more extant factions than this in your campaign, then simply run turns for the three or four most active or relevant ones and leave the others fallow for the turn.

To create a faction, first decide whether it is a small, medium, or large faction. A small one might be a petty cult or small free city or minor magical academy. A medium one might be a local baron's government or province-wide faith. A large one would be an entire kingdom or a major province of a vast empire.

It's perfectly acceptable to break a large institution down into a smaller faction. If the provincial government of Ruhark is the important element in the campaign, the empire that Ruhark belongs to can be ignored. If the One Red Dawn faction of the Howling God's clergy are the ones who hate the PCs, then making them into their own small faction is much easier and better than factionizing the entire Howling God hierarchy.

All factions have a Base of Influence at their primary headquarters with a hit point total equal to the faction's maximum. The faction's Magic rating is whatever the GM thinks suitable.

For a small faction, give them a 3 or 4 in their best attribute, a 2 or 3 in their second-best, and a 1 or 2 in their worst quality.

Medium factions should assign 5 or 6 to their best attribute, 4 or 5 to their second-best, and 2 or 3 to their worst. They should have two Assets in their primary attribute and two others among the other two.

Large factions should assign 7 or 8 to their strongest attribute, 6 or 7 to their second-best attribute, and 3 or 4 to their worst quality. They should have four Assets in their primary attribute, and four others spread among the other two. Their Magic rating will depend on whatever you think is appropriate for their scale, but remember that it's harder to concentrate effective magical resources when dealing with a whole province or nation than it is to enchant a single city-state or magical institution.

To determine a faction's maximum hit points, use the adjacent table. Thus, one with a Force of 3, a Wealth of 5, and a Cunning of 2 would have hit points equal to 4 plus 9 plus 2, or 15 total. The Base of Influence at their primary headquarters will always have a maximum hit points equal to the faction's maximum hit points, even if it later rises or falls due to attribute score changes.

Lastly, give a faction a goal, either one from the foregoing list or one chosen by the GM. When this goal is achieved, the faction earns experience points which it can later spend to increase its attributes. The cost for such increases is given on the table adjacent. Earlier levels must be purchased before later, so to raise Force from 5 to 7 will cost 9 XP to raise it to 6, then 12 more to raise it to 7.

Attribute Rating	Faction XP Cost to Purchase	Hit Point Value
1	-	1
2	2	2
3	4	4
4	6	6
5	9	9
6	12	12
7	16	16
8	20	20

EXAMPLE FACTION GOALS

The difficulty of a faction goal is the number of experience points earned on a successful completion of it.

Blood the Enemy: Inflict a number of hit points of damage on enemy faction assets or bases equal to your faction's total Force, Cunning, and Wealth ratings. Difficulty 2.

Destroy the Foe: Destroy a rival faction. Difficulty equal to 2 plus the average of the faction's Force, Cunning, and Wealth ratings.

Eliminate Target: Choose an undamaged rival Asset. If you destroy it within three turns, succeed at a Difficulty 1 goal. If you fail, pick a new goal without suffering the usual turn of paralysis.

Expand Influence: Plant a Base of Influence at a new location. Difficulty 1, +1 if a rival contests it.

Inside Enemy Territory: Have a number of Stealthed assets in locations where there is a rival Base of Influence equal to your Cunning score. Units that are already Stealthed in locations when this goal is adopted don't count. Difficulty 2.

Invincible Valor: Destroy a Force asset with a minimum purchase rating higher than your faction's Force rating. Difficulty 2.

Peaceable Kingdom: Don't take an Attack action for four turns. Difficulty 1.

Root Out the Enemy: Destroy a Base of Influence of a rival faction in a specific location. Difficulty equal to half the average of the current ruling faction's Force, Cunning, and Wealth ratings, rounded up.

Sphere Dominance: Choose Wealth, Force, or Cunning. Destroy a number of rival assets of that kind equal to your score in that attribute. Difficulty of 1 per 2 destroyed, rounded up.

Wealth of Kingdoms: Spend Treasure equal to four times your faction's Wealth rating on bribes and influence. This money is effectively lost, but the goal is then considered accomplished. The faction's Wealth rating must increase before this goal can be selected again. Difficulty 2.

CUNNING ASSETS

Bewitching Charmer: When the Bewitching Charmer succeeds in an Attack, the targeted Asset is unable to leave the same location as the Bewitching Charmer until the latter Asset moves or is destroyed. Bewitching Charmers are immune to Counterattack.

Blackmail: When a Blackmail asset is in a location, hostile factions can't roll more than one die during Attacks made by or against them there, even if they have tags or Assets that usually grant bonus dice.

Court Patronage: Powerful nobles or officials are appointing their agents to useful posts of profit. A Court Patronage Asset automatically grants 1 Treasure to its owning faction each turn.

Covert Transport: As a free action once per turn, the faction can pay 1 Treasure and move any Cunning or Wealth Asset at the same location as the Covert Transport. The transported Asset gains the Stealth quality until it performs some action or is otherwise utilized by the faction.

Cryptomancers: In place of an Attack action, they can make a Cunning vs. Cunning attack on a specific hostile Asset within one move. On a success, the targeted Asset is unable to do anything or be used for anything on its owner's next faction turn. On a failure, no Counterattack damage is taken.

Dancing Girls: Dancing Girls or other charming distractions are immune to Attack or Counterattack damage from Force Assets, but they cannot be used to defend against Attacks from Force Assets.

Expert Treachery: On a successful Attack by Expert Treachery, this Asset is lost, 5 Treasure is gained by its owning faction, and the Asset that Expert Treachery targeted switches sides. This conversion happens even if their new owners lack the attributes usually necessary to maintain their new Asset.

Hired Friends: As a free action, once per turn, the faction may spend 1 Treasure and grant a Wealth Asset within one turn's movement range the Subtle quality. This quality will remain, regardless of the Wealth Asset's movement, until the Hired Friends are destroyed or they use this ability again.

Idealistic Thugs: Easily-manipulated hotheads are enlisted under whatever ideological or religious principle best enthralls them for violence.

Informers: As a free action, once per turn, the faction can spend 1 Treasure and have the Informers look for Stealthed Assets. To do so, the Informers pick a faction and make a Cunning vs. Cunning Attack on them. No counterattack damage is taken if they fail, but if they succeed, all Stealthed Assets of that faction within one move of the Informers are revealed.

Interrupted Logistics: Non-Stealthed hostile units cannot enter the same location as the Interrupted Logistics Asset without paying 1d4 Treasure and waiting one turn to arrive there.

Just As Planned: Some sublimely cunning mastermind ensures that the schemes of this faction are unimaginably subtle and far-seeing. Whenever the faction's Assets make a roll involving Cunning, they may reroll a failed check at the cost of inflicting 1d6 damage on Just As Planned. This may be done repeatedly, though it may destroy the Asset. There is no range limit on this benefit.

Mindbenders: Once per turn as a free action, the Mindbenders can force a rival faction to reroll a check, Attack, or other die roll they just made and take whichever result the Mindbenders prefer. A faction can only be affected this way once until the start of the Mindbender's faction's next turn.

Occult Infiltrators: Magically-gifted spies and assassins are enlisted to serve the faction. Occult Infiltrator Assets always begin play with the Stealth quality.

Omniscient Seers: At the start of their turn, each hostile Stealthed asset within one turn's movement of the Omniscient Seers must succeed in a Cunning vs. Cunning check against the owning faction or lose their Stealth. In addition, all Cunning rolls made by the faction for units or events within one turn's movement of the seers gain an extra die.

Organization Moles: Sleeper agents and deep-cover spies burrow into hostile organizations, waiting to disrupt them from within when ordered to do so.

Petty Seers: A cadre of skilled fortune-tellers and minor oracles have been enlisted by the faction to foresee perils and allow swift counterattacks.

Popular Movement: Any friendly Asset is allowed movement into the same location as the Popular Movement, even if it would normally be forbidden by its owners and lacks the Subtle quality. If the Popular Movement later moves or is destroyed, such Assets must also leave or suffer the usual consequences of a non-Subtle Asset in a hostile area.

Prophet: Whether a religious prophet, charismatic philosopher, rebel leader, or other figure of popular appeal, the Asset is firmly under the faction's control.

Saboteurs: An Asset that is Attacked by the Saboteurs can't use any free action abilities it may have during the next turn, whether or not the Attack was successful.

Seditionists: In place of an Attack action, the Seditionists' owners may spend 1d4 Treasure and attach the Asset to a hostile Asset in the same location. Until the Seditionists are destroyed, infest another Asset, or leave the same location, the rebelling Asset cannot be used for anything and grants no benefits.

Shapeshifters: As a free action once per turn, the faction can spend 1 Treasure and grant the Shapeshifters the Stealth quality.

Smugglers: As a free action, once per faction turn, the Smugglers can move any allied Wealth or Cunning



Cunning Asset	Cost	HP	Magic	Attack	Counter	Qualities
Cunning 1						
Informers	2	3	None	C v. C/Special	None	Subtle, Special
Petty Seers	2	2	Medium	None	1d6 damage	Subtle
Smugglers	2	4	None	C v. W/1d4 damage	None	Subtle, Action
Useful Idiots	1	2	None	None	None	Subtle, Special
Cunning 2						
Blackmail	4	4	None	C v. C/1d4 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Dancing Girls	4	3	None	C v. W/2d4 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Hired Friends	4	4	None	C v. C/1d6 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Saboteurs	5	6	None	C v. W/2d4 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Cunning 3						
Bewitching Charmer	6	4	Low	C v. C/Special	None	Subtle, Special
Covert Transport	8	4	None	None	None	Subtle, Special
Occult Infiltrators	6	4	Medium	C v. C/2d6 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Spymaster	8	4	None	C v. C/1d6 damage	2d6 damage	Subtle
Cunning 4						
Court Patronage	8	8	None	C v. C/1d6 damage	1d6 damage	Subtle, Special
Idealistic Thugs	8	12	None	C v. F/1d6 damage	1d6 damage	Subtle
Seditionists	12	8	None	Special	None	Subtle
Vigilant Agents	12	8	None	None	1d4 damage	Subtle, Special
Cunning 5						
Cryptomancers	14	6	Low	C v. C/Special	None	Subtle
Organization Moles	8	10	None	C v. C/2d6 damage	None	Subtle
Shapeshifters	14	8	Medium	C v. C/2d6 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Cunning 6						
Interrupted Logistics	20	10	None	None	None	Subtle, Special
Prophet	20	10	None	C v. C/2d8 damage	1d8 damage	Subtle
Underground Roads	18	15	None	None	None	Subtle, Special
Cunning 7						
Expert Treachery	10	5	None	C v. C/Special	None	Subtle
Mindbenders	20	10	Medium	None	2d8 damage	Subtle
Popular Movement	25	16	None	C v. C/2d6 damage	1d6 damage	Subtle, Special
Cunning 8						
Just As Planned	40	15	None	None	1d10 damage	Subtle, Special
Omniscient Seers	30	10	High	None	1d8 damage	Subtle, Special

Asset in their same location to a destination within movement range, even if the destination wouldn't normally allow an un-Subtle Asset to locate there.

Spymaster: A veteran operative runs a counterintelligence bureau in the area and formulates offensive schemes for the faction.

Underground Roads: A well-established network of secret transit extends far around this Asset. As a free action, the faction may pay 1 Treasure and move any friendly Asset from a location within one round's move of the Underground Roads to a destination also within one round's move of the Roads.

Useful Idiots: Hirelings, catspaws, foolish idealists, and other disposable minions are gathered together in

this Asset. If another Asset within one turn's move of the Useful Idiots is struck by an Attack, the faction can instead sacrifice the Useful Idiots to negate the attack. Only one band of Useful Idiots can be sacrificed on any one turn.

Vigilant Agents: A constant flow of observations runs back to the faction from these watchful counterintelligence agents. Whenever another faction moves a Stealthed asset into a location within one move's distance from the Vigilant Agents, they may make a Cunning vs. Cunning attack against the owning faction. On a success, the intruding Asset loses its Stealth after it completes the move.

FORCE ASSETS

Apocalypse Engine: One of a number of hideously powerful ancient super-weapons unearthed from some lost armory, an Apocalypse Engine rains some eldritch horror down on a targeted enemy Asset.

Brilliant General: A leader for the ages is in service with the faction. Whenever the Brilliant General or any allied Force Asset in the same location Attacks or is made to defend, it can roll an extra die to do so.

Cavalry: Mounted troops, chariots, or other mobile soldiers are in service to the faction. While weak on defense, they can harry logistics and mount powerful charges.

Demonic Slayer: Powerful sorcerers have summoned or constructed an inhuman assassin-beast to hunt down and slaughter the faction's enemies. A Demonic Slayer enters play Stealthed.

Enchanted Elites: A carefully-selected group of skilled warriors are given magical armaments and arcane blessings to boost their effectiveness.

Fearful Intimidation: Judicious exercises of force have intimidated the locals, making them reluctant to cooperate with any group that stands opposed to the faction.

Fortification Program: A program of organized fortification and supply caching has been undertaken around the Asset's location, hardening allied communities and friendly Assets. Once per turn, when an enemy makes an Attack that targets the faction's Force rating, the faction can use the Fortification Program to defend if the Asset is within a turn's move from the attack.

Guerrilla Populace: The locals have the assistance of trained guerrilla warfare leaders who can aid them in sabotaging and attacking unwary hostiles.

Infantry: Common foot soldiers have been organized and armed by the faction. While rarely particularly heroic in their capabilities, they have the advantage of numbers.

Invincible Legion: The faction has developed a truly irresistible military organization that can smash its way through opposition without the aid of any support units. During a *Relocate Asset* action, the Invincible Legion can relocate to locations that would otherwise not permit a formal military force to relocate there, as if it had the Subtle quality. It is not, however, in any way subtle.

Knights: Elite warriors of considerable personal prowess have been trained or enlisted by the faction, either from noble sympathizers, veteran members, or amenable mercenaries.

Local Guard: Ordinary citizens are enlisted into night watch patrols and local guard units. They're most effective when defending from behind a fortified position, but they have some idea of how to use their weapons.

Magical Logistics: An advanced web of magical Workings, skilled sorcerers, and trained logistical experts are enlisted to streamline the faction's maintenance and sustain damaged units. Once per faction turn, as a free action, the Asset can repair 2 hit points of damage to an allied Force Asset.

Military Roads: The faction has established a network of roads with a logistical stockpile at this Asset's location. As a consequence, once per faction turn, the faction can move any one Asset from any location within its reach to any other location within its reach at a cost of 1 Treasure.

Military Transport: A branch of skilled teamsters, transport ships, road-building crews, or other logistical facilitators is in service to the faction. As a free action once per faction turn, it can bring an allied Asset to its location, provided they're within one turn's movement range, or move an allied Asset from its own location to a target also within a turn's move. Multiple Military Transport assets can chain this movement over long distances.

Purity Rites: A rigorous program of regular mental inspection and counterintelligence measures has been undertaken by the faction. This Asset can only defend against attacks that target the faction's Cunning, but it allows the faction to roll an extra die to defend.

Reserve Corps: Retired military personnel and rear-line troops are spread through the area as workers or colonists, available to resist hostilities as needed.

Scouts: Long-range scouts and reconnaissance experts work for the faction, able to venture deep into hostile territory.

Siege Experts: These soldiers are trained in trenching, sapping, and razing targeted structures. When they successfully Attack an enemy Asset, the owner loses 1d4 points of Treasure from their reserves and this faction gains it.

Summoned Hunter: A skilled sorcerer has summoned a magical beast or mentally bound a usefully disposable assassin into the faction's service.

Temple Fanatics: Fanatical servants of a cult, ideology, or larger religion, these enthusiasts wreak havoc on enemies without a thought for their own lives. After every time the Temple Fanatics defend or successfully attack, they take 1d4 damage.

Thugs: These gutter ruffians and common kneebreakers have been organized in service to the faction's causes.

Vanguard Unit: This unit is specially trained to build bridges, reduce fortifications, and facilitate a lightning strike into enemy territory. When its faction takes a Relocate Asset turn, it can move the Vanguard Unit and any allied units at the same location to any other location within range, even if the unit type would normally be prohibitive from moving

Force Asset	Cost	HP	Magic	Attack	Counter	Qualities
Force 1						
Fearful Intimidation	2	4	None	None	1d4 damage	
Local Guard	3	4	None	F v. F/1d3+1 damage	1d4+1 damage	
Summoned Hunter	4	4	Medium	C v. F/1d6 damage	None	Subtle
Thugs	2	1	None	F v. C/1d6 damage	None	Subtle
Force 2						
Guerrilla Populace	6	4	None	F v. F/1d4+1 damage	None	
Military Transport	4	6	None	None	None	Action
Reserve Corps	4	4	None	F v. F/1d6 damage	1d6 damage	
Scouts	5	5	None	F v. F/2d4 damage	1d4+1 damage	Subtle
Force 3						
Enchanted Elites	8	6	Medium	F v. F/1d10 damage	1d6 damage	Subtle
Infantry	6	6	None	F v. F/1d8 damage	1d6 damage	
Temple Fanatics	4	6	None	F v. F/2d6 damage	2d6 damage	Special
Witch Hunters	6	4	Low	C v. C/1d4+1 damage	1d6 damage	
Force 4						
Cavalry	8	12	None	F v. F/2d6 damage	1d4 damage	
Military Roads	10	10	None	None	None	Action
Vanguard Unit	10	10	None	None	1d6 damage	Action
War Fleet	12	8	None	F v. F/2d6 damage	1d8 damage	Action
Force 5						
Demonic Slayer	12	4	High	C v. C/2d6+2 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Magical Logistics	14	6	Medium	None	None	Special
Siege Experts	10	8	None	F v. W/1d6 damage	1d6 damage	
Force 6						
Fortification Program	20	18	None	None	2d6 damage	Action
Knights	18	16	None	F v. F/2d8 damage	2d6 damage	
War Machines	25	14	Medium	F v. F/2d10+4 damage	1d10 damage	
Force 7						
Brilliant General	25	8	None	C v. F/1d8 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Purity Rites	20	10	Low	None	2d8+2 damage	Special
Warshaped	30	16	High	F v. F/2d8+2 damage	2d8 damage	Subtle
Force 8						
Apocalypse Engine	35	20	Medium	F v. F/3d10+4 damage	None	
Invincible Legion	40	30	None	F v. F/2d10+4 damage	2d10+4 damage	Special

there. Thus, a Force asset could be moved into a foreign nation's territory even against their wishes. The unit may remain at that location afterwards even if the Vanguard Unit leaves.

War Fleet: While a war fleet can only Attack assets and locations within reach of the waterways, once per turn it can freely relocate itself to any coastal area within movement range. The Asset itself must be based out of some landward location to provide for supply and refitting.

War Machines: Mobile war machines driven by trained beasts or magical motive power are under the faction's control.

Warshaped: The faction has the use of magical creatures designed specifically for warfare, or ordinary humans that have been greatly altered to serve the faction's needs. Such forces are few and elusive enough to evade easy detection.

Witch Hunters: Certain personnel are trained in sniffing out traitors and spies in the organization, along with the presence of hostile magic or hidden spellcraft.



WEALTH ASSETS

Ancient Mechanisms: Some useful magical mechanism from ages past has been refitted to be useful in local industry. Whenever an Asset in the same location must roll to make a profit, such as Farmers or Manufactory, the faction may roll the die twice and take the better result.

Ancient Workshop: A workshop has been refitted with ancient magical tools, allowing prodigies of production, albeit not always safely. As a free action, once per turn, the Ancient Workshop takes 1d6 damage and the owning faction gains 1d6 Treasure.

Arcane Laboratory: The faction's overall Magic is counted as one step higher for the purposes of creating Assets in the same location as the laboratory. Multiple Arcane Laboratories in the same location can increase the Magic boost by multiple steps.

Armed Guards: Hired caravan guards, bodyguards, or other armed minions serve the faction.

Caravan: As a free action, once per turn, the Caravan can spend 1 Treasure and move itself and one other Asset in the same place to a new location within one move.

Cooperative Businesses: If any other faction attempts to create an Asset in the same location as a Cooperative Business, the cost of doing so increases by 1 Treasure. This penalty stacks.

Dragomans: Interpreters, cultural specialists, and go-betweens simplify the expansion of a faction's influence in an area. A faction that takes an *Expand Influence* action in the same location as this Asset can roll an extra die on all checks there that turn. As a free action once per turn, this Asset can move.

Economic Disruption: As a free action once per turn, this Asset can move itself without cost.

Farmers: Farmers, hunters, and simple rural artisans are in service to the faction here. Once per turn, as a free action, the Asset's owner can roll 1d6; on a 5+, they gain 1 Treasure from the Farmers.

Free Company: Hired mercenaries and professional soldiers, this Asset can, as a free action once per turn, move itself. At the start of each of its owner's turn, it takes 1 Treasure in upkeep costs; if this is not paid, roll 1d6. On a 1-3 the Asset is lost, on a 4-6 it goes rogue and will move to Attack the most profitable-looking target. This roll is repeated each turn until back pay is paid or the Asset is lost.

Front Merchant: Whenever the Front Merchant successfully Attacks an enemy Asset, the target faction loses 1 Treasure, if they have any, and the Front Merchant's owner gains it. Such a loss can occur only once per turn.

Golden Prosperity: Each turn, as a free action, the faction gains 1d6 Treasure that can be used to fix damaged Assets as if by the *Repair Assets* action. Any of this Treasure not spent on such purposes is lost.

Healers: Whenever an Asset within one move of the Healers is destroyed by an Attack that used Force against the target, the owner of the Healers may pay half its purchase price in Treasure, rounded up, to instantly restore it with 1 hit point. This cannot be used to repair Bases of Influence.

Hired Legion: As a free action once per turn, the Hired Legion can move. This faction must be paid 2 Treasure at the start of each turn as upkeep, or else they go rogue as the Free Company Asset does. This Asset cannot be voluntarily sold or disbanded.

Lead or Silver: If Lead or Silver's Attack reduces an enemy Asset to zero hit points, this Asset's owner may immediately pay half the target's purchase cost to claim it as their own, reviving it with 1 hit point.

Mad Genius: As a free action, once per turn, the Mad Genius may move. As a free action, once per turn, the Mad Genius may be sacrificed to treat the Magic rating in their location as High for the purpose of buying Assets that require such resources. This boost lasts only until the next Asset is purchased in that location.

Manufactory: Once per turn, as a free action, the Asset's owner may roll 1d6; on a 1, one point of Treasure is lost, on a 2-5, one point is gained, and on a 6, two points are gained. If Treasure is lost and none is available to pay it by the end of the turn, this Asset is lost.

Merchant Prince: A canny master of trade, the Merchant Prince may be triggered as a free action once per turn before buying a new Asset in the same location; the Merchant Prince takes 1d4 damage and the purchased Asset costs 1d8 Treasure less, down to a minimum of half its normal price.

Monopoly: Once per turn, as a free action, the Monopoly Asset can target an Asset in the same location; that Asset's owning faction must either pay the Monopoly's owner 1 Treasure or lose the targeted Asset.

Occult Countermeasures: This asset can only Attack or inflict Counterattack damage on Assets that require at least a Low Magic rating to purchase.

Pleaders: Whether lawyers, skalds, lawspeakers, sage elders, or other legal specialists, Pleaders can turn the local society's laws against the enemies of the faction. However, Pleaders can neither Attack nor inflict Counterattack damage on Force Assets.

Smuggling Fleet: Once per turn, as a free action, they may move themselves and any one Asset at their current location to any other water-accessible location within one move. Any Asset they move with them gains the Subtle quality until they take some action at the destination.

Supply Interruption: As a free action, once per turn, the Asset can make a Cunning vs. Wealth check against an Asset in the same location. On a success, the



Wealth Asset	Cost	HP	Magic	Attack	Counter	Qualities
Wealth 1						
Armed Guards	1	3	None	W v. F/1d3 damage	1d4 damage	
Cooperative Businesses	1	2	None	W v. W/1d4-1 damage	None	Subtle, Special
Farmers	2	4	None	None	1d4 damage	Action
Front Merchant	2	3	None	W v. W/1d4 damage	1d4-1 damage	Subtle
Wealth 2						
Caravan	5	4	None	W v. W/1d4 damage	None	Action
Dragomans	4	4	None	None	1d4 damage	Subtle, Special
Pleaders	6	4	None	C v. W/2d4 damage	1d6 damage	Special
Worker Mob	4	6	None	W v. F/1d4+1 damage	1d4 damage	
Wealth 3						
Ancient Mechanisms	8	4	Medium	None	None	Special
Arcane Laboratory	6	4	None	None	None	Special
Free Company	8	6	None	W v. F/2d4+2 damage	1d6 damage	Action, Special
Manufactory	8	4	None	None	1d4 damage	Action
Wealth 4						
Healers	12	8	None	None	None	Action
Monopoly	8	12	None	W v. W/1d6 damage	1d6 damage	Action
Occult Countermeasures	10	8	Low	W v. C/2d10 damage	1d10 damage	Special
Usurers	12	8	None	W v. W/1d10 damage	None	Action
Wealth 5						
Mad Genius	6	2	None	W v. C/1d6 damage	None	Action
Smuggling Fleet	12	6	None	W v. F/2d6 damage	None	Subtle, Action
Supply Interruption	10	8	None	C v. W/1d6 damage	None	Subtle, Action
Wealth 6						
Economic Disruption	25	10	None	W v. W/2d6 damage	None	Subtle, Action
Merchant Prince	20	10	None	W v. W/2d8 damage	1d8 damage	Action
Trade Company	15	10	None	W v. W/2d6 damage	1d6 damage	Action
Wealth 7						
Ancient Workshop	25	16	Medium	None	None	
Lead or Silver	20	10	None	W v. W/2d10 damage	2d8 damage	
Transport Network	15	5	None	W v. W/1d12 damage	None	Action
Wealth 8						
Golden Prosperity	40	30	Medium	None	2d10 damage	
Hired Legion	30	20	None	W v F/2d10+4 damage	2d10 damage	Action

owning faction must sacrifice Treasure equal to half the target Asset's purchase cost, or else it is disabled and useless until this price is paid.

Trade Company: Bold traders undertake potentially lucrative- or catastrophic- new business opportunities. As a free action, once per turn, the owner of the Asset may roll accept 1d4 damage done to the Asset in exchange for earning 1d6-1 Treasure points.

Transport Network: A vast array of carters, ships, smugglers, and official caravans are under the faction's control. As a free action the Transport Network can spend 1 Treasure to move any friendly Asset within two moves to any location within one move of either the target or the Transport Network.

Usurers: Moneylenders and other proto-bankers ply their trade for the faction. For each unit of Usurers owned by a faction, the Treasure cost of buying Assets may be decreased by 2 Treasure, to a minimum of half its cost. Each time the Usurers are used for this benefit, they suffer 1d4 damage from popular displeasure.

Worker Mob: The roughest, most brutal laborers in service with the faction have been quietly organized to sternly discipline the enemies of the group.

BACKGROUND ACTORS

There are times when a GM might want to add some extra motion and activity to their campaign setting, but including additional full-fledged factions may be overkill. A few hostile nobles, a rival adventuring party, a zealous new demagogue, an ambitious crime boss, or some other variety of actor can provide some extra liveliness to the campaign backdrop, even if their activities have no immediate bearing on the PCs. Simply hearing about their exploits or encountering the peripheral consequences of them can add extra flavor to a game, and help the players feel that the world exists even when they're not adventuring there.

These background actors need very little development unless you anticipate a direct encounter with the PCs. A petty noble is just a petty noble, and a few sentences of description about their holdings and ambitions are all you need. A rival adventuring party might have statistics assigned to as a group of mid- to high-hit die human foes, but it's rarely worth statting them out with class levels and all the trimmings. A simple conceptual hook for a background actor and a set of motivations are all a GM really needs. If they run into conflict with the PCs, you can build them out more fully, but it's best to start simple.

About three pertinent background actors is usually plenty for a game. Different groups or individuals might rotate in and out of relevance as their plans progress or the PCs involve themselves in nearby events, but more than three tend to create so much background noise that the players can have a hard time identifying specific actors. Combined with the larger-scale activities of factions, three actors should give plenty of both small- and large-scale events for the PCs to notice and potentially react to.

ACTORS IN THE FACTION TURN

Every time you run a faction turn, decide what each of your relevant actors has been up to in the meanwhile. If you have no active factions, make this decision between each gaming session, assuming a reasonable amount of time has passed.

To determine their actions, you can either simply decide it by GM fiat, or use the adjacent tables for inspiration. A generic table is provided for general rolls, and some actor-specific sub-tables for those occasions when you want results more closely personalized to a type of actor. Once you have the general gist of their activities, add details and specifics that fit the particular campaign region you're using; if an adventuring group is delving into a local Deep, then maybe they're investigating the same dungeon that the PCs have been exploring lately. In the same vein, a noble who betrays a peer might turn traitor on the lord of the town the PCs are currently occupying.

Try to make each result visible to the players, even if it's not strictly pertinent to them. They might hear about

military clashes nearby, or learn about an adventuring band that was wiped out, or pass through a village that's busily preparing for the local lord's wedding. The PCs might choose to take an interest in events, but even just hearing about them going on in the background will help add verisimilitude to the world. Some activities might be hidden from them, particularly those involving intrigue or deception, but if the actors' actions never become visible then your prep time is not doing you much good.

ADDING AND REMOVING ACTORS

Background actors come and go. Sometimes they make some mistake that proves unsurvivable, or they journey beyond the scope of the campaign, or they simply attain their goal and have no reason for further activity. Sometimes the PCs pull up stakes and move half a continent away, and there's no way that the old crew would have any bearing on events in their new home.

In such cases, it's fine to simply shuffle the expended actors offscreen and bring on a few new ones more suitable to the campaign. If the PCs ever return to them or they become relevant anew you can pull them out of retirement or use them as NPCs in your adventures. It's often particularly useful to turn consequential NPCs from recent adventures into these new actors, as the lord the PCs helped or the bandit chief they feuded with become a source of ongoing events.

d20 General Actor Activities and Events

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | They came into a large amount of money |
| 2 | They became sick or diseased somehow |
| 3 | A friend betrayed their trust |
| 4 | A stroke of luck aided their pursuit of their goal |
| 5 | They defeated a rival or significant enemy |
| 6 | They made a grave social mistake |
| 7 | A friend or ally was slain or lost to them |
| 8 | They overcame an obstacle to their goal |
| 9 | A source of power they have was threatened |
| 10 | They were defeated by a rival in their ambition |
| 11 | They were accused of a serious crime |
| 12 | They obtained a useful item of magic |
| 13 | They vanished mysteriously for a time |
| 14 | They were attacked by monsters |
| 15 | They made some unsavory associates |
| 16 | They stole something or were robbed in turn |
| 17 | They ventured into dangerous terrain |
| 18 | They offended a powerful entity |
| 19 | A plan of theirs came to its fruition |
| 20 | They gained a powerful new ally |

BACKGROUND ACTOR EVENTS

d12 Adventuring Parties

- 1 They're delving into a perilous Deep
- 2 They've been savaged by monsters
- 3 They slew a powerful foe
- 4 They're quarreling over some treasure
- 5 They committed an outrageous social crime
- 6 They're spending huge amounts of money
- 7 A member has betrayed the others
- 8 They murdered someone important
- 9 A promising new member joined them
- 10 They've gotten or lost a noble patron
- 11 They've been cursed or blighted by magic
- 12 They're heading into dangerous territory

d12 Nobles and Gentry

- 1 A rival has encroached on their lands or rights
- 2 They're making a familial tie by marriage
- 3 A trusted lieutenant has died or betrayed them
- 4 They've ruthlessly quashed a non-noble rival
- 5 A family scion has gotten in big trouble
- 6 Their superior has repaid a favor owed them
- 7 They're fighting with a rival local power base
- 8 They've formed an alliance with a neighbor
- 9 An old enemy of their line has struck them
- 10 They're fighting over rights to a particular title
- 11 They've committed some grave social faux pas
- 12 They've infuriated their superior somehow

d12 Merchants and Oligarchs

- 1 A local industry fell under their control
- 2 They made a deal with a local crime boss
- 3 They bought or built something fabulous
- 4 Criminals are assaulting their wealth sources
- 5 They cut a very profitable new deal
- 6 Their employees or minions are getting restive
- 7 They opened a new branch of operations
- 8 They made an alliance with a local noble
- 9 They've enlisted adventurers for dire work
- 10 A noble has marked them as a dangerous foe
- 11 They drove a rival out of business
- 12 Some enterprise of theirs has collapsed

d12 Demagogues and Religious Zealots

- 1 A noble patron is finding them useful
- 2 Their followers are getting out of hand
- 3 They're picking a fight with existing authority
- 4 They've made ties with local crime figures
- 5 They've struck against a hated local figure
- 6 They're spreading an appealing new idea
- 7 An important local has joined their cause
- 8 They've gotten a major donation from believers
- 9 They're being suppressed by local authorities
- 10 Followers are arguing over ideological points
- 11 They're trying to create a new power base
- 12 They've gotten a stroke of divine good fortune

d12 Warlords and Warband Chiefs

- 1 They've attacked a poorly-defended place
- 2 They've got a promising new lieutenant
- 3 One of their underlings betrayed them
- 4 Their men went on an undisciplined rampage
- 5 They've moved their base of operations
- 6 They've gotten backing from an outside power
- 7 They're trying to become legitimate rulers
- 8 They're infighting over loot, women, or rank
- 9 They were badly wounded in a fight
- 10 They pulled off a remarkable victory
- 11 Their band split due to a quarrel
- 12 They absorbed a weaker group

d12 Sorcerers and Magic-Users

- 1 They've acquired "subjects" for their work
- 2 They suffered a magical mishap of some kind
- 3 They've acquired an esoteric magic item
- 4 A rival sorcerer has struck at them
- 5 They've hired adventurers to acquire something
- 6 A noble has enlisted their aid in a cause
- 7 They've been venturing into ancient ruins
- 8 They've created a Working to pursue an end
- 9 They're accused of a heinous crime
- 10 The locals begged their aid in a time of need
- 11 They've acquired a promising apprentice
- 12 They've devised a new and potent magic



MAJOR PROJECTS AND PARTY GOALS

In any campaign, there will likely arise some occasion when the PCs take it into their heads to accomplish some great change in the world. Perhaps they want to abolish slavery in a country, or institute a new government in a howling wilderness, or crush the economic power of a hateful merchant cartel. The party wants to accomplish something grand or large-scale where there is no obvious direct path to success. No single killing or specific act of heroism will get them their aim, though the goal itself isn't so wild as to be obviously futile.

Such ambitions are *major projects*, and this section will cover a simple system to help the GM adjudicate their progress and success. This system is meant to handle sprawling, ambiguous ambitions that aren't clearly susceptible to a simple solution. If the party wants a dead town burgomaster, then they can simply kill him. If they want to turn his town into a major new trading nexus, something more complicated may be required.

RENOWN

The basic currency of major projects is called *Renown*, and it's measured in points much like experience points. PCs gain Renown for succeeding at adventures, building ties with the world, and generally behaving in a way to attract interest and respect from those around them. PCs then spend Renown to accomplish the changes they want to make in the world, reflecting their own background activities and the work of cooperative allies and associates.

Each individual PC has their own Renown score. They can spend it together with the rest of the party if they agree on the mutual focus of their interests, but a PC might also spend it on other ambitions or intermediate goals that come to mind. It's ultimately up to the player as to what they want to put their effort into; spending Renown reflects the kind of background work and off-screen support that the hero can bring to bear.

A GM doesn't have to track Renown unless they intend to use the this system. If the GM prefers to do things their own way, they can completely ignore Renown awards. If the GM changes their mind later and wants to introduce the system, they can simply give each PC a Renown score equal to their current accumulated experience points and then track things accordingly from there.

Generally, a PC will receive one point of Renown after each adventure. Some other activities or undertakings might win them additional bonus Renown, usually those works that increase the PC's influence and involvement with the campaign world, and some adventures might not give them much Renown at all if they left no impression on the people around the party. Specific guidelines on Renown awards are given in the adventure building section of the book, on page 254.

DETERMINING PROJECT DIFFICULTY

To find out how much Renown is needed to achieve a project, the GM must determine its difficulty. This total difficulty is a product of the intensity of the change, the scope it affects, and the powers that are opposed to it.

First, decide whether the change is plausible, improbable, or impossible. If the change is something that is predictable or unsurprising, it's a *plausible* change. A town with good transport links and a couple of wealthy neighbors might quite plausibly become a trade hub. A duke with an abandoned frontier keep and a raider problem might plausibly decide to give it to a famed warrior PC with the agreement that the PC would pledge fealty to him. A plausible change in the campaign is simply one that no one would find particularly surprising or unlikely.

An *improbable* change is one that's not physically or socially impossible, but is highly unlikely. Transforming a random patch of steppe grasslands into a trading hub might be an improbable change, as would convincing a duke to simply hand over the frontier fort with no particular claim of allegiance. Some things that are not particularly physically difficult might be improbable due to the social or emotional implications; a society with a relative handful of trophy slaves might find it improbable to give them up even if they serve only as status symbols for their owners.

An *impossible* change is just that; something that is physically or socially impossible to contemplate. Turning a desolate glacier on the edge of the world into a trading hub might be such, or convincing the duke to simply give the PCs his duchy. Accomplishing a feat like this might require substantial magical Workings, the involvement of ancient artifacts, or a degree of social upheaval on par with a war of conquest. Some changes might be so drastic that they require their own heroic labors simply to prepare the groundwork for the real effort, and entire separate projects must be undertaken before the real goal even becomes possible.

DETERMINING THE SCOPE

Once the change's probability is decided, the GM must identify how wide the scope of the change may be. The more land and the more people the change affects, the harder it will be to bring it about.

A village-sized change is the smallest scale, affecting only a single hamlet or a village's worth of people. A city-sized change affects the population of a single city or several villages, while a regional one might affect a single barony or small province. A kingdom-sized one affects a whole kingdom or a collection of feudal lordships, and a global change affects the entire Latter Earth, or at least those parts known to the PCs.

When deciding the scope of the change, focus on how many people are going to be immediately affected

Probability of the Goal	Base Difficulty	Scope Affected	Difficulty Multiplier	Greatest Active Opposition	Difficulty Multiplier
Plausible	1	Village	x2	Minor figures	x2
Improbable	2	City	x4	Local leaders	x4
Impossible	4	Region	x8	Major noble or beast	x8
		Kingdom	x16	King or famed monster	x16
		Known World	x32		

Multiply opposition by x2 if the local population is emotionally or socially against it.

by the project. Turning a town into a trading hub might incidentally affect a significant part of a kingdom, but the immediate consequences are felt only by the residents of that town, and perhaps their closest trading partners. The scope in that case would be simply that of a city, rather than a region. Banishing slavery throughout a kingdom would require a kingdom-sized change, while getting it banned within some smaller feudal region would require a proportionately lesser scope.

If the PCs are trying to establish an educational institution, or a religious order, or some other sub-group meant to serve a chosen cause, the scope should be the largest general area the order can have influence in at any one time. A very small order of warrior-monks might only have enough devotees to affect a village-sized community or problem. An order with multiple monasteries and bases of operations throughout a kingdom might have enough muscle to affect events on a nation-wide scale. In the same vein, a small academy might be enough to bring enlightened learning to a city, improving the lives of men and women there, but not have the reach to influence the greater region around it. Individual warrior-monks or specific scholars might play major roles elsewhere in the setting, but the institution itself can't rely on the certainty of being able to step into such roles.

In some cases, a PC might attempt to forge a Working or develop a specific bloodline of magical or cursed beings. Assuming that they have the necessary tools and opportunities to achieve such a great feat, the scope should apply to the total number of people affected by the magic over its entire course of existence. Thus, a village-sized change like this might apply to ten generations of a very small bloodline, the enchantment lasting for a very long time but applying only to a few people at any one time. It might be reproduced by special training, magical consecration, or a natural inherited bloodline. Once the scope limit is reached, the magic can no longer be transmitted, as it has either been exhausted or the subtle shiftings of the Legacy have damaged it beyond repair. Conversely, a very large scope for such a work might mean that many people are so affected, though a very large change like that would only last for a few generations before reaching the maximum affected population. Because of such limits, many such empowered bloodlines or augmented magical traditions are very selective about adding new members.

Optionally, PCs who want to create such a magical working can fix it indefinitely, causing it to be heritable or transmissible for the indefinite future. Such laborious workings are much more difficult than simply tying the effect to the natural flow of the Legacy, however, and so it costs four times more than it would otherwise. Thus, imbuing a village of people with some magical quality that they will forever after transmit down to a similar number of heirs would count as a x8 multiplier instead of a x2 multiplier.

DETERMINING THE OPPOSITION

Once you have decided on the difficulty and the scope, you now need to identify the most significant people or power bases that would be opposed to this change. In some cases, there may be no one opposed to the alteration; turning a steppe oasis into a trading post might not have anyone to object if there are no nomads who control the land, nor terrible beasts to threaten settlers. In most cases, however, there's going to be at least one person, creature, or other power in the area who would prefer things not change.

If the opposition comes in the form of ordinary peasants or citizens, minor bandit rabble, normal dangerous animals, or other disorganized and low-level threats, then the difficulty is multiplied by x2.

If the opposition is organized under competent leadership, such as a local baron, rich merchant, or persuasive priest, or if the opposition is some dangerous but not especially remarkable monster, then the difficulty is multiplied by x4.

If the opposition is entrenched and powerful, such as a group of nobles, an influential bandit king, a crime boss, a major city's mayor, or a monster impressive enough to have developed its own legendry, then the difficulty is multiplied by x8.

If the opposition involves facing down a king, a legendary monster, the primate of a major religion, or some similar monarchic power, then the difficulty is multiplied by x16.

When measuring opposition, only the greatest opponent counts. Thus, if the king, the nobility, and the local village chief all hate an idea, the difficulty modifier is x16. If the king is then persuaded to relent, the difficulty modifier becomes x8, until the barons are pacified,



after which the village chieftain is the only opposition left, for a x2 modifier.

On top of this, if the change inspires widespread popular disapproval or unease among the populace affected by the change, multiply the modifier by an additional x2. Such changes usually touch on delicate questions of group identity, cultural traditions, or basic values, and the people in the change's scope are likely to resist such measures on multiple levels.

As an example, assume an idealistic band of adventurers dreamed of extirpating slavery from an entire kingdom. The natives use slaves for work and status, but their labor isn't crucial to the economy's survival, so the GM decides it is merely improbable to give up slavery, for a base difficulty of 2. The scope is kingdom-wide, so 2 is multiplied by 16, for a difficulty of 32. As the situation stands now, the king has no desire to infuriate the wealthy magnates of his kingdom by taking away their free labor, so he would oppose it for an additional x16 multiplier, for a total difficulty of 512. Oh, and the natives find the idea of accepting slaves as equals to be emotionally abhorrent, so that's an additional x2 multiplier, for a final difficulty of 1,024.

It is very unlikely for the heroes to manage to scrape up the 1,024 points of Renown needed to make this change out of hand. They're going to have to alter the situation to quell the opposition and make specific strides toward making the ideal more plausible before they can finally bring about their dream.

DECREASING DIFFICULTY

Adventurers who have a dream bigger than their available Renown have several options for bringing it about more rapidly. The party can use some or all of these techniques for making their ambition more feasible, and the GM might well insist on at least some of them before the PCs can succeed.

They can spend money. Sometimes a problem can be solved by throwing enough money at it, either by paying off troublesome opponents, constructing useful facilities or installations, or hiring enough help to push the cause through. Money is often useful, but it eventually begets diminishing returns; once everything useful has been bought, additional coinage brings little result.

The adjacent table shows how much a point of Renown dedicated to the project costs. The first few points come relatively cheaply, but after that the price increases rapidly. Eventually, there comes a point where only the wealth of empires can shove a massive project through with sheer monetary force. Small projects and modest ambitions are generally easy to accomplish with cash, but society-wide alterations and massive undertakings can defeat the richest vault.

They can build institutions. If the PCs want a fortified monastery loyal to them, they can either throw enough Renown at their goal until allied NPCs and local potentates think it's a good idea to buy them off by building it for them, or they can actually go out and pur-

Renown Bought	Cost in Silver per Point
First 1-4 points	500 per point
Next 4 points	2,000 per point
Next 8 points	4,000 per point
Next 16 points	8,000 per point
Next 32 points	16,000 per point
Next 64 points	32,000 per point
Further points	Prohibitively expensive

Thus, purchasing 14 points of Renown would cost 2,000 for the first four, 8,000 for the next four, and 24,000 for the next six, for 34,000 total.

chase it with their own money. They can hire the masons, recruit the monks, and find a trustworthy abbot to act as regent for the heroes. Such steps may not be enough to completely attain the purpose, as they'll still have to deal with quelling any local opposition to the new monastery and any innate implausibility of establishing a monastery wherever they want to put it, but it'll get them a long way toward success.

The GM decides a reasonable cost for the institution they want to build and the assorted recruits they'll need to operate it, using the guidelines in this section. Prices will vary drastically based on the situation; building a splendid stone castle in a desert with no good source of stone will cost far more than listed, while hiring skilled artisans in a major metropolis won't be nearly as difficult as finding them in an empty tundra.

Once the cost is paid, the GM assigns a suitable amount of Renown toward attaining the goal. For example, if the overall goal is securing the trade route between two distant cities, building a fortified caravansary with patrolling road guards might give enough Renown to solve half the problem. The rest of it might require dealing with the opposition that's making the hazard in the first place, such as the depredations of a bandit chief or the perils of the savage monsters that haunt the road.

They can nullify opposition. Either through gold, persuasion, or sharp steel, the PCs can end the opposition of those powers who stand against their ambition. Opponents who can be bought off might be managed with nothing more than a lengthy discussion and an exchange of valuables, but other opponents might need full-fledged adventures to deal with. Some might demand favors in exchange for withdrawing their opposition, or quests accomplished on their behalf, or enemies snuffed out by the swords of the heroes. Others could be so unalterably opposed to the idea that they must either be killed or endured.

If the opposition is nullified, the difficulty decreases accordingly. If several sources of opposition exist, then only the biggest opponent counts for the multiplier; if they're eliminated, then the next largest counts.

They can adventure in pursuit of their goal. This adventure might be something as simple as finding the den of a troublesome pack of monsters, or it could be something as involved as delving into an ancient Deep to recover the lost regalia that will give them the moral authority to make demands of a troublesome prelate. Such adventures will give the PCs their usual award of Renown, but they can also give a bonus award toward their specific goal if their efforts are particularly relevant.

This bonus is determined by the GM. The easiest way for the GM to pick the proper amount for the award is to privately estimate how many such adventures their goal is worth and then award Renown accordingly. Thus, if the GM thinks that three adventures like this one is as much focus and effort as the group should have to spend toward accomplishing their aim, then each adventure will decrease the goal's difficulty by one-third.

Adventuring is by far the most efficient way to accomplish a group's goals, assuming they can come up with adventures that are relevant. This is intentional; a goal that gives the GM an easy supply of adventuring grist is a genuine contribution to the game. The more adventures that a GM gets out of PC ambitions, the easier it will be to prepare for the game and ensure the players are involved in the campaign.

ACHIEVING THE GOAL

Once the PCs have piled up enough Renown and lowered the difficulty enough to actually make it feasible to achieve the goal, they need to take the final steps necessary to complete the work. For a minor goal, this might be a simple matter of describing how they take care of the details, while a vast campaign of effort might culminate in several brutal, perilous adventures.

The time this change takes will rest with the GM's judgment. It might take half a year to build a large stone monastery, while a week could be time enough to throw up a palisade and other simple fortifications around a village. Persuading a kingdom to alter its laws about slavery might be done in a theoretical instant if the autocrat decrees but take years to truly percolate into the public consciousness. If the PCs have been working on the project for some time already this effort should be taken into account and lessen the time required.

For mundane changes or changes the GM doesn't really want to focus on, the PCs simply declare that they're spending their Renown and using their own good name, personal prowess, and accumulated friendships and contacts to pull off their ambition. They might give examples of some of the ways they're working to achieve the goal and specify what allies or resources they're deploying. The GM then describes the outcome of their efforts. They may not be completely successful and events may not work out exactly as they planned, but they'll get the substance of what they wanted.

For changes that push through opposition instead of subverting it, those that just pay the price for the opposition multiplier, the GM might make the PCs deal

with consequences of that unquelled opposition. The kingdom might outlaw slavery, but if not all the opposition was defeated there may remain small pockets where the law doesn't reach or the populace refuses to accept the freed slaves as fellow citizens. Solving these remnant problems might require their own projects or adventures.

For magical, impossible, or truly epic changes, the GM might oblige the PCs to face some culminating adventure or challenge before their ambition becomes real. They might've marshaled enough force and enough allies to depose the wicked king, but now the day of reckoning has come and they must face the tyrant and his elite guard in a pitched battle within the capital city. Some heroic changes might require several such adventures, with failure meaning that their efforts somehow fall short of complete success. If the tyrant is not slain, he might escape into exile to foment further trouble, or he might flee to a province he still can control.

Once the change is successfully achieved, the GM should take a little while to consider the larger ramifications of the event. Who in the surrounding area is going to take notice of the events, and what are they likely to do about it? What allies of the PCs might be strengthened by the change and able to push their own agendas further? What are the longer-term consequences of their actions, and how might these show up during future adventures?

The ultimate point of changes like these is not simply to make marks on the campaign map, but to create the seeds of future adventures and future events. The actions of the characters create reactions, and the deeper they involve themselves in the campaign setting, the more that setting is going to involve itself with them. This is ultimately a virtuous circle for the GM and the group, as it helps to generate adventures and events that matter to the players and spares the GM from confusion or uncertainty over what kind of adventuring grist to generate.

MAJOR CHANGES AND FACTIONS

Players are likely to end up with goals or ambitions that directly involve them with local factions or potentially touch on Assets or other resources significant to faction powers. This is normal, and it's not difficult to integrate the two systems when they happen to touch.

As a general rule, major projects should be treated just as adventures would be. When a project would plausibly damage a faction's Assets, then the Assets will be damaged or destroyed. When they would create an Asset useful for a faction, whether one belonging to the players or to another group, then the Asset is created. If a faction doesn't care for a project, it might turn into a source of opposition that must be quelled or overcome, while an allied faction might supply some portion of the Renown itself by taking an action to aid the PCs.

The help of a faction should be scaled by the GM; if an empire decides to give the PCs a castle, then it might be such a minor part of the faction's holding that no Treasure expense or other effort is required to do so. A small



religious cult that wants to help build a monastery for the PCs might not be able to give nearly as much help, and might simply be good for a quarter of the Renown needed if they spend an action assisting the PCs. Conversely, when a faction is opposed to some measure, the PCs will probably have to undertake an adventure to change its mind or pull the fangs that it's using to interfere with their efforts.

MAGICAL PROJECTS

Some projects are flatly impossible in nature, such as changing humans into some new humanoid species or creating a magical effect that covers an entire region. These efforts are a step beyond ordinary impossibility, as they often require measures entirely beyond the physical capabilities of normal civilizations.

While exceedingly difficult, such projects are not out of the question for powerful mages who have the help of skilled adventurers. They do require a few more steps than an ordinary project would require, however.

The heroes must create one or more Workings dedicated to enabling the change, using the guidelines given in the Magic chapter. The scope of these Workings must be large enough to affect the scope of the change itself; if the alteration is to be done to an entire region, then a region-sized Working must be built. Workings so large as to affect an entire kingdom are beyond the scope of modern magic, and only some special quest into the fathomless past could discover the keys to grand, world-spanning alterations.

The degree of the Working will depend on the degree of the change. The devising of a race of humanoid creatures similar to humans but cosmetically different might be a Minor Working, while more substantial alterations will require great degrees of power. The summoning of a river from the depths of the earth might be a Major change for a small stream, while something the size of the Amazon might be of Supreme difficulty.

If the magical change is impossible but relatively modest in scope, then one great Working will be necessary to empower it. If the change is significant and will have major repercussions on the future area, it will take two, while a change that seems barely within the limits of possibility will need three Workings to support it, all of the appropriate degree and scope. The construction of these Workings often require adventures in their own right to find the critical components or esoteric substances needed to erect them, to say nothing of the material cost of the work.

If these Workings are later destroyed or corrupted the change itself may be damaged as well. Sometimes the effect is so graven on the world that it continues unsupported, but other times the change fades away into something more mundane. In the worst cases, the magic goes rampant and terrible consequences are born from its uncontrolled fury. As a consequence, most nations are highly averse to the construction of large-scale magical infrastructure, even when they can afford to do so.

FACTIONS AND MAJOR PROJECTS

PCs who have the friendship or control of factions can leverage them to assist in their grand plans. A faction can assist on a project only once per faction turn, and this help counts as its action for the turn.

When a faction helps, it spends one point of Treasure and decreases the difficulty of the project by the sum total of its Wealth, Force, and Cunning attributes, down to a minimum difficulty of 1 point. The faction can't usually complete a major project on its own; it needs the PC or some driving personality to envision and implement the plan. A faction needs to spend Treasure and help only once on a project to decrease the difficulty. The difficulty reduction remains until the project is complete or the faction chooses to withdraw its support for some reason. More than one faction can contribute its help, if they can be persuaded.

If the faction is ideally suited to the project, such as a government establishing a new political order, or a religion instituting a new cultural norm, or a thieves' guild forming a cabal of assassins, then their attribute total is doubled for purposes of calculating the new difficulty.

If the faction is willing or forced to go to extremes in helping a project, either out of desperation or the ruthless demands of its leadership, it can commit its Assets and own institutional health to the project. Any Asset or Base of Influence in the same location as the project can accept hit point damage to lower the difficulty; each hit point they spend lowers it by one point. This kind of commitment is difficult to calibrate safely; at the end of the spend, each Asset or Base of Influence that contributed suffers an additional 1d4 damage. This may be enough to destroy an Asset, or even destroy the faction itself if enough damage is done to a Base of Influence. If the Asset is destroyed in the process of helping the project, the fallout of its collapse or exhaustion may have local consequences of its own.

If the faction is of a vastly larger scale than the project, such as a prosperous kingdom helping to construct a new border village, the entire project can be resolved in a single action. In some cases, the GM may not even require the faction to spend any Treasure, as the expense is so small relative to its resources that it's not worth tracking.

MAJOR PROJECTS IN STARS WITHOUT NUMBER

If you're importing these rules for use in *Stars Without Number*, they can be brought over largely verbatim. As a crude rule of thumb, 25 credits is worth 1 silver when buying Renown. GMs are within their rights to cap buyable Renown much lower, however, unless the PCs are sufficiently integrated with the local culture. Otherwise, they may not really know *how* to convert cash into great influence without just wasting it on parasites and con men.

CONSTRUCTION COSTS

It's often necessary for a GM to have some idea what a particular structure might cost to build or buy. PCs might want to establish a base of operations in the wilderness, or some grand plan they have might require the construction of a sprawling institution. Sometimes wealthy patrons will offer rewards in land and real estate rather than cash, and an idea of what their largesse is worth is useful for a GM.

The prices here reflect ordinary costs for purchase or construction materials in the places normal for each structure. A wealthy peasant's farmhouse would cost far more than 200 silver to build on the costly land within a walls, while a city townhouse could perhaps be had for a quarter of the price if it were built in some rural village.

These prices also assume that materials can be had relatively close to hand. A PC who wants to build a wooden manor house in the midst of a savanna may be disappointed, while one who wants a stone watchtower in a place that lacks any nearby quarries may have to undertake great labors or greater expenses to have his way.

These prices are for simply buying an existing property. If the PCs want to build one from scratch, they'll also need to pay for the labor they need to build it, hiring masons and common laborers at the wages given on the following page.

GENERAL CONSTRUCTION

Most of the time, PCs who want to build a structure not on the list can just pick something close. The GM can then adjust the price to what seems reasonable to them. Other times, however, the PCs want to build something unusual, and no existing structure seems a good match.

The general construction costs adjacent cover the abstract cost of building wooden or stone structures of a particular volume or complexity. Ordinary living spaces, walls, simple bridges, and other basic and common structures qualify as "simple" construction, while exceptionally artful, beautifully adorned, or difficult-to-engineer structures as counted as "elaborate".

To find the total price of a structure or delving, just add up all the ten-foot cubes or other spaces it involves and price it accordingly. The costs include ordinary furnishings or functional equipment within a structure appropriate to its nature and function.

BUILDING STRUCTURES

One skilled artisan-mason can build 25 silver pieces worth of the structure for each day of labor. Thus, a building worth 10,000 silver could be constructed in 40 days by a team of ten skilled laborers. Unskilled laborers or those with no experience in construction are worth only 5 silver pieces of completed work per day. Large or complex structures built with less than 10% skilled labor may be less than perfect in execution.

Cost	Common Buildings and Lands
500	Good, safe farmland for a family
25,000	Landholdings for a minor lord
200,000	Landholdings for a major noble
50	Humble peasant cottage
200	Prosperous peasant farmhouse
500	Village temple
250	Urban slum dwelling
1,000	Modest city shop
2,500	City townhouse
5,000	Military watchtower or outpost
5,000	Minor city temple
25,000	Rural gentry estate
50,000	Keep on the borderlands
50,000	Important urban temple
100,000	Merchant-prince's city house
250,000	Large royal palace
500,000	Major fortress

General Construction Costs	
50	Simple wooden / 10' cube
200	Elaborate wooden / 10' cube
200	Simple stone / 10' cube
500	Elaborate stone / 10' cube
100	Stone wall per 10'x10'x1'
10	Wooden palisade per 10'x10'x1'
250	Tunnel through stone, 10'x10'x5'
100	Shored tunnel through earth, "
10	Trench or earth mound, 10x10x10

PCs with the Administer skill, or Work skill related to the labor, or some other background suitable for oversight can personally oversee the labor to save 10% of the total labor and material costs, assuming they're willing to remain on site for the duration of the work.

PROPERTY TAXES

If the PCs own property on land that's meaningfully controlled by some other power, they can usually expect to pay 5% of its total worth to the local ruler each year. Exceptionally powerful PCs may be exempt from this if the ruler doubts his ability to make them pay, or if their presence is somehow useful to the ruler. Nobles and other titled folk are often exempt from these taxes as well, an often-sore point to the common gentry and merchants.

HIRELINGS AND SERVITORS

Heroes with large households to maintain, fortifications to construct, or other major projects to undertake might need to hire a wide range of employees. The servants listed here will work on a monthly basis, carrying out all ordinary duties of their role.

Hirelings will not generally venture into unusually dangerous places such as Deeps, *arratus*, untamed wilderness, or hostile territories, nor will they take risks beyond the customary scope of their duties. Smooth talking and the immediate application of silver might persuade some of the braver among them to take a few excess risks, but heroes who want companions in a dungeon will have to negotiate terms involving full shares of loot... and will likely find few takers even then.

The monthly hire prices listed assume that the hireling lives elsewhere. If the PC's estate can provide a home and lifestyle of a quality appropriate to the hireling's expectations, their hire price can be halved.

Where it matters, a hireling is assumed to have a skill bonus of +1 in relevant skill checks. Finding better servants than this usually requires an adventure.

Artisan: Whether a common blacksmith, harlot, mason, carpenter, or tailor, or a more exalted armorsmith, jeweler, or architect, an artisan will provide their services to the PC. While they can create items as noted on page 58, their help may be necessary for maintaining a large household, supporting its staff, or justifying progress in some major project.

Assassin: This criminal could be a killer for hire, or they might be an expert cat burglar, skilled fence, or some other criminal elite. An assassin can probably kill any ordinary man or woman, and might manage to bag tougher targets with a good skill check. Each time they act, roll 1d6, subtracting 1 or more if the target was important or well-guarded. On a 1 or less, something went badly wrong or they were traced back to their employer.

Bodyguard: These servants have the statistics of Veteran Soldiers and come equipped with light armor and hand weapons. They're skilled at guarding their employer from ordinary assassination attempts and polite enough to be taken into genteel society.

Farmhand or common laborer: An ordinary farmer, sailor, porter, hod-carrier, or other practitioner of an extremely common trade.

House servant: Maids, cooks, footmen, and other employees that require some modicum of social training but no esoteric skills.

Majordomo: A large household requires an experienced butler, chamberlain, or other majordomo to maintain discipline and efficiency in the staff. Houses of more than ten servants without such a leader might find themselves prey to pilferage or poor service.

Monthly Pay in SP	Hirelings
50	Artisan of a common skill
200	Artisan of a rare skill
250	Assassin
100	Bodyguard
20	Farmhand or common laborer
30	House servant
250	Majordomo
250	Minor Mage
50	Musician or performer
200	Physician
200	Priest
200	Reeve
75	Scholar
500	Spymaster

Minor Mage: While this servitor has the talents of a first level mage, they lack the ambition for a greater place in life. Such mages will cast spells for their patron or provide arcane consulting services, but they will not generally adventure with them.

Musician or Performer: Bards, dancers, singers, musicians, storytellers, or other purveyors of skilled amusement can be hired.

Physician: Not a magical Healer, but skilled in the mundane care of the sick or frail.

Priest: A cleric of whatever faith is best favored by their employer. While they cannot use magic, they can perform the rites of their faith, give educated advice, and give spiritual assistance to their employer and fellow servants.

Reeve: Whether a bailiff, reeve, agent, or overseer, this hireling can monitor farms and other landholdings and ensure order is maintained, rents are paid, and due services are rendered. Without a reeve, employers with landholdings too large to personally monitor may suffer losses of income from them.

Scholar: This employee is versed in some academic topic of interest to their employer. While they can answer many questions in their specialty, the broad character of learning in this age leaves them equipped with most scholarly languages and a nodding grasp of all major academic fields.

Spymaster: The spymaster comes with a small ring of informants and agents that can infiltrate one community or organization at a time, assuming the GM thinks it plausible. They'll usually dig up at least one interesting or profitable fact about their target each month.

SOLDIERS AND GUARDS

PCs with fortresses to garrison or raids to conduct may need to hire help. The prices given here are for quickly-hired mercenaries; if the PC can offer appropriate long-term housing for them, their monthly price is halved.

Soldiers will generally endure mundane risks, like dangerous overland travel or attacks on hostile forces, but they won't normally go Deep-crawling, exploring, or confronting supernatural or overwhelming perils.

While the core rules of *Worlds Without Number* don't include mass combat rules, GMs can estimate combat results with a quick approximation. For monsters and PCs, estimate their combat strength as compared to a human light infantry. You can add percentage bonuses to either side's total to reflect situational advantages.

Total each side's combat strength. Add them together and divide the weaker side's score by the total. That's the percentage chance that the weaker side wins a fight.

Archer: Wears a buff coat and uses a large bow, with a short sword for backup

Crossbowman: Wears a buff coat and uses a crossbow, with a short sword for self-defense

Heavy Cavalry: Fights as an Elite on a warhorse, uses mail hauberk, large shield, and one or more melee weapons

Heavy Infantry: Uses cuirass and greaves, large shield, and a melee weapon

Light Cavalry: Fights as a Skilled Veteran on a warhorse, uses a buff coat, small shield, and light spears for throwing and melee

Monthly Pay in SP	Soldiers and Guards	Combat Strength
40	Light Infantry	1
60	Heavy Infantry	2
100	Light Cavalry	4
200	Heavy Cavalry	8
75	Archer	3
150	Horse Archer	5
50	Crossbowman	2
x2	Sergeant	x2
x5	Captain	x5

Light Infantry: Usually uses linethorax, large shield, and a melee weapon

Horse Archer: A Skilled Veteran on a riding horse; uses a buff coat, small bow, and a hand weapon

Sergeant: Every ten troops need one sergeant to keep them sharp and in line. The sergeant costs half again as much as a usual trooper of his type, and has +1 hit die and +1 to hit compared to others of his type.

Captain: Every hundred troops needs one captain if they're to respond efficiently to their employer's commands. These cost five times as much as a usual trooper of their kind, and have +2 hit dice over their base type and +2 to hit. Captains won't usually serve unless they actually have troops to command, so PCs can't just hire a squad of such proven fighters.



ARTS OF THE GYRE

Every region of the Latter Earth has its own special arts and traditions of occult or martial skill. Many of these paths are long since lost to the ages, such as the gladiator-sages once employed by Tsagasthos the Prevalent or the holy vindicators of the Nagadi. Even so, fragments of these lost arts can survive the long eons to be reborn in more modern shapes.

This section of the book provides six professions unique to the Gyre region of the Latter Earth, though equivalents might exist elsewhere. The *Adunic Invoker* is a magical tradition that may be taken by partial or full Mages, while the other five are all non-spellcasting partial Mage classes that can be mixed by an Adventurer into the desired concept.

While these options are included in this book, they might not be included in your GM's campaign. They might not be appropriate for your particular table or setting, or the GM may have their own equivalents in mind. Players should also generally avoid selecting partial classes such as these for reasons of optimization alone; you should pick one of these classes because it fits your concept, and not because it gives you a combo bonus.

For campaigns that are not set in the Latter Earth, these partial classes can be reskinned to serve different conceptual needs. Individual powers or perks might be swapped out in order to insert other abilities that fit the particular setting, or that better suit the concept the GM is trying to emulate. Even for campaigns set in the Latter Earth, variant traditions and particular sub-sects might express these classes in their own unique way.

The *Adunic Invoker* is useful for GMs and players who dislike conventional Vancian magic and prefer a spell point system of casting.

The *Darian Skinshifter* can be used when a PC wants to add shapeshifting to their character's armory, or when they wish to emulate the traditional druidic shapeshifting powers of some other games.

The *Kistian Duelist* is an example of a swashbuckling light-armor combatant who trades durability and a little overall combat expertise for additional mobility options and bonuses in situational one-on-one duels.

The *Llaigisan Beastmaster* is a template for characters who want to rely on an animal companion who is useful in combat, such as some interpretations of the classic ranger or druid.

The *Sarulite Blood Priest* is there for PCs who want to play a traditional cleric-type hero. It focuses on a modest selection of generally-useful miracles rather than granting full spellcasting abilities.

The *Vothite Thought Noble* is one way to do a mindbender-PC who might not have other magical abilities and may be more mind-control-focused than a Partial Telepath from *Stars Without Number*.

Many concepts are perfectly well-supported by one of the base classes plus an apposite Focus or two. A GM generally shouldn't bother to build a whole new class for their campaign unless a specific player in it desires a concept that is both reasonable and unable to be supported in a simpler way. By using these classes as templates and examples, such creative work can be made less taxing.



ADUNIC INVOKER

The magical tradition of the Adunic Invoker have been long practiced in Ka-Adun. Most scholars say that the rudiments were first brought over by the Reaping King and his mysterious attendants, but a minority say that its versatile and polymorphous nature owes more to certain psychic disciplines found among the host-minds of the vile Emperor known as Tsagasthos the Prevalent. Naturally, modern adepts utterly deny such slanderous accusations.

An Invoker wields High Magic much like their more traditional brethren, but the plasticity of their mind is such that they are capable of much more precise distribution of their occult powers. A master High Mage's will is exhausted after a half-dozen spells are cast, while an Adunic Invoker of the same expertise can hurl twice as many minor enchantments. This flexibility comes at a price, however, and an Invoker is not capable of casting multiple powerful spells in quick succession the way a skilled High Mage can. The need for flexible integration of their powers also leaves their available prepared spells each day as somewhat fewer than their High Mage peer.

Still, even a novice Invoker is much less likely to run dry of sorcery in a day than their traditional counterpart. Their focus on magical energetics does limit their outside study, however, and they do not develop the arts that other sorcerers do. The rituals, meditations, and pacts established as part of this tradition are also highly antagonistic to the techniques used by conventional mages, so it is not possible to blend this art with more standard spellcasting expertise.

Even so, adventurers have been known to blend the Invoker's skills with more mundane pursuits, such that a Partial Warrior/Partial Adunic Invoker might have a number of useful spells to hand, or a Partial Vowed/Partial Adunic Invoker might delve into mysterious disciplines of inner energy and manifest will.

Full Adunic Invokers

Level	Max Spell Level	Spell Points	Spells Prepared
1	1	1 + Int Mod	2 + Int Mod
2	1	3 + Int Mod	3 + Int Mod
3	2	4 + Int Mod	4 + Int Mod
4	2	5 + Int Mod	4 + Int Mod
5	3	6 + Int Mod	5 + Int Mod
6	3	7 + Int Mod	6 + Int Mod
7	4	8 + Int Mod	7 + Int Mod
8	4	9 + Int Mod	7 + Int Mod
9	5	10 + Int Mod	8 + Int Mod
10	5	11 + Int Mod	9 + Int Mod

INVOKER BENEFITS

All Adunic Invokers gain Magic as a bonus skill, acquiring it at level-0, or level-1 if was already level-0. Their arcane versatility requires a thorough grounding in theory.

Adunic Invokers can learn and prepare spells of the High Magic tradition, and have the same limits on casting in armor as they do. Each Invoker can prepare a number of known spells as indicated by the table each day, plus their Intelligence modifier.

Each Invoker has a number of **spell points** based on their level, to which is added their Intelligence modifier. When they cast the spell, they subtract its level from their available spell points for the day. So long as they have sufficient spell points left, they can cast the same spell repeatedly. Spell points refresh each morning.

Invokers do not normally gain arts; their versatility requires complete focus. While it's possible to be a Partial Adunic Invoker, this partial class may not be mixed with another partial spellcasting class.

Adunic Invokers begin play knowing four first level High Magic spells, or two if a partial class. When they advance a level, they learn two more of any level or tradition from which they can cast, or one if a partial Invoker.

Focus: Traditional Education

Your Adunic Invoker has received a great deal of education in a specialist arcane tradition such as High Magic arts, Elementalism or Necromancy. Only Adunic Invokers can take this Focus, and it can only be taken once.

Level 1: You may learn and prepare spells of your chosen tradition as well as those of High Magic. You gain arts as if a first level practitioner of that tradition, full or partial based on whether you're a full or partial Invoker, and your maximum Effort score is equal to your Magic skill, to a minimum of 1. You cannot gain further arts from this tradition.

Partial Adunic Invokers

Level	Max Spell Level	Spell Points	Spells Prepared
1	1	1 + Int Mod	1 + Int Mod
2	1	1 + Int Mod	3 + Int Mod
3	1	2 + Int Mod	3 + Int Mod
4	1	2 + Int Mod	4 + Int Mod
5	2	3 + Int Mod	4 + Int Mod
6	2	3 + Int Mod	5 + Int Mod
7	2	4 + Int Mod	5 + Int Mod
8	2	4 + Int Mod	6 + Int Mod
9	3	5 + Int Mod	6 + Int Mod
10	3	6 + Int Mod	7 + Int Mod



DARIAN SKINSHIFTER

The fallen kingdom of Emed-Dar was once famed for the beauty of its people and the elegance of its art. Whether in the form of magnificent cities of marble and bronze, estates built in graceful harmony with the green hills of the countryside, or nobility possessed of a symmetry and loveliness seldom seen elsewhere, the Darians were celebrated for their impeccable aesthetic judgment.

Some of these aesthetes pressed their fascination with beauty beyond the conventional limits of humanity. Arcane techniques of self-sculpting and occult bio-modification were enlisted to their cause, and some even murmur that certain breeds of Blighted and Outsiders were “studied” to unlock the secrets of their flesh. These Darian shapeshifters emulated existing biological structures in new and intriguing ways, harmonizing the alien with the human to explore whole new realms of aesthetic perfection.

When Emed-Dar drowned under the tide of an Anak invasion, the shapeshifters were forced into hiding. Those that did not flee were compelled to adopt the shape of common beasts and innocuous creatures, ones that could escape the notice of the cruel invaders. Over the centuries since, their once-elegant sensibilities have been roughened and scraped down by the harsh demands of survival, and arts that owe little to beauty have been refined by desperate practitioners.

Presently, Skinshifters exist as guardians and scouts of the few remaining human remnants in what was once Emed-Dar. Most such bands are nomadic, fleeing from the Anak tribes and hiding in the most dangerous and desolate places. Some orphaned Skinshifters have left Emed-Dar entirely, teaching their occult arts to apprentices in other lands in exchange for protection or favors from the powerful there.

The presence of shapeshifters in lands far from old Emed-Dar is sometimes explained as being remnants of ancient offshoots of the original aesthete-mages. These schismatics are said to have their own purposes.

Partial Darian Skinshifter

Level	Form Bonus	Arts Gained
1	+1	Change Form and Any One
2	+1	Any One
3	+2	
4	+2	Any One
5	+3	Any One
6	+3	Any One
7	+4	
8	+4	Any One
9	+5	
10	+6	Any One

SKINSHIFTER BENEFITS

Skinshifter is a partial Mage class, meant to be taken by an Adventurer in conjunction with another partial class. A Partial Warrior/Skinshifter might be a shapeshifting assassin or feral savage warrior, while a Partial Expert/Skinshifter could be an undetectable impostor or con artist.

All Skinshifters gain Survive-0 as a bonus skill, or Survive-1 if they already have Survive-0 as a skill. Their acquaintance with the wild and feral parts of the world is substantial, and even the most ignorant among them can survive comfortably in the wilderness.

SKINSHIFTER FORMS

The arts of a Skinshifter revolve around improving or adjusting their alternate forms. These alternate forms have a few basic rules that apply to all their permutations.

A Skinshifter can master one alternate form per character level. A Skinshifter who wants to change a form selection can do so with a day of careful practice and adjustment. Skinshifter PCs should note down the special powers or traits of their alternate forms and keep in mind which of them they have available at any one time.

A Skinshifter's alternate forms use the same hit points, character attributes, and movement speed as their normal form, unless modified by particular arts. Thus, a Skinshifter shifted into a wolf's shape would do no more damage with its bite than the human's unarmed attack would do without some augmenting art. Alternate forms do grant a minimum level of combat competence, however, and so the “Form Bonus” hit bonus is used in place of the PC's basic class hit bonus when in a non-humanoid shape, assuming they don't already have a better basic bonus from their other partial class.

Arts that improve the alternate forms can apply their benefits even if the creature's natural shape wouldn't normally grant it. Thus, a Skinshifter with the *Manifest Wings* art could have a wolf-form that had wings and a flying speed if they wished. A given form can have no more than three arts applied to it.

A Skinshifter's alternate forms can be any size between a horse and a kitten, barring modification by some art. They do not need to emulate a specific type of creature; a Skinshifter could have a clawed and winged humanoid form as an alternate shape, or a dog with the head of a man, or a cat with razor-sharp mandibles.

The belongings carried by a Skinshifter meld into any new form unless the PC decides otherwise, granting any benefit to Armor Class or other worn advantage they may normally give. Melded objects can be manifested and dropped as an On Turn action, but cannot be re-melded again unless the PC changes form with them again.

Skinshifter forms cannot perfectly duplicate another individual creature without an appropriate art.

ARTS OF THE SKINSHIFTER

Skinshifter Effort is based on Survive, and is equal to the PC's Survive skill level plus the highest of their Constitution or Charisma modifiers, to a minimum of one point. All Skinshifters begin play with the **Change Form** art and one more of their choice. Additional arts are learned as the PC advances in experience.

Change Form: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action to transform into an available alternate form. This shift persists until you die, shift to a new form, or end the transformation as an On Turn action. Your hit points, System Strain, and other scores remain the same in any new form, but in a non-humanoid form your class's base attack bonus can be no worse than the one listed on the table. If your shape is quadrupedal, its Move is 10' faster than your base.

OTHER SKINSHIFTER ARTS

Eyes of the Hawk: This shape has remarkably acute senses. You can scent trails and objects like a dog, hear very faint noises, see objects clearly enough to identify faces at a thousand feet of distance, and see clearly in anything short of complete darkness. You gain a +2 bonus on all sensory Notice checks.

Feline Leap: This form can vault great distances. You can jump your full Move rating as a Move action, crossing the full distance horizontally or up to half the distance vertically. You subtract your Move rating from fall distance for damage calculations.

Feral Prowess: This form has an augmented degree of speed, strength, or hardness. For this form, pick either Strength, Dexterity, or Constitution; that attribute modifier is improved by +1 in this form, to a maximum of +2. These alterations are obvious and extreme; it is impossible to masquerade as a normal baseline human if using this art. Hit points gained from Con improvements are lost when shifting back.

Intrinsic Armor: This shape has tough scales, hide, shell, or other defensive integuments. Your base Armor Class is 14 plus half your character level, rounded down. This AC can be modified by your Dexterity modifier, and by shields if the shape can hold one.

Manifest Wings: This shape can form usable wings. You can't effectively attack while concentrating on remaining aloft, but you can fly at your normal movement rate +10' per action. If unhindered and flying overland you can travel up to ten miles an hour and fly up to five hours a day.

Octopus' Embrace: This shape can have more than four usable limbs. These additional tentacles, arms, legs, or grippers can hold and manipulate things; up to four Stowed objects can be held Ready by these limbs without counting against your Readied Encumbrance limit. These extra limbs cannot effectively employ extra shields, perform additional attacks or actions, or do other things that require significant focus beyond your current action.

Perfect Mimicry: This alternate form can exactly duplicate another creature, provided you either have a lock of their hair, a still-liquid drop of their blood, or ten minutes of observation of them from within five feet. Once learned, you need no further samples.

Pliant Flesh: You've mastered your shapeshifting skills, and **Change Form** can be used as an On Turn action, albeit only once per round. Alternately, it can take as long as a minute but cost no Effort. Whenever you spend Effort to shift shape, you heal lost hit points equal to 1d6 plus your level; this does not apply when merely reverting a form's change. This art is intrinsic to you, and doesn't count against the total number of arts allowed to apply to a form.

Savage Talons: This shape has extremely dangerous claws, fangs, pincers, or other body weapons. At first level these weapons do 1d8 damage, use either Str or Dex as the modifying attribute, Punch as the combat skill, and have a Shock value of 2/AC 13. At level 3 the damage and Shock increase by +1, at level 6 they increase to +2, and at level 9 they increase to +3. These weapons can harm even creatures immune to non-magical weaponry.

Sculptor's Beauty: You've developed a refined aesthetic sense that can directly appeal to the subconscious beauty preferences of viewers. This shape improves your Charisma modifier by +1, to a maximum of +2. There is always something alien about this beauty, and such forms can never be mistaken for an entirely normal human or animal, though they may be taken for some exotic demihuman or altered baseline.

Serpent's Kiss: This shape can exude a venom on its claws or fangs. Successful hits allow you to Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action to inflict an additional 1d8 damage plus your Survive skill. You can elect to make the toxin paralytic rather than fatal; foes reduced to zero hit points by such a blow are paralyzed and helpless for an hour rather than mortally wounded.

The Monkey's Road: This shape has an arboreal agility when it comes to climbing. You can travel up sheer surfaces at your usual movement rate provided at least three limbs are available for use and the surface is not glassily smooth. If you fall, you can halt your plunge without damage so long as a serviceable surface to cling to is within ten feet of you.

Warform: You gain a flat +2 bonus to all melee hit rolls in this shape and can use your form hit bonus even in a humanoid body. This shape is blatantly martial in appearance, however, and cannot pass as anything harmless or wholly human.

Wisdom of Fin and Scale: This shape can breathe water, swim at double your usual Move rate, and is impervious to any normal climatic extreme of cold or undersea pressure. It can see up to sixty feet while underwater even in the absence of normal light.



KISTIAN DUELIST

The swordmasters of Emed-Kist are famed for their more-than-mundane expertise with a blade and their uncanny powers of agility. Most of them have inherited their skills through a long line of descent from refugee Emed-Darian blade artists and their esoteric studies of aesthetic murder, while others are heirs to independent sword-scholars who learned their own ways to tap into special graces of steel.

The techniques of a Duelist are not entirely unmagical in nature. Secret meditations, occult training katas, and careful internal energy cultivation are all used to tap into the Legacy and imbue mundane steel with supernatural benefits. Some Duelists can go so far as to manifest weapons out of their own tangible will.

Such cultivation of the arcane comes at a price, of course. A Duelist is less hardy than a more traditional swordsman and less capable of surviving reverses if their perfectly-polished techniques prove insufficient. The high mobility required by the style also makes it impossible to use it with encumbering armors. Even so, some adventuring arcanists are known to practice the art so as to have a fallback if their magic proves inadequate.

Instruction in the arts of Kistian dueling is rare outside of Emed-Kist, and not overly common within it. Only a very few initiates have the innate talent and correct arcane capacities to wield the arts of a Duelist, and all too many masters are willing to take coin without end for lessons that never quite stick. Even so, there are a few masters with principles or wealth enough to teach only those capable of learning the full depth of their art. Most such Duelists are in the employ of nobility as protagonists, bodyguards, assassins, or trainers to their own staff. Others are protectors of their own native enclaves in Emed-Kist, prosecuting endless quarrels with rival groups or Darian interlopers. Those Duelists who weary of such work strike off on their own, trusting in their swords to bring them what their hearts desire.

Partial Kistian Duelist

Level	Favored Weapon Bonus	Arts Gained
1	+1	Favored Weapon and Any One
2	+1	Any One
3	+2	
4	+2	Any One
5	+3	Any One
6	+3	Any One
7	+4	
8	+4	Any One
9	+5	
10	+5	Any One

KISTIAN DUELIST BENEFITS

Kistian Duelist is a partial Mage class, meant to be taken by an Adventurer in conjunction with another partial class. Partial Warrior/Duelist is the most common pairing, for a skilled light-armor combatant with high mobility and a number of useful combat techniques. Partial Expert/Duelist might represent an assassin who relies on stealth as much as steel, while a rare few Mage/Duelist combinations speak of adventuring wizards who perhaps have more talent for the sword than for the spell.

All Duelists gain Stab-0 as a bonus skill, or Stab-1 if they already have the skill at level-0. No Duelist worth the name is entirely incapable of effective use of melee weapons, though the style lends itself heavily to specialization.

THE KISTIAN FLAW OF FRAGILITY

While the canons of the duelist make for an excellent one-on-one combatant, their practitioners spend much less time at raw physical conditioning than their more traditional warrior peers. The techniques they use are swift and lethal, but they aren't as generally applicable to enduring harm as are standard training methods.

As such, Partial Warriors/Partial Kistian Duelists use 1d6 for their hit dice, rather than the Partial Warrior's usual 1d6+2. Other partial class mixes are unaffected by this flaw.

MAKING MAGICAL WARRIORS AND EXPERTS

The Kistian Duelist is just one example of a common fantasy trope; the warrior with some sort of innate magical power. The same trope is often applied to skill-based concepts as well, producing shapeshifting assassins, sorcery-singing bards, or artisans with frankly impossible creative powers.

There's nothing wrong with this trope in of itself, but it's a hard one to execute in a balanced way. The natural assumption when adding magic to something is that it makes whatever it is even better. If a warrior is good, a warrior with magic must naturally be superior.

Resist this urge. Unless you want your entire campaign to consist of multiple flavors of mage, a plain, untainted warrior or straight-up thief has to be better at something related to their role than the magical equivalent. In *Worlds Without Number*, the Warrior has class abilities that make them better at general slaughter than the Duelist. If you make a class that can do as much reliable damage and take as much punishment as the Warrior can, you risk the deprecation of an entire swath of concepts.

ARTS OF THE KISTIAN DUELIST

Duelist Effort is based on Stab, and is equal to the PC's Stab skill plus the highest of their Dexterity or Intelligence modifiers, to a minimum of one point. All Duelists begin with the *Favored Weapon* art and one more of their choice. Additional arts are learned as the PC advances in experience.

The arts of the Kistian Duelist require agility and free motion. The Duelist cannot benefit from any art of this class while wearing medium or heavy armor or carrying a large shield. Dual-wielding is practiced by some Duelists, but most prefer the defensive advantages of a small offhand shield.

All Duelists begin play with the *Favored Weapon* art and one other of their choice.

Favored Weapon: Choose one specific type of non-unarmed melee weapon from the list on page 37. You begin play with such a weapon, and when using this type you may use the Favored Weapon attack bonus column on the Duelist table to determine your base hit bonus, unless it's already better for some other reason. If your second partial class is Partial Warrior, your class' base hit bonus with the weapon is instead equal to your level. You cannot apply this or other Kistian arts to thrown weapons.

OTHER DUELIST ARTS

Blood for Blood: Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action when an enemy hits you with a physical attack. If you attack that enemy with your favored weapon before the end of the next round, the first blow hits automatically and can do no less damage than was done to you, up to the weapon's maximum.

Burst of Speed: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action. You may move your full normal movement rate as an On Turn action. This art can be used only once per round.

Code Duello: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action when engaged with a single foe. So long as no other combatant attacks either your target or you, and you attack no one but your target, you gain a +4 bonus to your Armor Class and can roll your hit rolls twice, taking the better result. Once the *Code Duello* has been disrupted or ended, it cannot be invoked again during that scene.

Crushing Superiority: Your favored weapon gains the Less Lethal quality if it doesn't already have it. Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action when you hit a target; they must immediately make an Instinct check. This ability can be used only once per scene on any given target.

Dauntless Step: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action. The Move actions you make for the rest of the round can cross vertical surfaces or difficult terrain at your full normal movement rate, provided you end the round standing upright on a surface that can bear your weight.

Dodge Doom: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action when caught in some explosion or other burst effect. You take half damage, or no damage if the effect allows a save and you succeed at it. You can move yourself up to ten feet away from your original location, provided the new location is behind cover or away from the blast's point of origin.

Forced Engagement: Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action when making an attack with your favored weapon; you may ignore one foe's *Screen Ally* action for that attack.

Gentleman's Withdrawal: Commit Effort for the scene as a Move action. As part of this, you may move at your full movement rate without being hindered by armed foes unless they completely block your path. You count as having made a *Fighting Withdrawal* against any enemies engaged with you at the time.

Graceful Leap: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action to immediately leap up to ten feet horizontally or vertically, counting it as a *Fighting Withdrawal*. You can't use this art more than once per round or after you've attacked. You are immune to falling damage from plunges of less than 30 feet.

Lightning Draw: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action at the start of hostilities; you win initiative against anyone without a similar ability to act first and may ready a Stowed favored weapon Instantly.

Piercing Strike: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action and choose a visible target. For the rest of the scene, their AC is treated as 10 for purposes of resisting the Shock of your favored weapon.

Spiritual Weapon: You are able to translate examples of your favored weapon into a spiritual template that you may manifest as you wish. Any favored weapon can be turned into such a template, including a magical weapon, but the process destroys the object's physical form. To manifest a template, Commit Effort as an Instant action; a ghostly copy of the weapon appears Readied in hand for you until you release the Effort or stop touching the weapon. Dual-wielders can summon the same weapon into both hands with one use of this art.

Unbindable: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action whenever you wish to escape chains, grapples, shackles, ropes, or even a magical spell of physical binding. You automatically wriggle free from mundane restraints and gain an Evasion saving throw to instantly end a physical magical binding of some sort. You can use this art only once per round.

Unworthy Rabble: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action. For the rest of the scene, when using your favored weapon, reroll any failed hit roll against foes with one hit die. At eighth level, this ability applies to foes with two hit dice.

Whirling Evasion: Your base Armor Class becomes equal to 13 plus half your level, rounded up. This AC can be modified by small shields and your Dexterity modifier, but not by armor or large shields.



LLAIGISAN BEASTMASTER

The savage land of Llaigis does not lack for terrible beasts, either the native creatures of the dark hills and deep forests or the horrible abominations that stalk the *arratu* wastelands. It is perhaps inevitable that the natives of that place should learn how to tame and control these dire creatures, employing ancient Legacy-pacts and more conventional training methods to win the obedience of fearsome servants.

The beastmaster's art is not a formal matter of schools and training lineages. It is a collection of secret arts and cunning tricks passed on from teacher to pupil, or shared within small clans of wise folk. As such, it is not impossible for a foreigner or outsider to learn the methods by which these fell creatures are bound, and some other small societies of animal-tamers have developed similar techniques of control.

While some Beastmasters would insist that there is nothing magical about their affinity with the natural world, most acknowledge a significant measure of sorcery in their arts. Experienced Beastmasters can work impossible feats of mental communion or distant summons. Some rely entirely on magical pacts and occult bindings to win the obedience of their companions, using sacred signs and divine sigils of authority to force lesser beasts into subservience. Others use more mundane techniques of food, punishment, and repetition to break in their feral vassals, while a few practitioner are of lineages that have been altered to be in greater psychic sympathy with the wild creatures of the world. Such altered beastmasters not uncommonly have feral features of their own.

Beastmasters are valued members of their communities in Llaigis. Even those unable to control particularly fierce beasts still find much use in scouting for perils and guiding wayfarers. A few such Beastmasters find it prudent to leave Llaigis for a time, either for the sake of profit or the wisdom of avoiding some bitter enemy. Their skills find use in gentler lands, as do the beasts they bring with them.

Partial Llaigisan Beastmaster

Level	Arts Gained
1	Bind Companion and Any One
2	Any One
3	
4	Any One
5	Any One
6	Any One
7	
8	Any One
9	
10	Any One

BEASTMASTER BENEFITS

The Beastmaster exists only as a partial Mage class, meant to be taken by an Adventurer along with another partial class. A Partial Warrior/Beastmaster may be a savage barbarian or wood-wise ranger, while a Partial Expert/Beastmaster might be a masterful hunter or zoologist.

All Beastmasters get Survive as a bonus skill at level-0, or at level-1 if they already have it at level-0. The amount of time they spend in the wilderness learning of its ways can't help but teach them how to survive in hard conditions and navigate the perils of an untamed land.

BEASTMASTER COMPANIONS

Many Beastmaster arts apply to the PC's animal companion. There are a few basic guidelines for such companions that a GM should keep in mind during play.

A companion animal cannot have a number of hit dice greater than the Beastmaster's level plus one. Thus a 2 hit die wolf is an acceptable companion for a first-level Beastmaster, but a 5 hit die tentacular horror is too potent to be bound to service.

A companion animal cannot have human levels of intelligence. It must be more-or-less animal in its thought patterns, though it can be a magical beast or supernatural entity of some kind.

A Beastmaster can normally have only one companion animal at a time. They can leave an animal behind in any terrain suitable for its survival and expect it to be in the same vicinity later if they choose to return for it and no one has killed it in the meanwhile. Released creatures are usually friendly to the Beastmaster still, unless they have been mistreated or are exceptionally savage.

A companion animal functions as an independent allied creature. It will obey commands from the Beastmaster that are not contrary to its own nature or beyond its intellect, but it will fight, move, check Instinct and Morale as normal, and act independently in combat. If the creature is mistreated or used as mere cannon fodder, it can flee or turn on its former master.

A companion animal must be given a name by the Beastmaster. Without a name to focus the PC's arts, the creature cannot be controlled.

THE CHOSEN FRIEND

Some Beastmasters form a lifelong bond with a single dear companion. If a PC chooses this option, they can only ever Bind one companion, but it gains the benefit of the *Shared Vitality* and *Mind Call* arts automatically. So long as the Beastmaster lives, this chosen friend cannot truly die; if reduced to zero hit points, it disappears, but will manifest again at the Beastmaster's side the following dawn with its full hit points. Of course, the master is expected to treat this companion as the beloved friend it is, and not as mere battle-fodder.

ARTS OF THE BEASTMASTER

Beastmaster Effort is calculated with Survive, and is equal to the PC's Survive skill level plus the higher of their Wisdom or Charisma modifiers, to a minimum of one point. All Beastmasters start play with the **Bind Companion** art and one more of their choosing. They learn additional arts as they gain experience. Unlike some Mage traditions, Beastmasters can use their arts normally while armored.

Bind Companion: With a day's work in a location you can find and bind a suitable animal companion. If looking for a particular type of companion, it must be found in the area and may require a Wis/Survive skill check at a difficulty of 10 or more if it's a particularly rare creature. If you encounter a suitable animal on an adventure, you may bind it as a Main Action, with the creature allowed a Mental saving throw to resist and become impervious to your powers. You may release a companion as a Main Action if you no longer wish its service or want to bind a different beast.

OTHER BEASTMASTER ARTS

Beast Ward: Commit Effort as an On Turn action. So long as the Effort remains Committed, the Beastmaster will not be attacked by unintelligent beasts unless the beast is commanded to do so by its master, the beast is starving, or the Beastmaster or their allies performs some hostile act against it. Once the ward ends or is broken, it cannot be re-established in the same scene. Magical beasts and those trained specifically as guardians of an area get a Mental save to resist this power.

Eyes of the Beast: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action. For the rest of the scene, you can share the senses of your companion. Neither of you can be surprised unless both are surprised.

Feral Toughness: Your maximum hit point total is increased by the natural, unmodified hit dice of your companion; thus, a 5 hit die companion increases your maximum hit points by 5. You are impervious to normal outdoor extremes of heat or cold. Your base Armor Class is equal to 13 plus half your level, rounded up. This AC can be modified by shields or Dexterity modifiers, but not by armor.

Howl of Distant Summons: You can call former animal companions to your side by Committing Effort for the day as a Main Action. The howl extends through time as well as space, and the subject will have received the message in time to reach your side within five minutes after you call for it. Once summoned, you may bind it again if you have no current companion. If the journey is exceptionally dangerous, difficult, or long, you'll need to make a Cha/Survive skill check against a difficulty of 10 or more; on a failure, the beast could not make the journey and cannot be called by this power for another week.

Know the Weak Spot: Whenever inflicting damage on a beast with a weapon or physical attack, roll the damage twice and take the higher score. Optionally, Commit Effort for the scene as an Instant action when an ally within earshot hits a beast; your shouted advice or distracting help allows them to roll damage twice and take the better result as well.

Mind Call: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action. For the rest of the scene you forge a telepathic bond with your animal companion. You can give it orders and receive information from the creature, at least insofar as its limited intellect allows.

Natural Weaponry: You may have physically grown fangs and claws, or it may be that you just intuitively absorbed effective unarmed fighting techniques from your animal companions. When unarmed, your attacks count as weapons that use either Str or Dex as their modifier, use Punch or Stab as the skill, do 1d8 damage, and have a Shock value of 2/AC 13. These unarmed attacks can harm even creatures immune to non-magical weapons. The damage and Shock of these weapons gains a +1 bonus at level 3, a +2 bonus at level 6, and a +3 bonus at level 9.

Savage Senses: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action. For the remainder of the scene you are capable of seeing clearly even in pitch blackness, can scent out trails and belongings as perfectly as a wolf could, and gain a +2 bonus on all Notice skill checks involving sight, sound, or smell.

Shared Vitality: The animal companions you bind have hit dice no lower than your level, even if they normally have far fewer. Thus, a 2 hit die beast bound by a 7th level Beastmaster would have 7 hit dice while it remained bound. Its hit bonus can't be less than half its hit dice, rounded up. A Beastmaster can stabilize a Mortally Wounded companion by Committing Effort for the scene as an Instant action.

Swift Healing: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action to heal 1d6 damage per character level to a wounded companion. This healing can be extended only once per scene or fifteen minutes.

Tongue of the Beasts: Commit Effort as an On Turn action. While the Effort remains committed, you can speak with any animal that has fur, feathers, scales, or skin. This art allows them to temporarily speak as if they had human intellect, though their interests, knowledge, and desires do not change.

RESKINNING THE BEASTMASTER

A PC with a loyal animal companion is a common trope of fantasy adventures, and the Beastmaster class can fill in whenever a player wants a PC with a capable, effective fighting beast as a companion. Those players who want to emulate a more classic "druid" PC concept might make a Partial Elementalist/Beastmaster PC, while the conventional fantasy ranger works well as an archery-focused partial Warrior/Beastmaster.



SARULITE BLOOD PRIEST

The Blighted nation of Sarul holds the blood clergy as their spiritual and secular leaders. These chosen men and women of the Bleeding God are appointed to maintain the laws of the land, punish evildoers, and direct the labors of the populace toward the glory of God and the furthering of His purposes in the world. From the humblest village priest up to the Three Pontifexes themselves, blood priests are expected to comport themselves with the utmost personal rigor and integrity... and the internal inquisitors of the sect help ensure that such is the case.

The ancient faith of the Bleeding God gives much power to those who follow its inner teachings, and the miracles of the Blood Priests are very useful in their labors. These arts are available even to those who have no faith in the god whatsoever, presumably because the power is embedded in the Legacy itself rather than being a product of the wielder's belief. Heretic and apostate Blood Priests who have mastered these arts can use them as easily as the most pious believer, despite the common rumors and superstitions to the contrary.

Blood clerics are usually kept in a rigorous internal hierarchy in Sarul, obedient to their superiors and regularly monitored by the faith's inquisition. Some, however, are set to roam far beyond the boundaries of that nation, either as scouts, missionaries, diplomats, or crusaders in defense of the weak. Others merely claim as much, having fled the nation before their heresy or some more secular crimes could be discovered. The influence of the church of the Bleeding God is weak outside of Sarul, and a renegade who manages to avoid the hierarchy and placate their new neighbors can often hope to live out their days unhindered.

Most blood clerics are Blighted, either Anak or some other breed of cursed folk. The hierarchy has a pragmatic approach to the frailties and darker inclinations of its members; they are not blessed, but they are tolerated within limits as the inevitable price of existing in a fallen world. Serious crimes of murder, rape, blas-

phemy, or treachery against the church are punished with swift and summary execution, but lesser offenders are let off with beatings, fines, or periods of forced service. It is normal for even high-ranking clerics to be so rebuked by their superiors, and few are the bishop-generals of the faith who haven't felt the inquisitor's knout for some prior failing. Even so, some who are unjustly accused or unwilling to pay for their deeds have been known to flee the land, seeking anonymity elsewhere. An Anak without companions to vouch for them is unlikely to survive long in most human lands, however.

Outside of Sarul, the church of the Bleeding God is divided into numerous co-equal national or ethnic churches, some of which claim overlapping jurisdictions over the same believers. Few have any significant political authority, as they tend to draw their membership from the Blighted, the poor, and the outcasts of society. Many regions have no recognized church at all, and so an industrious and pious cleric can find it quite possible to establish their own sect of the faith.

The Bleeding God's clergy are notable for the strength of the miracles they invoke. It's not unknown for even a common believer to call down some marvel in a moment of dire need. Most suspect that at some point this faith was so powerful and influential that its beliefs and miracles were encoded into the Legacy, though believers insist that the miracles are God's work alone.

BLOOD PRIEST BENEFITS

The Blood Priest exists only as a partial Mage class, to be taken by an Adventurer alongside another partial class. A Partial Warrior/Blood Priest might be a Sarulite crusader for the Bleeding God, wielding steel and terror against the evils of this world. A Partial Expert/Blood Priest might be an inquisitor, investigating dubious figures and sifting out the truth of mysterious events.

All Blood Priests gain Pray as a bonus skill, acquiring it at level-0, or level-1 if they already have it at level-0. Even a "Blood Priest" who has only learned their abilities through study of the inner texts must master a wide variety of ecclesiastical rites and rituals in order to activate their powers.

RESKINNING THE BLOOD PRIEST

The Blood Priest can serve as a template for a classic fighting cleric found in many other RPGs. The miracles given here are specific to the more traditional interpretation of the class, but priests of other gods or more specific portfolios could have alternate arts provided related to the particular spheres of their patron deity. A traditional fighting priest should pick the Partial Warrior class to pair with this one; a PC who prefers to have some spell-casting powers would need to pick an appropriate partial spellcaster class instead, and be willing to sacrifice much of their martial capacity.

Partial Sarulite Blood Priest

Level	Miracles Gained
1	Any Two
2	Any One
3	
4	Any One
5	Any One
6	Any One
7	
8	Any One
9	
10	Any One

ARTS OF THE BLOOD PRIEST

Blood Priest Effort is calculated with Pray, with their total maximum Effort being equal to their Pray skill plus the higher of their Wisdom or Charisma modifiers, to a minimum of one point.

At first level, the Blood Priest may choose two of the following miracles to master, and gain more as they advance in levels. Once chosen, a miracle pick is permanent and cannot be changed later. Miracles are not hindered by the wearing of armor and require no gestures or free hand to employ, though usually a prayer must be vocalized as part of the action triggering it.

A Thousand Tongues: Commit Effort as an On Turn action; while it remains Committed, you can speak with and understand any sentient creature with a language of their own. To any listener, it will seem as if you are perfectly fluent in their own language, even as you speak in your own native tongue. This ability does not allow you to read or write unknown languages.

Armor of God: Commit Effort as an On Turn action. While the Effort remains Committed, you have a natural Armor Class of 15 plus half your level, rounded down. This AC can be modified by shields or your Dexterity modifier, but not by other worn armor.

Divine Guidance: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action and meditate upon a choice or potential action before you. The GM will tell you whether the likely outcome of that choice is weal, woe, a mix of both, or nothing significant, using their own best estimation. This insight cannot perceive likely outcomes more than an hour or so into the future.

Fear No Flame: Commit Effort for the day as an On Turn action while nominating a visible target. For the rest of the scene, they are immune to non-magical flame, smoke, or explosive damage, and decrease any sources of such magical damage they take by five points per level of Pray you have.

God Wills It: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action and loudly call down the Bleeding God's blessing on your comrades. For the rest of the scene, up to six allies per character level in earshot gain an effective Morale of 12 and a +1 bonus to hit and damage rolls, including any Shock that may be inflicted. At fifth level this becomes a +2 bonus, and at tenth level it becomes a +3 bonus.

Merciful Healing: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action and touch a target within melee range. The target receives 1d6+2 points of magical healing. If done in combat or used to revive a Mortally Wounded subject, the rushed haste of the healing adds 1 System Strain to the target, but no System Strain is added if it is applied outside of combat. At fourth level the healing done increases to 2d6+4 and at eighth level it becomes 4d6+8.

Sanctified Ward: Commit Effort as an On Turn action. While the Effort is maintained and until you take some hostile action against a creature, you are immune to Shock damage and gain a +4 bonus to your Armor Class and all saving throws. Enemies must pass an Instinct check each round to target you with attacks; on a failure, they may take some other action instead. Once this art is ended it cannot be reactivated for the rest of the scene. Healing and other indirect support of fighting comrades does not count as a hostile action.

Smite the Wicked: Commit Effort for the day as a On Turn action whenever you attack or take some damaging action toward a single target. You gain a +4 bonus to any hit roll, you inflict your character level as automatic damage, and you can roll any damage dice twice and take the higher result. This ability can only be used once per scene on a given target.

The Light of Faith: Commit Effort as an On Turn action; while it remains Committed, you can cast a clear, bright radiance that extends up to thirty feet away from you. At your discretion, this light is visible only to you and your comrades, including up to a dozen allies.

Transubstantiation: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action to transform up to a gallon of any liquid into sacred blood. A draught of this holy liquid is sufficient to sustain a drinker for a day without further food or drink and will heal 1d6 plus the user's Pray skill in lost hit points. A gallon of blood is sufficient to help a half-dozen people. The benefits of this art can be enjoyed only once per day, and any undrunk blood sublimates away within a minute.

Turn False Life: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action and make the sign of the Bleeding God before one or more visible targets within sixty feet. Roll 2d6 and add your character level; that many hit dice of undead, automatons, or other synthetic, extraplanar, or unnatural life forms must make Mental saving throws or cower for the rest of the scene or until they or their comrades are attacked. Cowering enemies will take no hostile action and may flee unless bound to their location. This power does not affect foes with twice as many hit dice as the blood priest has levels. If the rolled hit die total isn't enough to fully affect a creature, it is unaffected.

Words of Mercy: Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to reroll any failed social skill check related to maintaining peace, granting help, or encouraging virtuous acts of compassion, mercy, or truthfulness. This art can be used only once on any given skill check.

Wrath of the Most High: Commit Effort for the scene as a Main Action while you rebuke a visible target. The first time the target takes damage before the end of the next round, it suffers automatic additional damage equal to 1d8 plus your level.



VOTHITE THOUGHT NOBLE

The ancient mental arts of the Vothite Empire are largely lost in the present day. Most of their possessors were slaughtered a thousand years ago in the fall of the empire, and the few thought-houses that survived were left in tattered exile, bereft of their greatest minds and numerous vital training tools. Still, here and there a few fragments of the art have survived, either in the heirs of these refugee houses or in the studies of those seekers who have craved the power it provides.

Only specialist sages, the most erudite of scholars, and those with a personal acquaintance with thought-houses are likely to have any real understanding of a Thought Noble's abilities. Even in New Voth, their ancient oppressors are credited with so many heinous acts and awful powers that the truth of their abilities is unclear.

THOUGHT NOBLE BENEFITS

A Thought Noble exists only as a partial Mage class, to be taken by an Adventurer alongside another partial class. A Partial Warrior/Thought Noble might be a cunning duelist who chooses his enemies with uncanny foreknowledge, while a Partial High Mage/Thought Noble might be an arcanist who has managed to unearth the secrets of these psychic arts in the course of their own studies.

All Thought Nobles gain Notice as a bonus skill, acquiring it at level-0, or level-1 if they already have it at level-0. An ability to clearly sense perceptual inputs is fundamental to a Thought Noble's training, and it is all but impossible to make sense of foreign mental inputs without a disciplined and trained sensorium.

Thought Nobles do not cast spells, though the ancient Mentarchs were famous for their arcane power. Instead, they develop various cognitive and telepathic abilities based on the focus of their studies. In the ancient days, different thought-houses focused on different techniques suitable for their philosophical imperative, but in

these days the surviving Thought Nobles tend to learn whichever skills seem most immediately useful to them.

At first level, a Thought Noble gains the *Open Mind* art and may choose one more of their choice. As they advance in level, they'll come to master additional arts. Once chosen, an art cannot be changed.

ARTS OF THE THOUGHT NOBLE

Thought Noble Effort is calculated with Notice rather than Magic, with each PC's maximum being equal to their Notice skill level plus the better of their Intelligence or Wisdom modifiers, to a minimum of one point.

All Thought Nobles are trained in the *Open Mind* art, but may develop other techniques with time. If an art allows a saving throw to resist it, success renders the target immune to that art for the rest of the scene. Thought Noble arts are all entirely invisible to any but magical senses and provide no hint as to who is using them, even on a successful Mental saving throw.

Open Mind: Commit Effort as an On Turn action. While Effort remains Committed, you may detect the current emotional state of a visible living creature as a Main Action. This discernment isn't fine enough to identify the object of their emotions unless it's obvious from the context.

OTHER THOUGHT NOBLE ARTS

Block Memory: Target a visible living creature and Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action while specifying a particular event or situation that didn't extend longer than a scene. The target gets a Mental saving throw; on a failure, they simply cannot remember the event and will construct a plausible false memory to paper over the gap. The memory can be restored by use of this power once more or a magical dispelling ability, but detecting the alteration is difficult; any power that detects enchantments on a target does so with a +2 difficulty penalty to any skill check made to discern the ban.

Elicitation of Truth: This art can only be taken by those who have mastered *Surface Apprehension*. It can only be used on a helpless or cooperative target; the Thought Noble may Commit Effort for the day and ask the target a question that takes no more than two sentences to ask. If the target fails a Mental saving throw, they must fully and completely answer the question. They need not exercise any personal judgment or speculation, but they must answer directly and without conscious deception.

Facile Speech: An improvement to the *Far Speech* art, you may now nominate up to a half-dozen companions to be favored targets for *Far Speech*. You may link with a favored target as an On Turn action without Committing Effort. The range to contact a

Partial Vothite Thought Noble

Level	Arts
1	Open Mind and Any One
2	Any One
3	Any One
4	Any One
5	Any One
6	Any One
7	Any One
8	Any One
9	Any One
10	Any One

avored target is one mile per Thought Noble level. You can change your nominated companions with an hour's meditation in the new companion's presence.

Far Speech: Commit Effort for the scene as an On Turn action and target an intelligent creature known to you that is within two hundred feet per level. If they consent, you forge a telepathic link with them that can convey thoughts, speech, and images even without a common language. The link lasts for the rest of the scene. While linked with someone, both of you may reroll failed Mental saving throws and neither of you can be surprised unless both are.

Hypercognition: You can drive your mind to tremendous feats of calculation, estimation, and recall. You have an eidetic memory and can perform extremely advanced calculations in your head. As an Instant action, Commit Effort for the day and reroll any failed Int-based skill check. This ability can be used only once on any given check.

Iconograph: Commit Effort for the scene as a Main Action and target a visible written text, piece of sculpture, iconographic symbol, or other visible artifact. You receive a short description of the message or idea the maker was trying to convey with the object. Optionally, you may use this art when making a sigil, art object, or text of your own; any valid target will automatically understand your intended message when they see the item. You may restrict your audience to particular people or types if you wish.

Impress Imperative: Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action while targeting a visible living creature. You may give it an overwhelming urge to perform some action that takes no longer than a round and is not completely contrary to its nature or wishes. It can make a Mental save to resist, but on a failure it spends its next action carrying out the imperative.

Mind Light: Your *Open Mind* art is enhanced. While active, you become aware of the location of all living minds within sixty feet of you provided there isn't a physical barrier between you and the subject and they are not actively hiding from you. You can identify the species of these minds, if the species is known to you, any strong emotional states, and can recognize known individuals. While *Open Mind* is active you cannot be surprised by a living creature.

Mind Over Matter: Your mental control over your physical processes is considerable. Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to gain one of the following benefits: automatically stabilize if Mortally Wounded, go without sleep for twenty-four hours, heal 1d6 hit points of damage you've suffered, or completely ignore normal climatic extremes of heat or cold for one day. Similar tricks of bodily control may be allowed at the GM's discretion.

Mirror Mask: You become instantly aware of any mind-affecting power directed at you and can identify the user if they're within your current sensory

range. You may reroll any Mental saving throw the attacking ability allows you; if it doesn't allow a save, you get a single Mental save to resist anyway. If you succeed, you may Commit Effort for the day as an Instant action to give the power false information of your choice or a false impression of success.

Positive Association: As a Main Action, Commit Effort for the day and target a visible sentient creature. It gets a Mental saving throw to resist; on a failure, any thought of you or your actions is suffused by a glow of benign happiness and admiration. They will treat you as an admired friend and find all your actions to be eminently reasonable and wise until you or your allies attack them, bring harm to something they love, or leave their presence for more than an hour. Affected creatures that were not misused are unlikely to think themselves bespelled when this power ends unless given reason to. This ability can affect only one target at a time.

Read Intent: As an Instant action, Commit Effort for the scene and target a visible living creature. It gets a Mental saving throw to resist; on a failure, the GM will tell you exactly what it is currently intending to do on its next turn, or its next relevant action if used out of combat. If you perform a *Total Defense* action this round, your insight into its motions ensures that no attack it makes that you could theoretically physically avoid can hit you for the rest of the round.

Surface Apprehension: Commit Effort for the scene as a Main Action while targeting a visible living creature. If it fails a Mental saving throw, you become aware of its immediate surface thoughts for the rest of the round. If you ask specific questions of the creature during this round it will instinctively think of the answers, though the detail of these surface thoughts is generally limited to one or two sentences of information.

Thoughts Like Razors: As a Main Action, Commit Effort for the day to launch a psychic assault on any visible living creature within sixty feet. The target gets a Mental saving throw to resist; on a failure, it takes 1d8 damage per level of the Thought Noble. The damage can knock it unconscious but cannot kill. On a successful save, the Thought Noble is stunned by the backlash, taking one quarter of the damage, rounded down, and losing their next turn's actions. This ability can be used only once per scene.

Unthinkable Thought: Target a visible living creature and Commit Effort for the day as a Main Action while specifying a particular person, object, or situation that is currently ongoing in their presence. The target may make a Mental save to resist; on a failure, they simply cannot consciously acknowledge the existence of the subject or its actions unless ignoring it would obviously put their life at risk. This forced ignorance lasts for up to a scene; at its end, the target will have no memory of the subject.



HEROIC CLASSES AND CHARACTERS

The default tone for *Worlds Without Number* is fairly gritty, with heroes that are good at what they do, but still very mortal in their capabilities. A single good axe-blow can kill most novice heroes, and even expert adventurers sometimes meet a grim and unexpected end. While this tone works very well for sword and sorcery campaigns or those with a more low fantasy tone, not all groups are interested in those genre flavors.

Some prefer to run high fantasy games involving larger-than-life heroes and epic doers of mighty deeds. Such paragons might start from comparatively humble roots, but they're always significantly stronger, more capable, and better-destined than their ordinary peers. The characters in such campaigns are built a little differently from those in a normal game.

WHEN TO USE THESE RULES

These character classes are meant to be used from the start of a campaign in which the group wants to play substantially stronger, more capable adventurers, ones who've already attained substantial prowess before the game has even begun. They may not have much of a name in the campaign setting, being mere farm lads, street urchins, and excess apprentices, but they have the kind of natural talent and sublime innate gifts that make for the stuff of high fantasy heroes and destined legends. Not all groups enjoy the gritty ethos of a fast life and faster death, and heroic PCs give them a little more room to err.

This is not to say that they are invincible, however. Even a Heroic Warrior can be mobbed down by a crowd of foes, and a Heroic Expert can sometimes find their skills insufficient for a truly fearsome challenge. Such PCs have much less to worry about from more ordinary threats, however, and they're unlikely to die without significant misfortune or aggressively poor judgment. Even in that case, the group may decide beforehand to use some of the optional death rules listed on page 227 if they want to continue following the careers of these heroes through fortune and tragedy both.

These rules can also be used when the party is unusually small. Rather than send along a crew of henchmen to serve as meat shields, the GM can allow groups of one or two players to roll up heroic characters instead. Such small groups are able to take on adventures and challenges that would normally be suitable for a party of four, though they may have to be judicious about using their class abilities to aid in a rapid retreat.

HEROIC CHARACTER CREATION

In a normal campaign, PCs pick a single character class, or else choose to be an Adventurer and pick two partial classes. In a heroic campaign, a PC instead chooses from one of the four heroic classes below. These classes sometimes allow a hero to pick multiple ordinary full or partial classes and blend them together, gaining all their benefits

at once. Even so, any class restrictions, such as the use of armor while spellcasting, still apply to use of that class' abilities. Class advancement and experience point gains work just as they usually do.

HEROIC EXPERT

A Heroic Expert gets all the class abilities, hit dice, and hit bonus of a normal full Expert, including *Quick Learner*, but their *Masterful Expertise* ability is replaced by *Legendary Expertise*, and they gain the additional powers of *Heroic Skill* and *Heroic Expert's Fray*.

Legendary Expertise: Once per scene, as an Instant action, automatically succeed at any non-combat skill check of difficulty 12 or less. If used in an opposed skill check, you may instead reroll the check and use the best roll of the two.

Heroic Skill: Pick any one non-combat, non-Magic skill; that skill is immediately set to level-4 proficiency, regardless of your character level and the usual maximum allowed. If you already have that skill at some level from some other source, you may exchange the existing score for an equal rating in any other non-combat, non-Magic skill of your choice that you don't already have.

Heroic Expert's Fray: Once per round, as an On Turn action, inflict 1d8 damage plus half your level, rounded down, to any one target within reach of any of your Readied weapons, provided they have equal or fewer hit dice than you have levels. This damage is not modified by any ability or bonus, and can affect any creature who could be hurt by that Readied weapon.

HEROIC WARRIOR

A Heroic Warrior gets all the class abilities, hit dice, and hit bonus of a normal full Warrior, including *Killing Blow* and *Veteran's Luck*. In addition to this, they gain three bonus abilities exclusive to this class.

Slayer: Your hit rolls are always successful against any creature with equal or fewer hit dice than you have levels, assuming it's physically possible for your weapon to harm them.

Unbroken: Once per day as an Instant action, when reduced to zero hit points or affected by hostile magic, you can negate the magical effect or push through the injury. Using this ability reduces you to 1 HP.

Heroic Warrior's Fray: Once per round, as an On Turn action, inflict 1d8 damage plus your level to any one target within reach of any of your Readied weapons, provided they have equal or fewer hit dice than you have levels. This damage is not modified by any ability or bonus, and can affect any creature who could be hurt by that Readied weapon.

HEROIC MAGE

You may pick either three partial Mage classes or one full Mage class and one partial. All these classes must be spellcasting classes; non-casters like Vowed, Healers, or Kistian Duelists are not allowed. You gain access to the arts and spell lists of these classes as normal, but you use the table below for spells prepared and castable each day. When you advance a level, you gain new spells and arts just as given in your various partial or full classes. You also gain the class ability of *Heroic Mage's Fray*.

Heroic Mage's Fray: Once per round, as an On Turn action, inflict 1d4 damage plus half your level, rounded down, to any one target within sixty feet. This Fray functions on any target, even those with more hit dice than you have levels. This damage is not modified by any ability or bonus, and can affect any creature who could be hurt by magic.

Heroic Mage Spellcasting Abilities

Level	Max Level	Spells Cast	Spells Prepared	Arts Gained
1	1	2	4	As per each full or partial class, gaining each level's art picks as usual.
2	1	2	5	
3	2	4	6	
4	2	4	7	
5	3	6	8	
6	3	6	9	
7	4	8	10	
8	4	8	11	
9	5	10	12	
10	5	12	14	

HEROIC ADVENTURER

You may pick either one normal full class and one partial class, or three partial classes. Thus, you could choose to be a full Warrior/partial Expert, or a full High Mage/partial Warrior. You gain all the normal benefits of your chosen classes and use the best class' hit bonus and hit point rolls. If you pick three partial classes, you can use the best combination table from page 21 for hit points and hit bonus; thus a partial High Mage/partial Expert/partial Warrior would use the partial Warrior/partial Expert table for hit bonus and hit point rolls.

If by some odd turn the player picks all Mage partial classes that mix spellcasting and non-spellcasting classes, they use a full Mage's hit bonus and hit die table.

Heroic Adventurers get a free bonus Focus pick of any kind, in addition to their class Focus picks.

A Heroic Adventurer may pick one of the *Heroic Warrior's Fray*, *Heroic Expert's Fray*, or *Heroic Mage's Fray* class abilities provided they have at least a partial class of that type. Once chosen, the selection is permanent and cannot be changed.

UNIVERSAL ABILITIES

In addition to the special powers granted by their class, PCs in a heroic campaign all get the benefit of three special abilities that all Heroic PCs possess.

These benefits are meant to help fit the tone of the usual high fantasy campaign. PCs are significantly more resilient than the average farmboy-turned-soldier, so they get a boost to their hit points. They don't get wiped out by a superior force that beat them to the draw in combat, so they automatically win initiative, and they don't bleed to death on a dirty cavern floor unless they've already exhausted their energies with prior terrible wounds.

GMs using these rules for other genres can likewise add other abilities that fit the universal tropes or expectations of such campaign worlds.

Heroic Resilience: A Heroic PC has twelve bonus hit points added on to their usual maximum HP. Thus, a first level Heroic Mage who rolled a 3 on his 1d6-1 hit die would begin play with 15 hit points.

Heroic Reflexes: Heroic PCs always win initiative at the start of hostilities unless their foes successfully ambush them or otherwise have the drop on the group.

Heroic Determination: Once per scene, as an On Turn action, a Heroic PC can accept a point of System Strain to automatically heal 1d8 hit points of damage plus their character level. This can return them to the fray from a Mortally Wounded condition. Outside of combat, they can use this ability as often as they like during a five-minute rest, assuming they have the System Strain to support it.

HEROIC FRAY DAMAGE

The Fray damage done by heroes in *Worlds Without Number* is applied only to a single target; if it's more than needed to kill them, the excess is wasted. The Fray rules used in *Stars Without Number* and *Godbound* allow the excess damage to hit another valid target, as cutting down a rank of mere mortals fits with the general style of heroes in those games. A GM looking for the same flavor can allow such damage overflow here as well.

HEROIC PCs IN STARS WITHOUT NUMBER

The Heroic classes in this game are slightly different from those presented in *Stars Without Number*. Most of these tweaks are the product of the different power assumptions between space-operatic heroes and high fantasy protagonists, as the latter tend to be boosted by explicit magical powers in addition to the ambient plot armor used by many space opera heroes. If you mix the two game systems in a heroic campaign, you should probably use the versions given here unless your campaign is to be devoid of mages and other spellcasters.

LEGATES

Most heroes in *Worlds Without Number* are decidedly mortal. Novice characters risk a bloody death every time swords are drawn, and even tenth-level adventurers at the peak of their power can't dismiss the wrath of a mob of soldiers or the peril of a fearsome monster. They may be masterfully skilled at their chosen role, but they are still fundamentally normal human beings who must fear the things that all mortals fear.

Legates, however, are different. They have bonded with the power of the Legacy, becoming figures of uncanny prowess and superhuman skill. By tapping into archetypes embedded in the Legacy and receiving the gift of its power, even their mundane abilities are enhanced in magical ways. Even the least Legate can perform marvels, while the greatest among them can drive back armies, enrich nations, or raise fortresses from featureless plains.

Not every veteran hero becomes a Legate. There are many who reach the human peak of their profession and never advance farther. Some simply reach the limits of their own potential, while others lack the ambition to be more. Many simply do not have the necessary arcane makeup to bond properly with the Legacy, a victim of some ancient misalignment or god-king's inherited curse. Perhaps one in a half-million people ever touch the least degree of a Legate's power.

Nor is becoming a Legate the only route to superhuman strength. There are other ways to attain impossible power, whether through sinister pacts with the entities of other Iterums, the use of ancient artifacts, the performance of excruciatingly difficult magical rituals, or the sheer blind luck of birth or magical attunement. Not every more-than-mortal creature or warrior in the Latter Earth is a Legate, though these other paths often come with terrible drawbacks or awful prices.

Legates are a known quantity in the Latter Earth, though they remain extremely rare. There may only be a handful operating in an entire nation, and it's not uncommon for a realm to have none at all active. The shock of the tremendous power they receive often provokes novice Legates into daring risks that are beyond their newfound abilities, or becoming targets of existing powers who do not want to let them grow into greater rivals.

Most Legates make some sort of terms with their rulers of the lands they occupy. Some may act as mercenaries for kings, while others serve as high officials and royal champions. A few may even rule overtly, if the prior king was careless in his precautions or if they've forged a new realm out of some former wilderness. A considerable number are unknown to the wider public, however, doing deeds in secrecy or pursuing their own ends.

In this section, you will learn how to become a Legate and how to run a heroic fantasy campaign where even novice PCs have some portion of a Legate's tremendous might.

BECOMING A LEGATE

Some campaigns do not include Legates or similar superheroically-powerful heroes. It may not fit the tone of a gritty sword-and-sorcery game, or the GM may find it a poor match for their world. For such heroes the usual limits on advancement apply. For GMs with a different intent, however, there are two ways to become a legat.

High fantasy heroic campaigns that involve mighty heroes and brilliant paragons from the very start might begin with the heroes as Legates or their campaign-world equivalent. They might nominally be ordinary men and women, but their personal talents and natural gifts are so pronounced that they can perform feats that would dazzle more conventional veterans. For campaign settings like these, the GM might grant all the PCs Legate abilities from the start of the campaign.

Veteran heroes of a long-running conventional campaign might become Legates after reaching 10th level and performing some feat suitable for a legendary hero. This deed must usually be something heroic and dramatic enough to imprint their presence on the Legacy and connect them to the glorious archetypes of ancient heroes. Of course, this need not necessarily be a *good* deed; the Legacy recognizes mighty feats, whether they are benevolent or selfish. Generally, a single grand deed in which all the party contributed should be enough to make everyone a Legate, assuming they've reached 10th level and the apex of ordinary mortal power.

Once a PC breaches the limits of human capability, whether as a first-level PC in a heroic fantasy campaign or as a tenth-level veteran of a bloody epic of valor, they gain the basic abilities of a novice Legate.

LEGATE EFFORT

Much like many kinds of Mages, Legates fuel their powers and abilities with Effort, having a special pool of *Legate Effort* dedicated to their arts. This Effort works just as any other kind, as explained on page 63, and is Committed and regained as normal. A novice Legate begins with two points of Effort, a pool which can be improved with time and personal development.

LEGATE WRITS

The special abilities of a Legate are called *Writs*, focused manifestations of supernatural power enabled and empowered by the force of the Legacy. Writs manifest their power in ways and with flavors specific to the Legate who uses them; the fiery fury of the *Legate's Wrath* of a volcanic-hearted hero may not be the same as the crushing tide of a sea-queen's Writ, but both do the same damage, and any side-effects are up to the GM's discretion. In general, PCs should be allowed to flavor their Writs as they see fit, provided they don't get any general mechanical benefit from their interpretation.

NOVICE LEGATE ABILITIES

A Legate's basic level and statistics remain the same once they ascend to their new station, whether as a newly-minted heroic fantasy protagonist or a veteran tenth-level hero. Unless specified otherwise, everything on their character sheet remains the same.

If the new Legate does not already have a Heroic class from the section starting on page 356, they become one now and may pick a class accordingly, changing their existing class and re-rolling their hit points if necessary.

This new class selection should be an expansion or augmentation of their existing class rather than a complete rewrite; a full Warrior might turn into a Heroic Warrior, or perhaps become a Heroic Adventurer who has full Warrior/partial Expert as their classes, or some other combination that respects their original nature. The GM has the right to veto an unrelated selection.

These newly Heroic adventurers gain all the benefits of their new class, including any retroactive additions to maximum hit points, bonus non-combat skill points, or other abilities. They should never be losing any powers or perks, because they shouldn't be picking new heroic classes that don't already include their existing powers.

A Legate starts with a maximum of two points of Legate Effort. They can later buy up this pool with Legate XP as explained below; it does not naturally increase.

Every Legate begins with two automatic Writs: *Legate's Impunity* and *Legate's Wrath*. In addition to these, a novice Legate may pick two other Writs from the lists in this section. At least one of these Writs must come from a category appropriate to their class; Writs of Might for Warriors, Writs of Skill for Experts, or Writs of Sorcery for Mages. The other one may be any category.

LEGATE ADVANCEMENT

Legates continue to gain normal experience points until they reach tenth level, assuming they haven't already gotten that far by the time they become Legates. Beyond that point, they stop gaining additional normal experience. Renown continues to be gained as usual.

In addition to normal experience, Legates gain points of *Legate XP* for deeds and accomplishments appropriate to their mighty powers. This experience is usually gained much more slowly than normal XP, as their supernatural might is much harder to hone.

Legates must engage in adventures that actively change the world around them, ones that pursue goals that affect large numbers of people or considerable areas of land. Ordinary Deep-crawls or petty urban intrigues aren't enough to spark the power of the Legacy within them; they need to topple thrones, upend cities, forge wonders, establish faiths, and build legends worthy of their power. An adventure that might be perfectly adequate to earn the party normal adventuring XP might be insufficient to get them any Legacy XP, though it could be a necessary stepping-stone toward their eventual grand ambition.

If the GM agrees that a particular adventure, major project, or grand deed was significant enough, the party gets an award of Legate XP. By default, this is one point for each PC involved in the adventure. If each adventure takes one session, it means it will take about three sessions before the PCs can select a new Writ power or make another significant advancement.

This pace may not fit all groups. If you want to speed up the process you might grant two or even three Legacy XP for a successful adventure. In addition, you might add a bonus for particularly dramatic deeds or legendary feats. In general, you'll want to decide how many sessions of play the players should have between XP purchases and grant experience accordingly.

There is no limit to the amount of Legacy XP the heroes can accrue over time. Even after they reach tenth level and can no longer advance in normal experience, they can continue to build their supernatural might. Tales persist of Arch-Legates with powers scarcely less than those of true divinity, entities that somehow have surpassed the conventional limits of human ability. The path to this exalted state is unclear, but determined would-be demigods may learn more of it in time.

SPENDING LEGATE XP

Players can use the table below to spend their accrued Legate XP. Once spent, the points are lost, and more mighty deeds must be performed if additional powers are to be obtained.

XP Cost	Purchase
Current Pool x 2	Raise Legate Effort by 1 point
3	Universal or class writ
4	Writ from another class
1	Gain two skill points
9	Gain a Focus level

Heroes who want to increase their maximum Legate Effort can do so by spending Legate XP equal to their current pool times two. Thus, if a PC had 3 points of Legate Effort, they could increase it to 4 by spending 6 Legate XP.

For universal Writs or those associated with the hero's class, the price is 3 Legate XP to buy a new one. Thus, Writs of Might are in-class for Warriors, Writs of Skill are in-class for Experts, and Writs of Sorcery are in-class for Mages. Adventurers can buy Writs from any of their chosen classes at this discounted rate.

Writs from a class the hero does not possess cost 4 Legate XP, and in some cases may not be useful or applicable. A Writ that improves spellcasting is useless unless the hero can actually cast spells, for example.

An additional two skill points can be purchased for 1 Legate XP, and used to buy whatever type of skill the PC wishes or pay for attribute improvements.

Finally, Legate XP can be used to buy Focus levels. A PC who wanted to buy two levels of *Die Hard*, for example, would pay 18 Legate XP to do so.



WRITS OF THE LEGATES

Legates have certain special abilities that are far beyond the capacity of ordinary heroes. Indeed, even supposedly non-magical warriors or mundane experts can reach past the limits of conventional human ability to perform wondrous feats of martial prowess or superhuman deeds of skill. In one sense these abilities could be called “magical” due to their reliance on the Legacy, but the truth of the matter is more complex.

Each Legate embodies deep archetypes of heroism embedded in the Legacy. Concepts such as the Tyrant, or the Thief, or the Berserker, or the Healer are woven into the Legacy at a very deep level, peripheral fragments of unimplemented godhood and imprints of cosmic definitions combining to bestow tremendous power on those few heroes that successfully integrate with these hazy patterns. Just as the rain that falls is now ordered and directed by the Legacy, the impossible might of a warrior-hero or the superhuman subtlety of a legendary thief are encoded into the Latter Earth’s definition of reality.

As such, these “magical” powers are no more arcane than a falling raindrop. It may seem a defiance of reason that the Legate-thief can scramble up a glass tower, or a Legate-warrior can walk unharmed through a pike line, but these abilities are as natural as sunlight.

Because of this, a Legate’s Writs cannot be dispelled by ordinary sorcery or suppressed by conventional anti-magic measures. They will not be detected as magical effects, and special measures taken to prevent occult activities will not hinder them. Bonuses to saving throws that apply to magical effects do not apply to resisting their power, and Foci such as *Nullifier* cannot be used to resist their effects. As far as the Latter Earth is concerned these are perfectly mundane abilities.

WRIT DESCRIPTIONS

Each of the entries that follow describe the particular effects of a Writ. Each has a requisite Action to trigger it, a Legate Effort cost, and a Duration for that activation.

Writ action types might be “Main”, “On Turn”, “Instant”, or “None”. Writs with None for an action type are constantly in effect. They might grant the PC certain special options that require their own action to execute, but they do not need to be specifically activated. Writs cannot be disrupted or interrupted as spellcasting can be, nor does the Legate need any free hand or particular state of mobility to use them. So long as they are conscious and above zero hit points, they can activate their powers.

Effort costs are “Day” for day-long Commitments, “Scene” for Effort that must be Committed for a scene, “Duration” for Effort that can be reclaimed Instantly once the power is no longer needed, or “None” for Writs that require no Effort at all. In all cases, only a single point of Effort needs to be Committed at most to activate a power.

Durations are usually either for a full scene, a single attack or action, or “Commit” when the Writ remains in

effect for as long as the Effort remains Committed. A few Writs create permanent objects that last indefinitely.

Many Writs are noted as working on “allies”. This automatically includes the user unless specified otherwise. “Visible” targets are those the user can sense, provided they’re within bowshot; far-distant views are insufficient.

WRITS OF MASTERY

Some Writs aren’t direct in their blessings, but instead amplify the Legate’s ability to create major changes in the world. Their words are more persuasive, their understanding more penetrating, and their plans blessed with unnatural success by the cooperation of the world.

These “Mastery” Writs quarter the silver or Renown cost that relevant Workings or major projects would usually require, rounding up. The project’s major effect must fall under the Mastery’s aegis; smaller peripheral changes or effects might be included, but the GM is justified in applying the discount to only half the Working’s cost if only half the Working’s effect relates to the Mastery’s power.

Allies are always capable of contributing their own Renown toward their efforts, provided they can explain some way in which their help would be useful in accomplishing the end.

A Mastery Writ allows even a non-Mage to construct a Working, so long as the Working’s effects fall exclusively within the Mastery’s sphere of control. These mundane Workings often involve social rituals, civic institutions, and religious sects to create their wondrous effects rather than conventional runic obelisks or arcane circles. Damaging or disrupting the Working requires the corruption or extinction of these human institutions rather than any physical vandalism.

A Legate with a Writ of Mastery is capable of creating Supreme Workings, manifesting effects that would be too potent for a normal mage. The difficulty of a Supreme Working is at least 32 points, and may be up to 64 at the GM’s discretion.

Legates working in their sphere of Mastery are always competent to build and design a Working, whatever the total difficulty of the design.

LESSER AND WORTHY FOES

When so indicated by a Writ, *lesser foes* are any non-PC target with equal or fewer hit dice than the Legate has levels. Thus, for a 4th level Legate, all creatures with 4 HD or fewer are lesser foes, subject to being overwhelmed easily by many powers or being affected by the Legate’s heroic fray damage. PCs are never lesser foes.

Worthy foes, on the other hand, are simply those creatures with more hit dice than the Legate has levels. Thus, that same 4th level Legate treats all creatures with 5 HD or more as worthy foes. Some Writs they have may not work so well against such potent enemies.

CREATING NEW WRITS

It's entirely possible for a Legate to devise a new Writ appropriate to their character or ambitions, or for a GM to sprinkle new possibilities into the list. A few basic design principles should be kept in mind when building these new powers, however.

Use per-day Commitment for major powers. If you don't want the PC to be using the power in every scene where it's useful, give it a day-long Effort Commitment.

Use per-scene Commitment for every-scene powers. If it's acceptable for the power to show up in every relevant scene, then you can give it a scene-long cost. Remember that an experienced Legate might be able to spam this power three or four times in a single scene.

Use Duration Commitment for situational buffs. A Legate with all their Effort expended can't use Commitment-duration powers, so it's a limit, but they'll always have access to them until they really run low on juice.

Use Constant Writs for default PC abilities. If the power is something the PC should always have available or just be part of their nature, use a Constant duration.

Lesser foes always lose. A Writ that automatically kills or crushes a single lesser foe is perfectly acceptable. Powers that affect groups should give a save or some other method to resist, however.

Fit the Writ to the hero. The Writ's power should fit the hero's nature, past deeds, temperament, or existing powers. Abilities that are perfectly suitable to one PC may be entirely inappropriate to another, because they're just not the same in their interests or theme.

Healing powers always cost something lengthy. Either it should be taking day-long Effort Commitment from the user or it should be costing somebody System Strain, whether user or recipient.

Damage powers should not be spamable. Every power that inflicts direct damage on a target should cost at least scene-long Effort Commitment or else require some specific situation that can't be easily repeated. If PCs want to do damage constantly, they should hit something with a sword or sword-equivalent.

Damage powers should be limited. Single-target damage should be limited to around 1d6 damage per level at the very most, while area damage should be half that at most, and that's assuming day-long Effort Commitment and awkward targeting. There should also be some limiter preventing round-after-round spamming of these powers, or else it becomes mathematically optimal in combat to just dump all your Effort into murder before resorting to swordplay or spells. Generally, direct-damage powers should not be usable two rounds in a row, forcing PCs to do something else half the time.

Permanent changes should be small-scale. A Writ that summons crops or calls up springs or erects new construction should be able to change at most a village or small town, even with repeated use. Grand alterations or wide-spread changes should be left as the province of major projects or magical Workings. A Legate only has enough power to alter their close surroundings.

Don't allow optimization Writs. If the only thing a Writ gives the PC is the power to do something they already do 10% better, then don't allow it. Writs should let the PC do things that are flatly impossible otherwise, or make them flawlessly execute activities that mythic heroes of their type ought to be able to do perfectly. A few ability-booster writs might fit to emphasize a concept, but new Writs should break new ground.

Be ready to edit the Writ in play. If it turns out the Writ is too weak or too strong, change it. The GM is not obligated to cling to their mistakes.



MARTIAL WRITS

As a consequence of their superhuman mastery of war, all Legates with at least one Martial Writ treat all weapon or unarmed attacks as if they were magical weapons for purposes of overcoming a foe's defenses. Any thrown weapons they wield return to their hands automatically if so desired.

Banner of Glory

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** Scene

For the rest of the scene, allies within sight or sound of you have a Morale of 12, are immune to magical fear effects, and fight as if their weapons were +1 magical weapons. Affected allies intuitively understand what you want them to do, though they are not compelled to obey. On a battlefield, this Writ is usually sufficient to affect everyone in the leader's wing of the army.

Bar the Blade

Act: Instant **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Attack

You deflect, dodge, or parry an otherwise successful weapon or unarmed attack made against you.

Bread of Death

Act: Instant **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** Scene

For the rest of the scene, whenever you reduce a target to zero hit points, you may regain lost hit points equal to their hit dice. Such foes are instantly killed and cannot be stabilized.

Caress of Doom

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

Your unarmed attacks appear to be no more than pats or casual touches. Targets are not aware of their hit point loss unless they are in combat or hit zero hit points.

Corona of Endings

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Use

Pick a point within range of your weapon; all enemies within ten feet of that point suffer damage as if from a successful weapon or unarmed hit. Foes with 1 hit die are automatically killed or subdued.

Crushing Fray

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Whenever you roll your Fray die, roll it twice and take the higher result.

Font of Lead and Iron

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Hurlants, crossbows, and other ranged weapons that take no more than one minute to reload can be reloaded as an Instant action and require no physical ammunition.

He Shall Be Cut

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Target

Pick a visible target; for the rest of the scene or until you use this Writ on a different target, your weapon or unarmed attacks will hit them on anything but a natural 1.

Impassable Stance

Act: Instant **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

Target a foe who is currently within melee range of you or passing that close to you during movement. They must make a Mental save to either continue their movement or leave your melee reach. If they fail, they can make another attempt to save at the end of their next turn. They remain fixed until you either reclaim the Effort or they succeed at a saving throw, after which the power ends. Lesser foes get no saving throw.

Implacable Blow

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Attack

Your next unarmed attack roll made this turn is automatically successful and does maximum damage.

Long Hand

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

Your melee weapon or unarmed attacks can target foes up to 60 feet distant. This extra reach does not turn the weapon into a ranged weapon, nor can it be used to trigger melee-range Writs or effects on targets outside a more normal melee range.

March Without End

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Day

For the next 24 hours, you and up to twenty allied creatures per level need neither air, rest, food, nor drink. Those affected are immune to any otherwise hostile environment that would not kill a normal person in less than a minute. You heal lost hit points and lose accumulated System Strain normally at morning, as if you were well-rested.

Mastery of War

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving warfare, armies, fortifications, or other martial matters. Workings and major projects wherein the primary effect is related to these cost only a quarter of the silver or Renown usually required, provided their scope is not larger than City level.

Martial Fray

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Your Fray die now does damage to worthy foes. Against lesser foes, it always does the maximum possible damage.

One Perfect Edge

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Constant

The weapon you bear is capable of cutting or smashing through any non-magical barrier lighter than a stone wall. You can move through such barriers without slowing your Move actions.

Ruin Without Distance

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You may use ranged weapons in melee with no penalties, regardless of their size. Ranged weapons you use gain an extra die of damage; thus, if a bow normally does 1d8 damage, it now does 2d8 damage. For thrown weapons, this bonus damage only applies when the weapon is used for a ranged attack.

Sacrificial Blood

Act: Instant **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Attack

A visible opponent's weapon or unarmed attack is redirected from their target to you, regardless of the range. The attack roll is resolved as normal.

Scorn the Petty Blade

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Day **Dur:** Scene

For the rest of the scene, foes with 1 hit die cannot harm you with weapon or unarmed attacks, though they can still harm you with magic or environmental perils.

Seven Spears Deep

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** Scene

For the rest of the scene, your ranged attacks penetrate all non-magical cover less than three feet thick, and you ignore any concealment benefits for a foe whose location you at least approximately know. This Writ doesn't affect the target's base Armor Class.

Shadow of Iron

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

At will, you can manifest any type of man-portable weapon, treating it as a +2 magical weapon. In addition, you can attune to one existing weapon at a time with an hour's focus; you can make this weapon appear and disappear in your possession at will. If you are knocked unconscious or die, the weapon appears on you.

Skin of Steel

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Armor and shields have no Encumbrance for you and apply no penalties to your skills. They still interfere with spellcasting, however.

The Pursuing Sword

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Attack

The next non-unarmed melee attack you make this round automatically hits and does maximum damage, if doing so is physically possible.

The Tide That Advances

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Move

Move your normal movement rate in a straight line. You can pass through enemy lines or barriers no stronger than a thin stone wall without being harmed or drawing attacks. Any enemy within five feet of your path takes a normal attack from you; make one hit and damage roll and apply it to all valid targets. Writs that augment normal melee attacks cannot be applied to this roll. When used, this Writ bursts any physical bonds that may ensnare you, barring the strongest magical materials.

Transfix the Heart

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Attack

The next ranged attack roll you make this round automatically hits for maximum damage, if it's physically possible to do so.

Wide as the Heavens

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** Scene

For the rest of the scene, your ranged weapon attacks have a range out to your visible eyesight, up to a half-mile away.



SKILLFUL WRITS

The superlative mastery of those versed in the Skillful Writs is not hindered by material concerns. A Legate with at least one Skillful Writ never takes any skill check penalty for lacking otherwise-necessary tools, such as a healer's pouch or a smith's forge.

Absolute Perfection

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Choose one non-social skill you have at level-4 proficiency; you will never fail a skill check related to that skill unless it is impossible to succeed or your opponent in an opposed skill check has some magical augmentation to their roll.

Beastspeaker

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

You can communicate freely with animals. They will reply as if they had human intelligence, albeit they will be interested only in animal matters. They can be persuaded to provide services, if suitably induced, and will carry out these favors with human intelligence.

Clavis of Skill

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Use

You automatically succeed at opening a lock or disarming a trap you could physically disarm. If the lock or trap are magical in nature, make opposed Int or Dex/Sneak skill checks against the designer's Int/Magic and win or tie to succeed.

Consecrated Bargain

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Bargain

Make a deal with a sentient. Magic cannot be used to influence the target, but mundane threats and bribes can. If they break the spirit of the bargain, as the GM judges it, they may be made to suffer 2d6 damage per level or face a suitably equivalent curse. They are aware of the magical significance of the bargain. The deal lasts until completed, you release them, or you violate your own side of the deal.

Cornucopia

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** Permanent

You can produce a day's worth of food, water, clothing, and other survival necessities sufficient for up to twenty human-sized allies per level. These created goods are permanent and cannot be dispelled.

Effortless Advance

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** Scene

For the rest of the scene, you can navigate vertical or overhanging surfaces, however smooth, at your normal movement rate provided you have at least one hand free.

Eye of the Sun

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

Your visual senses become impossibly acute; you can read text a mile away, ignore penalties for long-range missile attacks, and can see clearly even in perfect darkness. Any visual Notice checks gain a +2 bonus.

Flawless Prediction

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Round

Choose a visible creature and dictate its next round's actions. Out of combat, the control lasts for six seconds. The actions must be plausible for it under the circumstances, and worthy foes get a Mental save.

Gifted Attribute

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Pick an attribute; its modifier increases by +1, up to a maximum of +2.

Healer's Hands

Act: Instant **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Ability

For one healing effect, spell, or action you apply to an ally, the results are double the usual maximum possible.

In Plain Sight

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** Scene

For the rest of the scene, lesser foes cannot detect you unless you do something to draw their attention or are about to attack them. Creatures looking at you when you use this Writ are not affected. Once this Writ is disrupted, it cannot be triggered again until your pursuers lose track of you.

Know the Way

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You cannot become lost and can always find your way back to any place you've ever been. You can faultlessly track any target from a location they've been within the past week, provided they aren't using magical means of transportation or concealment.

Little White Lie

Act: Main **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Lie

A single listener will believe a lie you tell them, however implausible, provided it does not defy their senses or cause emotional pain. They'll believe this until evidence proves them wrong; the bigger the falsehood, the less proof is needed. Worthy foes get a Mental save to resist.

Mastery of Gold

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving wealth, industrial production, or civil engineering. Workings and major projects wherein the primary effect is related to these cost only a quarter of the silver or Renown usually required, provided their scope is not larger than City level.

Mastery of Ways

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving social institutions, cultural traits, and religious beliefs. Workings and major projects wherein the primary effect is related to these cost only a quarter of the silver or Renown usually required, provided their scope is not larger than City level.

Mirror Mind

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are immune to any magic that would read your thoughts, and can provide false readings as you wish.

Myriad Tongues

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

When you meet a sentient, you instantly acquire the ability to speak, read, and write their native language, even if not normally physically possible. Your Writ adds a +1 bonus to all reaction rolls made by the group.

Passion's Herald

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** Scene

You speak or sing something that inspires a fierce passion in those around you. You can choose the target of the feeling, but you can't control how people act on their passions; peaceful people will not be driven to violence by their feelings, but rough or brutal sorts may. The emotion affects all chosen targets within sixty feet. If the targets are already under a great surge of excitement or emotion, such as in battle, they get a Mental save to resist.

Plans Within Plans

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Event

Suddenly have or produce one item, ally, or circumstance you could conceivably have prepared during downtime. This Writ can be used only once per scene.

Royal Mastery

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Your Mastery Graces from the Martial or Skillful categories increase in their maximum size. They can be applied to any domain of which you are the ruler or an official minister of such a ruler, up to Kingdom size.

Skillful Fray

Act: Instant **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Attack

Add your maximum Fray damage to a successful weapon or unarmed attack or to the Shock it otherwise inflicts. You can use this Writ only once on an attack.

Swift to Make

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

You can fashion portable objects with blinding speed. Choose one non-magical object or device you can carry unaided; it appears in your grasp and persists until destroyed or the Effort is reclaimed. Edible or ingestible substances cannot be called this way.

Ten Thousand Masks

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

You can appear as any humanoid creature within two feet of your height. While the change is illusory, it cannot be detected by touch, scent, or other senses.

Tireless Hands

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

You can labor without rest. While active, you need neither food, drink, or sleep. You can do the same crafting or building work single-handedly as a crew of twenty skilled laborers per level you have.

Wind of Mercy

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Action

You can heal a creature by touch. When this Writ is used, you can pick one effect to apply. The same effect can't be used twice on a creature in the same day.

- ♦ Heal 1d6 hit points per level you have
- ♦ Cure all diseases or poisons
- ♦ Revive a 1 HD creature that has been dead for less than a day, assuming the corpse is mostly intact

SORCEROUS WRITS

Those with mastery of at least one Sorcerous Writ have a keen sense of the Legacy's flow. As a Main action, they can concentrate to perceive any active magical enchantments or magical objects within sight, albeit they get no hint of their function or purpose.

Applied Mastery

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Scene

Once per game session, this Writ may be invoked to produce any effect related to a Mastery Writ you have, provided the effect is no stronger than could be accomplished by a spell of a level you can cast and the GM finds it reasonable. Thus, one with Mastery of Bone could spontaneously summon an undead minion, one of Space could teleport the party, one of Thought could bind a target's mind, or some other effect commensurate with their general spellcasting ability. Worthy foes affected by hostile powers get a saving throw to resist or lessen the effect. The benefits or effects granted by this ability do not normally last longer than a scene.

At My Word

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Spell

Cast an available spell as an On Turn action, regardless of any damage or disruption you may have taken this round. This Writ can be used only once per scene and cannot be used if you've already cast this round.

Bonelord

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Undead lesser foes cannot harm you with their attacks, spells, or special powers. Against worthy foes, you get a reroll on any failed saving throw against their abilities and take minimum damage from their attacks and spells. Only Necromancers or similar undeath-associated Legates can take this Writ.

Crystallized Sorcery

Act: Main **Eff:** Day **Dur:** Until Used

You can place a spell you can cast into a token or object. You or an ally can trigger the token as a Main action, casting the spell as if they were in control of its targeting and details, but using your level for the effects. You don't regain the Effort until the token is used or allowed to lapse and you can have only one token prepared at a time.

Eye of the Sorcerer-King

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Whenever you wish, you perceive active magic as a visible glow. You can get a sentence worth of description of the effect of any visible enchantment or spell.

Far-Reaching Workings

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Your Mastery Writs are now applicable to Region-sized alterations or smaller.

Fireshaper

Act: Main **Eff:** None **Dur:** One Scene

You can move, shape, or extinguish flames in your sight, affecting up to a 40' cube at a time and moving it up to 500 feet to a visible location. Flames moved to a non-flammable area will die out in a round. Creatures caught in a typical mass of flame will suffer 2d6 damage per round. At all times you are wholly impervious to heat or smoke damage, magical or otherwise.

Golem Lord

Act: Main **Eff:** None **Dur:** Until Release

Target a visible non-sentient construct or automaton. The target must make a Mental save or become your willing servant, obeying even self-destructive orders until you release them. Lesser foes get no saving throw to resist this Writ. You cannot use this Writ again while the total number of automaton hit dice under your control are greater than your level.

Malison on High

Act: Main **Eff:** None **Dur:** One Attack

You mold energies appropriate to your style of magic into an arcane attack on a target point within 200 feet. All creatures and objects in a radius of up to 20 feet take 1d6 damage per level from the blast. You take a quarter of this damage, rounded up, as backlash each time this Writ is invoked. This backlash cannot be averted or avoided by some other power.

Pavis of Sorcery

Act: Instant **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Effect

When you fail a saving throw against a magical effect, you can trigger this Writ to reroll the save. You can use this Writ only once on any failed save.

Perpetual Vitality

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are no longer conventionally mortal. You are immune to non-magical diseases and poisons and maintain your current state of vitality for up to one hundred years per level before old age will take you.

Revise the Ethers

Act: Instant **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Spell

When you or a visible target casts a spell, invoke this Writ to force a reroll of any random result, such as damage dice. This does not apply to any saving throws forced by the spell. This Writ can be invoked only once per target spell, but you may choose whether or not to use the rerolled result..

Sigil of Salt and Spray

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

While active, this Writ makes you and up to ten companions per level entirely immune to harm or negative effects from water. You can move through it, see through it, and breathe in it normally without being dampened, and water-based attacks cannot injure you.

Sorcerous Fray

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

Your *Heroic Mage's Fray* ability now inflicts 1d6 damage plus your full character level. This Writ is of no use to those without the ability.

Spell Eater

Act: Instant **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Spell

Expend a prepared spell slot to instantly disrupt some visible target's spellcasting, causing them to waste their action. If the target is a Legate or creature of similar power, make an opposed Wis/Magic skill check and win it to succeed at the disruption. This Writ can be used once per round at most.

Throne of the Sorcerer-King

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You can spend a month dedicating no more than a City-sized area as your personal arcane domain, provided no significant force opposes your rituals. Within this domain, your Workings and major projects cost only half the silver or Renown needed. This reduction is multiplicative with Mastery Writs. You can have only one domain at a time. If you have *Far-Reaching Workings*, your domain can be Region-sized, if it's suitably pacified.

Vault of the Sky

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Scene

The wind bears you up. For the rest of the scene, you can fly at your normal movement rate and hover in mid-air. This Writ can be conferred on an ally by Committing Effort for the day instead of the scene.

Mastery of Bone

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving undeath, immortality, and vital force, gaining the usual benefits to your relevant Workings and major projects.

Mastery of Eidolons

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving golems, automatons, or artificial minds, gaining the usual benefits to your relevant Workings and major projects.

Mastery of Energy

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving fire, cold, electricity, motion, or other energies, gaining the usual benefits to your relevant Workings and major projects.

Mastery of Flesh

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving biology, mutation, and physical alteration, gaining the usual benefits to your relevant Workings and major projects.

Mastery of Sight

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving scrying, detection, and other divinations, gaining the usual benefits to your relevant Workings and major projects.

Mastery of Space

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving spatial distortion, portals, and teleportation, gaining the usual benefits to your relevant Workings and major projects.

Mastery of Thought

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You are a master of Workings involving mental control, perception, and mind-reading, gaining the usual benefits to your relevant Workings and major projects.



UNIVERSAL WRITS

Some Writs aren't particularly wedded to concepts of martial power, personal skill, or sorcerous impossibilities. These powers are woven into the Legacy itself, signs and sigils of its power for those who bear its Writs. Others are so fundamental to being a Legate that all such heroes have these powers. Universal Writs may be purchased for 3 Legate XP by any character, regardless of their class.

All Legates of the Latter Earth can wield the *Legate's Wrath* and possess the *Legate's Impunity*. Heroes of other worlds and settings may have other special powers characteristic of their station.

Bearer of the Name

Act: None **Eff:** None **Dur:** Constant

You bear the seal of an archetypal concept or mythic form, usually expressed as a single word: Fire, Spring, Storm, Revenge, Grief, Knives, or something similar. You possess an extra point of Effort that can only be used to fuel Writs that produce effects appropriate to your seal. Once per game session, you can Commit Effort for the day to create a Writ-like effect in line with your seal, provided the GM thinks it appropriate and the power's effects don't last longer than a scene. This Writ can be taken only once, though legends say that it is but the gateway to a greater and more terrible power.

Legate's Impunity

Act: Instant **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Save

You may immediately re-roll a failed saving throw. This Writ can be invoked only once on any given save.

Legate's Wrath

Act: Main **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Use

You wield your weapons, arts, or some energy appropriate to your character to bring destruction on a single visible target. Lesser foes die or are subdued instantly, while worthy foes take 1d6 damage per two levels, rounded up. This Writ can be used only once per scene on any single target.

Regalia of Rule

Act: On Turn **Eff:** None **Dur:** Until Ended

You can consecrate certain items as part of your regalia as a Legate, however mundane or ordinary they may be. Up to three Encumbrance per level can be so consecrated by touching them and expending a Main Action. Afterwards, the items may be summoned to hand or dispatched into a micro-Iterum as an On Turn action. The items may appear Readied if you have sufficient Strength to bear the sudden burden.

Repudiator's Anathema

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Scene **Dur:** One Round

You invoke your connection with the Legacy to repudiate the existence of a single visible object or creature. An object of a size up to one 10' cube per level can be affected. Until the start of your next turn, neither you nor it exist to each other for purposes of physical interaction; you can sense each other but are wholly intangible. Spellcasting or other magical powers can still be used to affect each other, and magical constructs cannot be repudiated. Writs do not qualify as magic.

Shadow of God

Act: Instant **Eff:** None **Dur:** Until Ended

At will, you may adopt a single alternate form of your choice that fully expresses the terrible majesty of your power. This shape must be no more than twice your normal size, but is obviously and dramatically supernatural in some way appropriate to your character's nature. The terror and awe of your presence forces 1 HD creatures to make a Morale check to fight or impede you unless desperate. Onlookers are absolutely and intuitively convinced that you are supernatural or divine, though they may not agree on your nature.

Silver Threads of Harmony

Act: On Turn **Eff:** Duration **Dur:** Commit

You have the ability to bind allied Legates together into a mesh of shared thought through your mutual connections to the Legacy. You can connect only willing Legates, and all must be in your presence when this Writ is invoked. Until it is dropped thereafter, anyone so connected can share thoughts and images with other willing participants provided you are within twenty miles per level of both users. Provided they're within range, all users are aware of it should one of their number be killed or struck unconscious.

White Jade Lord

Act: Instant **Eff:** Day **Dur:** One Round

You are a living channel of rectification, a beacon of natural law made flesh. At your will, the Legacy crystallizes around your person, rendering you completely unaffected by all magic or spellcasting, friendly or hostile, until your next turn. Writs and other Legate powers do not qualify as magic, but spells, arts, or other enchantments do. At your discretion, you can apply an effect like the *Extirpate Arcana* spell to any object you touch when you trigger this Writ.

USING LEGATES IN YOUR CAMPAIGN

GMs who plan to run a Legate-heavy campaign are encouraged to get the free PDF version of Sine Nomine Publishing's *Godbound* role-playing game. While the system used in that game is different, the GM advice and adventure-building tools are applicable to the kind of high-powered, semi-divine adventures that are likely to absorb the attention of Legate parties.

For GMs without the chance to review that game's adventure creation chapter, however, there are a few basic principles to keep in mind for Legate campaigns.

LEGATES AND CHALLENGES

Some challenges that would seriously hinder even a high-level normal PC will provide nothing more than a momentary speedbump for a Legate. A tenth-level Legate Warrior can summarily execute creatures that would make an ordinary hero sweat, often with no more than a single use of a Writ.

In the same fashion, Writs can conjure up resources or produce environmental changes that might simply negate a challenge entirely. A labyrinth full of lethal traps is a casual morning stroll to a Legate Expert with the *Clavis of Skill* Writ.

This kind of quick disposal of content can frustrate and baffle GMs at times. It's not uncommon for a problem the GM thought would absorb the party for some time finds itself quickly resolved by some unanticipated combination of Writs or supernatural abilities. While disconcerting, this isn't as much of a problem as it might seem. The key is twofold: thinking past the challenge, and letting the PCs get themselves in deep.

When you put a challenge in an adventure, don't just think about the ways the PCs might solve it, think about the *consequences* for solving it. What happens after they butcher the bandit clan? What problems are going to happen if they tear down the corrupt lord? Who is going to care if they cut a path through some heretofore-hidden ancient ruin?

Often these consequences will be too muddy or tangled to be easily resolved with a swipe of a Writ. If the bandits were really working for a sinister local noble, now the PCs have gotten his enmity and may not even realize it until he springs his revenge. The corrupt lord might be replaced by a riot of competing rivals all struggling to take power, with the merit of any of them unclear to the heroes. That discovered Deep might spark a border war between neighboring powers trying to take control of its critical position. And when the PCs solve those problems, the very solutions will plant the seeds of new issues to confront.

This leads to the second technique for challenging the PCs, letting them get their own characters into trouble. As powerful and versatile as Legates are, PCs will naturally tend to push their actions as far as they can go, brushing aside minor foes and lesser powers as they drive

toward their ultimate goals. They'll keep going until they finally hit an enemy or a situation they can't simply wave away. There is always something bigger and toothier, and it's in the nature of PCs to keep going until they make such a thing mad.

In order for this to happen, however, the PCs need to have big dreams and big goals. If your players don't have ambitions that are dramatic enough to bring them into conflict with powers capable of threatening them, you should work with them until they *do* have those ambitions. They're viceroys of the cosmic law; they should have dreams bigger than those of mere mercenaries.

LEGATE XP REWARDS

GMs are sometimes confused over when to give out Legate XP rewards. The guidelines for normal XP awards on page 255 apply as usual if the heroes haven't already reached the maximum of tenth level, but how is a GM to tell when the party's earned Legate XP?

First, work backward from your desired advancement rate. It costs 3 Legate XP to get a new Writ; if you want PCs to be getting a new power every two sessions, aim for giving them one or two Legate XP every session. This basic desired rate of improvement helps guide your decisions about what to reward. Fast advancement makes for a more generous appraisal of PC deeds, while slow advancement lets you be more stringent.

Second, decide whether or not the party accomplished a meaningful change in the world during the session, one commensurate with their importance and influence. A party of novice Legates might justifiably deserve a reward for saving a market town from some supernatural peril or enriching a village with some splendid Working they fashioned. Legates who already bestride nations might have to do the same sort of trick with whole provinces or city-states in order to get the same credit, because it takes them about the same number of game sessions to do it as it took the novices to fix the village up.

The goals they pursue should be worthy of their station, and PCs who don't have ambitions big enough to fit their capabilities need to be encouraged to think bigger. A wandering swordsman-Legate is a perfectly fine concept, but that swordsman-Legate ought to dream of purging all wickedness from the kingdom, or throwing down a tyrannical emperor, or obtaining the secret to eternal life, or some other great accomplishment. He may wander the realm in search of ways to advance that goal, but the deeds he undertakes along the way ought to be the sort to fit his capabilities.

If you let the PCs stick around in the grubby mire of daily life, you risk their boredom when they prove superior to all the petty mundane challenges they face. Make sure to use Legate XP as a goad, and its reward as a prize for being the living legends that Legates ought to be.



ITERUMS AND THEIR DWELLERS

All Iterums were created for a purpose, whether it be as humble as a desire for a larger sorcerous closet or as grand as the survival of a civilization. Entire worlds have been forged to satisfy some lost Emperor's will, their names lost to history and the Black Gates that lead to them long since forgotten or destroyed. Occult voyagers into the unknown might stumble across them from time to time, but more often they survive only in scraps of summoning-spells designed to call forth their more useful natives.

As a GM, your uses for an Iterum are more likely to be as a source of antagonists, as a font for useful summoned creatures, or as a pocket dungeon-dimension where the rules of reality can accommodate some entertaining conceit. Those readers who are forging entirely new campaign worlds might want some extra tools for creating alternate planes of reality in which gods or demons might dwell, and where the souls of the blessed or damned can find their ultimate repose. Each of these purposes has their own considerations to keep in mind.

ITERUMS AS REALMS OF EVIL

Not every fantasy world needs a heaven, but you can usually expect to find a hell. Demons, devils, Lovecraftian entities from beyond, and other assorted offenses against mundane reality need a home, and some nebulous plane of eternal suffering usually fills the role. It's not uncommon for a setting to have multiple hells catering to different varieties of infernal entity, or as homesteads for different groups of dark gods.

It's rare that PCs ever actually set foot in such a plane; in many cases the natural environment may be such as to quickly kill mortal interlopers. Only the mightiest or most unfortunate heroes find themselves treading the brazen plains of Hell, but much less accomplished adventurers might end up fighting the realm's loathsome spawn. With that in mind, a GM's chief concern is usually thinking about the kind of creatures who dwell in that place, what they want from the mundane world, and how they might go about getting it. Once you have the game-relevant facts established, you can build the environment around them to suit their particular natures.

First, identify the structure of the antagonistic force. If there are multiple groups of malefactors or the main group is divided into different factions you might roll several times on the table. The results give you a basic template for organizing their society, such as it might be.

Next, figure out what these creatures want from the mundane world. Why should they have any interest in ordinary reality? There must be some reason they cross the gulf of worlds to reach your campaign world.

Now think about why they want that. In some cases it might be pure malice or unfathomable alien cogitation, but in other cases they might be motivated by more practical ends. Knowing what they want and why they want it

will help you figure out what kind of bargains they might strike and what kind of payment they're likely to accept.

Lastly, you should think about some characteristic way they might go about obtaining their end. For some interlopers this might be a simple matter of rending and slaying, while others engage in sophisticated trickery or honeyed blandishments. Not all entities of this world likely use this same method, but it's probably the way most mortals envision them behaving in myth and legend. If multiple factions of entities are used you might select different characteristic means for them.

Now that you know something about how these creatures behave and what they want, you can spend a little time detailing their home plane. The easiest way to generate a Hellish dimension is to take a mundane terrain and filter it through a particular extreme or unnatural quality. Hells are places of everlasting flame, eternal ice, impenetrable darkness, hideous stench, or unending pain. The native entities might treat these conditions as ordinary commonplaces, or they might also suffer from them, with that pain being one more reason why they want something from the sweeter realm of the mundane world. The table here offers some filter suggestions, and you could mix and match these for different regions of the plane. If you expect your PCs to ever go adventuring in the place, make sure the environment is not so drastic that they couldn't survive it, assuming they're prepared.

Having this information in hand, it's time to generate the appearance of these devils. You'll most likely want several different kinds for your campaign world, so you can use the monster generation tools in the bestiary chapter to put together basic body plans for these entities. You might pick one trait to be characteristic of all creatures from this world, such as ruddy hides, jagged horns, membranous wings, or some other distinctive quality.

You know what they look like, what they want, how they get it, and where they come from. Now you just need to figure out how they get here and how the locals view them. Some hell-planes might not be known to the locals, or they might confuse the denizens of one infernal realm with those of another place of misery. Different civilizations might also have different attitudes toward them, with some viewing them as holy scourges sent by the gods to punish humanity while others consider them mere brute beasts to be put down. Intelligent hell-beings might actively work to insinuate themselves into the societies and hierarchies of other realms.

This much development is usually sufficient for most worldbuilding. Once you actually need to use these creatures in an adventure, you can use the tools in the bestiary chapter to generate foes of whatever power level you need. If you want to develop their infernal culture in a more elaborate way, you can use the society creation tools in the campaign creation chapter by reading every result in the most villainous possible light.

INFERNAL ITERUM TOOLS

Infernal Iterums might be the product of an ancient Imperator's Working gone terribly wrong, a genesis-calculation meant for a heaven but resulting in a hell. Others could be the product of Legacy decay run rampant, or ancient magics gone awry, or more conventional disasters of radiation or cosmic mischance. The origin of the place is rarely all that important in play, but it can sometimes add some extra depth to the past of its denizens. GMs who are building infernal plans for their own campaign setting apart from the Latter Earth can give them whatever origins suit their needs.

These tables are meant to help you generate the dominant type of life in the Iterum, much as humans predominate in the Latter Earth. There may be other hellish flora and fauna there, but PCs are unlikely to encounter them as foes unless they manage to reach that unhappy realm or they're brought along as minions.

d12 What Do They Want?

- 1 Pain, the suffering and grief of mortals
- 2 Chaos, all law and order made to fall
- 3 Corruption, virtue spoiled and debased
- 4 Destruction, the physical ruin of things
- 5 War, with mortals marching on each other
- 6 Poverty, with goods ruined and riches lost
- 7 Worship, with mortals revering them
- 8 Death, the slaughter and extinction of all
- 9 Escape, making this world into a new home
- 10 Impiety, overthrowing the gods
- 11 Revenge, the ruin of some old enemy or foe
- 12 Dominion, the enslavement of all that lives

d12 How Do They Make It Happen?

- 1 They make bargains with unwise petitioners
- 2 They have powers well-suited to getting it
- 3 Their agents are hidden in the land
- 4 They have ancient cults devoted to them
- 5 They trick mortals into facilitating their ends
- 6 They use terrible hellish magics
- 7 They know dark secrets of the past
- 8 They are in league with a mundane nation
- 9 They manifest in this world naturally at times
- 10 They reward those who serve their ends
- 11 A popular religion is really devoted to them
- 12 They can warp mortal minds and desires

d12 What's the Structure of Their Society?

- 1 Militantly solitary and cooperation-shunning
- 2 Tyrannical rule by the strongest brute force
- 3 Constantly shifting warbands
- 4 Factional servitors of different dark powers
- 5 Byzantine intrigue and cruel legalistic rule
- 6 Frenzied packs driven by mad passions
- 7 Scheming leaders and their thralls
- 8 Brutal slavery of weaker to stronger
- 9 Philosophical or religious schools at war
- 10 Lineage-based with interline strife
- 11 Different dark purposes at mutual war
- 12 Darwinian survival of the strongest

d12 Why Do They Want It?

- 1 They feed on it and grow stronger
- 2 Their dark philosophies demand it of them
- 3 Their alien minds find it beautiful
- 4 They seek revenge for some ancient slight
- 5 Hatred and envy of the kinder world above
- 6 Mortals enrage them by their very existence
- 7 They must have it to further a greater plan
- 8 They use it to improve their own blasted land
- 9 Mortal losses give them slaves and wealth
- 10 It's a game that helps decide their status
- 11 They were created to want it somehow
- 12 They find it absolutely hilarious

d12 What's Hellish About Their Iterum?

- 1 Some terrible extreme of temperature
- 2 Eternal darkness or alien, unnatural light
- 3 Constant tectonic activity and moving land
- 4 Perpetually flooded or parched
- 5 It's made entirely of metal or other strangeness
- 6 It's one huge, corrupted megastructure
- 7 It writhes with unnatural and terrible life
- 8 It festers with horrible diseases and toxins
- 9 Some brutal weather is constantly active
- 10 Terrible psychic oppression is constant
- 11 Time or space are unstable and dangerous
- 12 The atmosphere is barely survivable



ITERUMS AND SUMMONED BEINGS

There are many genres of fantasy where the summoning of extra-planar beings is a wizard's chief trick, and great mages may be feared more for their servants than their personal magics. It's useful to have some tools on hand to define these eldritch entities, but it's also worth thinking about their role in your campaign.

SUMMONING ELDRITCH ENTITIES

At their simplest, summoned beings are tools for solving particular problems. The summoning spells given in the High Magic chapter of this book call forth beings that are useful for certain jobs and capable of being expended without lasting cost to the wizard. They're more-or-less disposable solutions.

They are designed, however, to not be especially powerful solutions, or solutions to very subtle or wide-ranging problems. They can sub in as meat shields, spare hands, unskilled workers, or recon scouts, but they aren't going to be slaying heroes or blighting kingdoms.

This doesn't necessarily fit with the traditions of pulp sword and sorcery, where the nameless minions of dark wizards bring hideous death or an abominable fate to those who oppose their master. They also don't do well for demon-gods, alien deities, the favored devil-angels of the gods, or other beckoned powers at the heart of strange cults or ancient faiths.

If you want to use summoned entities like that in your campaign, you'll want to keep one or both of the following framing tools in mind.

First, PCs can't normally summon these entities without sacrifices or special conditions that they can't reasonably fulfill. Perhaps a wizard sacrifices all other magical powers to gain the ability, or must perform time-consuming rituals of worship, or needs to belong to a specific pacted bloodline, or must commit horrible crimes that would make a PC unplayable. Contacting these entities and calling them forth to serve should usually be the hallmark of a wizard who has made sacrifices too great for any PC to willingly embrace them.

Second, if a PC *is* able to call up such things, the ability should be linked to specific magical relics, occult times and places, particular cosmic synchronies, or other limiting factors that probably require an adventure to bring about. These limits may have much more to do with the work than any innate magical power; it may be that it only takes a good Magic skill to perform the necessary rites, if all the ingredients are present. They should not be accessible by a mere Xth-level summoning spell.

GMs can use knowledge of particular eldritch powers as a reward in an adventure, with the necessary details of their summoning given to worthy PCs. Of course, there should always be some harsh price associated with calling them up, one that may require its own adventure to pay. If these things are going to solve a problem, they need to create enough adventure grist to compensate.

USING SUMMONED POWERS

Once the PCs or some antagonists have successfully beckoned forth a being, how is a GM supposed to handle it in the game world? There are two main ways to treat major summoned entities.

In the first, they're simply a powerful creature built with the tools in the bestiary section. This tactic is most appropriate for creatures meant to fight a foe or engage in direct combat. Beings not intended for open warfare often have little or no combat ability, and may not be susceptible to conventional harm at all. Getting rid of them may require spoiling the ritual components, casting spells of dispelling, or using specific banishing magic.

The strength of the creature should be based on the amount of effort required to call it up. It should have no more hit dice than the highest-leveled PC unless it took at least one adventure to enable its summoning. If it took one or more adventures, it's reasonable to give it 25% or 50% more hit dice for every adventure it took.

The second way to treat major summoned entities is as an equivalent lump of Renown points toward accomplishing some relevant major project. If the PCs want to overthrow the wicked baron, maybe they summon up an entity of murder and send it to slay the nobleman. The GM calculates the creature's Renown value and applies it to the major project of noble-killing. If it's enough to do the job then maybe it does kill the baron, and if not, it probably kills a lieutenant or two instead and thus moves the PCs closer to ultimate success.

The Renown value of a summoned creature is usually worth about the total levels of the PCs involved in summoning it, assuming it's a match for their power. This Renown value is increased just as hit dice would be if one or more adventures were required to call up the thing. Note that it's generally not possible to use the same spirit more than once to progress a major project. It's assumed that the first summoning accomplished all that it could reasonably do. In the same vein, some entities may be particularly unhelpful against particular problems, especially if the targets are well-versed in magical defenses.

A summoned spirit is generally useful for only one service or project. Even if it persists in this world, it's not going to work again until it's propitiated once more, either because it's unwilling to exert itself or because it needs the power of the service in order to fuel its abilities.

The cost of this propitiation is usually measured in services or sacrifices. The PCs may need to carry out a job to satisfy its wishes, or retrieve some esoteric object to sacrifice to it, or slay an ancient enemy it has, or otherwise do some sort of work that is inconvenient or difficult. Even those entities that do not require an entire adventure's worth of service to call up probably demand the sacrifice of magical items, large sums of wealth, or the offering of things that the PCs value.

SUMMONED ITERUM CREATURES

The physical appearance and combat statistics of summoned beings can be determined with the tools in the bestiary chapter, but the details of these beings need some special attention.

The first three tables on this page give a context for these entities, both the role they serve in their home Iterum and the history they have with your campaign setting. Their prior history suggests where the secrets of their summoning might be found, and what kind of NPCs might have them among their arsenal of servitors.

The fourth table indicates what the servitor is particularly good at doing. This may not be its natural role in its home Iterum, and it may not be its only power, but mortal summoners find it very useful for that end.

The final table gives a suggestion as to why they serve humans. This may be a price or reason in addition to whatever cost the summoning ritual itself presents.

d12 How Did They Start Getting Summoned?

- 1 Fighting for or against humanity in ages past
- 2 The obsessions of particular wizards
- 3 In consequence of a divine revelation
- 4 Their secrets were found in a hidden book
- 5 In an ancient empire's hour of dire need
- 6 In the face of a prehistoric calamity
- 7 They forced themselves on this world at first
- 8 A natural occult synchrony called them
- 9 A madman perceived the way to call them
- 10 Ancient nonhumans taught humans the way
- 11 They were brought by another summons
- 12 They convinced mages to call them up

d12 What Are They Mostly Good For?

- 1 Killing, being gifted in stalking and murder
- 2 Guardianship, protecting others from harm
- 3 Counsel, being wise and foresightful
- 4 Healing, giving blessings of health
- 5 Finding, able to hunt out the lost and hidden
- 6 War, loving open warfare and fighting
- 7 Pleasure, gifted in granting many delights
- 8 Deceit, given to trickery and useful lies
- 9 Wealth, making goods or finding treasure
- 10 Rule, bending others' hearts and minds
- 11 Travel, carrying their masters far and swiftly
- 12 Teaching, being able to impart secret lore

d12 What Is Their Function or Role At Home?

- 1 The ordinary human-analogs of their world
- 2 Predators or dangerous hunting beasts
- 3 Sages or seers, gifted with understanding
- 4 A conquered slave-race to other entities
- 5 Priestly or philosophical teachers and rulers
- 6 Sinister servants of a despised power
- 7 Guardians or protectors of something
- 8 Servitors and minions of their masters
- 9 Hermits and solitary dwellers
- 10 Laborers and craftsmen of their kind
- 11 Swift messengers or harriers
- 12 Tricksters, liars, and deceivers of their sort

d12 Who Are Their Most Famous Summoners?

- 1 A particular diabolical Imperator of old
- 2 A vanished cult of occult wisdom
- 3 A dark and terrible faith used them
- 4 A lost empire was partly built by their help
- 5 A venerable school of mages used them
- 6 A brilliant arch-wizard employed their arts
- 7 A warlord got an artifact that called them
- 8 A demihuman race had a pact with them
- 9 The Outsiders enlisted them in their service
- 10 They were angelic servitors of a religion
- 11 A mighty Legate used them as minions
- 12 Madmen or those afflicted in a certain way

d12 What Do They Get Out Of It?

- 1 The mundane world is paradisaical to them
- 2 The magical bindings compel them to obey
- 3 The spell energy empowers them at home
- 4 An ancient pact is invoked by the spell
- 5 The spell prep involves worship or sacrifice
- 6 They're forced to serve by peers at home
- 7 It's a religious imperative to them to serve
- 8 Their natures compel them to obey humanity
- 9 The energies of this world empower them
- 10 They satisfy their curiosity in this alien world
- 11 Their service furthers some deep plan or plot
- 12 Their service is intensely pleasurable to them



ITERUMS AS ALTERNATE WORLDS

Sometimes a GM needs a pocket dimension for their campaign, whether it be some misty Averogne through a forgotten forest road or an alternate dimension where some critical artifact the PCs need has not been destroyed. Other planes might be needed as blessed afterlives for the pious dead, or prison-realms for fallen divinities.

PLANAR TRAVEL

In the Latter Earth, the only “simple” way to travel between Iterums is through a Black Gate, a magical edifice that acts as a portal between worlds. For very small Iterums, such as pocket strongholds, otherworldly dungeons, or hidden wizardly estates the Black Gate may be indistinguishable from any other doorway, while portals to far worlds might be massive edifices thrumming with eldritch power. Due to its profound integration with the Legacy, a Black Gate might not even register as magical.

Travel through a gate is usually simply a matter of walking through it. Some gates are keyed to accept only particular subjects, however, or require keys to unlock them, or are only open at certain times and places.

Aside from the Black Gates, there do exist certain powerful, dangerous spells for hurling the caster to far worlds. Such travel is invariably risky and poorly-controlled, and the path through the infinite possibilities of the Legacy may involve a dangerous voyage through myriad hell-worlds to reach the safety of the mage’s destination. The availability of such spells is strictly up to the GM, along with the necessary occult lore needed to fix a particular Iterum as a valid destination.

ITERUMS AS DUNGEONS

Most Deeps and other dungeons exist in the campaign world, and operate on the same physical laws and assumptions as the campaign world does. Monsters get hungry, the walls can be dug through with enough effort, the structure has a history that exists in the world, and physical laws are generally the same inside and out.

Sometimes a GM needs something a little different. They might want to plant a truly weird structure in their campaign, or build an edifice that has nothing to do with the campaign world they’ve established. They might like some alternate twist to their campaign setting too much to abandon it, and so they create a pocket-place where their pleasant idea is how things really worked out. These places may not function on conventional logic at all, and instead operate on a mythical or narrative basis.

The challenge of such a dungeon often involves figuring out what its internal laws really are. A dungeon built on the logic of a story will react to random heroic vandalism in a very different way than one that echoes the emotions of its inhabitants. A GM should take care to sprinkle liberal clues about any differences in local laws, and particularly abstract changes may need an Investigation challenge to reward PCs with a direct explanation.

ITERUMS AS AFTERLIVES

Most religions make some kind of promises about a believer’s ultimate fate beyond the grave. Sometimes this destiny is one of reincarnation within the world, or complete extinction, or some other fate that can be compassed within the bounds of the campaign world. Other times a Hell or a Heaven is needed, and it is rarely the case that two religions are friendly enough to share the same afterlife.

An Iterum can serve as a religion’s afterlife, whether or not that same realm is the seat of its presiding gods. Due to the profound intertwining of the faith with the Legacy, believers who meet the standards of the religion may actually be reborn within the Iterum in whatever form the religion says they should be. Whether these souls are the actual deceased or merely perfect replicas is a valid question, but likely an abstract one for most GM purposes.

This transformation may be chiefly cosmetic and leave the “self” of the deceased intact and recognizable to others. Conversely, it may be such a profound enlightenment or damnation that the resultant spirit bears no resemblance to the person that died. Sometimes all memory of their past life is washed away by the new.

The existence of this afterlife opens up the possibility of calling souls back, either to commune with them, gain their help in this world, or restore them to life. It may be that the transformation is one-way, however, and their celestial existences can no longer be incarnated in the muddy, base world.

Of course, for every Heaven, there is often as not a Hell to match. Believers who fail their gods sufficiently may be cast into a miserable existence of torment or suffering. Some campaign settings may have agnostic Hells, realms of fire where all the wicked burn for their sins, while others may simply extinguish the identities of those without a patron willing to preserve them.

The rules that apply to a soul’s ultimate fate are not necessarily palatable to every sense of justice. The rules of the religion apply, not some abstract and generalized sense of right and wrong. Sins that might be heinous to one faith could be outright pious to another, and a soul seemingly blameless of evil could be cast into the flames for a “crime” unrecognizable to another faith.

GMs who don’t want to engage with such questions of right and wrong can leave the matter conveniently vague and uncertain, with enough hints in the world to satisfy priests and believers but not enough to bring up awkward questions about specifics.

Whether these blessed or damned can die again is up to the GM’s tastes. It may be that the Iterum itself regenerates them if they are slain, or they may be indestructible through conventional harm. Conversely, their second death may be an eternal one.

DEVIATIONS OF REALITY

If you're creating an alternate world for your campaign, it's for a particular reason, and it's assumed you'll build it to accommodate that need. Beyond that, however, it can be helpful to spice up the realm with some other quirks and novelties.

The table below offers a basic type of deviation for the Iterum, and a selection of examples showing how that quality might be warped in the realm. Such a change might have been an intention of the creator, or it could just be a tragic magical error in its genesis.

d6	Basic Deviation	d6	Specific Examples
1	Physical Law	1	Time progresses at an anomalous rate, fast or slow
		2	Space, gravity, or time can be molded there by mundane means
		3	Light, color, or some other intangible has some special effect or existence
		4	A natural requirement such as food, water, or air is not necessary there
		5	Physical laws are decayed and unstable, requiring special reinforcement
		6	Space is narrative; things are close when important to an entity, and far when not
2	Geography	1	The world is dominated by endless seas, deserts, or other specific terrain
		2	A massive mountain, volcano, or other feature is the central pole of the world
		3	The world is flat, and the edges are very significant for some reason
		4	Its various lands are very difficult to travel between for some reason
		5	The natural environment is hazardous or lethal to the unprepared
		6	The geography itself reflects powerful magical currents
3	History	1	It's the campaign world, but with a critical past event going the opposite way
		2	It's the campaign world, but where the most unsympathetic faction won
		3	It's the campaign world, but after some sort of apocalypse
		4	It's the campaign world, but with allied powers instead as dire enemies
		5	It's the campaign world, but with totally different major powers
		6	It's the campaign world, but with every problem in it somehow made worse
4	Inhabitants	1	The Outsiders are still in control, or they may be the only ones here
		2	The dominant life is demihuman or transhuman
		3	The inhabitants serve faiths or philosophies that are minor in the campaign world
		4	A particular human group of the campaign world is wholly predominant here
		5	A completely unheard-of species is a major element of the population
		6	Everyone seems the same, but each species has subtle but significant changes
5	Magic	1	Magic doesn't seem to exist in any way that the locals are aware of
		2	Magic has some dire consequence or cost to it in this world
		3	Magic is purely a function of enchanted objects or tools
		4	Only nonhumans have access to magic in this world
		5	Magic is viewed with tremendous hate or awe in this world
		6	Magic is profusely available in this world and is used even for minor ends
6	Psychology	1	The thinking of the inhabitants is strongly colored by a particular emotion or drive
		2	They've made societies that would be wholly impractical for ordinary humans
		3	They're touched with a remarkable degree of virtue or profound vice
		4	They're deeply dependent on philosophies or religions unique to them
		5	They may look like humans, but their thinking is based on totally alien principles
		6	They lack a particular emotion or faculty that normal humans possess



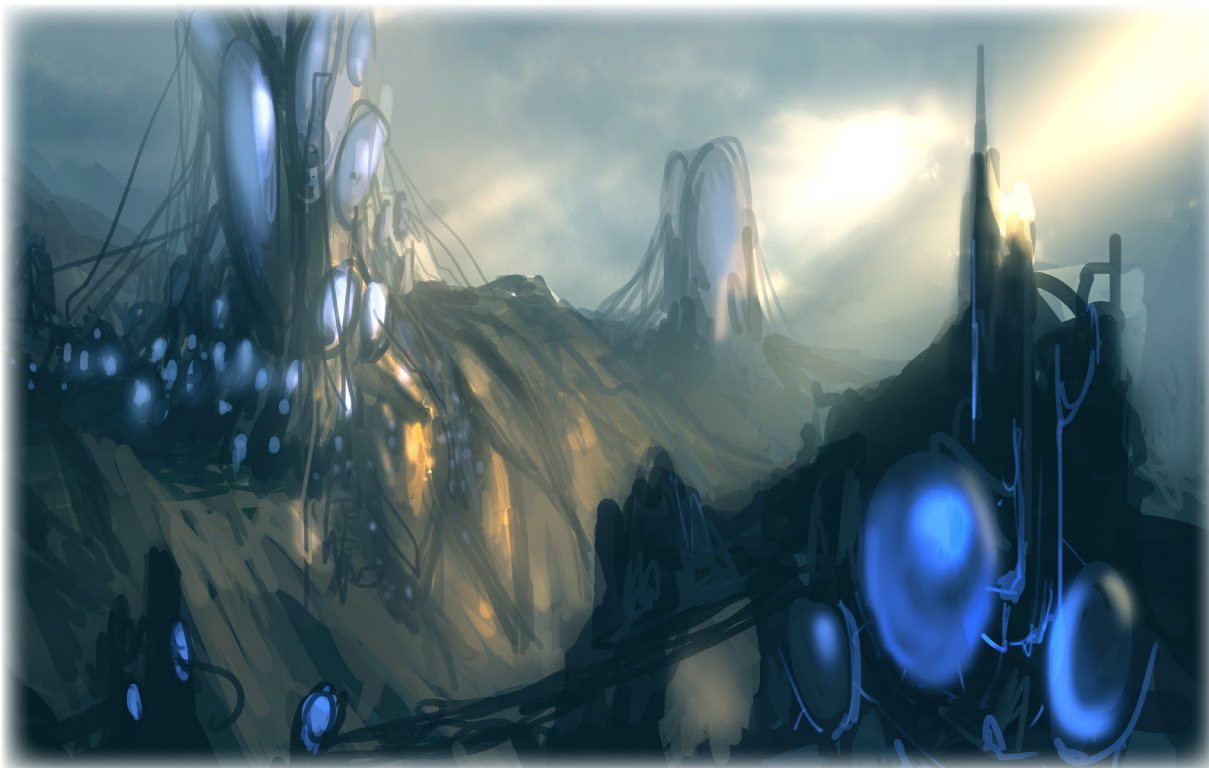
ADDITIONAL GM TOOLS

In this section you'll find a selection of system-neutral GM tools for buffing up particular parts of your creations. None of them are strictly necessary, but they might save you a little grief when it comes time to flesh out an NPC or establish some visual identity for a lost city.

Readers interested in more tools of this kind are advised to pick up at least the free versions of Sine Nomine Publishing's *Stars Without Number* and *Godbound* role playing games, as both of them contain extensive GM helps in this vein. Most of the rest of the current Sine Nomine catalog also consists of largely system-neutral GM tools and helps that could be used by almost any creator in need of a little extra boost.

d10	Bait for Adventure Hooks
1	Direct payment from a specific patron
2	The assurance of rich loot yet unplundered
3	Revenge against a foe the party hates
4	Help given to a sympathetic figure or friend
5	A magical item that they would prize
6	Occult lore and spells useful to mages
7	Ancient salvage for skilled mod-crafters
8	Escape from some looming calamity or foe
9	Fame and the admiration of others
10	Curiosity and learning of the unknown

d20	Ways of Introducing an Adventure Hook
1	Note or map on a defeated foe
2	Overheard market gossip or tavern talk
3	Sad tale of a survivor or escapee
4	Text found while exploring
5	Divine omen or magical disturbance
6	Former patron seeking them out
7	Desperate local looking for help with it
8	A plotter mistakes them for confederates
9	Encounter a place scarred by the adventure
10	Fight a monster made to flee from the site
11	Find a treasure with embedded information
12	Be hired by the antagonist as muscle
13	A friend of the party is affected by it
14	Town crier announces it in public
15	They stumble into an active part of it
16	Intercept a message meant for an antagonist
17	Government official needs to hire help
18	Failed first group tries to pass along the job
19	Plea for help nailed up in public
20	Guild or business looking for hired help



ORACULAR ADVENTURE ADJUSTMENTS

A GM is often dubious about their own creations; they have the general thread of an idea but they aren't certain it's the *right* idea. Sometimes they're confronted with a concept or a twist that's attractive, but just not quite right.

These tables offer some randomized prompts for situations, NPCs, or just general adventure and campaign ideas. When you hit a block in your creations or want to spice up a too-bland adventure outline, pick one or more of the tables and roll or choose from the results to twist an adventure element, get an oracular assessment of an adventure fact, or throw in a random event that might complicate the plans of both heroes and antagonists. When adding these twists, however, take care that they don't have too many assumptions about PC responses or fix outcomes as inevitable despite PC involvement.

d6 This Mistake Twists the Adventure

- 1 An NPC dies naturally at the worst time
- 2 An NPC fails at what they normally excel at
- 3 A fundamental premise is in error
- 4 The PCs are handed secrets from the start
- 5 The wrong people fall in love or hate
- 6 The NPC's scheme was doomed at the start

d8 This Theme Informs the Adventure

- 1 Pride, the refusal to admit error or weakness
- 2 Ignorance, lacking critical knowledge
- 3 Greed and the craving for wealth
- 4 Revenge and the cyclical cost of it
- 5 Idealism and its triumph or bitter failure
- 6 Natural consequences, cold and indifferent
- 7 Desire for love, friendship, or other passions
- 8 Duty and the grim obligations it lays on

d10 This Reality Intrudes Into the Situation

- 1 Someone's too poor for a vital necessity
- 2 Someone isn't as good as they think they are
- 3 A trusted relationship proves uncertain
- 4 A cherished dream is simply impossible
- 5 A grand ideal proves to be unworkable
- 6 Someone's self-image is totally inaccurate
- 7 Someone angered the gods or spirits
- 8 An old crime must now be paid for
- 9 Someone gives up in the face of hardship
- 10 A natural disaster or weather interferes

d4 Idea Affirmation or Negation

- 1 No; it's the opposite, or totally unrelated
- 2 No; it's related but different
- 3 Yes; but one of your assumptions is wrong
- 4 Yes; in fact, you should push it even farther

d12 How Do I Change This NPC?

- 1 Split them into more than one person
- 2 Flip an antagonist into an ally, or vice-versa
- 3 Make them deeply unsympathetic
- 4 Make them mistaken about an important fact
- 5 Make them strangely capable or strong
- 6 They're there because of a thing the PCs did
- 7 Give them a glaringly obvious character flaw
- 8 Make them friends with an unexpected figure
- 9 Put them in an unexpected setting or locale
- 10 Give them a new reason to want something
- 11 Magically bless or curse them
- 12 Make them a demi- or non-human

d20 Throw This Event Into the Adventure

- 1 An arsonist sets something ablaze
- 2 Someone gets a dangerous sickness
- 3 A thief robs someone involved
- 4 An unrelated enemy strikes at someone
- 5 Blighted raiders or bandits attack
- 6 A noble somehow gets in the way of things
- 7 A wizard did it, whatever it is
- 8 The PCs are mistakenly accused of something
- 9 Calamitously bad or troublesome weather
- 10 An enemy group attacks a nearby place
- 11 The PCs are caught in the crossfire of a fight
- 12 Something ancient finally collapses or breaks
- 13 Earthquake, disease outbreak, or wildfire
- 14 Disaster strikes the local rulers
- 15 An important local faith gets mad at a thing
- 16 An ally of the PCs makes a very bad move
- 17 Civil unrest makes problems
- 18 A sudden shortage of a vital good or service
- 19 A religious festival somehow gets in the way
- 20 The antagonist makes a grave mistake



ARCHITECTURAL STYLE GENERATORS

These tables are useful in giving a particular flavor and style to a given civilization's architecture. A GM can often be left at a loss when asked to distinguish one nation's rural villages from those of another, and even cultures that share very similar climates and terrain can end up having distinct styles and construction techniques for their buildings.

These same tools can also be used when generating Deeps, dungeons, ruins, or other edifices of some long-lost civilization. Building these edifices in some sort of

coherent, intentional way can give you considerable mileage during play.

Not only does it become easier to create new ruins when you know what they're generally supposed to look like, the PCs have a reason to pay attention to the architecture. Recognizing the star-patterned stonework of the M'gath Collective in an ancient ruin can clue them into the similarity of the perils and enigmas there with those of a prior Collective ruin they've explored. Such consistency helps build the world's sense of substance.

ARCHITECTURAL ADJECTIVES

Most GMs and players aren't equipped with an elaborate architectural vocabulary for describing every feature of a civilization's buildings. To begin, it's easier to just pick a few evocative adjectives to describe the structures and work out from there. The rural village might be described as a mass of squat adobe buildings or a collection of slim, tall wooden structures perched up above flood-prone land. The details of the architecture will usually bend to accommodate the special features of the climate and terrain. For extra complexity, you can roll several times but take only one word from each list to create a new set.

FAVORITE MATERIALS

The poor of every civilization will use whatever materials they have on hand to make their homes, but most cultures have preferences when they have the luxury of choice. Even when brick or stone is available, the nobles of a society might prefer grand wooden manors adorned with elaborate carvings for their seats of power. There's usually some reason behind such choices, whether because the alternate materials are inferior in some way, uncomfortable to live in, lacking in skilled craftsmen, or impractical for the climate. In the Latter Earth, some societies might use salvaged ancient materials that are very strange.

FAVORITE COLOR SCHEMES

A rich profusion of colors is a luxury of wealth and cheap dyestuffs. Most societies are obliged to work with the hues that nature gives them cheaply, and sometimes those are restricted. In other cases, certain colors or patterns may have cultural or religious significance, and wearing them is a matter of cultural meaning rather than personal aesthetic tastes. It's a commonplace for certain colors to bear special meaning in a society, either being reserved for certain castes or social roles, or indicative of qualities such as good luck, death, fertility, or good health.

d8 Architectural Adjectives

1	Narrow, pointed, spired
2	Squat, broad, blocky
3	Curved, organic, rounded
4	Slim, tall, looming
5	Arched, vaulted, peaked
6	Massive, cyclopean, bulky
7	Open, airy, encircling
8	Mazey, segmented, piled

d8 Favorite Materials

1	Local wood
2	Mud or clay brick
3	Quarried stone blocks
4	Stacked fieldstone
5	Rammed earth
6	Woven reeds or saplings
7	Wattle and daub
8	Metal or exotic substances

d8 Favorite Color Schemes

1	Dull, natural, earthen colors
2	Intensely bright, clashing colors
3	Reds, oranges, and warm hues
4	Bright but complementary colors
5	Intricate weaves of colors
6	Blues, greens, and cool hues
7	Monochrome shades
8	Subdued pastels and soft shades

COMMON VISUAL MOTIFS

Whether to give subjects for structural adornment or topics for interior decorations, these visual motifs show up often in the culture. Some of them might just be inheritances from the distant past, with duckweed-pattern posts and turtle-shell carvings added because they've always been added. In other cases, however, these motifs impart significant information about political alliances, religious devotion, or familial ties. The use of certain motifs and sigils might be reserved to certain buildings or people in a society.

STRUCTURE ADORNMENT

The architecture of the poor is often simple and unadorned out of necessity, but even the most impoverished peasants can often spare a winter evening to carve some good-luck symbol on their walls or fashion a figurine of some protective deity. Intricate carvings and simple color washes often require little more than personal skill to execute, while the grand displays of noble palaces, seats of government, or sacred temples can summon the ingenuity of whole legions of craftsmen. The motifs listed here might be executed in a simple way on humble homes, but grand structures could express them in truly grand style.

FAVORITE STRUCTURAL FEATURES

It can be difficult to distinguish one back-country village from another, or flavor one civilization's cities as opposed to their neighbor's towns. These structural features are buildings or constructions that are particularly predominant in the civilization's communities, with almost all of them having at least one example of these features prominent in its design. Private residences may echo this favoritism with smaller edifices scaled for private use and enjoyment, whether that consists of a townhouse's walled back garden or the fortified exterior face of a rural manor house.

SETTLEMENT DESIGN PATTERNS

Some civilizations favor rigorously-designed communities with even blocks of inhabitants or organized rings of progressively-less-important inhabitants radiating out from a central palace. Others just throw up buildings in the nearest open space, forming mazy tangles of narrow streets and dead-end alleyways. A few even base their communities on ritually-significant patterns or mandalas, requiring that all construction fit with the greater divine plan. These design patterns offer suggestions for building out this civilization's communities and the ways in which their streets and buildings could be laid out.

d8 Common Visual Motifs

- | | |
|---|---------------------------------|
| 1 | Culturally important animals |
| 2 | Rulers' faces or heraldry |
| 3 | Symbols of the dominant faith |
| 4 | Family heraldry or clan sigils |
| 5 | Important plants or local flora |
| 6 | Magically-meaningful runes |
| 7 | Decorative script or writing |
| 8 | Geometric shapes or patterns |

d8 Structure Adornment

- | | |
|---|-------------------------------|
| 1 | Figurative carvings |
| 2 | Frescoes and painted plasters |
| 3 | Bas-reliefs |
| 4 | Geometric markings |
| 5 | Religious symbolism |
| 6 | Solid blocks of color |
| 7 | Statues and figures |
| 8 | Plain and unadorned surfaces |

d8 Favorite Structural Features

- | | |
|---|---------------------------------|
| 1 | Towers or spires |
| 2 | Canals, fountains, or aqueducts |
| 3 | Broad or raised roads |
| 4 | Tunnels and underground rooms |
| 5 | Walls or fortifications |
| 6 | Gardens or parks |
| 7 | Courtyards or inner open spaces |
| 8 | Monuments or statues |

d8 Settlement Design Patterns

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | Organic, sprawling, and mazy |
| 2 | Even square blocks with broad streets |
| 3 | Concentric circles and ring roads |
| 4 | Strict segregation of districts |
| 5 | Neighborhoods with different patterns |
| 6 | Symbolic or ritually-significant plans |
| 7 | Ruling-class hub district with spokes |
| 8 | Stacked vertically or underground |



FRACTAL ADVENTURE SEEDS

While the tools in the adventure creation chapter of the book are useful in helping a GM create and flesh out an evening's play, sometimes a little extra help with the premise can come in handy. These fractal adventure seeds can be used to generate the outline of an adventure with a few d20 or d00 rolls.

First, get a handful of Enemies, Friends, Complications, Things, and Places derived from the tags you rolled for the site or from your own personal creativity. Don't worry about tying them together right now, just pick the NPCs and macguffins you want to play with. If you're not sure about some of them, leave them blank until you've developed your outline more completely.

Next, roll a d00 or pick from the following list of one hundred seeds to get an initial premise. This will be a simple phrase like "A Thing is located in a dangerous Place, and a Friend knows how to get it."

Now take your handful of components and plug them into the seed. If your Thing is a dead king's crown, your Place is a royal tomb, and your Friend is the hereditary guardian of that tomb, then you fill in those blanks with those components. This is all you really need for a basic premise, after which you can use the adventure creation chapter tools to build it out.

If you want to keep complicating, however, take one of those components and roll a d20 on the specific table for that component type. Thus, you could pick the Thing in that outline and then roll d20 to get a seed from the Thing Seeds table. You might get "A Thing is instrumental to an Enemy's plan, but the Friend who knows where to get it is in hiding."

Now plug that situation into the Thing-shaped hole in the first seed. You now get a situation where a dead king's crown is instrumental to the antagonist's plan, but it's in the royal tomb and the ancestral guardian who knows where it is currently in hiding. Maybe it's worth something to the PCs to help them protect the crown, or maybe the PCs think the shiny metal hat would look better on them than on the antagonist.

You can repeat this fractal process as often as you wish, taking an element from an existing seed and rolling on the appropriate table to complicate it. You may need to add some extra Enemies, Friends, or other components to keep things from getting implausible, but you can spin each individual part of the outline out as far as you like.

You can also create entirely separate events with multiple seeds; maybe two seeds are going on with two different groups of participants, but their interests somehow overlap or complicate things for each other.

At times a seed may not seem to fit well with an outline you've developed. In that case, you can either select a different one, or read the seed in a more metaphorical sense, using it as inspiration for a complication more appropriate to your existing framework.

ENEMY SEEDS

The main Enemy you drew up at the start of the process is usually the one involved in your initial seed; the prime villain or antagonist of the situation. When generating sub-elements of the adventure, further Enemies might be henchmen or lieutenants of the primary Enemy, or a second antagonistic group that has a reason to be involved.

1. An Enemy has suffered a dire reverse, and seeks a Thing in order to rescue their situation.
2. An Enemy is behind a recent flare-up of a Complication that is causing problems for the PCs.
3. An Enemy keeps a Thing at a well-guarded Place, and a Friend is willing to pass the PCs information on it.
4. An Enemy is being targeted by the negative effects of a Complication but is trying to pin it all on a Friend.
5. An Enemy is trying to take control of a Place, but is being hindered by the activities of a Friend.
6. An Enemy is trying to use a Complication to pry a valuable Thing out of the hands of a Friend.
7. An Enemy is using a Thing to bait a Friend into getting involved in a Complication that will probably destroy them.
8. An Enemy controls a Place where a Thing is located, but a Complication is currently keeping them from being able to extract it.
9. An Enemy has recently become active near a Place, and their actions have stirred up a Complication that a local Friend doesn't know how to handle.
10. An Enemy is struggling over a Thing with another Enemy, and the fallout from their fight is making problems for the PCs or a Friend.
11. An Enemy has a grudge against a Friend and is trying to frame them for some crime related to a Thing.
12. An Enemy has just destroyed the last obstacle that prevents them from full exertion of their malice and is using a Thing they claimed to prosecute it.
13. An Enemy lost a Thing at the worst possible time and is suffering from a Complication. They're trying to get it back before they're ruined.
14. An Enemy is currently at a Place and is exceptionally vulnerable for some reason. A Friend wants to take advantage of that.
15. An Enemy has promised an ally a Thing and is becoming increasingly desperate to obtain it, as the consequences for failure are dire.
16. An Enemy has imprisoned a Friend for some reason, and if they're not rescued soon a grim fate awaits them.
17. An Enemy has allied with another Enemy in order to obtain a Thing from a Place, yet both are preparing to betray each other and the Thing could be stolen in the chaos.

18. An Enemy is working to weaponize a Complication against a Friend, but their attempt has somehow left open the possibility of stealing or finding a Thing.
19. An Enemy has forced a Friend into service, but in the process the Friend has learned about how the PCs can obtain a Thing.
20. An Enemy has just had some personal triumph that's catalyzing a flare-up of a Complication that is harming the PCs or a Friend.

FRIEND SEEDS

Some Friends generated by the tag system are relatively weak, inconsequential NPCs who are meant to tug the sympathetic heartstrings of the players rather than be personally major actors in an adventure's conflict. If a Friend seed depicts them as being significant rivals or obstacles to the Enemy, you can instead use them as synecdoches or exemplary members of their social group or other, more powerful combine. Thus, if the innocent village waif is supposed to be opposed to the witchcraft-wielding bandit chieftess, you can instead read the opposition as the village itself, with the waif simply serving as the adventure's hook for the PCs.

21. A Friend stole a Thing from an Enemy. The Enemy doesn't know who did it, but their flailing retaliation threatens something precious to the Friend as they search for the culprit and the Thing.
22. A Friend carelessly fell into a peril related to a Complication, leaving them vulnerable to a threat from an Enemy.
23. A Friend needs to be rescued from the hostile attentions of an Enemy, and they're currently hiding out at a Place dangerously close to Enemy forces.
24. A Friend has acquired a Thing, but it's also being sought by an Enemy and they need help to get it safely away and out of their foe's reach.
25. A Friend got lost or snared in a Place, and a rising Complication threatens to kill or ruin them if they're not rescued in time.
26. A Friend needs help to get a Thing from an abandoned Place, but an Enemy is ahead of them and prepared to deal harshly with competitors.
27. A Friend is not really a Friend, but an Enemy agent, and is trying to lure the PCs into helping them acquire a Thing that will actually be turned over to their master.
28. A Friend is caught up in a Complication and cannot get to a Place where they know a Thing is being kept. The PCs need to act as their agent or get them free of the Complication.
29. A Friend has been charged with guarding or maintaining a Thing, but an Enemy has set in motion a Complication that threatens both of them.
30. A Friend is being compelled by an Enemy's threats to sacrifice something important to them or endure some grave loss.
31. A Friend desperately needs a Thing for their own purposes, but an Enemy stands between them and it, though the Enemy doesn't realize what's there.
32. A Friend has obtained ownership or responsibility for a Place, but an Enemy has set up a trap or disaster there that's meant to ruin or disgrace them.
33. A Friend has been gravely harmed by an Enemy before and fears to confront them, but a Complication looks like it's going to end up forcing them into conflict once more.
34. A Friend has acquired a Thing and is making use of it to further their desires, but an Enemy means to spoil their efforts and rob them of the Thing.
35. A Friend has a sure-fire map or lead to a Thing at a Place, but in actuality, the Thing is not there at all; only an Enemy or a Complication-related peril.
36. A Friend has been snatched away by an Enemy, who is convinced they are the key to acquiring a Thing. They may or may not be right about that.
37. A Friend has suffered a grave personal loss due to a Complication, but an Enemy offers to make good their suffering if they can bring them a Thing they're supposed to know how to get.
38. A Friend is sick or dying, and desperately needs a Thing if they're to live. Getting it would somehow directly put them in conflict with an Enemy, however.
39. A Friend had a Thing but they hid it at a Place. Unfortunately, that Place is now under the control of an Enemy who doesn't know what's hidden there.
40. A Friend is trying to protect someone from the consequences of a Complication, but their efforts are being thwarted by an Enemy who profits by the current situation.

COMPLICATION SEEDS

The Complications depicted in these seeds tend to be active, troublesome forces inside an adventure, things that cause problems for people and make situations dangerous. If the Complication you're using to build the adventure doesn't seem to behave that way, you can instead use it as the explanation for some more active conflict or consequence. Thus, if the Complication for the adventure is "The Blighted here look monstrous but are harmless", then a Complication flare-up might involve outside raiders coming to slaughter the obviously-dangerous Blighted, or having some of the Blighted suddenly turn out to be considerably less harmless than they seem.

41. A Complication threatens a Friend, who offers a way to get at a Thing to the PCs if they can help the Friend escape trouble.
42. A Complication's flare-up is the fault of an Enemy, who stirred it up in the process of seeking a Thing.
43. A Complication is showing a double edge, harming both an Enemy and the PCs in some way and making the former vulnerable.
44. A Complication threatens to ruin a Friend unless a particular Thing can be found and used to save them.



45. A Complication's activity opens the path to a lost Thing at some dangerous Place.
46. A Complication is only getting worse until an Enemy is defeated and forced to stop their provocations.
47. A Complication is causing problems for the PCs, but a Friend can help resolve things if they can be found at a dangerous Place.
48. A Complication has rendered an Enemy vulnerable to the PCs if they can get their hands on a Thing.
49. A Complication is centered at a Place that a Friend needs to get to for some reason.
50. A Complication is causing problems for a Friend that an Enemy is taking advantage of.
51. A Complication elsewhere is having knock-on effects that are reaching the PCs, but a Friend can help resolve it if they can hold back an Enemy that's threatening them.
52. A Complication is being provoked by a Friend who doesn't want to do it, but is forced to do so by circumstances until an Enemy's related machinations can be stopped.
53. A Complication just calmed down, with the lull exposing a Thing and making it accessible at an otherwise-dangerous Place. At some random near future time, however, the Complication will pick back up with a vengeance.
54. A Complication is empowering an Enemy's plans, allowing them far more influence than they'd normally have. A Thing or Friend can stop this, if the PCs can lay hands on it or find the NPC.
55. A Complication struck amid a struggle between an Enemy and a Friend, just before the latter's loss. If the Enemy is not defeated before the Complication dies down again, they'll win for certain.
56. A Complication is forcing a Friend and an Enemy to work together, but it's inevitable that there will be conflict the moment it ends, and the Friend is seeking help.
57. A Complication drove a Friend out of a Place before they could recover a Thing from there. Even though the Complication is still blocking the site, they need the Thing as quickly as possible.
58. A Complication has robbed an Enemy of the current use of their best tool or most effective underling, and a Friend has a plan to make that loss permanent.
59. A Complication has damaged or involved a Thing, Place, or institution that no one ever thought would become embroiled. A Friend associated with that target is in need of aid.
60. A Complication is delicately poised between an Enemy and a Friend, targeting neither right now, but both are working to manipulate it to hit the other or escape its eventual explosion.

THING SEEDS

The Things used in these seeds are macguffins that should hold the interest of the PCs or the other players in the adventure. Some Things are implicitly valuable for their own sake, such as a pile of treasure or a diamond as big as a fist. Others are valuable to specific NPCs in the adventure, such as a trove of blackmail material, a family register, or a cure for their chronic disease. And in some cases, the Thing is valuable because of what it can do, such as a powerful magical item, a key to some ancient Working, or a grimoire of forbidden magic. When using the seeds in this section, be ready to tweak Things to fit the kind of need or use the seed implies.

61. A Thing has been lost in a dangerous Place by a Friend, and now an Enemy hastens to retrieve it. A Complication is making it hard for them to get it, but they'll win through soon.
62. A Thing has turned out to be very dangerous to possess, and an Enemy is trying to bait the PCs or a Friend into taking or stealing it.
63. A Thing is the crux of a savage conflict between two or more Enemies, and their fighting is stirring up a Complication.
64. A Thing must be found if some calamity is to be avoided by the PCs or a Friend, but an Enemy stands to profit if it's never obtained.
65. A Thing is located in a dangerous Place, and a Friend knows how to get it.
66. A Thing is supposed to be located in a Place, but those who go there merely get caught in a Complication, though they do find out the real Place the Thing has been moved to.
67. A Thing seems to be useful for a particular function or value, but in actuality it's got a hidden value known to a Friend who is currently hiding from an Enemy. The PCs know there's more to it, but only the Friend can tell the full truth.
68. A Thing has been lost by a Friend and they're desperate to get it back before it's found by an Enemy.
69. A Thing is hidden in a Place controlled by an Enemy, but they're oblivious to it.
70. A Thing has been stolen from an Enemy by a Friend and hidden in a Place, but the Enemy's searching around there and it's too dangerous for them to try to retrieve it.
71. A Thing is instrumental to an Enemy's plan, but the Friend who knows where to get it is in hiding.
72. A Thing has been demanded of the Enemy by someone they fear, and their plans for getting it involve steps that will bring grave harm to a Friend.
73. A Thing holds the key to solving or being protected from a Complication, but the Place it's at is currently very dangerous due to that Complication.
74. A Thing is responsible for a flare-up of a Complication in a Place, and the PCs are somehow affected by it.

75. A Thing that a Friend is responsible for obtaining or guarding will be lost to an Enemy as soon as a Complication stops hindering them, unless the PCs can spirit it away from its current dangerous Place.
76. A Thing was being kept at a Place by an Enemy, but a Friend has figured out a way to get past their defenses.
77. A Thing was lost in a dangerous Place long ago, but an Enemy unwittingly holds the key to finding or unlocking it.
78. A Thing hidden in a Place is needed by two different Friends for different important reasons, but if an Enemy is overcome, one or both of those reasons will cease to trouble them.
79. A Thing has just been obtained by a Friend, but an Enemy now pursues them for it, and the PCs are asked to help drive off the Enemy or get the Friend someplace safe with the Thing.
80. A Thing was the lawful inheritance of a Friend, but an Enemy has seized it and a Complication prevents the Friend from obtaining it through conventional means.

PLACE SEEDS

Places often need the most tweaking in an adventure, since often the exploration or experience of them will be a significant part of the evening's fun. While emblematic of a theme or tag, a Place that isn't particularly dangerous or enigmatic may not serve your purpose. The easiest way to turn a safe Place into a dangerous one is to translate its metaphorical meaning; a tag's result of a "Grimy tavern" gets taken as a metaphor for a place of secret meetings and decadent distractions. If you need someplace dangerous to explore, you can then take that general meaning and turn it into a hidden meeting-lair buried beneath the city sewers, one studded with assorted narcotic fungi and mushroom liquors.

81. A Place has been overwhelmed by some danger related to a Complication, and a Friend is now trapped there.
82. A Place has changed, becoming much more dangerous due to the influence of an Enemy. This is causing problems for a Friend.
83. A Place has been overrun by an Enemy or their agents in an attempt to find a Thing that is supposedly located there.
84. A Place is currently the focal point of a Complication that is threatening a Friend.

85. A Place is being reclaimed by a Friend from its current difficulties, but an Enemy has reasons to oppose that change and is using a Complication to interfere.
86. A Place is the destination to which a Friend must take a Thing. An Enemy means to waylay them, however.
87. A Place is the source of an Enemy's power, and they guard it jealously. Despite this, a Friend knows of a Thing located there.
88. A Place offers refuge from a Complication that is currently making trouble in the area, but an Enemy is preventing others from making use of it unless bribed otherwise.
89. A Place is falling apart, but the chaos has exposed a chance to get a Thing that is being pursued by an Enemy and others.
90. A Place is under siege by an Enemy, who is determined to take it before a rival can claim it. A Friend would face disaster if either claimed it.
91. A Place is currently entrapping an Enemy, who is powerless to escape. They've taken a Thing from a Friend, however, and will release it only when the Friend releases them.
92. A Place is the inherited property or responsibility of a Friend, but they lack a Thing which is critical to their successful obtaining or maintenance of the place.
93. A Place conceals its true nature as a very different Place, and a Friend has been misfortunately taken in by it.
94. A Place has a Thing as an integral part of it, and when an Enemy took it, a resultant Complication started that won't end until it's returned.
95. A Place is used by an Enemy to create a Thing, the processes and events going on there utilized to produce the desired result.
96. A Place is distant and the journey there is dangerous, but a Friend offers a Thing if the PCs can get them there safely.
97. A Place is the seat of an Enemy's power, where they are both most fearsome and least wary. A Friend has a plan to take advantage of that.
98. A Place is the target of a Complication, and the consequences might ruin it. A Thing is located there, and if it's not grabbed first the Complication will probably wreck or take it.
99. A Place has been newly-established and is still fragile. A Complication threatens to destroy it.
100. A Place is a refuge for a Friend, but an Enemy means to bait them out of it or force them to leave with a Complication.



RANDOM NPC TYPES

When an NPC is needed for an intrigue or a participant is needed for a scene, you can roll or pick from an appropriate table to get a suitable character. The adjacent character twist table can be used to add a bit of a spin to the figure if additional spice is wanted. You can also make use of the Court tables on page 167 to add additional potential figures and characterizations.

The general tables below are for use when you don't really have a particular kind of NPC in mind, and just need someone who would fit a particular social class; an intrigue scene taking place in the slums is unlikely to involve a high priest, though exceptions doubtless exist. The tables on the opposite page are for those times when you know you need a particular flavor of NPC.

Some NPCs may seem intrinsically antagonistic or sympathetic from their descriptions. If you need them to fit a different role, just invert the objectionable traits.

d12 NPC Characteristic Twists

1	They're abnormally rich or poor for their class
2	They are extremely averse to using violence
3	They tend to break their deals, wisely or not
4	They have a reason to hate people like the PC
5	They have a useful but unusual friend
6	The PC or an ally owes them a debt
7	A disaster is looming rapidly for them
8	They have a reason to like people like the PC
9	They've got few reliable local social ties
10	They conceal a socially-lethal secret
11	They're an ex-convict or former underclass
12	They have a secret identity

d00	Underclass	Commoners	Gentry
1–4	Black sheep of a gentry family	Ambitious young entrepreneur	Abbot or head of a monastery
5–8	Cast-off former gentry mistress	Artisan of some local fame	Court wizard or gentry mage
9–12	Coldly professional criminal	Butler or servant to a major figure	Demihuman leader or high priest
13–16	Corrupt petty clerk or guard	Fearfully respected local gossip	Diplomat from a foreign land
17–20	Cynical dancing girl or boy	Foreigner with enough money	Discreet kingmaker or spymaster
21–24	Downfallen former gentry	Harried landlord	Ethnarch of a local minority
25–28	Foreigner struggling to survive	Herbalist or local healer	Feared semi-legit criminal boss
29–32	Gap-toothed local thug	Local innkeeper or taverner	Genteelly-kept noble hostage
33–36	Hardscrabble orphaned urchin	Merchant in grain or bulk goods	Kept pretender to a foreign title
37–40	Missionary of an unpopular god	Merchant on his way down	Local temple's high priest
41–44	Penniless country boy or girl	Military officer or guard official	Magistrate or judge
45–48	Popular actor or actress	Minor government functionary	Major local official or minister
49–52	Prostitute with a heart of gold	Modestly prosperous farmer	Mayor or chief city official
53–56	Salt-worn common sailor	Neighborhood shopkeeper	Merchant-prince of wide affairs
57–60	Scabby beggar	Obsessed local scholar	Military general or high officer
61–64	Shabby boarding-house owner	Peasant like all their neighbors are	Most popular courtesan in town
65–68	Shaky-handed slum physician	Priest of a local faith	Paid-off noble family disgrace
69–72	Slandorous poet or playwright	Respected local ascetic or hermit	Revered artistic genius
73–76	Thieving drunkard or junkie	Retired adventurer	Rusticating loser of a court feud
77–80	Tippling bargeman or boatman	Scuffed but respectable laborer	Ruthless noble clan patriarch
81–84	Unpopular but zealous artist	Ship's captain or officer	Sorcerer of fearsome name
85–88	Unpopular demihuman	Someone important's mistress	Spare prince or major noble scion
89–92	Weary ragpicker or scavenger	Venerable family elder	Traditional cultural office-holder
93–96	Widely-despised moneylender	Veteran soldier or guardsman	Wealthy but hated usurer
97–00	Worn-down day laborer	Wandering peddler or trader	Wealthy scholar-noble

d12 Specific Criminals

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Decadent noble turned crime boss for fun |
| 2 | Obsessively driven underclass-turned-capo |
| 3 | Psychopathically indifferent assassin |
| 4 | Notorious cat burglar |
| 5 | Infamously slippery con man |
| 6 | Wealthy madame with vast blackmail files |
| 7 | Terrifyingly brutal gang boss |
| 8 | Local protector of the poor for a profit |
| 9 | Smuggler dealing in very illegal wares |
| 10 | Renegade mage meddling with dark powers |
| 11 | Noble official robbing under color of law |
| 12 | Master spy for hire by the wealthy |

d12 Specific Nobility

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | Royal scion judged unfit for responsibility |
| 2 | Merchant-noble who bought their title |
| 3 | Head of a minor but very respected house |
| 4 | Heir to a major local noble title |
| 5 | Fallen foreign noble in safe exile here |
| 6 | Scheming lesser noble with grand ideas |
| 7 | Noble on their way down from bad choices |
| 8 | Court favorite with greater ambitions |
| 9 | Treacherous but trusted noble plotter |
| 10 | Idealistic and well-meaning young ruler |
| 11 | Grizzled noble who earned their title in war |
| 12 | House leader who's getting too old for this |

d12 Specific Villagers

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | Biggest and cleverest bully in the village |
| 2 | Maiden or boy of known easy virtue |
| 3 | Restless youth who yearns to roam afar |
| 4 | Best farmer in all the hundred |
| 5 | Half-feral shepherd or swineherd |
| 6 | Village priest of phlegmatic temperament |
| 7 | Local artisan of considerable talent |
| 8 | Urban gentry resenting forced rustication |
| 9 | Local wise woman or cunning man |
| 10 | Canny local headman or mayor |
| 11 | Reeve serving the village's lord |
| 12 | Traveler stuck here for some reason |

d12 Specific Merchants

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | Grasping usurer with a long list of debts |
| 2 | Trader in exotic and potentially illegal wares |
| 3 | Ambitious young merchant on their way up |
| 4 | Major landlord in the area |
| 5 | Monopolist with a royal patent for it |
| 6 | Brutally competitive merchant-thug |
| 7 | Cartel boss with plenty of enforcers |
| 8 | Supplier of arms or goods to the government |
| 9 | Wandering peddler or roaming merchant |
| 10 | Ship-owner or trader with far lands |
| 11 | Plantation owner or sharecropper master |
| 12 | Desperate oligarch with crumbling assets |

d12 Specific Tribals

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | Zealous shaman of an obscure god |
| 2 | The most fearsome warrior of the tribe |
| 3 | The tribe's most eligible maiden or bachelor |
| 4 | Outsider who's gone native with them |
| 5 | Missionary trying to convert the tribe |
| 6 | Ambitious tribal war leader |
| 7 | Merchant trying to cut a deal with the tribe |
| 8 | Xenophobic tribal elder of great influence |
| 9 | Keeper of occult tribal secrets |
| 10 | Fabulously talented tribal artisan |
| 11 | Tribal who spent some years out in the world |
| 12 | Sage tribal lorekeeper or historian |

d12 Specific Warriors

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Bronze-thewed barbarian giant |
| 2 | Coldly pragmatic bandit chief |
| 3 | Hard-bitten and cynical mercenary sword |
| 4 | Skulking archer-sniper favoring stealth |
| 5 | Determinedly foppish duelist |
| 6 | Philosophical-minded village militiaman |
| 7 | Proudly skilled longbowman |
| 8 | Consecrated temple defender or crusader |
| 9 | Cunning thug or hired enforcer |
| 10 | Foreigner bearing a strange weapon |
| 11 | Nondescript hired killer |
| 12 | Serial killer under thin societal justification |



ONE-ROLL CHARACTERIZATION TABLES

It's part of a GM's common duty to generate NPCs... to generate a *lot* of NPCs in most campaigns. Most of these characters are little more than throwaway faces needed for a single interaction or a momentary encounter, and a sentence worth of description is as much as the players will ever need from them.

Other times, however, a more developed NPC is needed. You know you need a malevolent schemer, or a corrupt noble, or the abbot of the monastery the PCs are trying to aid. You know this figure is going to play a significant role in the adventure and have goals and ambitions of their own to carry out.

Yet to simply give them this purpose and nothing more can leave them feeling a little lifeless, both to the GM and the players. NPCs that exist only to perform a function in the adventure are of little concern when that function is minor and brief, but a running antagonist, a long-standing ally, or an important figure that needs to be placated all deserve something a little better.

The tables in this section offer ways to add more history and complexity to an NPC's personality and motivations. You can pick and choose among them, selecting those that sound interesting to you, and you shouldn't feel obligated to let the dice have the last say about their results. Instead, you can take them as suggestions and allusions that can add depth to your creations.

Appearances and Mannerisms are useful for almost all NPCs, helping you to give them a visual hook or memorable trait that you can use to catch player attention.

Burning ambitions can be used to inform the current goals of the NPC; perhaps the reason they want to accomplish whatever it is you need them for is because of this ambition. Their goal might be related to this desire, and PCs who learn about it could potentially use it for their own ends.

Close friendships can be used to characterize the relationship between an NPC and one of their allies, minions, or superiors. Even villainous antagonists can have friends, and those friends may well involve themselves in the adventure's affairs.

Personal tragedies can provide the same fuel that a burning ambition does. A bitter loss, terrible mistake, or gnawing regret can drive an NPC to extremes of action, and most players will be inclined to look more charitably on antagonists motivated by suffering than those driven by avarice or malice. A good tragedy can be handy for those occasions when you want your antagonists to be somewhat more attractive to the players.

Troubled romances can be used to flavor marriages, illicit amours, or fraught courtships between NPCs. Just as ambition and grief can drive a person, so too can love, and making that path suitably rocky can suggest matters that might trouble an NPC or areas in which the players could put pressure on them or their beloved.

Remember that the goal of these tables is to make an NPC that is useful to you as a GM. A relationship or trait that has no impact on the adventure and provides no levers for the PCs is just so much background padding, and not likely to be worth your time to create.



APPEARANCES AND MANNERISMS

An NPC will generally look like whatever their neighbors look like in build and physical appearance; a Khalan in a town full of Khalans is going to usually be big, bronzed, and black-haired. With that in mind, sometimes it can be difficult for a GM to hang a clearly distinct appearance on an NPC without some extra hints.

These tables suggests ways in which you can tweak individual NPCs to give them more memorable qualities. Remember that most players won't recollect fine details about an NPC or pick up on subtle qualities; if you want them to be remembered, you're probably going to need to exaggerate these traits or play them up in a way that affects events at the table. Once they've made an impression you can worry about more nuanced qualities they have, but you'll need to give the heroes a hook first.

d6 The Way They Move

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | Hesitant, fluttery, or delicately precise |
| 2 | Clumsy, with broad, careless motions |
| 3 | Slow and measured actions |
| 4 | Sharp, brisk, vigorous movements |
| 5 | Laborious or weary motions |
| 6 | Smooth, relaxed, efficient movement |

d8 Clothing Idiosyncrasies

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 | A fondness for very bright or dull colors |
| 2 | Emblem of a faith or social group |
| 3 | Ill-kept, whether worn, dirty, or rumpled |
| 4 | Wears another group's style of clothing |
| 5 | Abnormally risqué or modest for the society |
| 6 | Shows regular dirt and marks of their trade |
| 7 | Fastidiously neat or tastefully adorned |
| 8 | Wears a very noticeable piece of jewelry |

d10 The First Thing Noticed

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Their voice is unusual and arresting |
| 2 | They're disfigured or missing a limb |
| 3 | They have a distinctive scent or stench |
| 4 | Their clothing is very unusual |
| 5 | They have distinct mannerisms of gesture |
| 6 | Their accent is unusual for the location |
| 7 | They're abnormally friendly or reserved |
| 8 | They have signs of a chronic illness or wound |
| 9 | They have an unusual hair style or texture |
| 10 | They are very fat, thin, short, tall or such |

d4 General Physical Build

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | Unusually short or slender |
| 2 | Unremarkably average |
| 3 | Plump, voluptuous, or soft |
| 4 | Bulky, built, or more massive than usual |

d12 One Way They Differ From Expectations

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Unusual skin coloration or texture |
| 2 | From a group not normally found here |
| 3 | Much older or younger than expected |
| 4 | Abnormal temperament for their trade |
| 5 | Overt devotee of an uncommon faith here |
| 6 | A pet animal not normally found here |
| 7 | They eat a cuisine that is not liked here |
| 8 | Abnormal hair texture or hue |
| 9 | They wear unusual tattoos or body jewelry |
| 10 | They're uncommonly socially awkward |
| 11 | A physical build abnormal for the area |
| 12 | A distinct mutation or body alternation |

d20 Visible Mannerisms or Traits

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | An often-used catchphrase or verbal tic |
| 2 | Always drinking or near a drink |
| 3 | Hands never stop moving |
| 4 | Talks very slowly and deliberately |
| 5 | Tends to shift their weight constantly |
| 6 | Has an unusual hairstyle or beard |
| 7 | Appears often to be slightly drugged or drunk |
| 8 | Prefers to always be in shade if possible |
| 9 | Asks far too many questions |
| 10 | Never looks you in the eye when lying |
| 11 | Visibly avaricious for gold, food, or such else |
| 12 | Always circuitous about answering questions |
| 13 | Never directly denies or refuses anything |
| 14 | Paces constantly; always prefers to stand |
| 15 | Has work-stained or scarred hands |
| 16 | Old pox marks or disease scars are present |
| 17 | Prefers elaborate hats, belts, or adornments |
| 18 | Always toying with worry beads or such |
| 19 | Knocks things over carelessly |
| 20 | Checks written notes regularly |



BURNING AMBITIONS

Some soaring ambitions are automatic for an NPC when the GM needs them to crave some particular end. Other times, the specifics don't matter so much; so long as they want *something* the GM can use it as a catalyst for them doing whatever terrible or profitable things they're doing right now in the adventure.

These tables help a GM pick out some suitably overarching dream for an NPC and give suggestions for the tools and problems they might have in accomplishing it. Why they might want this ambition is likely predicated on a past personal tragedy, a formative life event, or simply because the ambition is naturally attractive.

The intensity of this ambition will vary depending on your needs for the game. Crazy zealots have their place, but so do rational, reasonable, goal-oriented NPCs.

d6	Who Knows or Has Been Involved in It?
1	They keep the ambition secret or hidden
2	They have a partner with a similar goal
3	Their family and friends are aware of it
4	A retired seeker of the goal is involved
5	They've gotten rivals involved somehow
6	Everyone knows, but no one is helping now

d8	What Tools Are Used to Advance It?
1	Money is being spent where it will help
2	They're getting training or help from a patron
3	They've resorted to magical means of aid
4	They have friends and allies aiding them
5	They're taking dangerous risks to get ahead
6	A great natural talent helps their pursuit
7	Extended family is proving helpful for it
8	Government authority is somehow enlisted

d10	What's the Basic Ambition's Form?
1	To win the love or possession of someone
2	To obtain riches and personal wealth
3	To win political power or an particular office
4	To obtain glory or get fame for a skill
5	To gain a particular property or piece of land
6	To go to or explore a far-off place
7	To become a difficult-to-become profession
8	To kill or ruin a hated rival
9	To topple an institution, business, or faith
10	To repay some immeasurable debt

d4	When Was the Ambition Sparked?
1	It's burned since childhood
2	An event while young inspired it
3	It came after mature adulthood
4	It's a fairly recent zeal

d12	What's the Biggest Immediate Obstacle?
1	A disinterested third party is blocking the way
2	They've made promises that are coming due
3	They're burning out a resource in the pursuit
4	They're physically pushing themselves too far
5	They suffered a recent considerable setback
6	A friend or loved one is somehow in the way
7	A backlash is about to rebound on them
8	They're chasing the goal in the wrong way
9	They've been fed some false information
10	They've lost a critical resource or tool
11	A traitor is sabotaging their efforts
12	Their success is bringing hostile attention

d20	Things to Help or Hinder the Ambition
1	A cache of saved or discovered wealth
2	A useful magical item
3	A book with critical information in it
4	A jealous "ally" seeking to sabotage them
5	A loved one who thinks it all folly
6	An addiction they use to cope with the strain
7	A patron who needs favors at times
8	A failed ambition-seeker with bitter jealousy
9	A rival with no hard feelings toward them
10	A teacher who can impart a great skill
11	A religious zeal to carry out the ambition
12	A terribly good or bad coincidence
13	A sorcerer involved in it somehow
14	A deal they made is coming back to haunt
15	A recent stroke of luck, good or bad
16	A crime they committed for their ambition
17	Someone integral to helping them further it
18	A magical trait that aids their purpose
19	A mistake which taught them a great deal
20	Reluctant rival-partner in their ambition

CLOSE FRIENDSHIPS

Almost every NPC will have at least one good friend or trusted ally, and sometimes the details of this relationship matter to an adventure. If you know why the antagonist is such a good friend of a given NPC, you can come up with hooks for the PCs to interfere with that relationship, or be alerted of the danger of trusting to the NPC's cooperation.

A GM should be careful to give PCs something to dig into when it comes to meddling with NPC relationships. An invincible friendship gives the PCs nothing to work with, while one based on specific shared interests and mutual goodwill is one they can take advantage of and manipulate. In addition, no friendship is stronger than the natural amity of the friend; a monstrously evil NPC will often cheerfully discard a now-useless friend.

d6 How Did They Meet?

- 1 They're relatives or associated by family
- 2 One did important work for the other
- 3 They shared a mutual hobby or interest
- 4 One rescued the other from a peril
- 5 They shared in a successful plan or scheme
- 6 They're in similar lines of work

d8 What Have They Done Together?

- 1 They've enjoyed socializing together
- 2 They've shared in a profitable crime
- 3 They covered up a serious mistake one made
- 4 They've married each others' relatives
- 5 They overcome a shared foe together
- 6 They made money together somehow
- 7 They got out of a dangerous situation together
- 8 They improved their social standing together

d10 What Tie Harmonizes Their Differences?

- 1 A shared appetite for money and luxury
- 2 Mutual or complementary carnal hungers
- 3 Very compatible personalities
- 4 Respect and admiration for each other
- 5 Trust in each others' judgment
- 6 Confidence in each others' trustworthiness
- 7 They both have fatal blackmail on the other
- 8 An artistic sensibility only they fully share
- 9 Blood ties or familial bonds between them
- 10 Shared love for a particular cause or faith

d4 How Old is the Relationship?

- 1 It's a very new one between them
- 2 They've spent some time together
- 3 They're old friends or allies
- 4 They've been friends since early youth

d12 What Threatens to Divide Them?

- 1 They both want the same man or woman
- 2 One of them has erred, threatening both
- 3 One has something the other direly wants
- 4 One feels painfully inferior about something
- 5 Their associates disapprove of the relation
- 6 A religious dispute lingers between them
- 7 One owes the other a large sum of money
- 8 One is failing to provide needed help
- 9 One of them is wooing the other's spouse
- 10 They want the same office, title, or role
- 11 One has become useless to the other lately
- 12 A misunderstanding has festered of late

d20 Things Between Friends

- 1 They amiably share a mistress
- 2 They have a getaway they both favor
- 3 One has a secret the other would detest
- 4 One hides some contraband for the other
- 5 Their children are wedded
- 6 They both have stakes in a business
- 7 Staff or servants are traded between them
- 8 One watches out for useful help for the other
- 9 They have regular shared meals and drinks
- 10 They have a friendly rivalry about something
- 11 They share ownership of a piece of property
- 12 One covers up a vice of the other
- 13 They often gamble things between them
- 14 They share illicit or delicate books or art
- 15 They both make use of the same mage's help
- 16 They go to the same temple regularly
- 17 They go hunting together often
- 18 They throw celebrations for each other's wins
- 19 They patronize the same artists or performers
- 20 They both resent the same group or faith



PERSONAL TRAGEDIES

All that lives must suffer troubles sooner or later, but sometimes you need a really emphatic misery to give to an NPC. A standard-issue tragic loss, personal failure, or thwarted ambition is nice for humanizing a character, but the better grade of calamity is one that produces some actual activity on the NPC's part.

The tables below create a generalized tragedy for the NPC and provide some possible consequences and quirks that might come from it. You can use the tables as inspiration for why your antagonist NPC might not be totally rational in their actions, or why a friendly NPC might be so desperate for the help of the heroes.

The amplitude of the tragedy can be dialed up or down based on how dramatically you want it to affect the NPC's actions.

d6	What Was Their Responsibility For It?
1	A mistake they made contributed to it
2	A fit of passion or emotion involved them
3	A character flaw was instrumental in it
4	A failure or success of theirs was involved
5	None whatsoever; a rival or enemy did it
6	None whatsoever; it was just bad luck

d8	How Did They Try to Cope With It?
1	They lost themselves in work or duty
2	They plotted revenge against someone
3	They sought forgetfulness in an addiction
4	They left and went far away
5	They tried to find a duty to consume them
6	They sought a way to undo the tragedy
7	They behaved with suicidal recklessness
8	They tried to remake what they had lost

d10	What Was Its Basic Form?
1	A family member died or worse
2	They suffered horrible abuse or torment
3	A treasured ambition was crushed
4	A loving relationship was ruined
5	A terrible betrayal from a trusted one
6	They failed at some critical moment of need
7	A friend or lover died or was lost
8	They killed someone they never meant to
9	They were maimed or crippled somehow
10	They were beggared or lost a dear thing

d4	When Did It Happen?
1	Its immediate aftermath is still playing out
2	It's still a fresh memory
3	It's a regular shadow in their thoughts
4	Past enough that they can pretend to forget

d12	What Ugly Consequences Followed?
1	Someone blames them and seeks revenge
2	They lost confidence in a great talent of theirs
3	They have a great debt to pay
4	They're bitterly resented by a former friend
5	They lost the ability to trust others
6	They re-enact their suffering on others
7	They bear physical scars from the aftermath
8	They're estranged from their family
9	The tragedy made a bitter rival for them
10	They're sought as a criminal by someone
11	They despise themselves and act accordingly
12	They made enemies of former allies

d20	What Scars Do They Have From It?
1	They hate a type of person associated with it
2	They picked up an addictive habit
3	They are irrational about similar situations
4	They want to share the misery around
5	They're haunted by lost possibilities
6	They remake the past in makeshift ways
7	They made deals they're still laboring under
8	They have visible associated physical scars
9	They accepted a role they hate because of it
10	They try to substitute others for the lost
11	They meddled with sinister magic
12	They lost or sold something precious to them
13	They despise a place and its natives
14	They insist on a false narrative of events
15	They made bargains with dark powers
16	They aggressively make light of their loss
17	They obsess over a physical token of it
18	They try to keep it a secret from those near
19	They act so as to punish themselves for it
20	They've displaced their wrath on another

TROUBLED ROMANCES

A happy pair of lovers is easy enough to describe, but they seldom offer much useful adventure grist. Sometimes a more fraught relationship offers a GM more opportunities to involve the PCs in work meant to bring two lovers together, or safely separate an unsuitable match.

The tables below can be tuned up or down in emphasis based on your need for the relationship. If you want to portray a cruelly abusive marriage, you can read the d10 problem table in the worst possible light, making them prone to furious rages or cruelly selfish disregard for the other. More nuanced romances could tone down the results to something more sympathetic to players.

The default assumption here is a pair of NPCs, but the tables can also be used for love triangles or other more complex arrangements with a few more rolls.

d6 How Did They Meet?

- 1 They were opposed in a recent conflict
- 2 They're childhood acquaintances
- 3 Their families put them in contact
- 4 One needed something the other had
- 5 Employment or service of one to the other
- 6 Some unlikely random chance

d8 What Sparked the Romance?

- 1 Tremendous physical attraction
- 2 Very complementary personalities
- 3 Social obligation that turned to real love
- 4 A shared secret that brought them close
- 5 A desperate emotional need of one or both
- 6 Mutual understanding not found elsewhere
- 7 A shared hardship they weathered together
- 8 Rivalry that transformed to mutual love

d10 What Problem Does One or Both Have?

- 1 The pairing is totally socially unacceptable
- 2 Profound insecurity about their worthiness
- 3 Abusive ways of expressing anger or worry
- 4 A serious addiction or compulsive flaw
- 5 They're already tied in an existing relationship
- 6 A deep lack of trust, perhaps from past history
- 7 They love a false image they have of the other
- 8 Expectation the other will or won't change
- 9 Self-centered or thoughtless behavior
- 10 Self-destructive degree of sacrifice

d4 Past Length of the Relationship

- 1 Those involved are just now aware of it
- 2 It's new but established between them
- 3 Long enough to change their lives somehow
- 4 Long enough to have consequent effects

d12 What's the Current Issue They Face?

- 1 Recent infidelity or suspicion thereof
- 2 A rival moving in on one of them
- 3 One made a mistake that threatens the other
- 4 One takes a dire risk for the sake of the other
- 5 A sense of lack, that something's missing
- 6 A recent furious argument over something
- 7 One is being asked to sacrifice a dear thing
- 8 They cannot agree on a future path
- 9 One made a mistake that shamed the other
- 10 A relative is interfering with the two
- 11 They're being separated by circumstances
- 12 A shared dream is being threatened

d20 Quirks or Traits of the Relationship

- 1 Inability to candidly admit their feelings
- 2 They can't keep their hands off each other
- 3 They wear tokens the other gave or made
- 4 One is smitten with a physical trait of the other
- 5 They've established a secret meeting-place
- 6 Feelings are expressed in ways only they see
- 7 One side thinks the other really hates them
- 8 They prefer to communicate by letter or note
- 9 They only show affection when alone
- 10 One is burying their feelings in work
- 11 One or both are cheerfully unfaithful
- 12 One feels intense pressure to provide a thing
- 13 They're currently upset and not talking
- 14 They have very different future hopes
- 15 One is convinced the relationship will die
- 16 They share an addiction or vice
- 17 Their friends disapprove of the relationship
- 18 They're shockingly innocent about love
- 19 One is plotting a grand deed for the other
- 20 They operate largely through a go-between



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INDEX

A

administer (skill) 10
 Adunic invoker (class) 345
 adventurer (class) 21
 heroic adventurer 357
 adventure seeds 380–383
 aiding a skill check 41
 Anak 306–307
 Anak Speech 107
 historical threat 96–97
 animals 300–301
 arcane tradition (ability) 19
 architectural style 378–379
 armor 35
 armor class 35
 arratu 110–111
 arts (ability) 63
 attribute modifiers 8
 attributes 8
 improving attributes 55
 Automaton 302–303
 Autumn War 97

B

background actors 334–335
 backgrounds 11–17
 base attack bonus 28
 Black Brass Legion 96–97, 302
 Bleeding God 109
 Sarulite Blood Priest 352–353
 Blighted 284, 304–305
 Blight, The 284
 Brass Cult 108
 Brass Hegemony 96–97, 188
 Brass Cult (faith) 108
 business income 258

C

calyxes 264–265
 campaign 114
 Carceral Sea 98
 casting a spell 44, 62
 character advancement 54
 for Legates 359
 character creation 4–37
 character advancement 54
 example character 30
 charging 44
 charisma 8
 class 18–21
 Adunic Invoker 345
 adventurer 21
 Darian Skinshifter 346–347
 Elementalists 76–77

expert 18
 Healers 80–81
 heroic classes 356–357
 High Mages 66–67
 Kistian Duelist 348–349
 Llaigisan Beastmaster 350–351
 mage 19
 Necromancers 82–83
 Sarulite Blood Priest 352–353
 Vothite Thought Noble 354–355
 Vowed 86–87
 warrior 20
 combat 42–47
 common actions 44–45
 dual-wielding 43
 grappling 43
 hit rolls 42
 initiative 42
 instinct checks 298
 judging combat challenges 295
 morale checks 297
 rounds 42
 shock damage 43
 types of actions 42
 commit effort 63
 community tags 148–165
 connect (skill) 10
 constitution 8
 construction costs 341
 convince (skill) 10
 court tags 166–185
 craft (skill) 10
 creating factions 327
 cunning assets 328–329
 cursed magical weapons 271

D

damage roll 43
 Darian Skinshifter (class) 346–347
 death 48
 handling PC 227
 Deeps 96, 188
 demihumans 310–311
 dexterity 8
 diseases 48
 domains 258–259
 drudges 308
 dual-wielding weapons 43
 dwarves 312–313
 Ubarun 317

E

effort 63
 eidolons 303
 elemental (class) 76–77
 elemental spells 78–79

elixirs 276–279
 elves 314–315
 Emed-Dar 97
 Emed-Kist 100
 encumbrance 32
 equipment 32–37
 crafting equipment 58
 equipment mods 56–57
 masterwork equipment 58
 starting packages 29
 esser foes 360
 evasion saves 40
 execution attack 44
 exemplars 264–265
 exert (skill) 10
 experience points 54
 experience rewards 255
 Legate XP 359, 369
 expert (class) 18
 heroic expert 356

F

factions 322–333
 actions 326
 and major projects 340
 creating 327
 cunning assets 328–329
 faction tags 325
 faction turn 324
 force assets 330–331
 wealth assets 332–333
 falling 49
 fighting withdrawal 45
 first aid 48
 fleeing 52, 297
 foci 22–27
 foci list 22–27
 gaining new foci 55
 foraging 51
 force assets 330–331
 frail condition 48
 fray damage 357
 Free Cities Compact 96

G

geography construction 120–123
 Golden Path 108
 Golden Rule of Preparation 116
 government construction 132–135
 grappling and shoving 43
 grimoires 264–265
 Gyaros 96
 Gyre, the 94–113

H

halfmen 308
 healer (class) 80–81
 healing 48
 first aid 48
 frail condition 48
 magical healing 48
 mortal wounds 48
 natural healing 48
 heal (skill) 10
 heroic classes 356–357
 high mage (class) 66–67
 High Mage spells 68–75
 high magic 62
 hirelings 34, 342
 history construction 136–139
 hit points 28
 hit roll 42
 horses 33, 50
 houris 309

I

emperors 316–317
 initiative 42
 instant action 42
 instinct checks 298
 intelligence 8
 Iterums 112–113, 370–375

J

Jikegadi
 Nakris 317
 Jikegida 110, 188, 318

K

Ka-Adun 101
 Khalan 106
 killing blow (ability) 20
 Kistian Duelist (class) 348–349
 know (skill) 10

L

land ownership 258–259
 languages 106–107
 list of languages 107
 starting languages 28
 lead (skill) 10
 Legates 4, 358–369
 Writs 358
 level (character) 54
 level (spell) 62
 light sources 53
 Lin 106
 Llaigis 102
 Llaigisan Beastmaster (class)
 350–351

locks 53
 Lost Emad 98
 luck saves 40

M

mage (class) 19
 arts 63
 dual partial mage traditions 64
 Elementalists 76–77
 Healers 80–81
 heroic mage 357
 High Mages 66–67
 Necromancers 82–83
 starting spells 28
 Vowed 86–87
 magic 60–63
 casting a spell 44
 dual partial mage traditions 64
 High Magic spell list 64–65
 magical armor and shields
 262–263
 magical devices 272–275
 magical healing 48
 magical items
 elixirs 276–279
 magical weapons 266–271
 magic items 261–279
 armor and shields 262–263
 creating magic items 92–93
 grimoires, exemplars, and calyxes
 264–265
 magical devices 272–275
 magical weapons 266–271
 magic (skill) 10
 main action 42
 major projects 336–340
 masterful expertise (ability) 18
 masterwork equipment 58
 mental saves 40
 monster stat list 283
 morale checks 297
 mortally wounded 48
 move action 42

N

nation construction 124–127
 natural healing 48
 necromancer (class) 82–83
 necromancer spells 84–85
 new magic 62
 New Voth 103
 notice (skill) 10

O

Old Lords 108
 Old School Renaissance 2
 Olok 106
 on turn action 42
 opposed skill checks 41

Osirin 107
 Outsiders 96–97, 110–111
 Jikegida 110
 languages 107
 Old Lords (faith) 108
 Polop 110
 Tuhulot 111

P

partial expert 21
 partial mage 21
 partial warrior 21
 Perfected Circle, the 96
 perform (skill) 10
 physical saves 40
 poisons 48, 49
 Polop 110, 319
 pray (skill) 10
 punch (skill) 10

Q

quick learner (ability) 18

R

reaction rolls 296
 readied items 32
 Reaping King 96–97
 relic automatons 303
 religion construction 140–145
 reloading a weapon 45
 renown 254, 336
 rewards 254–255
 Legate XP 369
 ride (skill) 10
 round 42
 ruin tags 186–203
 Rule of Shun 96, 189, 317
 Servants of Shun (faith) 108

S

sail (skill) 10
 sandbox gaming 228
 Sarul 104
 Sarulite Blood Priest (class)
 352–353
 saving throws 28, 40
 evasion 40
 luck 40
 mental 40
 physical 40
 scene 40
 screen an ally 45
 searching 53
 Seers of Voth 109
 sentient weaponry 267
 Servants of Shun 108
 shock damage 43

shoot (skill) 10
 skill checks 41
 aiding a skill check 41
 opposed skill checks 41
 skill points 55
 skills 9–10
 gaining in character creation 11
 skill list 10
 skill points 55
 using social skills 226
 snap attack 44
 sneak (skill) 10
 society construction 128–131
 sorcerer-kings 96
 spells 62
 developing new spells 88–89
 Elementalist spells 78–79
 High Mage spells 68–75
 Necromancer spells 84–85
 preparing 62
 stab (skill) 10
 starving 51
 stowed items 32
 strength 8
 suffocation 49
 surprise 42
 survive (skill) 10
 swarm attack 44
 system strain 48

T

tags 147
 communities 148–165
 courts 166–185
 ruins 186–203
 wilderness 204–219
 thought house
 Vothite Thought Noble 354–355
 thought houses 96
 Thur 105
 Time of Three Senates 96
 total defense action 45
 trade cant 107
 trade (skill) 10
 transport 33
 travel 49
 treasures 256–257
 Tsagasthos 317
 Tsagasthos (Imperator) 317
 Tuhulot 111, 319
 turn 40
 turns while exploring 52

U

Ubarun 317
 undead 320–321

V

veteran's luck (ability) 20
 Vothians 106
 Voth (Imperator) 96, 317
 Seers of Voth (faith) 109
 Vothite Empire 96, 189
 Vothite Republic 96, 189
 Vothite Thought Noble (class)
 354–355
 vowed (class) 86–87

W

wandering encounters 51, 53,
 246–247
 surprise 53
 warrior (class) 20
 heroic warrior 356
 wealth assets 332–333
 weapons 36–37
 traits 37
 weapon list 37
 wilderness tags 204–219
 wisdom 8
 Workings 90–91
 creating Workings 90–91
 work (skill) 10
 worthy foes 360
 writs 358
 martial 362–363
 skillful 364–365
 sorcerous 366–367
 universal 368
 writs of mastery 360

SPELL INDEX

Abdication of Temporal Presence 68
 Adopt the Simulacral Visiage 68
 Apprehending the Arcane Form 68
 Aqueous Harmony 78
 Augment Mortal Vitality 84
 Banishment to the Black Glass Labyrinth 68
 Boneshaper 85
 Boreal Wings 78
 Burrower Below, The 78
 Calcifying Scourge 79
 Calculation of the Evoked Servitor 68
 Calculation of the Phantasmal Eidolon 68
 Call of the Tomb 85
 Casting Forth the Inner Eye 68
 Cognitive Supersession of the Inferior Orders 69
 Command the Dead 84
 Compel Flesh 85
 Conjunction of the Inexorable Step 69
 Conjunct the Vital Viscera 69
 Contingent Excision of Arcana 69
 Coruscating Coffin, The 69
 Damnation of the Sense 69
 Dazzling Prismatic Hemicycle, The 69
 Decree of Ligneous Dissolution 70
 Decree of Lithic Dissolution 70
 Deluge of Hell 70
 Disjunctive Temporal Reversion 70
 Earth as Clay, The 70
 Elemental Favor 78
 Elemental Guardian 79
 Elemental Spy 78
 Elemental Vallation 78
 Enfeebling Wave 84
 Everlasting 85
 Evert the Inwardness 70
 Excellent Transpicious Transformation, The 70
 Exhalation of Congelating Cold 71
 Extirpate Arcana 71
 Festering Curse 85
 Final Death 84
 Flame Scrying 78
 Flame Without End 78

Foresightful Apprehension 71
 Forgetting the Grave 85
 Fury of the Elements 79
 Glass Chimes of the Bamboo Terrace, The 71
 Grinding Geas, The 71
 Howl of Light, The 71
 Imperceptible Cerebral Divulgence 71
 Ineluctable Shackles of Volition 71
 Inexorable Imputation, The 72
 Invocation of the Invincible Citadel 72
 Jade Palanquin of the Faceless God, The 72
 Like the Stones 79
 Long Amber Moment, The 72
 Mantle of Disjecting Dissection 72
 Merge Souls 85
 Obnubilation of the Will 72
 Ochre Sigil of Juxtaposition, The 73
 Open the High Road 73
 Pact of Stone and Sea 78
 Phantasmal Mimesis 73
 Phobic Storm 73
 Pierce the Pallid Gate 73
 Prudentially Transient Abnegation of Life 73
 Query the Skull 84
 Raise Corpse 84
 Raise Grave Knight 85
 Resounding Temporal Echo 73
 Scorn the Fetters of Earth 74
 Sigil of Aeolian Auctoritas 74
 Smite the Dead 84
 Terrible Liveliness 84
 Torment of Tumefaction, The 74
 Tremors of the Depths 79
 Vallation of Specified Exclusion 74
 Velocitous Imbuement 74
 Verdant Vallation, The 75
 Visitation of the Clement Clime 75
 Wardpact Invocation 75
 Wind of the Final Repose, The 75
 Wind Walking 79

